The Noble Great Vehicle Sūtra on the Descent into Laṅkā

Āryalaṅkāvatāramahāyānasūtra · Toh 107 · Derge Kangyur
འཕགས་པ་ལང་ཀར་གཤེགས་པའི་ཐེག་པ་ཆེན་པའོ་མདོ

The Noble Great Vehicle Sūtra on the Descent into Laṅkā, known in Sanskrit as the Āryalaṅkāvatāra Mahāyāna Sūtra and in Tibetan as Phakpa Langkar Shekpé Tekpa Chenpo'i Do, is one of the most influential scriptures of Mahāyāna Buddhism. It opens with the Buddha dwelling in the city of Laṅkā on the jewel-adorned summit of Mount Malaya by the ocean, surrounded by a great assembly of monks and of bodhisattvas gathered from many buddha fields, led by the bodhisattva Mahāmati. Through a long series of questions and answers between Mahāmati and the Buddha, the sūtra explores the nature of mind and perception, teaching that the appearances of the world arise from mind itself. It is especially celebrated for its treatment of the storehouse consciousness and of buddha nature, themes that shaped the Yogācāra tradition and later schools such as Chan and Zen. It is Toh 107 in the Kangyur, where it belongs to the general collection of Mahāyāna sūtras and is divided into several fascicles.

In the language of India: ārya laṅka avatāra mahāyāna sūtra. In the language of Tibet: The Noble Great Vehicle Sūtra on the Descent into Laṅkā. The first fascicle.

Homage to all buddhas and bodhisattvas.

Thus did I hear at one time. The Blessed One (the Buddha) was dwelling in the city of Laṅkā, on the summit of Mount Malaya by the ocean, which was adorned with all kinds of jewels and with various flowers. He was together with a great saṅgha of monks and with a great assembly of bodhisattvas, great beings, who had gathered from various buddha fields. They sported in many meditative absorptions, masteries, powers and superknowledges, and were headed by the bodhisattva Mahāmati. They had been empowered by the empowerment of the hands of all the buddhas, and were skilled in the meaning of fully understanding that the domain of experience is the appearance of one's own mind. They bore the semblances of different kinds suited to the various minds, forms and dispositions of sentient beings and to the ways of disciplining them. They had realized and penetrated the five dharmas, the natures, the consciousnesses, and the two kinds of selflessness.

At that time the Blessed One, having spent seven days in the abode of Sāgara, king of the nāgas, came forth, and was welcomed by Śakra (Indra), by Brahmā, and by many tens of millions of nāga maidens. He looked toward Mount Malaya in Laṅkā and thought: "Here on the summit of Mount Malaya in the city of Laṅkā, the tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly complete buddhas of the past also taught the Dharma which they cultivated: the wisdom that noble ones know individually within themselves, which is not the domain of the views of logicians, of non-Buddhists (tīrthikas), of śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas. I too, in this very place, will set it forth and teach the Dharma for the sake of Rāvaṇa, lord of the yakṣas." With this thought, he smiled.

Then Rāvaṇa, lord of the yakṣas, through the blessing of the Tathāgata, heard this: that the Blessed One had come forth from the abode of Sāgara, king of the nāgas, surrounded and preceded by Śakra, by Brahmā, and by many hundreds of thousands of nāga maidens; that he had gazed upon the waves of the ocean, and, seeing how the consciousnesses that enter the ocean of the all-base consciousness are stirred by the wind of objects, and seeing the arising of their minds, he had uttered an inspired utterance.

Having heard this, he thought: "I shall go and request the Blessed One to enter Laṅkā. That will bring lasting benefit, help and happiness to me and to gods and humans."

Then Rāvaṇa, lord of the yakṣas, together with his retinue, entered a celestial palace of flowers and went to where the Blessed One was. When he arrived, he descended from the palace together with his retinue, and they loudly sounded drums and cymbals. They circumambulated the Blessed One three times. He took a vīṇā whose body was ornamented with sapphire, beryl and musāra stone, and from which hung as a fringe priceless ochre cloth like kapriyaṅgu. Having delighted the assembly, with the melodies ṣaḍjā, riṣabha, gāndhāra, dhaivata, niṣāda, madhyama and kauśika, and with many melodies blended together, harmonizing his voice with the strings and bringing it within the sound of the vīṇā, he sang in the melody of verse:

The very nature and way of mind, a treasury of Dharma,
Selfless, free from views, without stain,
The way of Dharma that reveals the knowing realized within oneself:
O Protector, please teach it here as well.

Your body truly amassed by virtuous qualities,
You, the Sugata, who display emanations through miraculous power,

Delighting in the Dharma that is realized within oneself,
O Sage, now is the time to enter Laṅkā.

Here in Laṅkā the Victors of the past
And their sons, bearing many forms, have dwelt.
O Protector, please expound the excellent Dharma here;
All the yakṣas of many forms will listen.

Thus Rāvaṇa, lord of Laṅkā, sang in the toṭaka meter, and then again he sang in the melody of verse:

When seven days had passed, the Blessed One
Came forth from the abode of the ocean's lord,
Within the ocean, home of sea monsters,
And afterward stayed upon its shore.

As soon as the Buddha had taken his seat,
Rāvaṇa, together with goddesses
And many kinds of yakṣas
Graced by Śuka and Sāraṇa,

Went by magic power along the way
To where the Protector was staying,
Came down from his flowery vehicle,
And honored and bowed to the Tathāgata.

Blessed by the Lord of Victors,
Not speaking of it openly to him, he said:
"I am Rāvaṇa, the Ten-Necked (Daśagrīva),
Lord of the rākṣasas, who have come here.

Please accept whoever lives in this city,
And accept my Laṅkā as well.
The perfect buddhas of the past also
Expounded the domain of self-awareness

In the middle of this city
Adorned with its jeweled peak.
Blessed One, you too, upon that same
Jewel-adorned peak,

Surrounded by the Victors' sons,
Please teach the stainless Dharma.

Those who dwell in Laṅkā and we ourselves
Wish to listen today.

Liberated from the ways of verbal explanation,
The domain of self-awareness,
The Sūtra of the Descent into Laṅkā,
Was taught by the buddhas of the past.

Surrounded by the Victors' sons,
The buddhas of the past as well,
I recall, explained this very sūtra.
Blessed One, please teach it.

The buddhas and the buddhas' sons
Who will appear in future times
Will also teach this magical way
On the jewel-adorned peak;
Out of compassion for the yakṣas
The Guides will teach it here.

This magical city of Laṅkā
Has delightful jewels of every kind,
Pleasing terraces and stone platforms,
And is adorned with canopies of jeweled nets.

Blessed One, here are yakṣas
Free of faulty yoga,
Who contemplate self-awareness,
Whom past buddhas have cared for,
Who have faith in the way of the Great Vehicle,
Who are devoted to it and lead others in.
There are yakṣiṇīs and yakṣa youths
Who wish to understand the Great Vehicle.

To Laṅkā, to Mount Malaya,
Teacher, Buddha, please come.
Kumbhakarṇa and the others,
The rākṣasas who dwell in the city,
Who rely upon the Great Vehicle,
Wish to hear of self-awareness.

I have done what is to be done for the buddhas,
And now too I do it fully.
Out of compassion for me,
Come to Laṅkā together with your sons.

My dwellings and the hosts of goddesses,
Necklaces of many kinds,
And the delightful Aśoka grove:
Great Sage, please accept them.

I act according to the command
Of those Victors' sons and of the buddhas.
There is nothing at all that I would not offer.
Great Sage, regard me with compassion.

When he had heard these words of his,
The Lord of the three realms of existence said:
"Lord of the yakṣas, the Protectors of the past,
Upon the jewel mountain,
Taught the teachings of self-awareness.
Regarding you too with compassion,
On the mountain adorned with jewels
Those of the future will also teach.
This is the abode of those endowed with yoga
Who practice the Dharma that is seen.
I and my sons as well
Should regard the lord of the yakṣas with compassion."

The Blessed One gave his consent and, without speaking,
Remained with a peaceful mind.
He took his seat upon the flower chariot
That Rāvaṇa had offered.

Then Rāvaṇa
And the other fearless Victors' sons as well,
Honored by goddesses with laughter and music,
Went to the city.

Having gone to that delightful city,
He received abundant offerings once more.
The host of yakṣas led by Rāvaṇa
And the yakṣiṇīs also made offerings.

The yakṣa daughters and yakṣa sons
Made offerings with nets of jewels.
Rāvaṇa too hung jewel-adorned necklaces
Upon the upper bodies
Of the Buddha, the Victor,
And of the Victors' sons.

The Blessed One, with the wise Victors' sons,
Having accepted the offerings presented,
Taught the Dharma
Of the domain of self-awareness.

The host of yakṣas and Rāvaṇa
Honored the best of speakers,
And greatly honoring Mahāmati,
Entreated him again and again:

"You are the one who asks all the buddhas
About the domain of self-awareness.
I, the yakṣas, and the Victors' sons
Wish to hear this.
The wise Victors' sons
And the yakṣas too entreat you.
You, great speaker among speakers,
Have entered the yoga even of yogins.
We respectfully entreat you:
Fearlessly ask about the way!

Free of the faults of the pratyekabuddhas,
The śrāvakas, and the non-Buddhists (tīrthikas),
The pure nature of reality that is self-awareness
Brings attainment of the buddha ground."

The jewel-adorned peaks,
And others too, adorned
With ten million jewels of divine substance,
The Blessed One emanated there,
And on each of the mountains the Protector
Displayed his own body.
On each of them Rāvaṇa

And the yakṣas were present.
The whole assembly, undiminished,
Appeared clearly on each one.

There all the fields
And whatever Guides were there,
And the lords of the rākṣasas there
Who dwell in Laṅkā, also appeared.
A Laṅkā rivaling that one,
Other Aśoka groves,
And those fine forests too
The Victor emanated.

On each of the Protector's mountains,
Urged on by Mahāmati,
Proclaiming self-awareness,
He taught the Dharma to the yakṣas.
The sūtras of a hundred thousand lines
Were taught in full upon the mountain.

Then right there the Teacher
And the Victors' sons vanished.
The yakṣa Rāvaṇa, seeing himself
Dwelling in his own house,
Reflected, thinking, "What was this?
Who taught it, and who heard it?
What was seen, and who saw it?
Where have those cities gone?
Those buddhas, those fields,
Those fine jewel forests, where are they?

Was this an illusion, or the play of a dream?
Or what is called a city of the gandharvas?
Was it a blur of the eyes, or a mirage?
Was it a dream, a barren woman's son?
What I saw here,
Was it a whirling firebrand, or smoke?
Or else, in the domain of the mind,
Was it the nature of reality of phenomena?

There is no view and no viewing,
No speaker and nothing to be spoken;
Yet the childish, intoxicated
By their own conceptions, do not know this.
Conceived otherwise, this conceptuality
Appears as if it were the Buddha and the Dharma.
Those who view things just as they appear
Do not see the Guide.
When conceptuality does not engage
And one does not see the Buddha,
If one then sees that non-engagement
Is the Buddha, that is the Buddha."

The lord of Laṅkā had undergone a thorough transformation of his basis, and the very moment he fully realized and understood that all is merely the appearance of his own mind, he abode in the stirring of conceptuality. Urged on by his former roots of virtue, with an intelligence skilled in all the treatises, he saw suchness just as it is. He did not depend on others. He was skilled in investigation by his own intelligence. He saw free of the views of the logicians. He did not rely on others. He was a yogin of the great yoga. He had realized and understood the great skill in means of bearing manifold forms. He was skilled in realizing the specific characteristics of all the grounds, higher and higher. He delighted in the solitude that is the intrinsic nature of mind, mentation, and mental consciousness. He saw the severing of the three continua. Since his intelligence had become free of causes and of the causes of all the non-Buddhists, he abode in the inner absorption into the tathāgatagarbha, the buddha ground. Then, through the intelligence of the buddhas, he heard a voice from the sky and from within: "Lord of Laṅkā, excellent, excellent! Again, lord of Laṅkā, you are excellent. As you train, so should yogins train."

"Just as you have seen, so should the tathāgatas and phenomena be viewed. If one views them in any other way, one will come to rest in annihilationism. Free from your mind, your mentation and your mental consciousness, and practicing inwardly, you should cultivate all phenomena, and not through attachment to views of external objects. You should not dwell in the realizations of the śrāvakas, the pratyekabuddhas and the non-Buddhists (tīrthikas), nor in views and meditative absorptions that fall within the domain of the meaning of words. You should not delight in talk and tales, not view

things in terms of the nature of the Vedas, not fall into the arrogance of royal power, and not meditate on the six meditative concentrations and the like. Lord of Laṅkā, this is the commitment of those who practice the Great Vehicle: the children of the Victor endowed with the yoga of great yogins, who utterly crush opponents, who dispel wrong views, who are skilled in turning back the view of a self, whose intellect is subtle and discerning, and who are skilled in thorough transformation.

"You must strive to understand entry into the ground of the Tathāgata's own personal realization. If you do so, Lord of Laṅkā, this path that you have embraced through the absorptions of one skilled in meditative absorption will be practiced again and again, ever higher and higher. It is not the domain of the approach followed by the śrāvakas, the pratyekabuddhas and the tīrthikas: as in the yoga of childish tīrthikas, the arising of attachment to the characteristic of appearing as the grasping of the yogin as a self; following after qualities and substances; clinging through attachment to views that have ignorance as their condition; being distracted by emptiness and by arising; attachment to conceptual thought; and imagining with an intention that has fallen into characteristics.

"Lord of Laṅkā, this understanding of the Great Vehicle, which brings about the realization of my own personal awareness, brings the attainment of various forms. One will also attain birth in distinctive states of existence. Lord of Laṅkā, this entry into the yoga of the Great Vehicle turns back the waves of the various consciousnesses, which are veils that cover; it does not fall into the state of the yoga of the tīrthikas. Lord of Laṅkā, the yoga of the tīrthikas arises from the tīrthikas' clinging to a self. Because they view with attachment the objects of the two natures of consciousness, this too of the tīrthikas is not yoga. Lord of Laṅkā, that is excellent. Seeing the Tathāgata, reflect upon that very meaning just as you have reflected upon it, and that itself is seeing the Tathāgata."

Then, on that occasion, Rāvaṇa thought: "Once again I would see in this way the Blessed One (the Buddha), master of all yogas, who turns back the yoga of the tīrthikas, who teaches the domain of personal awareness, who is free of illusions conjured by a conjurer, and whose mind has realized. For when yogins realize yoga, they come to understand the bliss of meditative absorption and the absorptions, and because they understand that, the yogins' term 'yoga' is designated as 'by this one understands.' Therefore I shall behold in this way the Compassionate One, who brings to an end the cause of the blaze of

afflictions and conceptual thought, who is surrounded by the children of the Victor, who has entered the minds and intentions of all sentient beings, who is all-pervading and works toward omniscience, through a miraculous power that has turned away from characteristics. By seeing him, what has not been understood will be understood. And what I have understood will further increase, so that I attain the ground realized by the Tathāgata, who dwells in the blissful meditative absorption and the absorptions that engage in nonconceptuality."

Then at that time the Blessed One, knowing that the lord of Laṅkā had attained forbearance toward unborn phenomena, out of compassion for Daśagrīva, displayed himself on his mountain peak, adorned with many jewels and covered with jeweled nets, in just such beauty as before. And once again Daśagrīva, lord of Laṅkā, saw the beauty he had seen and experienced; on the peak, the body of the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha, adorned with the thirty-two excellent major marks; on each mountain, his own body as well, seated before the tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly complete buddhas; the Tathāgata discoursing together with Mahāmati on the domain of personal awareness; surrounded by yakṣas, giving discourse in explanation; and also those fields together with their protectors.

Then at that time the Blessed One looked upon the assembly with the fleshly eye of a buddha, stretched himself like a lion king, and laughed a great laugh. From his ūrṇā hair, his sides, his thighs, his waist, his śrīvatsa and all the pores of his skin, rays of light poured forth. He blazed like the fire at the end of time; his splendor was like a rainbow; his maṇḍala of light blazed intensely like the rising sun. As Śakra (Indra), Brahmā and the world guardians looked on from the expanse of the sky, he, seated on a peak that rivaled the summit of Mount Meru, laughed a great laugh.

Then that assembly of bodhisattvas, and Śakra, Brahmā and the others, thought: "For what cause and what condition has the Blessed One, master of all phenomena, first smiling, laughed a great laugh and sent forth rays of light from his own body? And having sent them forth, he has settled his mind in the bliss of meditative absorption, the domain where the noble wisdom of his own personal awareness is seen; and without gazing at any sight, he has looked toward the directions with a lion's gaze, contemplating the course of Rāvaṇa's realization of yoga, and has fallen silent."

Then the bodhisattva mahāsattva Mahāmati, who had made his request earlier, felt compassion for Rāvaṇa. He knew the minds, the intentions and the conduct of that assembly of bodhisattvas, and he also looked toward the multitudes of people yet to come. He thought: "There are sentient beings who delight in reciting explanations, there are those who cling to sounds just as they sound, and there are all those who cling to the power of the yoga of the śrāvakas, the pratyekabuddhas and the non-Buddhists (tīrthikas). They will think, 'So even the Blessed Ones, the Tathāgatas, who have turned back from the domain of consciousness, burst into great laughter!' It would not do for their minds to become confused."

To dispel their astonishment, he asked the Blessed One, "Blessed One, for what cause and for what condition do you smile in this way?"

The Blessed One said, "Excellent, Mahāmati, excellent! And again, Mahāmati, you have looked at the nature of the world and at the wrong views of worldly beings, and understanding the minds of the three times, you have undertaken to question me. That is excellent of you, Mahāmati. In this way the wise should make it their nature to inquire thoroughly, for their own sake, for the sake of others, and for the sake of both.

"Mahāmati, this Rāvaṇa, lord of Laṅkā, asked two questions of the tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly complete buddhas of the past. Now he wishes to ask me too, in order to cultivate the characteristic of understanding the distinction within the two questions, something the yogis in the yoga of the śrāvakas, the pratyekabuddhas and the non-Buddhists have never experienced. This Daśagrīva, who wishes to ask in this way, will also put his questions to the Victors of the future."

Then the Blessed One, knowing this, spoke these words to the lord of Laṅkā: "Lord of Laṅkā, the Tathāgata grants you leave. You whose crown sways, ask me without delay whatever you wish. As I answer each of your questions, the ground of your conceptual thought will be thoroughly transformed. With an intellect skilled in and discerning the factors opposed to the grounds, you will examine, by way of personal self-awareness, the characteristics of the blissful abiding in samādhi. You will be embraced by the buddhas of samādhi, and you will abide in the bliss of peace. Passing beyond the faults of the samādhi of the śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas, you will abide on the grounds called Immovable, Good Intelligence and Cloud of Dharma. Being thoroughly skilled in the reality, just as it is, of the selflessness of phenomena, you will receive

empowerment from the Victors of samādhi upon a great jewel lotus spread out for you. On lotuses that accord with it you will bless your own body into many different forms, you will see your own body seated on those lotuses, and you will have each of them look into the face of the others. Thus that inconceivable domain is accomplished by one who is skilled in accomplishment, by such a one alone. Abiding on the ground of practice, by accomplishing an accomplishment embraced by skillful means, you will attain that inconceivable domain as well, and you will also attain the ground of a Tathāgata, transforming into a multitude of forms, never before seen by śrāvakas, pratyekabuddhas, non-Buddhists, Brahmā, Indra or Upendra (Viṣṇu). Let your mind rejoice!"

Then the lord of Laṅkā, surrounded by his assembly together with his goddesses, having been granted leave by the Blessed One, rose from that jeweled peak, which through the rays of the jewel lotus was like a jewel lotus of stainless light. He conjured up flowers, garlands, incense, fragrant smoke, perfumed ointments, parasols, victory banners, divine pennants, necklaces, pearl strands, diadems and crest ornaments of many kinds, varied and distinct, together with other outstanding and supremely excellent kinds of ornament never seen or heard of before; drums and cymbals of gods, nāgas, yakṣas, rākṣasas, gandharvas, kinnaras and mahorogas, surpassing even those finer than human ones; and all the musical instruments belonging to the desire realm. He also emanated whatever special kinds of music are seen in other buddha fields. He covered the Blessed One and the bodhisattvas with a net of jewels. He raised up divine pennants of various cloths. He rose into the sky to the height of about seven palm trees. He sent down a rain from great clouds of offerings. He sounded drums and cymbals. Then, descending from the sky, he sat down on a second jeweled peak, adorned with a great jewel lotus like the light of the sun and of lightning.

Having sat down, he first smiled respectfully, and when the Blessed One had granted him the opportunity, he asked the Blessed One two questions:

"I questioned the tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly complete buddhas of the past as well, and they too gave answers. Now I ask the Blessed One also. Among the teachings that are spoken, this is one that the buddhas, and you as well, will surely explain. Blessed One, these two dharmas were taught by emanations conjured by magical power; they were not spoken by the tathāgatas in their essential nature. Blessed One, the tathāgatas in their essential nature teach the domain of the gateways of samādhi; they do not

teach what has fallen into the conceptuality that is the domain of words. So, Blessed One, master of the Dharma, Tathāgata, arhat, perfectly complete Buddha, please explain those two dharmas well to me yourself. Blessed One, these sons of the Victors will also listen, and I too shall come to understand."

The Blessed One said, "Lord of Laṅkā, state those two dharmas!"

Then the lord of the rākṣasas, who wore on his body a diadem, armlets, a necklace and a garland of the finest diamonds, his body adorned with fine ornaments, said: "If even dharmas are to be abandoned, how much more so non-dharmas! Blessed One, how are these two dharmas to be abandoned? What are dharmas, and what are non-dharmas? These things are subject to abandonment as a pair. They fall within the characteristic of conceptuality. Their nature is conceptual, and they are neither the elements nor what is derived from the elements. Because the all-base consciousness is not fully known, they have no distinguishing characteristics. They abide with the nature of a tangle of hairs, and their objects belong to impure cognition, which comes to an end. How, then, are such natures to be abandoned?"

The Blessed One said: "Lord of Laṅkā, jars and the like are breakable by nature and subject to destruction, yet in the domain of the conceptuality of fools they appear as distinct particulars. Why do you not take this in the same way? If one adopts the individual conceptualizations of fools, then there is indeed a distinction between dharma and non-dharma. But it is not so for the seeing that leads to the realization of noble wisdom.

"Lord of Laṅkā, things such as jars, which fall into various characteristics, belong to fools; never mind that they do not belong to the noble ones. Consider blazing flames that are of a single nature and arise from a single blaze. In houses, dwellings, parks and buildings, depending on the wood, they appear with differences of long and short light and as distinct particulars. In the same way, why do you not take it that here too there is a distinction between dharma and non-dharma?

"And it is not only that the light radiating from a single continuum of flame appears as distinct particulars. Lord of Laṅkā, although they arise from a seed, there are the distinctions of sprout, shoot, stalk, node, leaf, branch, flower, fruit and awn. In the same way, for the outer and inner dharmas, which are of a nature to arise and which issue from ignorance, all that belongs to the aggregates, the elements and the sense sources, and all dharmas born in the three realms, there appear differences of pleasant form, of speech and of

movement. And consciousness, though of a single character, as it engages in grasping objects, appears with distinctions of superior, middling and inferior, and as purified, as virtuous and as nonvirtuous.

"Lord of Laṅkā, it is not only that there are distinct particulars among those dharmas. If even on the yogic path of yogis who cultivate yoga there appear differences in the character of what each knows by personal awareness, then why would there be no difference between dharma and non-dharma, which arise from individual conceptualizations? There is indeed. Lord of Laṅkā, because of the characteristic of conceptuality, there is a distinction between dharma and non-dharma.

"Lord of Laṅkā, what, then, are dharmas? They are what is imagined by the conceptuality of non-Buddhists (tīrthikas), śrāvakas, pratyekabuddhas and fools, established from causes as qualities and substances; these are called dharmas. They are to be abandoned, to be let go; one should not individually imagine them as having characteristics. Because of attachment to dharmas that are the appearances of one's own mind, dharmas such as pots, which are imagined by fools and have never attained a body, do not exist. When one sees clearly in this way through insight, they are abandoned.

"Then what are non-dharmas? They are those that have not attained a self-nature. They are dharmas in which no conceptuality of characteristics moves, and which arise from the cause that is the object. When one sees that they do not enter into either the real or the unreal, one therefore abandons non-dharmas.

"Again, what are the dharmas that have not attained a self-nature? They are dharmas such as the horn of a rabbit, of a camel, of a donkey or of a horse, and the son of a barren woman. Because they have not attained a self-nature, they should not be imagined as having characteristics. Otherwise, they are spoken of for the sake of convention, but not with attachment, as with jars and the like. Just as these are to be abandoned because consciousness cannot grasp them, so too the entities of conceptuality are to be abandoned. Therefore dharma and non-dharma are abandoned. Lord of Laṅkā, what you asked, 'How are the two, dharma and non-dharma, to be abandoned?', has been explained in this way.

"And as for what you said, Lord of Laṅkā, 'I asked the former tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly complete buddhas as well, and they too answered me,' Lord of Laṅkā, this word 'former' is a conceptual designation. Even the past is

conceived of in this way as 'past.' The future and the present are conceived of likewise. The tathāgatas, by their very nature, are nonconceptual; they have passed beyond all the elaborations of conceptuality. They are not as one imagines the essential nature of form. Rather, for the sake of the ease of realizing wisdom, they meditate with a discernment that engages in the signless. Therefore the tathāgatas have wisdom as their very self; they are the body of wisdom, and they are not to be imagined.

"By what are they not to be imagined? They are not to be imagined by the mind as a self, a life or a person. How are they not to be imagined? They are not to be imagined by the mental consciousness, which arises from the cause that is the object, as one imagines the characteristics, shapes and aspects of form. Therefore you should be free of what is to be imagined and of conceptuality.

"Lord of Laṅkā, moreover, the activities of beings are like figures painted on a wall. Lord of Laṅkā, because no dharma exists, the abiding of the world is without movement, free of action and agent. In it there is no one who listens and nothing to be heard. Lord of Laṅkā, though the abiding of the world is like a magical emanation, the foolish yogis of the non-Buddhists do not cultivate this."

Lord of Laṅkā, whoever sees in this way sees correctly. If one sees in any other way, one is engaged in conceptual thought. Those who have conceptual thought in this way grasp things dualistically. It is like the reflection of one's own form in a mirror, the shadow of one's own body in water, moonlight, the shadow of one's own body cast by a lamp burning in a house, or an echo. Moreover, they firmly grasp what their own conceptual thought has grasped and conceive of dharma and non-dharma. They do not engage in abandoning both dharma and non-dharma. Instead they engage in them, they conceptualize, they proliferate, and they do not attain peace. This is a synonym for one-pointedness. It is the arising of the supreme samādhi, which leads into the tathāgatagarbha, the domain of the noble wisdom that each realizes within himself.

This is the first chapter, on Rāvaṇa's request.

Then the bodhisattva mahāsattva Mahāmati, who travels to all the buddha-fields, rose from his seat through the power of the Buddha, together with the bodhisattva Mati. He draped his upper robe over one shoulder, placed his right knee on the ground, joined his palms toward the Blessed One (the

Buddha), and bowed. Then he praised the Blessed One with these verses:

The world is free of arising and perishing,
Much like a flower in the sky.
Through your wisdom and compassion
You apprehend neither existence nor nonexistence.

All phenomena are like illusions,
Free of mind and consciousness.
Through your wisdom and compassion
You apprehend neither existence nor nonexistence.

The world, free of permanence and annihilation,
Is ever like a dream.
Through your wisdom and compassion
You apprehend neither existence nor nonexistence.

The selflessness of phenomena and of persons,
Your afflictions and the knowable,
Through your wisdom and compassion
And through signlessness, are ever pure.

How can one praise the Dharma body,
Whose nature is illusion and dream?
The non-arising of things that lack intrinsic nature,
That itself is praise.

He whose seeing is free of senses and objects
And without appearance:
Whether one praises him or reviles him,
What can be said of that Sage?

You do not pass into nirvāṇa, nor are you in it;
Nirvāṇa does not abide in you.
Free of knower and of known,
You have abandoned the positions of existence and nonexistence.

Whoever sees the Sage at peace,
Thus free of arising and perishing,
Here and hereafter as well,
Will be free of attachment and free of grasping.

Then the bodhisattva mahāsattva Mahāmati praised the Blessed One with these fitting verses, and announced his name and family to the Blessed One:

Blessed One, I am Mahāmati,
Who has come to understand the Great Vehicle.
One hundred and eight questions
I shall put to the supreme of speakers.

When he had heard those words,
The Buddha, supreme knower of the world,
Surveyed the whole assembly
And spoke to the son of the Sugata:

"Ask me, children of the Victor!
Mahāmati, you too, ask!
The domain of individual self-awareness
I shall explain to you."

Then, the Blessed One having given him the opportunity, the bodhisattva mahāsattva Mahāmati touched the Blessed One's feet and asked the Blessed One:

How does reasoning become purified?
For what reason does reasoning arise?
In what way is there error?
For what reason does error arise?
Why are there emanations and fields,
Your marks, and the tīrthikas too?
Why are there the stages of the imageless?
From where have your children of the Victor come?

Where do the liberated go?
Who is bound, and by what is one freed?
What is the domain of meditators?
How are there three vehicles?
What are the things that arise from conditions?
What is the result, and what is the cause?
Why is an extreme stated by way of the two?
And in what way do they arise?

The formless attainments,
And cessation, what are they like?
What is the cessation of perception like?
Why and how does one rise from it?

Going, and the holding of a body as well:
For what reason do such activities arise?
How does one meditate on what appears?
How does one enter the grounds?

Who is it that breaks through the three existences?
What is the abode, and what is the body?
Where does one abide, and where does one go?
How does one become a child of the Victor?
The masteries and the samādhis,
And the superknowledges, how are they attained?
How is the mind settled in equipoise?
Victor, supreme among bulls, tell me!

Mentation and consciousness,
And the ālaya too, what are they like?
How does one engage with appearance?
How does one turn back from appearance?
Lineage and non-lineage, how and through what?
How does one come to mind-only?
The establishing of characteristics,
And selflessness too, how do they come about?

What is the nonexistence of sentient beings like?
What is conventional teaching like?
How is it that views of permanence
And annihilation do not arise?
How is it that you and the tīrthikas
Are not at odds in your characteristics?
In what way have you said
The schools will arise in time to come?

Why and how is there emptiness?
How, for you, do things perish in an instant?
How does the essence come about?
How is there no maker of the world?
Why is the world like an illusion,
Like a city of gandharvas, a mirage,
And like the moon in water?

For what reason have you told me so?

How are there limbs of awakening?
From what do the factors of awakening arise?
Upheaval in the land, and bloodshed,
How are they seen to arise?
How are the unarisen and unceasing
Like a flower in the sky?
How have you understood the world?
How do you speak without letters?

What makes one free of conceptual thought?
How is one like space?
How many kinds of suchness are there?
How many minds, and how many perfections?
By what does one pass through the stages of the grounds?
What is the moving in the imageless?
By what are the two kinds of selflessness realized?
How is the knowable purified?

Protector, how many kinds of wisdom are there,
Of moral discipline, and of sources of beings?
Who brought forth the kinds
Of gems, pearls, and gold that come to be?
The variety of beings and things,
And their designations, who produced them?
The fields of knowledge and the crafts,
Who taught them, and how?

How many kinds of verse are there?
What is plain verse like?
How many kinds of reasoning are there?

And how do explanations come to be?
Drinks and the many kinds of food,
and how does sexual union come about?
Universal monarchs
and lords of the realms, what are they like?
How is a kingdom protected?
How many kinds of gods are there?

From what do the earth and the hosts of stars arise?
And the sun and moon, what are they like?
How many kinds of liberation are there?
How many kinds of yogins are there?
How many kinds of disciples are there?
And how does one become a teacher?
How many kinds of buddhas are there?
How many kinds of birth stories are there?
How many kinds of māras are there?
And how many kinds of heterodox ones?
How many kinds of your nature are there?
How many kinds of drawings are there?
And what is mere designation like?
Best of speakers, tell me!
From what do the clouds and winds of the sky arise?
How do memory and keen intelligence arise?
How do the trees and creepers come to be?
Lord of the three realms of existence, tell me!
Why is it that elephants, deer,
and dull horses can be caught?
From what do base people arise?
You who guide the mind, tell me!
Why are the six elements grasped?
And how does one become an icchantika?
How are men, women,
and those of neither sex born? Tell me!
How does one turn back from yoga?
And how does one enter into yoga?
In what kind of person, and in what way,
is yoga established? Tell me!
Of beings who have gone into the destinies,
what are the characteristics and the signs?
By what, and how, does one become wealthy?
You who are like space, tell me!
How and why did the Śākya clan
and the Ikṣvākus come to be?
Who was the sage of long austerities,

and how did he instruct you?
Why are you, in all the fields,
with various names and likewise forms,
surrounded by the Victor's heirs,
present everywhere?
How is it that meats are not fit to eat?
How is it that meat is forbidden?
And how do those born
in the lineage of flesh-eaters come to eat meat?
Why are the fields shaped like the sun and moon,
like Mount Meru and the lotus,
and shaped like the śrīvatsa and the lion?
Tell me why!
Those lying crosswise and those upside down,
and those like illusions, what are they like?
And the fields made of every jewel,
how and why are they? Tell me!
Those shaped like lutes and drums,
those like various fruits and flowers,
and those without sun and moon,
how and why are they? Tell me!
Some are emanation buddhas,
some buddhas arise from ripening,
and buddhas of true wisdom,
how and why are they? Tell me!
Why and how, in the desire realm,
is one not fully awakened? Tell me!
For what purpose, in Akaniṣṭha,
amid those free of attachment, does one become fully awakened?
After the Sugata has passed into nirvāṇa,
who will hold the teaching?
How long does the Teacher remain?
And how long will the system endure?
How many kinds of tenets are yours?
And how many kinds of views?
The true monk and the Vinaya too,
why and how are they? Tell me!

Of pratyekabuddhas, the Victor's heirs, and śrāvakas,
why is there the king of transformation,
and the king of the imageless too?
Tell me why!
By what do the worldly superknowledges arise?
And how the transcendent ones as well?
And mind and the seven grounds,
how and why are they? Tell me!
How many kinds of Saṅgha are yours?
How does schism in the Saṅgha come about?
And the treatises for healing beings,
how and why are they? Tell me!
"I am Kāśyapa, Krakucchanda,
and Kanakamuni as well":
why, Great Sage, do you say this
to the Victor's heirs?
Why do you proclaim no self and no being?
How is there talk of permanence and destruction?
Why do you not teach everywhere
that mind-only is the very truth?
How are the groves of men and maidens,
the groves of harītakī and āmalakī,
the snows of Kailāsa and the Cakravāla mountains,
and the vajra-hard as well?
Within them, the many mountains,
richly adorned with various jewels
and filled with sages and gandharvas,
how and why are they? Tell me!

When the Buddha, foremost of those who know the world,
the great god, heard this,
the supreme heart of the buddhas,
the many ways of the Great Vehicle,
he said: "You of great wisdom, excellent, excellent!
All that you have asked
I shall explain in order.
Great-minded one, learn from me.

Birth and non-birth,
how nirvāṇa is, and emptiness,
transmigration and the absence of intrinsic nature,
buddhas, the perfections, and the heirs,
śrāvakas and the Victor's heirs,
non-Buddhists (tīrthikas) who practice the formless,
Mount Meru, the oceans and the mountains,
continents, lands and fields,
stars, sun and moon,
tīrthikas, gods and asuras,
liberations, masteries and superknowledges,
powers, dhyānas and samādhis,
cessation and the bases of miraculous power,
the factors of awakening and the paths,
the immeasurables and the dhyānas,
the aggregates, going and coming,
the meditative attainments and cessation,
emergence and the various explanations,
mind, mentation and consciousness,
selflessness and the five dharmas,
intrinsic nature, conceptualizing and the conceptualized,
appearance and the two views, how they are,
the source of the vehicles,
the mines where gold, gems and pearls arise,
icchantikas and the great elements,
the one buddha and the tumult,
knowing and the knowable, arising and attainment,
the possible and the impossible for beings,
why elephants, deer and horses
can be caught and how: this you asked me.
How is the exposition of tenets
endowed with examples and reasons?
Why are there cause and effect?
Methods and the various errors,
mind-only, which is imageless,
the absence of sequence in the grounds as well,
imagelessness and the transformations:

why these hundred? This you asked me.
The treatises of healing and the crafts,
the arts and the sciences likewise,
the mountains, likewise Mount Meru,
and what the measure of the earth is,
the measure of sun, moon and ocean,
how great it is: this you asked me.
In the bodies of beings, how many particles,
of the superior, the middling and the inferior?
In each field, how many particles?
In each fathom, how many are there?
In a cubit, a fathom, a pace, a krośa,
a half yojana and a yojana,
how many rabbit-hair motes, sunbeam motes, nits,
sheep-hair motes, and barley grains?
In a full measure, how many barley grains?
In a half measure, how many barley grains?
Likewise in one load of measures,
in a hundred thousand, ten million and a shudok, how many?
In a mustard seed, how many atoms?
In a peppercorn, how many mustard seeds?
In one ri, how many peppercorns?
In one nam, how many ri are there?
In one zho, how many nam are there?
In one sang, how many zho are there?
With such heads of reckoning as these,
how many sang are there in Mount Meru?

Thus my son has asked me.
Why do you ask in another way?
Why do you not ask in this way:
"How many atoms are there in the bodies
Of the pratyekabuddhas, the śrāvakas,
The buddhas and the children of the Victor?"
How many atoms are there in a tongue of flame?
How many atoms in the wind?
How many atoms in each single sense faculty?

How many pores in the hair of the eyebrows?
From what do wealthy people come to be?
And the wheel-turning kings,
How do they guard their kingdoms?
How do they become liberated?
How does one speak in single verses?
Sexual union, the various kinds of beings,
The many kinds of food and drink,
How it is that persons are young,
How and why the mountains
Are hard like vajra, tell me.
Why are things like illusions and dreams?
In what way are they like a mirage?
Where is it that clouds arise?
From what do the seasons arise?
From what does the savor of flavors come?
From what do male, female and neuter come?
The beauty of the children of the Victor,
Why, my son, do you ask me of these?
How are the mountains of the gods
Adorned with sages and gandharvas?
Where does the liberated one go?
Who is bound, and by what is one freed?
What is the domain of the meditators?
Emanations and also the tīrthikas,
Existence, nonexistence, non-doing, why are these?
How does one turn back from appearances?
How do the logicians cease?
Why does logic arise?
Through what does action arise?
Why do you speak to me of the going of beings?
By what is perception to be cut off?
Through what is meditative absorption realized?
Who is it that abides having conquered the three realms of existence?
What is the abode, and what the body?
It is said there is no self and no sentient being;
In what way is the conventional taught?

Why do you ask about characteristics?
In what way do you ask about selflessness?
Why, about the essence and the classes,
Do you ask me, child of the Victor?
Views of permanence and annihilation,
And by what the mind is settled in equipoise,
Speech, and likewise wisdom,
Moral discipline, lineage, child of the Victor,
Teacher and disciple, and the showing of reasoning,
In what way sentient beings are various,
Food and drink, space and the intelligent,
The māras and mere designation,
Trees and creepers, why these,
Why, child of the Victor, do you ask me?
Why are the fields various?
The austerities of the long-lived sages,
And what is your lineage and your teacher,
Why, child of the Victor, do you ask me?
Why is it that one who is lowly among humans
Does not awaken in the desire realm?
The culmination attained in Akaniṣṭha,
How it is reasoned, you ask me.
Why are there worldly supernormal knowledges?
How does one become a monk in actuality?
About the emanated buddha and the buddha abiding in ripening,
In what way do you ask me?
The buddhas of true wisdom,
And the Saṅgha too, how do they come to be?
Like a lute, a flower, a drum,
And the fields free of appearances,
The mind, and the seven grounds,
These too, child of the Victor, you ask me.
These, and very many others besides,
The questions my son has asked me,
Each one endowed with its marks,
And free of the faults of wrong views,
The established conclusion on the side of explanation,

I shall explain; listen to me.
I shall set forth the statements,
The hundred and eight statements,
Just as the buddhas have explained them;
Listen to me, my son.

Then the bodhisattva, the great being Mahāmati, said this to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, what are the hundred and eight statements?"

The Blessed One said: "The statement of arising and the statement of non-arising; the statement of permanence and the statement of impermanence; the statement of characteristics and the statement of no characteristics; the statement of transformation and the statement of non-transformation; the statement of the momentary and the statement of the non-momentary; the statement of intrinsic nature and the statement of no intrinsic nature; the statement of emptiness and the statement of non-emptiness; the statement of annihilation and the statement of non-annihilation; the statement of mind and the statement of no mind; the statement of the Middle Way and the statement of what is not the Middle Way; the statement of the everlasting and the statement of the non-everlasting; the statement of conditions and the statement of non-conditions; the statement of causes and the statement of no causes; the statement of afflictions and the statement of no afflictions; the statement of craving and the statement of no craving; the statement of skillful means and the statement of non-means; the statement of skill and the statement of non-skill; the statement of purity and the statement of impurity; the statement of reasoning and the statement of non-reasoning; the statement of example and the statement of no example; the statement of the disciple and the statement of the non-disciple; the statement of the teacher and the statement of the non-teacher; the statement of lineage and the statement of no lineage; the statement of the three vehicles and the statement of no three vehicles; the statement of appearance and the statement of no appearance; the statement of aspiration and the statement of no aspiration; the statement of the three spheres and the statement of no three spheres; the statement of signs and the statement of no signs; the statement of the position of existence and nonexistence and the statement of what is not the position of existence and nonexistence; the statement of both and the statement of neither; the statement of the personally realized wisdom of the noble ones and the statement of no personally realized wisdom of the

noble ones; the statement of happiness in this very life and the statement of no happiness in this very life; the statement of fields and the statement of no fields; the statement of atoms and the statement of no atoms; the statement of water and the statement of no water; the statement of delusion and the statement of non-delusion; the statement of the real and the statement of the unreal; the statement of number and calculation and the statement of no number and calculation; the statement of supernormal knowledge and the statement of no supernormal knowledge; the statement of weariness and the statement of no weariness; the statement of density and the statement of non-density; the statement of the arts, sciences and crafts and the statement of no arts, sciences and crafts; the statement of wind and the statement of no wind; the statement of earth and the statement of no earth; the statement of mind and the statement of no mind; the statement of designation and the statement of no designation; the statement of intrinsic nature and the statement of no intrinsic nature; the statement of the aggregates and the statement of no aggregates; the statement of sentient beings and the statement of no sentient beings; the statement of intellect and the statement of no intellect; the statement of nirvāṇa and the statement of no nirvāṇa; the statement of the knowable and the statement of no knowable; the statement of the tīrthikas and the statement of no tīrthikas; the statement of turmoil and the statement of non-turmoil;

the statement of illusion and the statement of no illusion, the statement of dream and the statement of no dream, the statement of mirage and the statement of no mirage, the statement of reflection and the statement of no reflection, the statement of the wheel and the statement of no wheel, the statement of gandharvas and the statement of non-gandharvas, the statement of gods and the statement of non-gods, the statement of food and drink and the statement of no food and drink, the statement of sexual union and the statement of no sexual union, the statement of views and the statement of no views, the statement of the perfections and the statement of no perfections, the statement of moral discipline and the statement of no moral discipline, the statement of sun, moon and stars and the statement of no sun, moon and stars, the statement of truth and the statement of no truth, the statement of the fruit and the statement of no fruit, the statement of cessation and the statement of no cessation, the statement of emergence from cessation and the statement of no emergence from cessation, the statement of healing and the statement of no healing, the statement of the marks and the statement of

no marks, the statement of limbs and the statement of no limbs, the statement of knowledge of the arts and crafts and the statement of no knowledge of the arts and crafts, the statement of meditative concentration and the statement of no meditative concentration, the statement of error and the statement of no error, the statement of appearance and the statement of no appearance, the statement of protection and the statement of no protection, the statement of lineage and the statement of no lineage, the statement of sages and the statement of non-sages, the statement of kingship and the statement of non-kingship, the statement of the apprehended and the statement of nothing apprehended, the statement of jewels and the statement of no jewels, the statement of prophecy and the statement of no prophecy, the statement of icchantikas and the statement of no icchantikas, the statement of male, female and neuter and the statement of no male, female and neuter, the statement of taste and the statement of no taste, the statement of action and the statement of no action, the statement of the body and the statement of no body, the statement of reasoning and the statement of no reasoning, the statement of movement and the statement of no movement, the statement of the sense faculties and the statement of no sense faculties, the statement of the conditioned and the statement of the unconditioned, the statement of cause and effect and the statement of no cause and effect, the statement of the lowest and the statement of Akaniṣṭha, the statement of time and the statement of no time, the statement of trees, shrubs and spreading creepers and the statement of no trees, shrubs and spreading creepers, the statement of diversity and the statement of no diversity, the statement of introduction through teaching and the statement of no introduction through teaching, the statement of Vinaya and the statement of no Vinaya, the statement of monks and the statement of no monks, the statement of blessing and the statement of no blessing, and the statement of letters and the statement of no letters. These, Mahāmati, are the one hundred and eight statements spoken by the buddhas of the past.

The Noble Descent into Laṅkā, second fascicle.

Then again the bodhisattva, the great being Mahāmati, said this to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, of how many kinds are the arising, abiding and cessation of consciousnesses?"

The Blessed One said: "Mahāmati, the arising, abiding and cessation of consciousnesses are of two kinds, which the logicians do not understand: namely, cessation of the continuum and cessation of the characteristic. The

arising of consciousnesses is likewise of two kinds: arising of the continuum and arising of the characteristic. Abiding too is of two kinds: abiding of the continuum and abiding of the characteristic.

"Mahāmati, consciousness has three aspects: the characteristic of functioning, the characteristic of karma, and the characteristic of its own kind. Mahāmati, the consciousness that is taught as having eight characteristics is, in brief, of two kinds: the appearing consciousness and the consciousness that discriminates entities one by one. Mahāmati, just as forms appear in a mirror, so the appearing consciousness takes hold of what appears. Mahāmati, these two, the appearing consciousness and the consciousness that discriminates entities one by one, are not different in character, and each is the cause of the other.

"Mahāmati, of these, the appearing consciousness arises from the cause of the transformation of inconceivable habitual tendencies. Mahāmati, the consciousness that discriminates entities one by one arises from the cause of conceptualizing objects and from the cause of the habitual tendencies of beginningless conceptual elaboration.

"Mahāmati, the cessation of all the sense consciousnesses is this: the cessation of the various habitual tendencies of false imagination in the all-base consciousness. Mahāmati, this is the cessation of the characteristic. Mahāmati, the cessation of the continuum concerns that from which it arises. Mahāmati, 'that from which' means that on which it rests and that on which it is focused. Here, 'that on which it rests' means the habitual tendencies of the negative states of beginningless conceptual elaboration. 'That on which it is focused' means conceptualizing the appearances of one's own mind as the objects of consciousness.

"Mahāmati, it is like this. For example, the atoms of clay and a lump of clay are neither one nor different, just as gold and its ornaments are. Mahāmati, if the lump of clay were something different from the atoms of clay, it would not be made from them; but since it is made from those very atoms of clay, it is therefore not different. Yet if they were not different, there would be no distinction between the lump of clay and the atoms. Likewise, Mahāmati, if the functioning consciousnesses were separate and different from the characteristic of the all-base consciousness's own kind, they would not arise from the all-base consciousness as their cause.

If, however, they were not different, then when the evolving consciousnesses ceased, the all-base consciousness would cease as well. Yet its own class-characteristic does not cease in that way. Therefore, Mahāmati, the consciousnesses' own class-characteristic does not cease; what ceases is the characteristic of their activity. If their own class-characteristic ceased, the all-base consciousness would cease as well. And, Mahāmati, if the all-base consciousness ceased, this doctrine would be no different from the annihilationist doctrine of the non-Buddhists (tīrthikas).

Mahāmati, the doctrine of the tīrthikas is this: when the grasping of objects is cut off, the continuum of consciousness is cut off; and when the continuum of consciousness is cut off, the continuum of beginningless time is cut off as well. Mahāmati, the tīrthikas assert that the continuum arises from a cause. They do not assert that eye consciousness arises from the coming together of form and light apart from that cause. Mahāmati, the cause they speak of is the principal (pradhāna), the person (puruṣa), the Lord (Īśvara), time, or atoms.

Furthermore, Mahāmati, there are seven kinds of intrinsic nature of things: the intrinsic nature of collection, the intrinsic nature of existents, the intrinsic nature of characteristics, the intrinsic nature of the great elements, the intrinsic nature of causes, the intrinsic nature of conditions, and the intrinsic nature of accomplishment. These are the seven.

Furthermore, Mahāmati, there are seven kinds of ultimate: the domain of mind, the domain of wisdom, the domain of the two views, the domain beyond the two views, the appearance-less domain, the domain where the sons of the buddhas pass beyond, and the domain of the Tathāgatas' individual self-awareness. These, Mahāmati, are the intrinsic nature of things and the heart of the ultimate of the tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly complete buddhas of the past, future and present. Because they possess that intrinsic nature of things and that heart of the ultimate, the tathāgatas, with the eye of noble wisdom, set forth the supreme dharmas, worldly and transcendent, that belong to specific and general characteristics; and they set them forth in such a way that they are not held in common with the doctrines of the tīrthikas and with wrong views.

Mahāmati, if one asks how they are not held in common with the doctrines of the tīrthikas and with wrong views, it is like this. Mahāmati, because they do not understand the view that conceptualizes the consciousnesses' own domain, and do not enter into the fact that it is merely the appearance of their

own mind, ordinary childish beings come to speak dualistically, taking things and the nature of non-things as ultimate.

Furthermore, Mahāmati, I shall explain the cessation of the conditions of ignorance, craving and karma; the reversal of the conceptualized suffering of the three realms of existence; and the seeing of the domain that appears to one's own mind as an illusion.

Mahāmati, certain śramaṇas or brahmins hold that a result becomes manifest from a cause, out of what has not come to be or out of what exists; that things endure; that from conditions the aggregates, elements and sense sources arise and abide, and having arisen, perish. Mahāmati, they come to view continuity, activity, birth, existence, nirvāṇa, the path, karma and its result, and the truths as destroyed and annihilated. And why is that? Because no beginning is seen, since it is neither directly perceived nor apprehended.

Mahāmati, it is like this: a potsherd does not perform the function of a pot, for the pot is no more. Nor does a burnt seed perform the function of a sprout. Likewise, Mahāmati, those things, the aggregates, elements and sense sources, that have ceased, are ceasing and will cease, arise from the cause of seeing the conceptualizations that appear to one's own mind; therefore they do not arise in an unbroken continuum.

Mahāmati, if the three kinds of consciousness were to arise, out of what has not come to be or out of what exists, by virtue of the function of the condition that is the meeting of the three, then, Mahāmati, nonexistent things such as a tortoise's hair would arise, and sesame oil would come even from sand. Mahāmati, for those who assert arising from the existent and the nonexistent, their thesis collapses, they contradict what is certain, and action, karma and agent also become meaningless.

Mahāmati, they too, because they hold to the function of the condition that is the meeting of the three, teach cause and result and specific characteristics. They take the characteristics of existence and nonexistence to be present in what is past, future and presently arisen; and abiding on the ground imagined by their treatises, they teach under the influence of the habitual tendencies of their own wrong views. Thus, Mahāmati, ordinary childish beings, seized by wrong views and of uneven understanding, out of ignorance say of what they teach, "This was taught by the Omniscient One."

Mahāmati, certain śramaṇas or brahmins see things as without intrinsic nature, like clouds, a whirling firebrand, a city of gandharvas, the unborn, an

illusion, a mirage, the moon in water, and a dream; they see the conceptualization of what appears to the mind as external, and the proliferation of beginningless time. By so seeing, they will come to meditate upon the arising of their own mind: the appearance of their own mind, in which the conditions for conceptuality do not return; free from imagined expressions, from characteristics and the bases of characteristics, and from what is to be expressed; free from the all-base consciousness that appears as body, enjoyments and abode, from objects, and from apprehended and apprehender; the appearance-less domain; that which has abandoned arising, abiding and destruction. Mahāmati, those bodhisattva great beings will before long attain the sameness of saṃsāra and nirvāṇa.

Mahāmati, there are those whose practice has made great compassion and skill in means spontaneously present. They regard all the realms of sentient beings as equal to illusions and reflections, as not brought about by conditions, and as empty of outer and inner objects. Because they view nothing as lying outside the mind, they are endowed with the blessing of signlessness. They gradually enter the domain of samādhi of the successive grounds. By meditating thoroughly, with deep conviction that the three realms are an illusion of their own mind, they will attain the illusion-like samādhi.

By entering into the mere nonappearance of their own mind, the attainment of abiding in the perfection of wisdom arises. Bodhisattvas endowed with that activity will then attain the body of a Tathāgata. That body is like the vajra-form samādhi and accords with the body of the Tathāgata. It is endowed with the emanations of suchness, and adorned with the powers, the superknowledges, the masteries, loving-kindness, compassion and skillful means. It goes even to the abodes of the non-Buddhists (tīrthikas) in all buddha fields. It is free of mind, mentation and mental consciousness, and it is attained through the gradual transformation of the basis.

Therefore, Mahāmati, bodhisattva mahāsattvas who attain conformity with the body of the Tathāgata should follow mind-only. They should remain free of the proliferation of concepts about aggregates, elements and sense bases; about mind, causes, conditions and activity; and about arising, abiding and destruction.

They clearly see that the three existences arise from the habitual tendencies of the dysfunction of proliferation from beginningless time. Because they bring to mind the nonappearance and nonarising of the buddhas, they come to

understand the realization of the noble ones' Dharma, realized by each for oneself, and so they gain mastery over their own mind. Because they come to understand spontaneous conduct, they will put forth emanated forms, like a jewel of many colors, extremely subtle and adapted to the minds of sentient beings. And by entering into mind-only, they will firmly establish the links that join the successive grounds. Therefore, Mahāmati, bodhisattva mahāsattvas should become skilled in their own established tenets.

Then Mahāmati again made a request: "Blessed One, please explain the flower of the Dharma discourse, the heart of the teachings of all the buddhas. It concerns mind, mentation and consciousness, the five dharmas, and the characteristics of the natures, which the buddhas and bodhisattvas have followed. It frees one from the domain of what appears as one's own mind, and it demolishes the characteristics of assertion, reasoning and reality. For the sake of the bodhisattvas dwelling in the city of Laṅkā and on Malaya in the ocean, please explain the domain of the all-base consciousness, which is like the waves of the ocean, as the Dharma-body Tathāgata has proclaimed it."

Then the Blessed One spoke thus to the bodhisattva mahāsattva Mahāmati: "Mahāmati, eye consciousness arises through four causes. What are the four? They are these: not understanding that what is grasped is the appearance of one's own mind; clinging to the habitual tendencies of form produced by the dysfunction of proliferation from beginningless time; the intrinsic, essential nature of consciousness; and fascination with the characteristics of the various kinds of form. Mahāmati, through these four causes the waves of the engaging consciousnesses arise from the all-base consciousness, which is like a flowing river.

"Mahāmati, what holds for eye consciousness holds also for the atoms of all the sense faculties and for the pores of the skin. Forms of objects appear in a mirror all at once or one after another, and the ocean is stirred when struck by the wind. Just so, Mahāmati, the five groups of consciousness arise as waves on the ocean of mind, stirred by the wind of objects. They have the characteristic of the uninterrupted activity of causes. They are free from being either one or different. They do not understand the intrinsic, essential nature that is closely bound up with the characteristics of action and birth.

"Mahāmati, together with those five groups of consciousness there arises mental consciousness, which is called 'that which understands the characteristic of discriminating causes and objects.' It arises as a self produced

from them as its cause. Yet neither they nor it think, 'We arise together, each the cause of the other, through clinging to the conceptuality of what appears as our own mind.' Rather, they engage together in discriminating the objects of cognition, as mutually non-different.

"When they engage in this way, even yogins in meditative equipoise do not know how the habitual tendencies, moving with extreme subtlety, are operating. These yogins think, 'We enter absorption having stopped the consciousnesses.' But they enter absorption while consciousness has not ceased. It has not ceased because the seeds of the habitual tendencies have not ceased. It has ceased in the sense that there is no engaging with or grasping of objects.

"Mahāmati, the moving and engaging of the all-base consciousness is extremely subtle. Apart from the tathāgatas and the bodhisattvas well established on the grounds, it is not easy for others to understand it, for śrāvakas, pratyekabuddhas, and practitioners of the non-Buddhist yogas. They cannot readily realize it even by the power of samādhi and wisdom.

"Mahāmati, it is otherwise with yogins who are skilled in the characteristics of the grounds, in wisdom and in primordial wisdom. They have no doubt concerning the analysis of words, and they have accumulated limitless roots of virtue with the Victors. They are free of the proliferation of concepts about what appears as their own mind. They dwell in dense forests, in caves and in woodlands, and they practice superior, middling or lesser yoga. Such yogins are able to see the stream of their own mind's conceptuality as it appears. They are able to receive empowerment from the Victors of limitless fields, and to attain the masteries, the powers, the superknowledges and the samādhis."

Mahāmati, those who honor spiritual friends are able to cross the ocean of existence, the saṃsāra of conceptual thought. That ocean is the domain whose nature is the appearance of their own mind, namely mind, mentation and mental consciousness, and it arises from the causes of karma, craving and ignorance. Therefore, Mahāmati, the yogin should exert himself diligently in relying on spiritual friends.

Then, at that time, the Blessed One spoke these verses:

Just as the ocean's waves,
Arising through the condition of the wind,
Dance and surge forth,
And their stream is never cut off,

So too the flood of the ālaya, the storehouse,
Is constantly stirred by the wind of objects,
And the waves of the various consciousnesses
Dance and surge forth.

Blue and red, and salt,
Butter and milk and sugar,
Astringent fruits and flowers,
Just as the rays of sun and moon,
And the ocean's waves
Are known to be neither one nor different,
So too the seven consciousnesses
Are joined together with mind.

The transformation of the ocean
Is those various waves;
Just so, what is called consciousness:
From the ālaya the various arise.

Mind, mentation and consciousness
Are examined in terms of their characteristics;
The eight are not different in mark;
There is neither basis of characterization nor characteristic.

Just as the ocean and its waves
Are without distinction,
So too with mind and consciousness:
No transformation is to be found.

Mind accumulates karma;
Mentation too accumulates;
Through consciousness one cognizes;
The five conceive what appears.

"In forms of blue and red
The consciousness of human beings appears.
Why are the waves of like nature to mind?
Great Sage, please explain."

"Forms of blue and red
Do not exist in the waves;

For the sake of characteristics, to the childish,
The operation of mind is explained.
In it there is no operation;
One's own mind is free of anything grasped.
Where there is something grasped, there is a grasper too;
Thus it is shown to accord with the waves.
Like body, enjoyments and abode,
The consciousness of human beings appears;
Therefore its operation
Appears like the waves."

"If the ocean, in the form of waves,
Is perceived as dancing,
Then why is the operation of the ālaya
Not likewise perceived by the intellect?"

"Because the childish lack understanding,
The ālaya is like the ocean;
Because it accords with the nature of arising waves,
It is presented through an example."

"Just as for people good, bad and middling
The sun rises alike,
So you, lamp of the world,
Teach the truth to the foolish.
Since you abide fully in the Dharma,
Why do you not speak of suchness?"

"If I were to speak of suchness,
There is no suchness in the mind.
Just as the ocean's waves,
And just as a mirror and a dream,
Appear all at one time,
So too mind, in its own domain,
Since it is not joined with its objects all at once,
Arises operating in sequence.
Consciousness cognizes;
Mentation likewise conceives;
To the five, appearance is manifest;

In meditative equipoise there is no sequence.

Some master painter,
Or a painter's apprentice,
Lays out colors to make a picture;
This teaching too is like that.
There is no picture in the colors,
Nor likewise in the brush or in the dish;
For the sake of guiding beings
A picture is fashioned with colors.
In reality there are no letters;
Teachings are deceptive.
Having taken my stand among phenomena,
I teach reality to yogins.
The reality that is personally realized
Is wholly free of the imagined and of imagining.
This is taught to the heirs of the Victors;
It is not explained to the childish.
Just as various illusions
Appear yet do not exist,
So too, though teachings are various,
Teachings are deceptive.
What is taught to one
Is not fit to be explained to another;
Just as a physician gives
Medicines to each patient individually,
So the Buddha, to beings,
Also teaches mind only.
The domain of personal self-awareness
Of which the protectors speak
Is not the domain of those who conceptualize,
Nor likewise is it that of the śrāvakas."

Furthermore, Mahāmati, a bodhisattva who wishes to understand fully the domain of conceptual thought concerning grasped and grasper, which are appearances of his own mind, should be free of gatherings, bustle, sleep and obscurations. He should be diligent in the practice of not sleeping in the evening, at dawn and at midnight. He should keep apart from non-Buddhists

(tīrthikas), from bad treatises and idle talk, and from the characteristics of the vehicles of the śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas. The bodhisattva, the great being, should realize and thoroughly comprehend the characteristic of conceptualizing the appearances of his own mind.

Furthermore, Mahāmati, the bodhisattva, the great being, abiding in the establishment of the characteristics of mind, wisdom and gnosis, should strive in the three characteristics of superior noble gnosis. And what, Mahāmati, are the three characteristics of superior noble gnosis? They are these: the characteristic of non-appearance, the characteristic of the blessing of the own aspirations of all the buddhas, and the characteristic of noble personal gnosis. By comprehending these, the yogin abandons the characteristics of mind, wisdom and gnosis as one would a lame donkey, and, having attained the eighth ground of the heirs of the Victors, strives beyond that in the three characteristics.

Here, Mahāmati, the characteristic of the nonappearance of everything arises from thorough familiarity with the characteristics of the śrāvakas, the pratyekabuddhas, and the non-Buddhists (tīrthikas). Mahāmati, the characteristic of empowerment arises from the empowerment of the past buddhas' own aspirations. Mahāmati, the characteristic of noble wisdom individually realized by oneself arises from the movement of realization that comprehends the buddha ground. That realization comes from not clinging to any of the qualities of a buddha or to any characteristic, and from attaining the body of the illusion-like samādhi. Mahāmati, these are the three characteristics of the noble ones. When the noble ones are endowed with these three noble characteristics, they come to comprehend the domain of their own noble wisdom, individually realized. Therefore, Mahāmati, one should strive at these three characteristics of noble wisdom.

Then the bodhisattva, the great being Mahāmati, empowered by all the buddhas, understood the minds and the intentions of that assembly of bodhisattvas. He then asked the Blessed One (the Buddha) about the Dharma discourse called "Discerning the Reality of Noble Wisdom":

"Blessed One, please explain to me the Dharma discourse on the nature that discerns the reality of noble wisdom, the subject in which the hundred and eight statements are thoroughly distinguished. It is that in which the tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly complete buddhas abide. It teaches the bodhisattva great beings the method of distinguishing the realization of the

imagined nature that belongs to particular and general characteristics. Through thoroughly realizing the distinctions of that method, they thoroughly purify the movement of selflessness of persons and of phenomena and become skilled in the grounds. They pass beyond the bliss of the meditative concentration, samādhi, and absorption of all śrāvakas, pratyekabuddhas, and non-Buddhists. They enter the domain known by the Tathāgata, which is inconceivable and free from the five dharmas and from the realization of the natures. They come to attain the body of the Tathāgata: the Dharma body of the Tathāgata, intimately united with wisdom and gnosis, brought forth through an illusory domain, which goes to all the buddha fields, to the palace of Tuṣita, and to the abode of Akaniṣṭha."

The Blessed One said: "Mahāmati, there are some here who hold the views of non-Buddhists and cling to nonexistence. They think, 'Because the cause of conceptual mind has been exhausted, there is no intrinsic nature, and so there is no horn on a hare.' Just as the hare has no hare's horn, so too they conceive all phenomena.

"Moreover, Mahāmati, others see the distinctions among the elements, qualities, atoms, substances, shapes, and arrangements. Clinging and attached to the nonexistence of the hare's horn, they conceive, 'The cow's horn exists.'

"Mahāmati, those have fallen into the view of the two extremes, and their minds do not understand mind-only. They conceive by way of the element of their own mind. But, Mahāmati, with regard to body, possessions, abode, and destinies, which are mere conceptualization, the hare's horn, which is free from existence and nonexistence, should not be conceived. Likewise, Mahāmati, all things too are free from existence and nonexistence, and they should not be conceived.

"Mahāmati, some conceive of the hare's horn, which is free from existence and nonexistence, as nonexistent. Since these depend on one another as causes, one should not conceive, 'The hare's horn does not exist.' Mahāmati, when one analyzes down to the subtlest particle, no entity is found. Because it does not exist, the existence of a cow's horn, which lies outside the domain of noble wisdom, is not to be conceived."

Then the bodhisattva, the great being Mahāmati, said this to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, if, having seen the characteristic of the nonarising of conceptuality, one infers, then in dependence on the nonarising of

conceptuality one will say, 'It does not exist.'"

The Blessed One said: "Mahāmati, it is not that it does not exist in dependence on the nonarising of conceptuality. Why is that? Because it is the cause from which conceptuality arises. Mahāmati, conceptuality arises in dependence on its horn. Mahāmati, since conceptuality thus arises in dependence on the horn, it is a dependent cause. And because it is free from being either different or not different, it is not the case that the hare's horn does not exist in dependence on that.

"Mahāmati, if the hare's horn and conceptuality were different, conceptuality would not arise from the horn as its cause. If they are not different, then conceptuality arises from that cause. Yet when the horn is thoroughly analyzed down to the subtlest particle, it is not found. Since conceptuality is not different from the horn, it too would be nonexistent. If neither of the two is an entity, what would depend on what, and what would be held to be so? Mahāmati, if nonexistence does not come about through dependence, then because the causes do not correspond, one cannot conceive, in dependence on the existence of a cow's horn, 'The hare's horn does not exist.' Mahāmati, because the causes are unequal, the existence and nonexistence asserted by those who speak of existence and nonexistence are not established.

"Further, Mahāmati, there are those who hold the views of non-Buddhists, attached to form, cause, and shape, and clinging to them. Unskilled in thoroughly understanding the reality of space, they conceive with a view that distinguishes form as separate from the reality of space. Mahāmati, because space follows upon the arising of forms, space itself is form, and form itself is space. Mahāmati, the distinct kinds of cause of form and space should be understood as being related as what is supported and its support. Mahāmati, when the elements arise, they are distinct from one another through the particularity of their own characteristics, and they do not abide in space either. Yet in them too there is no space."

Mahāmati, in the same way, the horn of a hare is posited in relation to the horn of an ox. Yet if the ox's horn is analyzed into atoms, and the atoms too are broken down, so that it does not remain even in the characteristic of an atom, then in relation to what could the hare's horn be nonexistent? And if it were an entity posited in relation to something else, that too would be of just the same nature.

Then the Blessed One spoke these words to the bodhisattva, the great being Mahāmati: "Mahāmati, you and the other bodhisattvas should be free from the conceptuality that views the horns of the hare and the ox, space, and form. Mahāmati, you should also become one whose mind understands that conceptuality concerns the appearances of your own mind. Among all the children of the Victor and throughout all the maṇḍalas of buddha-fields, you should teach the yoga of the appearances of one's own mind."

Then, at that time, the Blessed One spoke these verses:

The manifold appearances do not exist;
from appearance, mind arises.
As if it were body, enjoyments, and abode,
the all-base appears to people.

Mind, mentation, and consciousness,
the natures and the five dharmas,
and the two selflessnesses, purified:
these the Guide proclaims.

From mutual relation
arise long and short and the rest.
Existence establishes nonexistence,
and nonexistence establishes existence.

Break matter down into atoms,
and form is not to be imagined.
The establishing of mind-only
is not made clear by those with wrong views.

What the protectors teach
is the domain of individual self-awareness.
It is not the domain of the conceptual-minded,
nor is it that of the śrāvakas.

Then the bodhisattva, the great being Mahāmati, again made a request to the Blessed One, for the sake of purifying the continuum of the appearances of one's own mind: "Blessed One, how is the continuum of the appearances of one's own mind purified? Is it all at once, or by gradual entry?"

The Blessed One said: "Mahāmati, the continuum of the appearances of one's own mind is purified by gradual entry, not all at once. Mahāmati, it is like this: the fruit of the mango tree ripens gradually, not all at once. Mahāmati, in the

same way, the continuum of the appearances of beings' own minds is purified gradually, not all at once. Mahāmati, it is like this: a potter makes vessels gradually, not all at once. Mahāmati, in the same way, the Tathāgata purifies the continuum of the appearances of beings' own minds gradually, not all at once. Mahāmati, it is like this: from the great earth, grasses, shrubs, medicinal herbs, and forests grow by gradual entry, not all at once. In the same way, Mahāmati, the Tathāgata purifies the continuum of the appearances of beings' own minds gradually, not all at once. Mahāmati, it is like this: skill in comedy, music, song, the lute, cymbals, and painting comes about gradually, not all at once. In the same way, Mahāmati, the Tathāgata purifies the continuum of the appearances of all beings' own minds gradually, not all at once.

"Mahāmati, it is like this: in a mirror, all the reflections of forms appear all at once, without conceptuality. In the same way, Mahāmati, the Tathāgata purifies all at once the continuum of the appearances of all beings' own minds, domains that are free of conceptuality and without appearance. Mahāmati, it is like this: the orbs of the moon and the sun, with their rays, make manifest all at once everything that appears as form. In the same way, Mahāmati, to beings who are free from the habitual tendencies of the dysfunction belonging to the appearances of their own minds, the Tathāgata truly reveals all at once the domain of the inconceivable wisdom of the Victors, and its sphere of activity. Mahāmati, it is like this: the all-base consciousness displays all at once the body, the abode, and the objects of enjoyment that are the appearances of one's own mind. In the same way, Mahāmati, the buddha of natural outflow (niṣyanda) also ripens all at once the spheres of beings and establishes them as yogins of the yoga of the abode of the palace and the celestial mansion of Akaniṣṭha. Mahāmati, it is like this: the buddha of the nature of reality (dharmatā) shines all at once with the rays of the buddha of natural outflow and of the emanation. In the same way, Mahāmati, the characteristic of the Dharma realized by the individual self-awareness of the noble ones also shines all at once, by turning back the wrong views of existence and nonexistence.

"Furthermore, Mahāmati, the buddha who flows forth in accordance with the nature of reality teaches that, because the attachment to the manifold things that are not the true nature of that illusory person with its many kinds of illusory limbs is not to be found, all phenomena included within particular and general characteristics arise from the cause, namely attachment to the imputed nature, which is bound up with the causal characteristic of the

habitual tendencies of the appearances of one's own mind.

"Furthermore, Mahāmati, the characteristic of the arising of the imputed nature comes from attachment to the dependent nature. Mahāmati, it is like this: relying on grass, wood, and pebbles, by means of an illusion spell together with a person who wields it, there appears the form of an illusory person, complete with the limbs of the forms of all beings and bearing manifold forms, a body of a being not established as a single nature, imagined through manifold kinds of conceptuality. Mahāmati, although it appears in that way, it is not of that nature. In the same way, Mahāmati, in the dependent nature, the imputed nature appears as the characteristics of the many and manifold kinds of conceptualizing mind. Mahāmati, through imagining the habitual tendencies of attachment to things as having the characteristic of imagination, it becomes the characteristic of the imputed nature. Mahāmati, this is the teaching of the buddha of natural outflow."

Mahāmati, the buddha of the nature of reality establishes the domain of the noble ones' individual self-realization, which is free from the characteristics of the intrinsic nature of mind. Mahāmati, the buddhas emanated by magical transformation set forth the course of generosity, meditative concentration, moral discipline, meditative absorption, mind, wisdom, gnosis, the aggregates, the elements, the sense sources, the liberations, and the analyzed characteristics of the functioning of consciousness. They also teach the characteristics of the stages of formless absorption, which go beyond the views of the non-Buddhists (tīrthikas). Mahāmati, the buddha of the nature of reality is without an object and free from any object. It has turned away from all the characteristics of activity, of the faculties, and of valid cognition. It is taught as not being the domain of fools, of śrāvakas, of pratyekabuddhas, or of non-Buddhists, who cling because they are attached to the characteristic of a self. Therefore, Mahāmati, one should strive for the distinctive characteristic of the noble ones' individual self-realization. You must regard even the appearance of the characteristics of your own mind as something to be turned away from.

Furthermore, Mahāmati, the characteristics that distinguish the approach of the Śrāvaka Vehicle are of two kinds, namely the distinctive characteristic of the noble ones' individual self-realization, and the characteristic of clinging to an intrinsic nature conceptualized as entities.

Mahāmati, what, then, is the śrāvakas' distinctive characteristic of the noble ones' individual self-realization? It is this. Through weariness with the pleasure of objects that are empty, selfless, suffering, and impermanent, and through the cutting off of the continuum, and by fully knowing, just as it truly is, the characteristic of the non-destruction of the aggregates, the elements, the sense sources, and the external in their individual and general characteristics, they place the mind in equipoise. Mahāmati, having placed their own minds in equipoise, the śrāvakas come to realize fully the meditative concentrations, the liberations, the meditative absorptions, the paths, the fruits, the meditative attainments, release, and the abiding in the bliss of the noble ones' individual self-realization, in which inconceivable habitual tendencies are transformed and which is free from death and transmigration. Mahāmati, this is the śrāvakas' characteristic of the noble ones' individual self-realization.

Mahāmati, having understood the bliss of the abode of the śrāvakas' noble individual self-realization, the bodhisattva mahāsattva, because of having long regarded sentient beings with compassion and in order to fulfill the aspirations made in the past, should not actualize the bliss of the gateway of cessation or the bliss of meditative equipoise. Mahāmati, this is the bliss of the śrāvakas' characteristic of noble individual self-realization, and the bodhisattva should not train in that bliss of the characteristic of noble individual self-realization.

Again, Mahāmati, what is the śrāvakas' clinging to an intrinsic nature conceptualized as entities? It is this. Having seen that the great elements, blue, yellow, warmth, moisture, motion, and solidity, arise without a maker, and having seen individual and general characteristics, reasoning, scripture, and valid cognition as closely connected, there arises a conceptuality that clings to their intrinsic nature. Mahāmati, the bodhisattva, having understood this, should reverse it. By entering into the characteristic of the selflessness of phenomena, one turns back the view of the characteristic of the selflessness of persons, and should abide in the progressive linking of the stages of the grounds. Mahāmati, this is the explanation of what was spoken of as the śrāvakas' characteristic of clinging to an intrinsic nature conceptualized as entities.

Then the bodhisattva mahāsattva Mahāmati said this to the Blessed One: "The Blessed One has spoken of the domain of the noble ones' individual self-realization as ultimate, permanent, and inconceivable. Blessed One, in just the same way there are also non-Buddhists who say that causes are permanent and inconceivable."

The Blessed One said, "Mahāmati, the cause of the non-Buddhists does not attain permanence and inconceivability. Why is that? Mahāmati, the permanence and inconceivability of the non-Buddhists are not endowed with the own-characteristic of a cause. Mahāmati, as for one whose permanence and inconceivability are not endowed with the own-characteristic of a cause, by what and in what way could it be shown to be called permanent and inconceivable? Mahāmati, if the doctrine of permanence and inconceivability were endowed with the own-characteristic of a cause, then, since it would have the characteristic of a cause that depends on causes, it would become impermanent; it would not be permanent and inconceivable.

"Mahāmati, my ultimate permanence and inconceivability is endowed with the characteristic of an ultimate cause and is free from existence and nonexistence. It is endowed with a characteristic because it has the characteristic of the noble ones' individual self-realization. It is endowed with a cause because ultimate gnosis has become its cause. Being free from existence and nonexistence, it is permanent, because its qualities resemble the examples of unconditioned space, nirvāṇa, and cessation. Therefore, Mahāmati, this is not in accord with the non-Buddhists' doctrine of permanence and inconceivability.

"Mahāmati, this permanence and inconceivability is the suchness to be realized by the Tathāgatas' noble individual self-gnosis. Therefore, Mahāmati, the bodhisattva mahāsattva should strive in order to understand permanence and inconceivability through noble individual self-gnosis.

"Furthermore, Mahāmati, the permanence and inconceivability of the non-Buddhists are impermanent, because they have arisen from a cause that has the characteristic of impermanence, of nonexistent things. They are not permanent, because they are brought forth by the characteristic of a cause that they themselves have fabricated."

Mahāmati, suppose the permanence and inconceivability of the non-Buddhists (tīrthikas) were held to be permanent through inference, by seeing permanence in the absence of produced things. Then, Mahāmati, by this very reason my own as well, seen as permanent in the absence of produced things, would be permanent because it is taught as being without a cause.

Mahāmati, suppose the permanence and inconceivability of the tīrthikas were something endowed with a cause and a characteristic. Then, since its cause and its own characteristic do not exist, Mahāmati, that permanence and

inconceivability would be like the horn of a hare. Mahāmati, for the tīrthikas it becomes mere verbal conceptualization. Why is that? Because, Mahāmati, the horn of a hare, lacking its own cause and characteristic, is mere verbal conceptualization.

Mahāmati, my permanence and inconceivability is permanent because its cause is the characteristic of the noble ones' individual self-realization, and because it is free from the produced, from things and from non-things. It is not permanent through inference from the absence of external things or from permanence.

Mahāmati, those who hold to permanence because the external does not exist, and to inconceivability by inference from permanence, do not know the cause and the characteristic proper to permanence and inconceivability. Mahāmati, they stand outside the domain realized by the noble ones' individual self-wisdom, and they are not fit to be spoken of.

Moreover, Mahāmati, those who do not know the difference between saṃsāra and nirvāṇa, terrified by the fear that comes from conceptualizing the suffering of saṃsāra, seek nirvāṇa. Mahāmati, they imagine that nirvāṇa is attained through the absence of all conceptualization about things and through the cutting off of the future objects of the sense faculties. Mahāmati, they do not place first the wisdom of individual self-awareness that has become the all-base. Therefore, Mahāmati, those foolish people speak of three vehicles; they do not speak of the non-appearance of conceptualization as mind-only. Mahāmati, in this way they do not recognize the domain of the Tathāgatas of the past, the future and the present, the domain of what appears as one's own mind. Mahāmati, those who cling to external appearances as the domain of mind revolve on the wheel of the destinies of saṃsāra.

Moreover, Mahāmati, the Tathāgatas of the past, the future and the present teach that all phenomena are unborn. Why is that? Because, Mahāmati, what appears as one's own mind is not a thing, and there is no arising from existence or from nonexistence; therefore all things are unborn. Mahāmati, all phenomena are like the horns of a hare, a horse, a donkey or a camel. Mahāmati, all things are unborn, because childish ordinary beings conceive of them as having a falsely imagined nature. Mahāmati, the arising of the characteristic of the intrinsic nature of all things is the domain of the wisdom of the noble ones' individual self-awareness; it is not of the nature of the

domain of the dualistic conceptualization of the childish.

Mahāmati, the all-base consciousness, whose characteristic is the nature of the forms of body, enjoyments and abode, operates with the characteristics of grasped and grasper. With regard to it, the childish, whose minds have fallen into the duality of views of arising, abiding and perishing, imagine that all things arise from existence and nonexistence. Mahāmati, you should exert yourself in this.

Moreover, Mahāmati, there are five lineages of realization. What are the five? They are the lineage of realization of the śrāvaka vehicle, the lineage of realization of the pratyekabuddha vehicle, the lineage of realization of the Tathāgata vehicle, the lineage that is not fixed in any of them, and those without a lineage: these five.

Mahāmati, how is the lineage of realization of the śrāvaka vehicle to be recognized? When the teaching that brings understanding through thorough knowledge of the aggregates, the elements, the sense sources, and their specific and general characteristics is taught, the hair of such a person's body stands on end, and his mind enters into the knowledge that makes him thoroughly familiar with characteristics, but not into thorough familiarity with the characteristic of non-difference from dependent origination. This, Mahāmati, is the lineage of realization of the śrāvaka vehicle. Through the view of realization of the śrāvaka vehicle, having abandoned the manifest afflictions on the sixth and fifth grounds, though not having abandoned the afflictions of habitual tendencies, and being subject to inconceivable death and transmigration, they truly roar the lion's roar: "My births are exhausted, I have lived the holy life, what was to be done is done." Saying this and the like, they come to have an understanding that extends from familiarity with the selflessness of the person up to nirvāṇa.

Mahāmati, others seek nirvāṇa by understanding that a self, a sentient being, a life, a nourisher, a man and a person exist. Mahāmati, still others, seeing all things as dependent on causes, come to have the thought of desiring nirvāṇa. Mahāmati, because they do not see the selflessness of phenomena, there is no liberation for them. Mahāmati, this is the one of the lineage of realization of the śrāvaka vehicle, and of the tīrthikas, who has the idea of deliverance where there is no deliverance. Mahāmati, you should strive in this in order to turn back wrong views.

Mahāmati, as for those of the lineage that will realize the vehicle of the pratyekabuddhas: when realization in solitude is taught, they shed tears, their hearts thrill, and the hair on their bodies stands on end. Through the condition of non-association they become attached to things. When the miracle of displaying their own bodies' many and various magical powers, and the twin miracle, are explained, they are delighted. Knowing them to be of the lineage that will realize the vehicle of the pratyekabuddhas, one should give them talk that accords with realizing the vehicle of the pratyekabuddhas. Mahāmati, this is the characteristic of those of the lineage that will realize the vehicle of the pratyekabuddhas.

Mahāmati, the lineage that will realize the vehicle of the Tathāgata is of three kinds: the lineage that will realize the dharma that is devoid of intrinsic nature, the lineage that will realize one's own individual inner attainment, and the lineage that will realize the vast external buddha fields. Mahāmati, when any one of these three is taught, or when the inconceivable domain of body, ālaya, enjoyments and abode, which are appearances of one's own mind, is taught, if one is not afraid, not frightened, and does not become terrified, that one should be known as being of the lineage that will realize the vehicle of the Tathāgata. Mahāmati, this is the characteristic of those of the lineage that will realize the vehicle of the Tathāgata.

Mahāmati, those of undetermined lineage should be guided toward whichever of these three they delight in when these three are taught. Mahāmati, this establishing of the lineages is a ground of purification; it is to be established in order that they may enter the ground of non-appearance. Once the habitual tendencies of their own afflictions in their own individual ālaya have been purified, because they see the selflessness of phenomena, they attain dwelling in the bliss of samādhi, and then the śrāvakas too will fully attain the very embodiment of the Victor's body.

Then the Blessed One spoke these verses:

The fruit of stream-entry,
and likewise that of once-returning,
the fruit of non-returning,
and arhatship as well, are confusions of the mind.

To childish ones of feeble intellect
I speak of three vehicles, of one vehicle,
and even of no vehicle;

for the noble ones there is solitude alone.

The abandonment of the two kinds of cognizance
is the gateway to the ultimate meaning.
Where could the establishing of three vehicles
exist for one who dwells in non-appearance?

The meditative concentrations, the immeasurables,
the formless states and samādhi,
and the cessation of perception, without exception,
do not exist in mind-only.

Mahāmati, how does the icchantikas' not desiring liberation come about? It is through abandoning all roots of virtue, and through making aspirations for the sake of all sentient beings since beginningless time.

What is abandoning all roots of virtue? It is rejecting and denigrating the Bodhisattva Piṭaka by saying, "These are not sūtras and Vinaya that accord with liberation." Because they have abandoned all roots of virtue, they do not pass into nirvāṇa.

Mahāmati, in the second case, the bodhisattva great being has previously made, with regard to existence, the aspiration "Until all sentient beings have passed into parinirvāṇa, I too shall not pass into nirvāṇa," along with skillful means; for that reason he does not pass into nirvāṇa. Mahāmati, this is the specific characteristic of those whose nature is not to pass into parinirvāṇa; by it they come to take up the way of the icchantikas.

Mahāmati asked again, "Blessed One, which of these never passes into nirvāṇa at all?"

The Blessed One said, "Mahāmati, it is the bodhisattva icchantika who, knowing all phenomena to be in nirvāṇa from the very beginning, never passes into nirvāṇa at all; it is not the icchantika who abandons all roots of virtue. Mahāmati, even the icchantika who abandons all roots of virtue may at some time, through the blessing of the tathāgatas, purify the roots of virtue. Why is that? Mahāmati, because the tathāgatas never forsake any sentient being. Mahāmati, it is for this reason that the bodhisattva icchantikas do not pass into parinirvāṇa.

"Furthermore, Mahāmati, the bodhisattva great being should become skilled in the three characteristics of intrinsic nature. Mahāmati, the imputed nature

arises from signs. Mahāmati, how does the imputed nature arise from signs? Mahāmati, the dependent nature appears as though it had the characteristic of the signs of things. Mahāmati, attachment to the characteristic of the signs of things is established by the tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly complete buddhas, as the imputed nature in two forms: the characteristic of attachment to names, and the characteristic of attachment to the signs of things. Mahāmati, the characteristic of attachment to the signs of things is attachment to inner and outer phenomena. Mahāmati, attachment to the characteristic of signs is the full knowing and comprehending of the specific and general characteristics of those very inner and outer phenomena. Mahāmati, that is the twofold characteristic of the imputed nature. That which arises from the basis and object of this is the dependent.

"Mahāmati, what then is the perfected nature? It is suchness, free from conceptualization of signs, names and the characteristics of things, the domain of the noble ones' wisdom of individual self-awareness, reached by attaining the realization of noble wisdom. Mahāmati, this perfected nature is the very heart essence of the tathāgatas."

Then at that time the Blessed One spoke this verse:

"Names, signs, and conceptual thought
Are the characteristic of the two natures;
Right knowledge and suchness
Are the characteristic of the perfected."

Mahāmati, this Dharma discourse called "The Analysis of the Characteristics of the Intrinsic Nature of the Five Dharmas" is the domain of the noble wisdom realized individually within oneself. You and the other bodhisattvas should train in it.

Furthermore, Mahāmati, the bodhisattva mahāsattva should become skilled in analyzing the knowledge of the characteristics of the two kinds of selflessness. Mahāmati, what are the characteristics of the two kinds of selflessness? Because of clinging to the grasping of name, form and so forth, consciousness arises from all the faculties. That is to say, it cognizes the aggregates, elements and sense sources that arise from ignorance, karma and craving, which are without self and without anything belonging to a self, and which one's own mind has imagined as the vessel of the world, the body and the abode, though they are only appearances of one's own mind. Like a river, a seed, a lamp, the wind and clouds, it is distinct from one moment to the next

and so is ever separate; restless like monkeys and flies; it roams among impure objects; it is without protector; like fire it is never satisfied; it arises from the cause of the habitual tendencies toward the objects of proliferation from beginningless time. Like the wheel of a waterwheel device, it turns in the wheel of the destinies of saṃsāric existence, and bearing the forms of bodies of many different kinds, it enters and arises like an illusion, a vetāla, or a mechanical puppet. Mahāmati, the knowledge that is skilled in this characteristic is called the knowledge of the selflessness of persons.

Mahāmati, what then is the knowledge of the selflessness of phenomena? It is the realization of the nature of the imputed characteristic of the aggregates, elements and sense sources. Mahāmati, just as the aggregates, elements and sense sources are devoid of a self and the like, being merely a heap of aggregates bound together by the thread of the cause, karma and craving, and arise without any mover through serving as conditions for one another, likewise, Mahāmati, the aggregates are also devoid of particular and general characteristics. Childish beings conceptualize them as differentiated by the conceptuality of unreal imputed characteristics, but the noble ones do not. Mahāmati, the bodhisattva mahāsattva who meditates on all phenomena as devoid of mind, mentation and consciousness, of the five dharmas and of the natures, is skilled in the selflessness of phenomena.

Mahāmati, the bodhisattva mahāsattva who is skilled in the selflessness of phenomena, because he fully realizes the absence of appearances, before long attains the first ground of a bodhisattva. Because he understands the analysis of the characteristics of the grounds, after the Joyous ground he becomes skilled in the nine grounds as well, and attains the Cloud of Dharma. Abiding there, he is accomplished through discerning the domain of the illusion-like nature, and in a great celestial palace like a lotus he sits upon a great king of precious lotuses, richly adorned with many jewels and pearls. Surrounded by children of the Victor who are of like kind, he is consecrated by the empowerment of the hands of the buddhas who come from all the buddhafields, like the son of a universal monarch. Passing beyond the ground of the children of the Buddha, because he understands the Dharma realized individually by the noble ones, through seeing the selflessness of phenomena he becomes a Tathāgata who possesses the Dharma body. Mahāmati, this is the characteristic of the selflessness of phenomena itself. Mahāmati, you and the other bodhisattvas should train in it.

The Noble Descent into Laṅkā, the third fascicle.

Then once again the bodhisattva mahāsattva Mahāmati addressed the Blessed One, saying: "Blessed One, please explain to me the characteristics of superimposition and denial, so that I and the other bodhisattvas, with minds that have cast off the bad views of superimposition and denial, may swiftly and fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening, and having fully awakened, may cast off the views of permanence, superimposition, denial and annihilation, and so never disparage your way of the buddhas."

Then the Blessed One, perceiving that the bodhisattva mahāsattva Mahāmati had made his request once more, spoke these verses:

"Superimposition and denial
Do not exist in mind-only.
Those who do not know the mind
That appears as body, enjoyments and abode,
Unskilled, are fully engaged
In superimposition and denial."

Then, in order to show the meaning of these very verses, the Blessed One further declared: "Mahāmati, superimposition of what does not exist is of four kinds. What are the four? They are superimposing a nonexistent characteristic, superimposing a nonexistent view, superimposing a nonexistent cause, and superimposing a nonexistent entity. Mahāmati, these are the four kinds of superimposition.

Mahāmati, what is denial? It is this: when this very bad view of superimposition is not found, then, for lack of discernment, it turns into denial. Mahāmati, these are the characteristics of superimposition and denial.

Furthermore, Mahāmati, what is the characteristic of superimposing a nonexistent characteristic? It is clinging to the particular and general characteristics of the aggregates, elements and sense sources, thinking, 'This is just so, and not otherwise.' Mahāmati, this is the characteristic of superimposing a nonexistent characteristic. Mahāmati, this conceptuality that superimposes a nonexistent characteristic arises from clinging to the various habitual tendencies of the dysfunction of proliferation from beginningless time. Mahāmati, this is the characteristic of superimposing a nonexistent characteristic.

Mahāmati, superimposing a nonexistent view is superimposing on those very aggregates, elements and sense sources the bad view of a self, a sentient being, a life, a nourisher, a man, or a person. Mahāmati, this is called superimposing a nonexistent view."

Mahāmati, superimposing a nonexistent cause is this. A consciousness that was not previously born from a cause later arises, like an illusion, out of what had not come into being before and did not exist, from the eye, form, light as a cause, and mindfulness going before. Having arisen from the nonexistent, it then perishes again. Mahāmati, this is superimposing a nonexistent cause.

Mahāmati, superimposing a nonexistent entity is this: clinging to space, cessation, and nirvāṇa as unconditioned entities, and superimposing them as such. Mahāmati, all these phenomena are beyond entity and non-entity. Like the horns of a hare, a horse, a donkey, or a camel, or like a tangled net of hairs, they are free from the positions of existence and nonexistence. Mahāmati, it is fools, whose minds do not understand that all this is merely the appearance of their own mind, who conceive in terms of superimposition and denial; the noble ones do not. This, Mahāmati, is the characteristic of superimposition and denial that comes from conceiving what is not an entity. Therefore, Mahāmati, one should be free from the views of superimposition and denial.

Furthermore, Mahāmati, bodhisattvas, having realized and fully comprehended the characteristics of mind, mentation, and mental consciousness, of the five dharmas, of the natures, and of the twofold selflessness, take on forms and guises for the benefit of others. Just as the imputed nature rests upon the dependent nature, they are like a wish-fulfilling jewel that takes on all kinds of forms. They go into the maṇḍalas of all the buddha fields, and there, in the presence of all the tathāgatas, they hear directly the teachings of the Dharma: teachings that phenomena are like a dream, an illusion, a mirage, a reflection, and the moon in water, free from all arising and perishing, permanence and annihilation, and teachings that are free from the vehicles of all the śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas. They attain a hundred thousand samādhis, and go on to attain as many as a hundred thousand koṭis of niyutas of samādhis. Having attained them, devoted to worshipping the buddhas, they travel by means of those samādhis from field to field. In every birth, in the palaces of the gods, and in every abode, they correctly teach the Three Jewels. Taking the form of a buddha and surrounded by assemblies of śrāvakas and bodhisattvas, in order to turn beings back from

the positions of existence and nonexistence, they lead them into the mere appearance of their own mind and so show that external entities do not exist.

Then, on that occasion, the Blessed One spoke this verse:

When the Victor's children clearly see
The world as nothing but mind,
Then a body that is an assembly,
Fashioned, yet free of all activity,
Endowed with powers, superknowledges and mastery,
Is what they come to attain.

Then once again the bodhisattva mahāsattva Mahāmati made a request to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, please explain to me the characteristics of emptiness, non-arising, nonduality, and the absence of intrinsic nature in all phenomena, by realizing which I and other bodhisattvas will completely abandon conceiving of existence and nonexistence, and will swiftly and fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening."

Then the Blessed One spoke these words to the bodhisattva mahāsattva Mahāmati: "Mahāmati, then listen very well and keep it in mind, and I shall explain it to you."

"Excellent, Blessed One," said the bodhisattva mahāsattva Mahāmati, and he listened to the Blessed One.

The Blessed One said to him: "Mahāmati, this saying 'emptiness, emptiness' is a word of the imputed nature. Mahāmati, it is through clinging to the imputed nature that people speak of emptiness, non-arising, the absence of entities, nonduality, and the absence of intrinsic nature as though they were entities.

"Mahāmati, in brief, emptiness is of seven kinds, namely: the emptiness of characteristics, the emptiness of the intrinsic nature of entities, the emptiness of becoming, the emptiness of non-becoming, the emptiness of the inexpressibility of all phenomena, the great emptiness of the ultimate wisdom of the noble ones, and the emptiness of each of the other. These are the seven.

"Mahāmati, what is the emptiness of characteristics? It is this: all entities are empty of individual and general characteristics. Mahāmati, because in combinations there is no mutual dependence and no distinction to be analyzed, there is no entering into individual and general characteristics. Mahāmati, because self, other, and both do not exist, characteristics do not

abide; therefore all entities are said to be empty of characteristics.

"Mahāmati, what is the emptiness of the intrinsic nature of entities? It is this: Mahāmati, because entities do not arise by their own intrinsic nature, all phenomena are empty of the intrinsic nature of entities. Therefore it is called the emptiness of the intrinsic nature of entities.

"Mahāmati, what is the emptiness of becoming? It is this: the aggregates are devoid of a self and of what belongs to a self, and they are born and arise from cause, reasoning, agency, karma, and the full presence of conditions. Therefore it is called the emptiness of becoming.

"Mahāmati, what is the emptiness of non-becoming? It is this: in the aggregates, nirvāṇa has never come to be from the very beginning. Therefore it is called the emptiness of non-becoming.

"Mahāmati, what is the emptiness of the inexpressible? It is this: because the imputed nature is inexpressible, all phenomena are empty in being inexpressible. Therefore it is called the emptiness of the inexpressible.

Mahāmati, what is the great emptiness of the ultimate noble wisdom? It is this: the realization of my own individual noble wisdom is empty of views and of all the habitual tendencies of faults. Therefore it is called the great emptiness of the ultimate noble wisdom.

Mahāmati, what is mutual emptiness? It is this: where something is not, that place is called empty of it. For example, Mahāmati, I have explained that in the mansion of Mṛgāramātā there are no elephants, cattle, sheep and so on, but that it is not empty of monks, nuns and so on. It is called empty of those animals. Yet, Mahāmati, the mansion is not without the being of a mansion, nor are the monks without the nature of monks, nor is it the case that those things, the elephants, cattle, sheep and so on, do not abide somewhere else. Mahāmati, in the same way, the particular and general characteristics of all phenomena are not found in one another. Therefore it is called mutual emptiness.

Mahāmati, these are the seven kinds of emptiness. Mahāmati, this mutual emptiness is the lowest of them all, and you should abandon it completely.

Mahāmati, a thing does not arise of itself, nor does it arise outside the state of meditative absorption, and yet it is not non-arising either. Therefore, with reference to the unborn, to the absence of intrinsic nature, and to what is untenable, it is said that all things lack intrinsic nature. Mahāmati, because the

momentary series has no continuity, and because things appear to change into something else, all phenomena lack intrinsic nature. Therefore it is said that all things lack intrinsic nature.

Mahāmati, what is the characteristic of nonduality? It is this: things divided into two, such as shade and sunlight, long and short, or black and white, are not separate and distinct from one another. Mahāmati, in the same way, all phenomena are nondual, like saṃsāra and nirvāṇa. Mahāmati, this is because there is a cause of distinct characteristics. Where nirvāṇa is, there saṃsāra is not; and where saṃsāra is, there too nirvāṇa is not. Therefore it is said that all phenomena are nondual, like saṃsāra and nirvāṇa. Therefore, Mahāmati, you should apply yourself to the characteristics of emptiness, non-arising, nonduality and the lack of intrinsic nature.

Then, at that time, the Blessed One (the Buddha) spoke these verses:

Though I always teach that saṃsāra is like a dream and an illusion,
And teach emptiness, which abandons permanence and annihilation,
Even so,
Karma does not perish.

Nirvāṇa and space,
And the two cessations as well,
The childish imagine as uncompounded;
The noble see them as free of existence and nonexistence.

Then again the Blessed One said this to the bodhisattva, the great being Mahāmati: Mahāmati, this characteristic of emptiness, non-arising, nonduality and the lack of intrinsic nature is contained within the sūtras of all the buddhas. Whatever sūtra it may be, in all of them this very meaning should be understood. Mahāmati, a sūtra taught in accordance with the dispositions of all sentient beings is misleading in its meaning; it is not a discourse that establishes reality. Mahāmati, it is like a mirage that deceives deer: it makes them fixate on it by fixating on it as water, yet there is no water in it. Mahāmati, in the same way, all the teachings set out in the sūtras serve to gratify the childish in their own conceptual thought; they are not discourses that present noble wisdom. Therefore, Mahāmati, you should follow the meaning and not become attached to the expression of the teaching.

Then the bodhisattva, the great being Mahāmati, said this to the Blessed One: In the course of the sūtras, the Blessed One has taught the tathāgatagarbha. The Blessed One describes it as naturally luminous and pure, and thus pure

from the very beginning, endowed with the thirty-two major marks, and present within the bodies of all sentient beings. The Blessed One says that, like a precious jewel of great value wrapped in a soiled cloth, it is wrapped in the cloth of the aggregates, the elements and the sense sources, overwhelmed by attachment, aversion and delusion, and stained by the stain of conceptualization, and yet it is permanent, stable and everlasting. If so, Blessed One, how is this teaching of the tathāgatagarbha not like the self-doctrine of the non-Buddhists (tīrthikas)? Blessed One, the non-Buddhists too teach a doctrine of the self, saying, "It is permanent, not an agent, without qualities, all-pervading and imperishable."

The Blessed One said: Mahāmati, my teaching of the tathāgatagarbha is not the same as the self-doctrine of the non-Buddhists. Mahāmati, the Tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly complete buddhas, teach the meanings of such words as emptiness, the limit of reality, nirvāṇa, the unborn, the signless and the wishless as the tathāgatagarbha. Then, so that the childish may avoid the state of being terrified by selflessness, they teach, through the doorway of the tathāgatagarbha, the nonconceptual state, the domain free of appearances. Mahāmati, bodhisattva great beings of the future and the present should not cling to this as a self.

Mahāmati, it is like a potter who, from a single mass of clay particles, makes vessels of many different kinds with his hands, his craft, a rod, water, string and diligent effort.

Mahāmati, in the same way the tathāgatas also teach that very selflessness of phenomena, which is the turning away from all the characteristics of conceptual thought. They do so with many kinds of wisdom and skill in means, whether by teaching it as the tathāgatagarbha or by teaching it as selflessness. Like the potter, they teach with many kinds of words and many forms of expression. Thus, for that reason, Mahāmati, the teaching of the tathāgatagarbha is not like the teaching of the non-Buddhists (tīrthikas) who proclaim a self.

Mahāmati, the tathāgatas teach the tathāgatagarbha in order to draw in the non-Buddhists who cling to proclaiming a self. One may ask how those whose minds have fallen into the view that imagines a false self might come to have minds that abide in the sphere of the three gateways to liberation, and how they might quickly awaken to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening. Mahāmati, it is for that purpose that the tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly

complete buddhas, teach the tathāgatagarbha. Therefore this is not the same as the non-Buddhists' proclamation of a self. Mahāmati, therefore, in order to reverse the views of the non-Buddhists, one should follow the tathāgatagarbha in accordance with selflessness.

Then, at that time, the Blessed One spoke these verses:

The person, the continuum, the aggregates,
likewise conditions and atoms,
the Principal, the Lord, the Creator:
these are imagined in what is mind alone.

Then the bodhisattva, the great being Mahāmati, looking toward the multitude of people of the future, again made a request to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, please explain to me the realization of yoga by which bodhisattva great beings become yogins of the great yoga."

The Blessed One declared: "Mahāmati, bodhisattva great beings who possess four qualities become yogins of the great yoga. If you ask what the four are, they are these: contemplating appearances as one's own mind; abandoning the views of arising, abiding and perishing; realizing that external things are without existence; and aspiring to realize the personal wisdom of the noble ones. Mahāmati, bodhisattva great beings who possess these four qualities become yogins of the great yoga.

"Mahāmati, how is a bodhisattva great being skilled in contemplating appearances as his own mind? He reflects in this way: 'These three realms are only my own mind. They are free of self and what belongs to a self, unmoving, and free of taking up and casting away. They are imbued with clinging to the habitual tendencies of the corrupting dispositions of conceptual proliferation from beginningless time. They are bound up with the experience of the many kinds of forms of the three realms. They appear as bodies, possessions, abodes and destinies, following conceptual thought.' Mahāmati, in this way a bodhisattva great being is skilled in contemplating appearances as his own mind.

"Mahāmati, how does a bodhisattva great being abandon the views of arising, abiding and perishing? It is like this. All things are like an illusion, like forms arising in a dream. Because they do not come from self, from other, or from both, they do not arise. By following mere appearances of his own mind, and seeing that external things do not exist, the consciousnesses no longer engage. He sees that conditions too are not heaped up or accumulated, and

he sees that the three realms arise from the condition of conceptual thought. Because he does not apprehend any inner or outer phenomena and sees that they lack intrinsic nature, the view of arising turns away. Realizing that phenomena have the nature of an illusion and so forth, he attains forbearance toward the non-arising of phenomena. Abiding on the eighth ground, he comprehends the transformation of his understanding of mind, mentation, mental consciousness, the five dharmas, the natures, and the two kinds of selflessness, and for that reason he also attains the mind-made body."

"Blessed One, why is it called a mind-made body?"

The Blessed One declared: "Mahāmati, it is called a mind-made body because, like the mind, it is unobstructed and moves swiftly. Mahāmati, it is like this: the mind, unobstructed by mountains, walls, rivers, trees and the like, travels many hundreds of thousands of leagues, recalling objects it has seen and experienced before; the body of one's own unbroken mind-stream moves with unobstructed motion. Mahāmati, in the same way, as soon as the mind-made body is attained, through the illusion-like samādhi it is in full flower with the powers, the masteries, the superknowledges, wisdom and the marks; it is born together with the class of the noble ones; it moves without obstruction; and, recalling the objects of its former aspirations, it goes forth like the mind in order to bring sentient beings to maturity. In this way, Mahāmati, a bodhisattva great being has abandoned the views of arising, abiding and perishing.

"Mahāmati, how is a bodhisattva great being skilled in realizing that external things are without existence? Mahāmati, it is like this. All things are like a mirage, a dream, or a tangle of hairs. All things arise from the cause of clinging to the many kinds of habitual tendencies of conceptual thought, the corrupting dispositions of conceptual proliferation from beginningless time. Seeing correctly that they are without intrinsic nature, he aspires to the domain realized by the personal wisdom of the noble ones. Mahāmati, a bodhisattva great being who possesses these four qualities is a yogin of the great yoga."

"Mahāmati, you should strive in that."

Then once again the bodhisattva, the great being Mahāmati, made a request to the Blessed One (the Buddha): "Blessed One, please explain to me the characteristics of the causes and conditions of all phenomena. By understanding these characteristics of causes and conditions, I and the other

bodhisattvas would be free from the conceptuality of views that things exist or do not exist, and would not conceive of any thing as arising either gradually or all at once."

The Blessed One said: "Mahāmati, the characteristic of the dependent origination of all phenomena is of two kinds: external and internal. Mahāmati, as for external dependent origination, a pot comes about through conditions such as a lump of clay, a stick, a wheel, string, water, and human effort. Mahāmati, just as a pot comes about from a lump of clay, so too cloth comes from threads, a mat from grass, a sprout from a seed, and butter from curd through human effort with a churning stick and the like. This, Mahāmati, is external dependent origination, in which each later thing comes about from the one before it.

"Mahāmati, as for internal dependent origination, it is this: ignorance, craving, karma, and phenomena such as these receive the name 'dependent origination.' Mahāmati, the phenomena called aggregates, elements, and sense sources that are born from these also receive the name 'dependent origination.' Although these are without distinction, the childish imagine them.

"Mahāmati, causes are of six kinds: the cause of what is to come about, the connecting cause, the characteristic cause, the agent cause, the manifesting cause, and the cause of dependence. These are the six.

"Mahāmati, the cause of what is to come about performs the function of a cause for the arising of outer and inner phenomena. Mahāmati, the connecting cause performs the function of an objective support for the coming about of outer and inner aggregates, seeds, and so on. Mahāmati, the characteristic cause produces a connection with the characteristic of immediately succeeding activity. Mahāmati, the agent cause performs a function of sovereign power, like a wheel-turning monarch. Mahāmati, the manifesting cause performs the function of making manifest the characteristic of a conceptualized thing once it has arisen, like a lamp for forms and the like. Mahāmati, the cause of dependence, at the time of cessation, keeps the activity of the continuum from being cut off, for the sake of the coming about of a nonconceptual thing.

"These, Mahāmati, are imagined by childish ordinary beings through the conceptuality of their own minds. They do not come about by gradual progression, nor do they come about all at once. Why is that? Mahāmati, if they came about all at once, then, because the characteristic of a cause would

not be found, there would be no distinction between action and agent. If they came about by gradual progression, then gradual progression could not come about from a nature whose characteristic is not found. Mahāmati, just like designating someone a father when no son has been born, the logicians' mode of connection through gradual progression is also untenable. Mahāmati, they are not born by gradual progression in the manner of producer and produced through the conditions such as the causal condition, the objective condition, the immediately preceding condition, and the dominant condition. Mahāmati, because of the characteristic of clinging to the imputed nature, they are born neither gradually nor all at once. Mahāmati, because beings have bodies and enjoyments that are appearances of their own mind, and because the specific and general characteristics are without external things, they are born neither gradually nor all at once. Rather, consciousness comes about because things are imagined by the conceptuality of what appears to one's own mind. Therefore, Mahāmati, you should be free of the view that the characteristic of possessing causes, conditions, and agency is gradual or all at once."

On this it is said:

Here nothing at all is born
Through conditions, nor does anything cease;
It is only imputed conditions
That arise and come to cease.

Arising and perishing bound up with conditions
Are not to be rejected;
What the childish imagine through conditions,
That is what is to be rejected.

Because the mind, deluded by habitual tendencies,
Appears within the three realms of existence,
Phenomena do not come about
From conditions, whether existent or nonexistent.

What has not come about is not born through conditions,
Nor does anything come to cease.
When conditioned things are seen
As sky-flowers and a barren woman's son,
Then grasped object and grasping subject too
Are seen as error, and the mind turns back.

The unborn is not something to be produced;
Conditions, whatever they may be,
Exist nowhere and at no time;
They are spoken of as mere conventions.

Then once again the bodhisattva, the great being Mahāmati, said this to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, please explain to me the Dharma discourse called 'the essence of the characteristics of the conceptuality of speech.' Through thoroughly understanding the distinctions among its various divisions, I and the other bodhisattva great beings would comprehend both meanings, the expressed and the inexpressible, and would quickly awaken fully into unsurpassed, perfect, complete enlightenment; and the understanding of all sentient beings regarding both meanings, the expressed and the inexpressible, would be purified."

The Blessed One said: "Mahāmati, then listen very well and keep it in mind, and I shall explain it to you."

Saying "Excellent, Blessed One," the bodhisattva, the great being Mahāmati, listened to the Blessed One. The Blessed One then spoke to him as follows: "Mahāmati, there are four kinds of characteristics of the conceptuality of speech: the speech of characteristics, the speech of dreams, the speech of clinging to negative tendencies (dauṣṭhulya), and the speech of beginningless conceptuality."

Mahāmati, among these, the speech of characteristics arises from clinging, as to signs, to the forms that one's own conceptuality has fashioned. Mahāmati, the speech of dreams arises from recollecting objects experienced before, and from the absence of the object once one has awakened. Again, Mahāmati, the speech of the conceptuality of negative tendencies arises from recollecting actions an enemy did in the past. Mahāmati, the speech of conceptuality from beginningless time arises from one's own seeds, the negative tendencies of clinging to the conceptual proliferation of beginningless time. These, Mahāmati, are the four kinds of characteristics of verbal conceptuality. This is the further explanation of what was stated.

Then once more the bodhisattva, the great being Mahāmati, made a request to the Blessed One on this very matter: "Blessed One, may the Blessed One please explain to me further the sphere in which verbal conceptuality clings: where, from what, how, and by what the speech of human beings, verbal expression and conceptuality, arises."

The Blessed One said: "Mahāmati, speech arises from the coming together of the head, the chest, the nose, the throat, the palate, the lips, the tongue, and the teeth."

Mahāmati asked: "Blessed One, are conceptuality and speech different, or are they one, or how is it?"

The Blessed One said: "Mahāmati, speech is neither different from conceptuality nor one with it. Why is that? It is because verbal conceptuality arises with the characteristic of having arisen from that as its cause. Mahāmati, if this speech were different from conceptuality, it would not have arisen from conceptuality as its cause. If it were one with it, speech would not illuminate meaning; but it does illuminate it. Therefore it is neither different nor one."

Again Mahāmati asked: "Blessed One, is speech itself the ultimate? Or is what speech expresses the ultimate, or how is it?"

The Blessed One said: "Mahāmati, speech is not the ultimate, nor is what speech expresses the ultimate. Why is that? It is because the ultimate, the noble wisdom that is the ultimate truth, is entered by way of verbal expression. Speech itself is therefore not the ultimate. Mahāmati, the ultimate is to be realized by the wisdom of the noble ones' individual self-awareness. It is not the sphere of a mind of verbal conceptuality. Therefore conceptuality does not express the ultimate. Mahāmati, speech arises and perishes, is unstable, and arises from mutual causes and conditions. Mahāmati, whatever arises from mutual causes and conditions does not express the ultimate. Mahāmati, because there is no characteristic of self or other, speech does not express characteristics. Moreover, Mahāmati, because conceptuality follows what is merely the appearance of one's own mind, and because diverse and various external things have no characteristics, conceptuality does not conceive the ultimate. Therefore, Mahāmati, you should be free of conceptuality about the various kinds of speech."

On this it is said:

No thing at all has intrinsic nature;
Speech likewise does not exist.
Emptiness, the meaning of emptiness,
Fools do not see, and so they run about.
All things lack intrinsic nature;
Human speech too is imagined,

And that also does not exist.
One who examines their essence
As like a dream or an emanation
Neither circles in saṃsāra nor passes into nirvāṇa.
Just as kings and merchants
Lure their sons with various clay animals,
Set them to play,
And then give them real animals,
So I too, with reflections
Of the various characteristics of phenomena,
Teach my sons
The true limit of individual self-awareness.

Then again the bodhisattva, the great being Mahāmati, said this to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, please explain to me the characteristic that distinguishes the realization that all phenomena are the sphere of the appearance of one's own mind: that which has abandoned existence, nonexistence, oneness, difference, both, neither, neither existence nor nonexistence, permanence and impermanence; in which the conceptions of non-Buddhists (tīrthikas) do not operate; which is to be known by the individual wisdom of the noble ones; which is turned away from the specific and general characteristics of the imputed; which enters suchness, the ultimate; whose characteristic is to join the grounds and to become purer and purer, higher and higher; whose characteristic is to follow on into the ground of a Tathāgata; which, through former aspirations, operates like a jewel of various forms; and which ranges spontaneously through the characteristics of limitless domains. Please explain these and the like to me, so that I and the other bodhisattva great beings may come to hold a view turned away from the specific and general characteristics of the imputed nature, may swiftly awaken fully to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening, and may bring to perfection all the excellent happiness of all sentient beings."

The Blessed One said: "Excellent, Mahāmati, excellent! Mahāmati, in thinking to ask about this matter you have set out for the benefit of many beings, for the happiness of many beings, out of compassion for the world, for the sake of the multitude of beings, and for the benefit and happiness of gods and humans. Mahāmati, you have done well. Therefore, Mahāmati, listen very well and keep it in mind, and I shall explain it to you."

Saying, "Excellent, Blessed One," the bodhisattva, the great being Mahāmati, listened to the Blessed One.

The Blessed One then spoke to him as follows: "Mahāmati, childish ordinary people do not understand that things are merely the appearance of their own mind, and they cling to the various kinds of external things. Clinging in this way, they cling to conceptuality, the cause of habitual tendencies, whose nature is existence, nonexistence, oneness, difference, both, neither, neither existence nor nonexistence, permanence and impermanence, and so they conceptualize."

Mahāmati, it is like this. Deer tormented by the spring sun take the water of a mirage to be real water and run toward it, wanting to drink. Because they do not understand that the error lies in their own mind's view, they do not even know that there is no water here. In the same way, Mahāmati, childish ordinary beings, too, have intellects imbued from beginningless time with conceptualization of elaborations of many kinds. Their minds are thoroughly tormented by the fire of attachment, aversion and delusion. They are intent on objects of many different forms, they are disposed to view things as arising, perishing and abiding, and they are unskilled regarding inner and outer things. They fall into grasping at oneness, difference, existence and nonexistence.

Mahāmati, it is like this. A city of the gandharvas, the celestial musicians, is not a city, yet those who are unskilled perceive a city there. That likeness of a city appears because, since beginningless time, they have clung to the habitual tendencies that are the seeds of a city. Mahāmati, that city is neither a city nor is it not a city. In the same way, Mahāmati, the non-Buddhists (tīrthikas), whose intellects do not understand that all this is mere appearance of their own mind, and who since beginningless time have clung to the habitual tendencies of elaboration, become attached to doctrines of oneness, difference, existence and nonexistence.

Mahāmati, it is like this. A certain person, asleep, dreams that he has gone to a land, a city of jewels, beautified with women, men, elephants, horses, chariots, foot soldiers, villages, towns, cities, cattle, buffaloes, forests, pleasure gardens, mountains, rivers and ponds of many kinds. Then he wakes, and once awake he recalls that land, that city of jewels. Mahāmati, what do you think of that? Is the man who recalls the many unreal things of his dream in this way someone of a wise nature?

Mahāmati replied, "No, Blessed One."

The Blessed One said: "In the same way, Mahāmati, childish ordinary beings who are in the grip of wrong views, whose intellects are those of the non-Buddhists, and who do not understand that the things that appear from their own mind are like a dream, rely on views of oneness, difference, existence and nonexistence.

"Mahāmati, it is like this. A painted surface has no high or low, yet the childish imagine high and low in it. In the same way, Mahāmati, in times to come there will be people whose dispositions carry the habitual tendencies of the wrong views of the non-Buddhists and whose conceptuality has grown very great. They will cling to doctrines of oneness, difference, both and neither, and so ruin themselves. Of those who teach non-arising, who are free from the positions of existence and nonexistence, they will say that they are nihilists. They will say, 'These people deny cause and effect. With their wrong views they have uprooted the cause of the pure white side of virtue. Those who wish for what is good should keep far away from them.' Their dispositions have fallen into views of self, of other and of both. Having imagined existence and nonexistence, their dispositions have fallen into the wrong views of superimposition and denial. Such beings are headed for hell.

"Mahāmati, it is like this. Those with diseased eyes see a net of hairs and say, 'This is wonderful! This is truly wonderful! O friends, look!' Yet that net of hairs, because it is both seen and not seen, is neither truly existent nor nonexistent. In the same way, Mahāmati, those who cling to dispositions of conceptuality rooted in the wrong views of the non-Buddhists, who cling to the positions of existence and nonexistence and to doctrines of oneness, difference, both and neither, and who deny the true Dharma, make both themselves and others fall into error.

"Mahāmati, it is like this. Although a whirling firebrand is not a wheel, the childish imagine its wheel to be a real wheel, but not the wise. In the same way, Mahāmati, those who have fallen into the dispositions of the non-Buddhists with their wrong views imagine every birth into existence as oneness, difference, both or neither.

"Mahāmati, it is like this. When rain falls, bubbles arise from the water that look like crystal gems. The childish cling to them as real crystal gems and run after them. Yet, Mahāmati, because those water bubbles are both graspable and not graspable, they are neither gems nor are they not gems. In the same way, Mahāmati, those imbued with the habitual tendencies of dispositions of

conceptual views of the non-Buddhists will come to proclaim that, through conditions, arising takes place from what does not exist, and that perishing takes place from what exists.

"Furthermore, Mahāmati, they will set up the components of the three means of valid cognition one by one, and then, concerning that which is to be known by the noble ones' wisdom, realized individually within oneself, and which is free from the two natures, they will imagine, 'It exists as the intrinsic nature of a thing.' Mahāmati, yogins whose basis of mind, mentation and mental consciousness has been transformed, who have completely abandoned conceptualizations of grasped and grasper, which are appearances of their own mind, and who have attained the ground of the Tathāgata, the wisdom that the noble ones realize individually within themselves, do not have the perception of existence or nonexistence. Mahāmati, if yogins whose domain is of this kind were ever to engage in grasping at existence and nonexistence, that very thing would for them be grasping at a self, grasping at a sustainer, grasping at a cosmic man, and grasping at a person.

"Mahāmati, this teaching of the intrinsic nature of things and of their specific and general characteristics, Mahāmati, is taught by the emanated buddha. It is not taught by the buddha of the nature of reality."

Mahāmati, the teaching arises from views that are present in the dispositions of the childish. It does not speak of the Dharma whose nature is the realization of what is established, the abiding in the bliss of the samādhi of noble wisdom known individually by oneself.

Mahāmati, it is like this. The shadow of a tree appears in water. Because it has the shape of a tree and yet has no shape, it is neither a shadow nor not a shadow. In the same way, Mahāmati, those whose conceptualizations are perfumed by the habitual tendencies of the views of non-Buddhists (tīrthikas), whose minds do not understand that all this is merely the appearance of their own mind, conceive of things as one, as different, as both, as neither, as existent, and as nonexistent.

Mahāmati, it is like this. In a mirror, reflections of all forms appear in accordance with conditions. Those reflections are one's own conceptualization. Because they are seen as form and as not form, they are neither form nor not form. Yet, Mahāmati, to the childish, the conceptualization that is the appearance of their own mind appears as though it were form. In the same way, Mahāmati, the reflection of one's own mind also appears in the aspect of

the views of one, different, both, and neither.

Mahāmati, it is like this. An echo arises from the meeting of a person, flowing water, and wind, and it resounds separately. Because it resounds as sound and as not sound, it is neither an entity nor a nonentity. In the same way, Mahāmati, the views of existence, nonexistence, one, different, both, and neither appear as conceptualizations that are the habitual tendencies of one's own mind.

Mahāmati, it is like this. On ground where there is no grass, no thicket, and no spreading creepers, when the sun strikes it, the waves of a mirage shimmer. Because they are craved and not craved, they are neither entities nor nonentities. In the same way, Mahāmati, the conceptualizing consciousness of the childish, perfumed by the habitual tendencies of the dysfunction of proliferation from beginningless time, ripples like the waves of a mirage, in the manner of arising, ceasing, abiding, one, different, both, neither, existent, nonexistent, and even the entity of the noble one's individual wisdom.

Mahāmati, it is like this. A vetāla and a mechanical man, though there is no sentient being in them, perform the activity of moving when they are joined with a spirit and a contrivance. Because they go and do not go, the childish cling to that conceptualization of what does not exist. In the same way, Mahāmati, childish ordinary beings who have fallen into the thinking of non-Buddhists with wrong views cling to assertions of one and different. That is an unreal superimposition.

Therefore, Mahāmati, you should become free of conceptualizations of arising, non-arising, ceasing, abiding, one, different, both, neither, existent, nonexistent, and of an entity to be realized by the noble one individually.

On this it is said:

The aggregates, five with consciousness,
Are like the shadow of a tree in water.
Appearances resemble illusions and dreams;
Do not conceive them through cognition.

These three realms of existence are like a dream,
Like a tangle of hairs, and like an illusion.
The error, like the water of a mirage,
When thoroughly contemplated, one is thoroughly freed.

The mirage that deceives the mind:
Just as, when it shimmers in spring,
Deer take it to be water,
Though no entity is there,

So too the seed of consciousness
Stirs toward the objects of views,
And the childish take it as arising,
Like the floaters seen by one with cataracts.

What the childish, grasping at things,
Have embraced from beginningless saṃsāra,
Just as one nail drives out another,
Draw out that grasping and turn it back.

Seeing beings as like illusions, vetālas, machines,
Dreams, lightning, and clouds,
With the three continua forever cut off,
One is fully liberated.

Here there is no cognition whatsoever;
It is like a mirage in the sky.
If one fully knows phenomena thus,
There is nothing at all to assert.

This cognition is a mere name;
It does not exist by its characteristic.
The aggregates upon which these are imputed
Are like a tangle of hairs.

A painting, a tangle of hairs,
An illusion, a dream, a city of gandharvas,
A firebrand wheel, and mirages,
Though nonexistent, appear vividly to people.

Likewise permanent and impermanent,
One, both, and neither:
Through their bond with beginningless faults,
The deluded childish conceive of these.

In eyes, in mirrors, and in waters,
In vessels and in jewels as well,
Reflections appear in them,

Yet the reflection exists nowhere.

The mind appearing as things is just so:
Like a mirage in various forms,
Just as it appears in the sky,
Like a dream, and like a barren woman's son.

Furthermore, Mahāmati, the Dharma teaching of the Tathāgatas is free from the four. That is, it has abandoned the positions of one, different, both, and neither, and it is free from existence and nonexistence, from superimposition and denial. Mahāmati, the Dharma teaching of the Tathāgatas puts first truth, dependent origination, the path, cessation, and the entry into liberation. Mahāmati, the Dharma teaching of the Tathāgatas is not connected with primal nature (prakṛti), the Lord (Īśvara), causelessness, chance, atoms, time, or essential nature.

Furthermore, Mahāmati, in order to purify the two obscurations, the afflictive and the cognitive, they gradually establish, like a caravan leader, the hundred and eight nonappearances and the characteristics that thoroughly distinguish the vehicles and the limbs of the grounds.

Furthermore, Mahāmati, there are four kinds of meditative concentration. If one asks what the four kinds are, they are these: the meditative concentration practiced by the childish, the meditative concentration that discerns meanings, the meditative concentration that takes suchness as its object, and the meditative concentration of the Tathāgatas. These are the four.

Mahāmati, what is the meditation practiced by the immature? It is this. Yogins on the yoga of the śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas begin by clinging to the selflessness of the person, and to the characteristics of things: their own and general forms, the skeleton, impermanence, suffering, and unattractiveness. Having seen, "This has such a characteristic and not otherwise," they progress from the very beginning, higher and higher, up to the cessation of perception. This is the meditation practiced by the immature.

Mahāmati, what is the meditation that analyzes meaning? It is this. One sets aside the selflessness of the person and own and general characteristics, and sees that the self, the other, and both, as the non-Buddhists (tīrthikas) hold them, do not exist. One then proceeds in order, analyzing the meaning of the characteristics of the grounds of the selflessness of phenomena. This is the meditation that analyzes meaning.

Mahāmati, what is the meditation focused on suchness? It is this. One abides, just as things truly are, in non-conceptualization regarding the two selflessnesses, which are themselves imputed. Because of this, conceptual thought does not arise, and so it is called the meditation focused on suchness.

Mahāmati, what is the meditation of the Tathāgata? It is this. One enters the condition of the ground of the Tathāgata and abides in the bliss of the threefold characteristic of the wisdom that the noble ones realize individually within themselves. Because one thereby accomplishes the inconceivable benefit of sentient beings, it is called the meditation of the Tathāgata.

On this it is said:

The meditation that analyzes meaning,
the meditation practiced by the immature,
the meditation focused on suchness,
and the Tathāgata's virtuous meditation:
when a yogin strives at these,
he sees shapes like the sun and moon,
things like light and lotuses,
like drawings, and like fire in the sky.
These various signs
lead him onto the path of the tīrthikas,
and make him fall as well
into the domain of śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas.
When all these are wholly abandoned
and he has become free of appearances,
then the divine hands of the buddhas,
coming forth from every field,
stroke his head:
the sign of following what is real.

Then the bodhisattva mahāsattva Mahāmati again spoke to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, people say 'nirvāṇa, nirvāṇa.' Blessed One, of what phenomenon is this word 'nirvāṇa' a designation?"

The Blessed One said: "The transformation of the ālaya, which is the habitual tendency of the intrinsic nature of all consciousnesses, together with the transformation of the habitual tendencies of the views of the mind and the mental consciousness, is the mode of nirvāṇa. It is the domain of the reality that is empty of intrinsic nature. The buddhas and I declare this to be nirvāṇa.

"Further, Mahāmati, nirvāṇa is the domain of the wisdom that the noble ones know individually within themselves. It is free from conceptualizing things as permanent or annihilated, and free from conceptualizing them as existent or nonexistent. How is it not permanent? Because conceptualization in terms of own and general characteristics has been abandoned, it is not permanent. And it is not annihilation, because all the noble ones of the past, future, and present realize it individually within themselves. That is why it is not annihilation.

"Further, Mahāmati, complete nirvāṇa is not destruction, and it is not death. Mahāmati, if complete nirvāṇa were a death, it would still lead to a continuum of rebirth. If it were a destruction, it would fall into the characteristics of the conditioned. Therefore, Mahāmati, complete nirvāṇa is not destruction and not death. Yogins realize a refuge free of dying and transmigrating.

"Further, Mahāmati, nirvāṇa is called nirvāṇa because there is nothing in it to be abandoned and nothing to be attained, and because it is neither annihilation nor permanence, neither one in meaning nor different in meaning.

"Further, Mahāmati, the nirvāṇa of the śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas is this. They understand own and general characteristics, are free of bustle, and see objects without distortion, and so conceptual thought does not arise. Therefore they come to think of that as nirvāṇa.

"Further, Mahāmati, there are two kinds of characteristic of the two intrinsic natures. If one asks what the two kinds are, they are clinging to the intrinsic nature of expression and clinging to the intrinsic nature of things. Mahāmati, clinging to the intrinsic nature of expression arises from clinging to the habitual tendencies of verbal proliferation since beginningless time. Mahāmati, clinging to the intrinsic nature of things arises from not understanding that it is merely the appearance of one's own mind.

"Further, Mahāmati, bodhisattvas who are blessed by two blessings bow their heads at the feet of the tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly complete buddhas, and ask them their questions. If one asks by what two blessings they are blessed, they are these: the blessing of entering into samādhi, and the blessing of empowerment by the body, the face, and the hands.

"Mahāmati, from the first ground onward, the bodhisattva mahāsattvas are blessed with the blessing of the buddhas and enter the bodhisattva samādhi called Illumination of the Great Vehicle. As soon as the bodhisattva

mahāsattvas have entered the bodhisattva samādhi Illumination of the Great Vehicle, the tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly complete buddhas dwelling in the world systems of the ten directions show their faces and fully manifest body, face, and speech. In this way, Mahāmati, they bestow their blessing, just as they did for the bodhisattva mahāsattva Vajragarbha and for the other bodhisattva mahāsattvas endowed with qualities of this kind.

Mahāmati, in this way, on the first ground, bodhisattva great beings obtain the blessing of entering into meditative absorption. Through the roots of virtue they have amassed over a hundred thousand eons, they gradually come to understand the characteristics of what is favorable to the grounds and what is opposed to them. Then, on the bodhisattva ground called Cloud of Dharma, a bodhisattva great being is seated on a seat in a great lotus palace, wearing a crown adorned with every jewel ornament, and surrounded by bodhisattva great beings of the same kind. The hands of the Victors come forth from the worlds of the ten directions, hands that resemble orpiment, gold, the campaka flower, the rays of the moon and the lotus, and they anoint that bodhisattva great being seated on his seat in the great lotus palace on the crown of his head, as one anoints a sovereign, a wheel-turning king, or Indra, king of the gods. Because they confer empowerment with their bodies, faces and all their hands, that bodhisattva and those bodhisattvas are said to be blessed by the blessing of the empowerment of the hand.

Mahāmati, these are the two blessings of bodhisattva great beings. Blessed by these two blessings, bodhisattva great beings behold the faces of all the buddhas. Were it otherwise, they would be unable to see the Tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly complete buddhas.

Furthermore, Mahāmati, whatever eloquence bodhisattva great beings display in meditative absorption, in miraculous powers and in the forms of teaching, all of it is blessed by the two blessings of the buddhas. Mahāmati, if the eloquence of bodhisattva great beings were to arise without blessing, then, Mahāmati, even foolish ordinary beings would come to have eloquence. Why is that? It is because they are not blessed.

Mahāmati, when even grass, shrubs, creepers, trees, mountains, musical instruments of every kind, towns, houses, dwellings and palaces give forth sound through the blessing of the Tathāgata's coming, Mahāmati, what need is there to speak of those who have minds? Mahāmati, even the mute, the deaf and the blind are freed from their defects. Mahāmati, so great are the special

qualities of the Tathāgata's blessing.

Mahāmati again asked, "Blessed One, why do the Tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly complete buddhas bestow blessing upon bodhisattva great beings at the time when they abide in meditative absorption, and the blessing of empowerment on the distinguished ground?"

The Blessed One said, "So that they will not be disturbed by the works of Māra and by the afflictions; so that they will not fall into the meditative concentration and the ground of the śrāvakas; and in order to increase the Tathāgata ground, which is to be known personally by oneself, the Dharma that is attained, and realization. For these reasons, Mahāmati, the Tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly complete buddhas bless bodhisattva great beings with their blessing. Mahāmati, bodhisattva great beings who are not blessed fall into the outlook of the non-Buddhists (tīrthikas), of the śrāvakas and of Māra, and do not fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfectly complete awakening. That is why bodhisattva great beings are taken under the care of the Tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly complete buddhas."

On this it is said:

From the blessing of the Lord of Men
Come empowerment, absorptions and the rest;
Purified by aspirations,
They arise on the first and on the tenth.

Then again the bodhisattva great being Mahāmati said this to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, in explaining dependent origination, the Blessed One has only spoken in terms of causes, and has not taught it in a manner of his own. Blessed One, the tīrthikas too declare that things arise from causes, namely from primal nature, from the Lord (Īśvara), from the person (puruṣa), from time, and through the combining of atoms. The Blessed One speaks of the arising of things with another term, namely conditions, but there is no difference in tenet. Blessed One, the tīrthikas also declare that things arise from what exists and from what does not exist. The Blessed One too says that things come into being from nonexistence through conditions, and having arisen, perish. And what the Blessed One taught, that with ignorance as condition there are formations, and so on up to old age and death, here too the Blessed One has taught a statement of causelessness, not a doctrine of causes.

"Blessed One, the saying 'When this exists, that exists' fits things that are present simultaneously, but not things that are present in dependence on sequential arising. So the account given by the tīrthikas is the better one, and yours is not good. Why is that, Blessed One? The tīrthikas bring about the result through a cause that is not dependent origination. But Blessed One, your cause depends on the result, and the result depends on the cause, so cause and condition become mixed up, and in the same way there is an endless regress between them. Saying 'When this exists, that exists' makes the world causeless."

The Blessed One said, "Mahāmati, because there is neither grasped nor grasper, and because one understands that all is the mere appearance of one's own mind, even though I say 'When this exists, that exists,' it is neither a doctrine of causes and agents, nor does it mix up cause and conditions.

Mahāmati, those who cling to the grasped and the grasper, and who do not understand that there is no external entity as their own object, that it is only an appearance of their own mind, incur such a fault. But no fault attaches to my teaching of dependent origination.

Mahāmati then asked again, "Blessed One, it is not that there is no expression, so surely all things exist. Blessed One, if things did not exist, expression would not arise either. But since it does arise, expression is not absent, and therefore, Blessed One, all things exist."

The Blessed One said, "Mahāmati, even nonexistent things can be expressed. Thus the horn of a hare, the hair of a tortoise, the son of a barren woman and the like appear in expression in the world. Yet, Mahāmati, these are neither things nor non-things, and still, though they are expressed, they are expressed. Therefore, Mahāmati, the argument you put forward, that all things exist because there is expression, is refuted.

"Mahāmati, expression is not known in every buddha-field. Mahāmati, expression is something made. Mahāmati, in some buddha-fields the Dharma is taught by gazing without blinking, in some by gestures, in some by raising the eyebrows, in some by movements of the eyes, in some by laughing, in some by yawning, in some by the sound of clearing the throat, in some by recollecting the field, and in some by moving the body. For example, Mahāmati, in the world-system called Unblinking, Sweet Fragrance, the buddha-field of the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Samantabhadra, the bodhisattva great beings, by gazing without blinking,

attain the forbearance toward phenomena that do not arise, as well as other special samādhis.

"Mahāmati, therefore it is not the case that all things exist because there is expression. Mahāmati, this can be seen in this very world as well: particular kinds of beings, such as insects and bees, do their own work without expression."

On this it is said:

Just as space, the horns of a hare,
And the sons of a barren woman too,
Are spoken of in words though they do not exist,
So too is conceiving of things.
What is held to arise
From the coming together of causes and conditions is conceptuality.
Not knowing this way thoroughly,
They wander, dwelling in the three realms of existence.

The Noble Descent into Laṅkā, the fourth section.

Then again the bodhisattva great being Mahāmati asked the Blessed One, "Blessed One, with regard to what did the Blessed One also use the word 'permanent'?"

The Blessed One said, "Mahāmati, because this delusion appears even to the noble ones as not inverted, the word is applied to delusion. For example, Mahāmati, in the world the unwise grasp in an inverted way a mirage, a whirling firebrand, tangled hairs, a city of the gandharvas, a magical illusion, a dream, a reflection and a phantom figure of a person; but the wise do not, though it is not that these do not appear to them. Mahāmati, the fact that this delusion appears in many forms does not make delusion impermanent. Why is that? Because it is free from both existence and nonexistence.

"And how, Mahāmati, is delusion free from existence and nonexistence? It is like the waves of the ocean and the water of the Ganges, which pretas see and do not see: all fools have various domains of experience. Therefore, Mahāmati, delusion is not an existent thing. Yet since that water appears to others, it is not a nonexistent either. Thus, for the noble ones, delusion is free from both the inverted and the non-inverted. Moreover, Mahāmati, since the characteristic of its marks is not different, delusion is permanent. Mahāmati, although delusion is imagined by conceptuality in many various marks, it does

not become different. Hence, Mahāmati, delusion is permanent.

"And how, Mahāmati, is delusion reality? Mahāmati, the noble ones engage this delusion neither with an inverted mind nor with a non-inverted mind. Mahāmati, the noble ones perceive this delusion as nothing other than something ordinary; they do not perceive it as an object of noble wisdom. Mahāmati, 'ordinary' is what fools speak of, not what the noble ones speak of.

"Mahāmati, that delusion, when imagined as inverted or non-inverted, brings about the attainment of two lineages: the lineage of the noble ones, or the lineage of foolish ordinary beings. Mahāmati, the lineage of the noble ones is further divided into three kinds: the division into śrāvakas, pratyekabuddhas and buddhas.

"Now, Mahāmati, how is it that fools, by imagining delusion, produce the lineage of the śrāvaka vehicle? Mahāmati, it is like this: when one clings with attachment to particular and general characteristics, one comes to belong to the lineage of the śrāvaka vehicle. In this way, Mahāmati, that delusion brings about the attainment of the lineage of the śrāvaka vehicle.

"Then, Mahāmati, how does imagining that very delusion bring about the attainment of the lineage of the pratyekabuddha vehicle? Mahāmati, it is like this: clinging to the particular and general characteristics of that very delusion, and being free from social bustle, brings about the attainment of the lineage of the pratyekabuddha vehicle.

"Then, Mahāmati, how is it that the wise, by imagining that very delusion, attain the lineage of the buddha vehicle? Mahāmati, it is like this: when, because one understands it to be only an appearance of one's own mind, one imagines it without conceiving of external things as existent or nonexistent, one attains the lineage of the buddha vehicle. Therefore, Mahāmati, this is lineage; this is the meaning of lineage."

Mahāmati, when the childish imagine, with regard to error, the intrinsic nature of the various things and think, "This is just so, and not otherwise," they come to obtain the lineage of the vehicle of saṃsāra. Therefore, Mahāmati, the childish imagine error to be various things. Yet it is neither a thing nor the absence of a thing.

Mahāmati, when that very error is examined, the noble ones' mind, mentation and mental consciousness turn away from phenomena whose nature is the habitual tendencies of negative propensities. Through this, error is called

suchness for the noble ones. That, Mahāmati, is why it is said that suchness is free from mind. Mahāmati, to teach this very point I said, up to the words "abandoned even by conceptions, free from all conceptions."

Mahāmati asked, "Blessed One, does error exist or not?"

The Blessed One said, "Mahāmati, error exists like an illusion, but it does not exist as attachment to characteristics. Mahāmati, if error existed through attachment to characteristics, then, Mahāmati, attachment to things could not be reversed. Mahāmati, this too would then be like the dependent arising, the arising from a cause, that the non-Buddhists (tīrthikas) teach."

Mahāmati asked, "Blessed One, if error is like an illusion, then it would become the cause of further error."

The Blessed One said, "Mahāmati, an illusion does not bring about the faults of negative propensities, and so it is not a cause of error. Mahāmati, as long as it is not imagined, an illusion does not bring about the faults of negative propensities. Mahāmati, an illusion arises through the power of another person's spell, not through the power of the habitual tendencies of the negative propensities of one's own conceptual thought. Therefore it does not bring about faults. Mahāmati, it is merely that the childish, attached to whatever it may be, are deceived by viewing it as a sign. It is not so for the noble ones."

On this it is said:

The noble ones do not see error,
Nor is there anything real at that point either.
For if at that point there were something real,
Error itself would become the real.
Even when all error has been abandoned,
If one still gives rise to signs,
That very thing is one's error,
Like the impurity of cataract.

Further, Mahāmati, it is not by seeing that they share with illusion the property of not being nonexistent that all phenomena are like illusions.

Mahāmati asked, "Blessed One, are all phenomena like illusions through the characteristic of attachment to various illusions, or through the characteristic of attachment to what is false? Blessed One, if all things are like illusions through the characteristic of attachment to various illusions, then, Blessed

One, things are not like illusions. Why is that? Because the various characteristics of form are seen to be without cause. Blessed One, there is no cause whatever by which, as with an illusion, various characteristics of form come to appear. Therefore, Blessed One, things are not like illusions by sharing a property with attachment to the characteristics of various illusions."

The Blessed One said, "Mahāmati, it is true that all phenomena are not like illusions by sharing a property with attachment to the characteristics of various illusions. But, Mahāmati, all phenomena are like illusions by sharing a property with lightning, which is false and swift. Mahāmati, it is like this: a flash of lightning perishes in an instant, so that as soon as it is seen it is gone, and it does not appear to the childish. In the same way, Mahāmati, all things appear because there is no discernment of the general characteristics of one's own conceptual thought, and because of attachment to the characteristics of form."

On this it is said:

By sharing with illusion the property of not being nonexistent,
Things are spoken of as existing.
Because they are like lightning, false and swift,
They are therefore known to be like illusions.

Again Mahāmati asked, "The Blessed One has said that all things are unborn, and also that they are like illusions. Blessed One, if you say this, declaring that things are without arising and are like illusions, will your words not surely fall into the fault of contradicting one another, earlier and later?"

The Blessed One said, "Mahāmati, when I declare that things are without arising and are like illusions, my words do not fall into the fault of contradicting one another. Why is that? It is because I see arising and non-arising, realize them to be merely the appearance of one's own mind, and see that external things do not arise from the existence or the nonexistence of things. Therefore, Mahāmati, my words do not fall into the fault of contradiction. Mahāmati, all things are called unborn, like illusions, in order to demolish the non-Buddhists' position that things arise from a cause. Mahāmati, the deluded schools of the non-Buddhists hold that things arise from existence or from nonexistence, and not from the condition of attachment to the various conceptions of their own conceptual thought. Mahāmati, as I see it, things arise neither from existence nor from nonexistence. Therefore, Mahāmati, I speak in terms of non-arising.

"Again, Mahāmati, things are taught as existing in order to uphold saṃsāra, to avert the nihilism that says 'they do not exist,' and so that my disciples may uphold the ground of birth through various karmas. By holding to the word 'thing,' saṃsāra is upheld."

Mahāmati, these childish ordinary beings are fixated on the characteristics of wrong views. Because they do not see all phenomena as they truly abide, they might deceive both themselves and others. With that concern, I teach that the intrinsic nature and the characteristics of things are like an illusion, and by teaching this I turn them away from the intrinsic nature and characteristics of things. Childish ordinary beings have minds that have fallen into the characteristics of wrong views. They do not realize that things are merely the appearance of their own mind, and they are fixated on the characteristic of arising from causes, conditions and agency. Because they are foolish in this way, I teach that all phenomena have the intrinsic nature and the characteristics of an illusion and a dream. Now, Mahāmati, seeing all phenomena as they truly abide means entering into the mere appearance of one's own mind.

On this it is said:

Where there is no arising, there is no cause.
Through entities, saṃsāra is wholly gathered.
If one sees it as like what comes from causes and the rest,
one does not conceive in terms of characteristics.

Furthermore, Mahāmati, I set forth the characteristics of the groups of names, phrases and letters. When bodhisattva mahāsattvas fully understand these groups, they do not follow after meanings, phrases and letters. They quickly awaken fully into unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening, and then they bring all sentient beings to the same understanding.

Mahāmati, the group of names is this: the entity on which one relies to designate a name. "Group," "entity" and "body" do not differ in meaning. That, Mahāmati, is the group of names.

Mahāmati, the group of phrases is this: the many meanings of a phrase. "True," "certain," "conclusive" and "referent" do not differ in meaning. That, Mahāmati, I have taught as the group of phrases.

Again, Mahāmati, the group of letters is this: that by which names and phrases are made manifest. "Letter," "sign," "mark," "referent" and "designation" do

not differ in meaning.

Furthermore, Mahāmati, the group of phrases is this: the completion of a phrase. Mahāmati, a name is this: the distinct names that the letters themselves have, from A up to Ha. Mahāmati, the group of letters is this: short pronunciation, long pronunciation, and the ending of the letters.

Mahāmati, as for the group of phrases: elephants, horses, humans, deer, cattle, buffalo, sheep, livestock and all the others that go upon the ground are given the name "group of phrases."

Again, Mahāmati, as for name and letter: name is so called because the four formless aggregates are expressed by names. Letter is so called because it makes things manifest through its own characteristic. That, Mahāmati, is the characteristic by which names and phrases express things, within the groups of names, phrases and letters. You should become thoroughly familiar with it.

On this it is said:

Attached to the groups of phrases and of letters,
and to names, not knowing how they differ in kind,
the childish are stuck fast,
like a great elephant sunk in the mud.

Furthermore, Mahāmati, in times to come, the wise will put questions to unwise and misguided logicians. They will ask about the way of the two extremes, which is free from the characteristics of the views of oneness, difference, both and neither. Then the logicians, lacking reasoning, grounds and intelligence, will say: "This is not a question; it is not proper." For instance, they will be asked whether form and the like are one with impermanence or different from it. Likewise they will be asked about nirvāṇa in relation to formations, the bearer of marks in relation to the marks, the possessor of qualities in relation to the qualities, the elements and what derives from the elements, seeing in relation to what appears, atoms in relation to particles, and yogins in relation to wisdom. When they are asked about these and other things that have been answered by way of characteristics, in sequence one after another, they will say: "This is to be set aside; the Blessed One did not answer it."

As for those deluded people: because listeners such as these lack understanding, the Tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly and completely awakened buddhas, do not answer the questions that are not to be answered,

so as to spare sentient beings occasions for terror. And, Mahāmati, the Tathāgatas did not explain those things in order to undo the views of the non-Buddhists (tīrthikas).

Mahāmati, the non-Buddhists speak like this: "This body is one with the life principle," and "The body is one thing and the life principle another," and so on, and they declare that such matters are not to be answered. Mahāmati, leaving questions unanswered belongs to the non-Buddhists, who are confused about causes. It does not belong to my teaching. Mahāmati, in my teaching, those who are free from grasped and grasper do not even have conceptual thought at work. So how could there be any setting aside for them? Mahāmati, setting aside exists for those who are fixated on grasped and grasper, whose minds do not know things to be merely the appearance of their own mind.

Mahāmati, when questions are put to them, the Tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly and completely awakened buddhas, teach the Dharma to sentient beings through four kinds of answer. Mahāmati, what is called "setting aside" I taught on another occasion. Setting aside is for those whose faculties have not fully matured.

Furthermore, Mahāmati, all phenomena are without action and agent. Because there is no agent, they do not arise. Therefore all phenomena are said to be unborn.

Mahāmati, all phenomena are without essential nature. Why is that? Mahāmati, when one examines them with one's own intelligence, no entity holds up under scrutiny as having either a particular or a general characteristic. Therefore all phenomena are said to be without essential nature.

Now, Mahāmati, all phenomena are without taking up and casting off. Why is that? Mahāmati, even if one takes up particular and general characteristics, there is nothing to take up. Even if one casts them off, there is nothing to cast off. For that reason, Mahāmati, all phenomena are without taking up and casting off.

Again, Mahāmati, all phenomena are unceasing. Why is that? Entities have no essential nature and no characteristic, so no phenomenon is ever found. Therefore all phenomena are said to be unceasing.

Furthermore, Mahāmati, all phenomena are impermanent. Why is this said? Because the arising of characteristics is impermanent, all phenomena are called impermanent. Furthermore, Mahāmati, all phenomena are permanent. Why is that? It is this: the arising of characteristics is understood as permanent, because it has the nature of non-arising. Therefore, Mahāmati, all phenomena are called permanent.

On this it is said:

Answers are of four kinds:
the categorical, the counter-question,
the distinguishing, and setting aside;
by these the doctrines of the non-Buddhists (tīrthikas) are refuted.
That things arise from the existent or the nonexistent
is what the Vaiśeṣikas and Sāṃkhyas say.
All the questions left unanswered
were put forward by those very people.
Even when examined by the intellect,
since no intrinsic nature is found,
they cannot be expressed,
and the absence of essential nature is taught.

Then the bodhisattva, the great being Mahāmati, again addressed the Blessed One: "Blessed One, please explain to me the characteristics of the way in which the courses of stream-enterers, who have entered the stream, are classified. When I and the other bodhisattva great beings are skilled in those characteristics, we will know the characteristics of the means by which one advances, ever higher, to become a once-returner, a non-returner and an arhat, and we will teach the Dharma to beings in just the way that suits each. Then we will purify the two characteristics of selflessness and the two obscurations, each in turn, and come to realize the passing beyond the characteristics of each of the grounds. Having found the inconceivable course, domain and sphere of activity of the Tathāgatas, we will become like a jewel of many forms, the sustenance of all beings, and we will sustain them by enjoying, as we wish, the domain and course of all phenomena."

The Blessed One said: "Therefore, Mahāmati, listen well and keep it well in mind, and I will explain it to you."

"Excellent, Blessed One," replied the bodhisattva, the great being Mahāmati, and he listened to the Blessed One. The Blessed One then said to him:

"Mahāmati, the fruit of stream-entry attained by stream-enterers is classified in these three ways. What are the three? They are the lowest, the middling and the supreme. The lowest, Mahāmati, has at most seven more lives in existence. The middling, Mahāmati, attains complete nirvāṇa after three or five existences. The supreme, Mahāmati, attains complete nirvāṇa in that very life. For these three, Mahāmati, there are three fetters, great, middling and small.

"And what, Mahāmati, are the three fetters? They are the view of the perishable collection, doubt, and clinging to moral discipline and vows as supreme. These, Mahāmati, are the three fetters. By overcoming them in their gradations, one rises ever higher to the arhat's fruit of arhatship.

"Mahāmati, the view of the perishable collection is of two kinds: the innate and the imputed. It is like the imputed nature, which is imputed upon the dependent. For, Mahāmati, on the ground of the very nature of the dependent, various kinds of clinging to the imputed nature arise. Since that nature is characterized by imputation, it is neither existent nor nonexistent, nor both existent and nonexistent. Yet the childish, clinging to the characteristics of various natures like a deer to a mirage, construct concepts. That, Mahāmati, is the stream-enterer's imputed view of the perishable collection, a clinging built up over a long time through ignorance. It is abandoned through non-grasping, because the person is without self.

"Mahāmati, the stream-enterer's innate view of the perishable collection is overcome by seeing this: one's own body and the bodies of others are the same; the four aggregates have the characteristic of being formless; form arises from the elements and from what is derived from the elements; and because the elements have the characteristic of being causes of one another, form does not come into being. Since the stream-enterer sees no view that takes the side of existence or nonexistence, the view of the perishable collection is abandoned. Therefore one who has abandoned the view of the perishable collection in this way does not give rise to attachment. That, Mahāmati, is the characteristic of the view of the perishable collection.

"Mahāmati, the characteristic of doubt is this: because the stream-enterer has seen clearly the dharma of attaining realization, and because he has abandoned the conceptualizing of the two kinds of view of the perishable collection described above, he has no doubt about the teachings, and he does not look to another teacher as pure or impure. That, Mahāmati, is the

stream-enterer's characteristic of doubt.

"Mahāmati, how does the stream-enterer not cling to moral discipline as supreme? It is this: because he clearly sees the characteristic of birth as a state of suffering, he does not cling to it. Clinging, Mahāmati, is this: through moral discipline, vows and austerities kept without fail, childish ordinary beings who long for enjoyments and pleasure seek birth in saṃsāra. He does not cling in that way. Not clinging thus, he dedicates his practice to something else, to going on to the distinction of what is realized personally, within oneself. He applies himself to the limbs of moral discipline without conceptualizing them, as though they had the characteristic of undefiled phenomena.

That, Mahāmati, is the characteristic of the stream-enterer with respect to pride in moral discipline and ascetic observances. Mahāmati, in the stream-enterer who has abandoned the three fetters, attachment, aversion, and delusion do not arise.

Mahāmati asked, "The Blessed One has taught attachment in many forms. Which attachment has he abandoned?"

The Blessed One said, "Mahāmati, there is the attachment of the bodily sense faculty to its objects, born from union with women, which is pleasant in the present but becomes a cause for the arising of suffering in the future. Such attachments, of fondling with fist and palm, of joining the lower bodies, of kissing, of embracing, of smelling, and of glancing from the corner of the eye, do not arise in him. Why is that? Because he has abandoned them by attaining abiding in the bliss of meditative absorption. But he has not abandoned the attachment by which nirvāṇa is to be realized.

"Mahāmati, what is the characteristic of the once-returner? It is this: the conceptuality that views things as signs and takes them as the basis of signs, and that which, although without characteristics, appears as the characteristic of form, arises just once. Having clearly seen the characteristic of the domain of meditative concentration, he comes to this world once, and in order to put an end to suffering he passes into final nirvāṇa. Therefore he is called a once-returner.

"And how, Mahāmati, is one a non-returner? It is this: he does not engage with the existence or nonexistence of the entity that is the characteristic of past, future, and present form, and since the conceptuality of the latent faults of views does not return, he is a non-returner. Because he has abandoned the

fetters, he is called a non-returner.

"Mahāmati, the arhat is called an arhat because he has no conceptuality regarding meditative concentration, what is to be meditated upon, meditative absorption, the liberations, the powers, the superknowledges, the afflictions, and suffering."

Mahāmati asked, "The Blessed One has spoken of three kinds of arhat. Blessed One, to which of them is this word 'arhat' applied? Blessed One, is it one who has attained the path of solitary peace? Or one who, having cultivated aspirations for awakening, is bewildered about the roots of virtue? Or is it a magical emanation?"

The Blessed One said, "Mahāmati, it is the śrāvaka who has attained the path of solitary peace, not the others. Mahāmati, the others, those spoken of because they have practiced the conduct of a bodhisattva, and the magical emanations of the buddhas, through skill in means and preceded by their aspirations, display birth within the circles of the assembly in order to adorn the assemblies of the buddhas.

"Mahāmati, the various other grounds into which conceptuality enters, which are taught, are these: meditative concentration for attaining the fruit, what is to be meditated upon, and seclusion from the meditator. These are taught as characteristics of attaining the fruit through acknowledging them as appearances of one's own mind.

"Furthermore, Mahāmati, if a stream-enterer thinks, 'These are the fetters, and I am not endowed with them,' he falls into duality and into the view of a self, and the fetters remain unabandoned.

"Furthermore, Mahāmati, in order to completely transcend the meditative concentrations, the immeasurables, and the formless realm, one should turn away from the characteristic of the appearance of one's own mind. Since the absorption of the cessation of perception and feeling belongs to mind-only, Mahāmati, it is not possible for even that to pass beyond the continuum of the appearance of one's own mind."

On this it is said:

The meditative concentrations and the immeasurables,
Meditative absorption and the formless states,
And the cessation of perception, without remainder,
Do not exist in mind-only.

The fruit of stream-entry,
And likewise that of the once-returner,
The fruit of the non-returner,
And arhatship too, are in the confusion of mind.
Meditation, the object of meditation, the meditator,
Abandonment, and the seeing of the truths:
Whoever understands these to be mere conception
Is thereby set free.

"Furthermore, Mahāmati, there are two kinds of intellect: the intellect of thorough discernment, and the intellect that posits through clinging to the apprehension of conceptual characteristics. Here, Mahāmati, what is called the intellect of thorough discernment is this: the intellect by which, when one thoroughly examines the intrinsic nature and characteristics of things, nothing is found, for they are free from the four extremes. That is the intellect of thorough discernment.

"Here, Mahāmati, the four extremes are these: being free from oneness, difference, both, and neither, and from existence, nonexistence, permanence, and impermanence, is what is explained as the four extremes. Mahāmati, all phenomena are said to be free from these four extremes. Mahāmati, these four extremes should be applied in the thorough examination of all phenomena.

"And what, Mahāmati, is the intellect that posits through clinging to the apprehension of conceptual characteristics? It is this, Mahāmati: through clinging to the apprehension of conceptual characteristics, one asserts that heat, moisture, motion, and solidity, which have the character of false imagination, are the great elements, and through clinging to reasons, characteristics, and examples, one superimposes by false superimposition. That is the intellect that posits through clinging to the apprehension of conceptual characteristics."

Mahāmati, these are the characteristics of the two kinds of intellect. Endowed with these characteristics of the two kinds of intellect, bodhisattva great beings realize and fully understand the characteristic of the selflessness of phenomena and of persons. Skilled in the ground of practice in which an intellect free of appearances thoroughly discerns, they attain the first ground and enter into a hundred samādhis. Having attained the distinctions of

samādhi, they see a hundred buddhas and bodhisattvas. They enter into the prior limit and the final limit of a hundred eons, and they illuminate a hundred fields. Having illuminated a hundred fields, they come to know the procedure of the characteristics of the grounds, each higher than the last. Through the distinctions of their aspirations they display miraculous transformations, and they are empowered with the empowerment of the Cloud of Dharma. Having attained the Tathāgata's ground of personal realization, they become endowed with the qualities that possess the ten culminating states. Absorbed in the bliss of what is personally realized, they are adorned with the various light rays of emanation in order to bring sentient beings to full maturity.

Furthermore, Mahāmati, the bodhisattva great being should become skilled in the great elements and in what is derived from the elements. Mahāmati, if one asks how the bodhisattva great being is skilled in the great elements and in what is derived from the elements: Mahāmati, here the bodhisattva great being trains properly in this, and clearly sees, "That in which the great elements are unborn is the truth. These great elements have never truly come into being." Seeing it clearly in this way, he understands that it is merely the appearance of his own mind, and, because external things have no existence, he clearly sees that this triple realm is without elements and without what is derived from the elements; that it is mere name and conceptuality, mere conceptuality of names and of the appearance of one's own mind; that it is pure in the manner of the four extremes, without self and without what belongs to a self; that it abides just as it is, in the true abode of its own characteristic; and that its own characteristic is established as unborn.

Then, Mahāmati, if one asks how what is derived from the elements comes from the great elements: Mahāmati, it is like this. Mahāmati, the great element conceived as moisture produces the water element, outer and inner. Mahāmati, the great element conceived as heat produces the fire element, outer and inner. Mahāmati, the great element conceived as motion produces the wind element, outer and inner. Mahāmati, the great element of the conceptuality that divides off the distinctions of form produces the earth element, outer and inner, together with space. Through clinging to what is false as true, the assemblage of the five aggregates arises, and the great elements and what is derived from the elements arise. Mahāmati, consciousness too, through the cause of clinging to and desiring words and various objects, comes to link up with rebirth in another destiny. The earth element and what is derived from the elements have the great elements as

their cause, but for the great elements there is none. Why is that? Mahāmati, it is like this: because there is no entity, no sign, no characteristic, no shape, no nature of activity, and no combination, the great elements do not arise. What is endowed with entity, sign, characteristic, shape, activity, and combination arises from the coming together of activities, not from what lacks signs. Therefore, Mahāmati, the characteristic of the great elements and of what is derived from the elements is something imagined by the non-Buddhists (tīrthikas), not by me.

Furthermore, Mahāmati, I shall teach the intrinsic nature of the aggregates as aggregates, and their characteristics. Mahāmati, there are the five aggregates. If one asks what the five are, they are form, feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness. Among them, Mahāmati, four aggregates are formless: feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness. Mahāmati, form is what is derived from the four great elements, the elements whose characteristics are mutually discordant. Mahāmati, the formless ones cannot be counted as four, just as with space. Mahāmati, it is like this: space is beyond the characteristic of number, yet it is conceived of as "space is one." In the same way, Mahāmati, the aggregates too are beyond the characteristic of number and beyond counting. Although they are free of the four extremes, having abandoned the aspects of existence and nonexistence, the childish speak of them by expressing them in terms of number and counting; but the noble ones do not. Mahāmati, the noble ones designate them as having abandoned oneness and difference, like various illusory forms, and as not being another basis, like dreams and like the persons in reflections. Because of deep delusion regarding the realization of noble wisdom, the conceptuality of aggregates appears. Mahāmati, that is the characteristic of the intrinsic nature of the aggregates as aggregates, and you should reverse that conceptuality. Having reversed it, you should teach the Dharma of utter solitude to the maṇḍala of the assembly in all buddha fields, in order to reverse the views of the non-Buddhists. Mahāmati, by teaching the Dharma of utter solitude, the vision of the selflessness of phenomena becomes pure, and one also enters the ground called Gone Far. Then, having entered the great ground Gone Far, one gains mastery over many samādhis. By attaining the mind-made body, one attains the illusion-like samādhi. By realizing and fully understanding the powers, the superknowledges, and the masteries, one becomes, like the earth, the sustenance of all sentient beings. Mahāmati, it is like this: the earth is the sustenance of all sentient beings, and in the same way the bodhisattva great

being too becomes the sustenance of all sentient beings.

Furthermore, Mahāmati, there are four kinds of nirvāṇa. If one asks what the four are, they are these: the nirvāṇa that is the absence of an intrinsic nature in entities; the nirvāṇa that is the absence of entities with various characteristics; the nirvāṇa that is the realization that entities with their own characteristics do not exist; and the nirvāṇa that is the cutting off of the stream of the continuum of the individual and general characteristics of the aggregates. These, Mahāmati, are the nirvāṇas of the tīrthikas; they are not found in my teaching. Mahāmati, in my teaching, it is the turning back of the mental consciousness, together with its conceptuality, that is called nirvāṇa.

Mahāmati asked, "Has the Blessed One not established eight consciousnesses?"

The Blessed One said, "Mahāmati, I have established them."

Mahāmati asked, "If the Blessed One has established them, how is it that the mental consciousness turns back, but not the seven consciousnesses?"

The Blessed One said, "Because it is their cause and their object, the collection of seven consciousnesses arises. Mahāmati, the mental consciousness arises with attachment to the discrimination of objects, and through habitual tendencies it greatly nourishes the all-base consciousness. Together with manas, through attachment to grasping at 'I' and 'mine,' it proceeds as if conceiving 'I.' The all-base consciousness has become its cause and is its object, and its characteristic is that it is not a separate body. Through attachment to objects that are appearances of one's own mind, a collection of minds arises, each one becoming the cause of the other. Mahāmati, like the waves of the ocean, stirred by the wind of objects that are appearances of one's own mind, they proceed and they cease. Therefore, Mahāmati, through the turning back of the mental consciousness, the seven consciousnesses also turn back."

On this it is said:

I do not pass into nirvāṇa
Through activity, characteristics, or entities.
Through turning back from conceptual consciousness,
I pass into nirvāṇa.

With that as its cause and that as its object,
The continuum of manas is firmly established.

The continua of mind bring it forth,
And consciousness too is firmly established.

Just as, when a great body of water is exhausted,
Waves no longer arise at all,
So too the various consciousnesses,
Once they have ceased, will not arise.

Furthermore, Mahāmati, I shall teach the characteristic of the modes of analysis of the imputed nature, by realizing whose fine distinctions you and the other bodhisattva great beings will abandon conceptuality and imputation; will have a mind that clearly sees the domain of my noble, individual self-realization and the ways of the non-Buddhists; will abandon the conceptuality of grasped and grasper; and will no longer discriminate the various distinct aspects of the dependent characteristic as though they were the imputed nature.

Now, Mahāmati, what is the characteristic of the modes of analysis of the imputed nature? It is this: discrimination of expression, discrimination of what is to be expressed, discrimination of characteristics, discrimination of wealth, discrimination of intrinsic nature, discrimination of cause, discrimination of views, discrimination of reasoning, discrimination of arising, discrimination of non-arising, discrimination of connection, and discrimination of bondage and non-bondage. That, Mahāmati, is the characteristic of the modes of analysis of the imputed nature of expression.

Now, Mahāmati, what is discrimination of expression? It is attachment to various melodies and sweet songs. That, Mahāmati, is discrimination of expression.

Now, Mahāmati, what is discrimination of what is to be expressed? It is the conceptual thought, "There exists some intrinsic nature of an entity to be expressed, an object to be known by noble wisdom and realization, resting on which expression comes to proceed."

Now, Mahāmati, what is discrimination of characteristics? It is to cling, through attachment, to various characteristics in what is to be expressed, which is like a mirage; that is, to conceive of all entities as having the characteristics of heat, moisture, motion, and solidity.

Now, what is discrimination of wealth? It is expression referring to objects such as gold, silver, and the many kinds of precious wealth.

Now, what is discrimination of intrinsic nature? It is to grasp entities as having an essential nature, and to view them with the view of false conceptuality, thinking, "This is just so and not otherwise."

Now, what is discrimination of cause? That by which causes and conditions make arising from the characteristic of a cause appear as existent or nonexistent: that is discrimination of cause.

Now, what is discrimination of views? It is attachment to the conceptuality of non-Buddhists who hold the wrong views of existence, nonexistence, oneness, difference, both, and neither.

Now, what is discrimination of reasoning? It is to argue through reasoning and to teach the characteristics of self and of what belongs to self.

Now, what is discrimination of arising? It is attachment to the arising, through conditions, of entities that exist and that do not exist.

Now, what is discrimination of non-arising? It is the notion that all entities are bodies without a cause that did not arise before, and that, having not come into being, they come about through conditions.

Now, what is discrimination of connection? It is being connected with this and that, like a golden thread.

Now, what is discrimination of bondage and non-bondage? It is like attachment to a cause of binding and to something to be bound, just as a person skilled in means ties a knot in a rope and unties it.

Mahāmati, these are the characteristics of the way the imputed nature is analyzed. All childish, ordinary beings cling to these characteristics of the way the imputed nature is analyzed. Mahāmati, because they cling to existence and nonexistence in the dependent characteristic, they cling to the various characteristics of the imagined, just as one sees various things in the basis of a magical illusion. The childish conceptualize with a mind that sees the illusion as something other. Mahāmati, the variety and the illusion are neither one nor different. If they were different, the variety would not arise from the illusion as its cause. If the variety were not different, there would be no distinction between the illusion and the variety. Since a distinction between them is seen, they are neither one nor different. Therefore, Mahāmati, you and the other bodhisattva great beings should not cling to existence and nonexistence with

regard to illusion.

On this it is said:

The mind is bound up with objects;
consciousness engages in conceptual thought.
In the appearanceless and in what is distinct,
wisdom truly enters.

The imputed nature exists;
the dependent does not exist.
What the mistaken imagine appears;
they do not imagine the dependent.

Just as an illusion made up of many parts
is not established,
so too the various signs,
when examined, are not established.

Signs are the very substance of the dispositions of negativity;
bondage arises from the mind.
What the ignorant impute,
they conceptualize as the dependent as well.

This very entity that is imagined
is itself the dependent.
The appearance of the various imaginings
is what is called the dependent.

There are the conventional and the ultimate;
there is no third that arises from causes.
The imagined is explained as the conventional;
its cutting off is the domain of the noble ones.

Just as for the object of a yogin
the variety shines beautifully as one,
yet in it there is no variety,
such is the characteristic of the imagined.

Just as those afflicted with cataracts
imagine variety in visible forms,
while the cataract is neither form nor non-form,
so the wise regard the dependent.

Just as gold that has been purified,
water rid of its turbidity,
and the sky free of clouds,
so purity is fully discerned.

The imagined has no substance;
the dependent exists.
Superimposition and denial,
when examined, are destroyed.

If the imagined has no substance
and yet the dependent truly exists,
then where there is no entity there is an entity,
and an entity arises from no entity.

Abiding in the imputed,
one perceives the dependent.
From the connection of name and sign
the imputed comes to arise.

The imagined is utterly unestablished;
it does not arise from another.
Then the ultimate nature
is known to be utterly pure.

The imputed is tenfold;
the dependent is sixfold.
Suchness is to be known by individual self-awareness;
therefore there is no distinction.

The five dharmas are reality itself,
and so likewise are the three natures.
If a yogin meditates on them,
he does not pass beyond suchness.

The signs are the dependent;
whatever is name, that is the imagined.
The imputed and the signs
arise from the dependent.

When the intellect examines,
there is no dependent and no imagined either.
If there is no perfected entity,

what is it that the intellect examines?

If there is a perfected entity
that is free of existence and nonexistence,
how could an entity
released from existence and nonexistence become two?

In the imputed nature
the two natures are established.
The imagined appear as variety;
the pure is the domain of the noble ones.

The appearance of the various imaginings
is called the dependent.
If it is imagined in any other way,
one comes to abide in the doctrine of the non-Buddhists.

Conceptual thought is called the imagined;
because it is seen, it arises from causes.
Freedom from the two kinds of conceptuality
is itself the perfected.

Then Mahāmati again asked, "Blessed One, please explain the characteristic of the realization of the noble individual self-wisdom and of the one vehicle, the characteristic through which I and the other bodhisattva great beings may become skilled in the noble individual self-wisdom and in the one vehicle, and may come to rely on no one else with regard to all the qualities of a buddha."

The Blessed One said, "In that case, Mahāmati, listen very well and keep it in mind, and I shall explain it to you."

Saying, "Excellent, Blessed One," the bodhisattva great being Mahāmati listened to the Blessed One, and the Blessed One spoke as follows:

"Mahāmati, a bodhisattva great being goes alone into solitude. Without conceptualizing in terms of valid cognition and trustworthy scripture, he examines with his own individual intellect, relying on no one else. Having abandoned views and conceptuality, he strives to enter ever higher into the ground of the Tathāgata. Mahāmati, that is the characteristic of realizing the individual noble wisdom.

"What, then, is the characteristic of realizing the Great Vehicle? It is this: it is called the one vehicle because one knows and understands the path of the

one vehicle. And what is it to know and understand the path of the one vehicle? It is this: because, through abiding in reality just as it is, the conceptuality of grasped and grasper does not arise, the one vehicle has been understood. Mahāmati, this understanding of the one vehicle has never before been attained, apart from me, by other non-Buddhists, by śrāvakas, by pratyekabuddhas, or by Brahmā and other teachers. Therefore, Mahāmati, it is called the one vehicle."

Mahāmati asked, "Why has the Blessed One taught three vehicles and not taught a single vehicle?"

The Blessed One said, "Mahāmati, it is like this. All śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas are liberated through the Tathāgata's discipline and through the instruction in the yoga of utter solitude, not by their own power. Mahāmati, because they are not of a nature to attain final nirvāṇa by themselves, the single vehicle has not been taught to all the śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas.

"Furthermore, Mahāmati, all śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas have not abandoned the obscuration to the knowable or the habitual tendencies of karma. Because of this they have not realized the selflessness of phenomena, and they have not attained the inconceivable death by transformation. Therefore the three vehicles are taught to the śrāvakas, and not the single vehicle.

"Mahāmati, when they have abandoned all the habitual tendencies of faults and have realized the selflessness of phenomena, they become free of the faults of habitual tendencies and of the intoxication of samādhi. Then they awaken once more from the undefiled realm, and having completed the accumulations, both worldly and transcendent, that belong to the undefiled realm, they come to attain mastery over the inconceivable Dharma body."

On this it is said:

"The vehicle of the gods and the vehicle of Brahmā,
And likewise that of the śrāvakas,
Those of the Tathāgatas and the pratyekabuddhas:
These vehicles I have taught.
As long as beings go on entering,
There is no end to the vehicles.
When the mind is thoroughly transformed,
There is no vehicle, and no one who goes.
Though there is no setting up of vehicles,

In order to lead sentient beings
I have taught the various vehicles;
I have taught the single vehicle.
Likewise the three liberations,
And the selflessness of phenomena itself,
The wisdom of sameness, and the afflictions:
Through liberation these are abandoned.
Just as logs upon the ocean
Are tossed about by the waves,
So too the deluded śrāvakas
Are tossed about by characteristics.
Though free of the manifest afflictions,
They are bound up with the habitual tendencies of affliction.
Drunk with the intoxication of samādhi,
They dwell within the undefiled realm.
For them there is no reaching the end,
Yet they do not turn back from there again.
Having attained the body of samādhi,
They do not awaken for eons.
Just as a drunken man,
Once free of liquor, becomes sober,
So they too will then
Attain my Dharma body."

This concludes the second chapter, called The Compendium of All Phenomena, from the Laṅkāvatāra in Thirty-Six Thousand Lines.

Then again the Blessed One spoke these words to the bodhisattva mahāsattva Mahāmati: "Mahāmati, I shall teach the characteristics that distinguish the realization of the mind-made body. Listen very well and bear it in mind, and I will explain it to you."

Saying, "Excellent, Blessed One," the bodhisattva mahāsattva Mahāmati listened to the Blessed One, and the Blessed One spoke to him these words: "Mahāmati, the mind-made body is of three kinds. What are the three? They are the mind-made body that is absorbed in the bliss of samādhi, the mind-made body that has come to understand the realization of the essential nature of phenomena, and the mind-made body of the activity of formations born together with one's class. Yogins attain these by fully knowing the

characteristics of the grounds, higher and higher from the first ground onward.

"Among these, Mahāmati, what is the mind-made body that is absorbed in the bliss of samādhi? On the third, fourth, and fifth grounds, by practicing the many aspects of one's own mind in solitude, the mentation absorbed in bliss, which has the character of the waves of consciousness entering the ocean of mind, no longer arises. Through fully knowing the existence and nonexistence of entities in the objects that appear as one's own mind, it is called a mind-made body.

"Among these, what is the mind-made body that has come to understand the realization of the essential nature of phenomena? On the eighth ground, through understanding the thorough discernment that phenomena such as illusions do not appear, the basis of the mind is thoroughly transformed. One fully attains the illusion-like samādhi and fully attains the other doors of samādhi. The flowers of the signs, the masteries, and the many superknowledges blossom. Swift as thought, like an illusion, a dream, or a reflection, it is not made of the elements, yet it resembles the elements and what derives from them. Gathering together all the various limbs of form, it follows the circles of the assemblies in all the buddha fields. Because it has come to understand the realization of the essential nature of phenomena, that body is called a mind-made body.

"Among these, what is the mind-made body of the activity of formations born together with one's class? Through understanding the blissful character of the individual self-knowing of all the qualities of a buddha, it is called the mind-made body of the activity of formations born together with one's class.

"Mahāmati, you should exert yourself in this knowledge that thoroughly discerns the characteristics of the three bodies."

On this it is said:

"My Great Vehicle is not a vehicle;
It has no letters, and no sound either;
There are no truths, there is no liberation,
No appearance, and no sphere of activity.
Yet the Great Vehicle is a vehicle:
It has mastery over samādhi,
And the various mind-made bodies
Are adorned with the flowers of mastery."

Then again the bodhisattva mahāsattva Mahāmati spoke these words to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, what are the five acts of immediate retribution spoken of by the Blessed One, by committing which a son or daughter of good family goes to the Avīci hell?"

The Blessed One said, "Mahāmati, then listen very well and bear it in mind, and I will explain it to you."

Saying, "Excellent, Blessed One," the bodhisattva mahāsattva Mahāmati listened to the Blessed One, and the Blessed One spoke these words: "Mahāmati, what are the five acts of immediate retribution? They are killing one's father, one's mother, or an arhat; dividing the Saṅgha; and drawing the blood of the Tathāgata with malicious intent."

Now, Mahāmati, what is the mother of beings? Craving, which brings renewed existence and is accompanied by delight and attachment, stands as the mother. Ignorance is like the father, because it gives rise to the village of the sense sources. If these two, father and mother, are cut off entirely at the root, that is the killing of father and mother. And what is the killing of an arhat? The latent tendencies are like enemies, and like rat poison they have the nature of rising up from within. If they are utterly destroyed, that is the killing of an arhat. And what is the splitting of the Saṅgha? The aggregates form an assembly whose characteristics are at odds with one another. When that assembly is utterly destroyed at the root, it is called the splitting of the Saṅgha.

Mahāmati, consider the eight assemblies of consciousness, which take particular and general characteristics, and the external world, to be mere appearances of one's own mind. If they are utterly destroyed by the uncontaminated malice of the three liberations, that is the drawing of blood with malice from the buddha who is consciousness, and it is called committing the deeds of immediate consequence. Mahāmati, if a son of good family or a daughter of good family commits these five deeds of immediate consequence, that one comes to clear realization. Such a one is a doer of the deeds of immediate consequence.

Furthermore, Mahāmati, I shall explain to you the external deeds of immediate consequence, so that through this explanation you and the other bodhisattva great beings will not fall into deep confusion in the future. They are the deeds of immediate consequence spoken of in the expression of the teaching. One who has committed them does not come to clear realization through any of

the three liberations, except for realization through the blessing of emanation.

Mahāmati, a śrāvaka who is an emanation, through the blessing of a bodhisattva or the blessing of a tathāgata, may have someone in mind who has committed a deed of immediate consequence and become remorseful. He thinks, "I will make him enthusiastic once more, to turn back his remorse and so that he does not dwell in remorse at having abandoned his effort." With that aim, this emanated śrāvaka displays clear realization through the blessing of emanation.

Mahāmati, for one who commits the deeds of immediate consequence there is no certainty whatever of clear realization. The one exception is this: he may understand body, enjoyments and abode as mere appearances of his own mind, and see that the conceptual thought which conceives them, grasping at self and mine, is utterly void. Then, if he perchance meets a spiritual friend, he will be freed from the faults of his own conceptual thought in another rebirth.

On this it is said:

Craving is declared to be the mother,
And ignorance is known as the father.
Because consciousness cognizes objects,
It in turn is taught to be the buddha.
The latent tendencies are the arhat,
The five aggregates assembled are the Saṅgha.
Because these are cut off with no interval between,
That is the deed of immediate consequence.

Then Mahāmati again requested, "Blessed One, please explain to me the buddhahood of the buddhas. Blessed One, in what way is it the buddhahood of the buddhas?"

The Blessed One said, "It comes from realizing the selflessness of phenomena and of persons, from thoroughly knowing and comprehending the two obscurations, from attaining the two kinds of death and transference, and from abandoning the two afflictions. Mahāmati, that is the buddhahood of the buddha blessed ones. Mahāmati, by comprehending these very dharmas, śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas also attain buddhahood. Therefore, Mahāmati, I teach a single vehicle."

On this it is said:

The two selflessnesses, the afflictions,
And likewise the two kinds of obscuration,
And by attaining the death and transference
Of inconceivable transformation, one is a tathāgata.

The Noble Descent into Laṅkā, fifth fascicle.

Then once again the bodhisattva great being Mahāmati spoke to the Blessed One: "The Blessed One, entering the midst of the assembly, said: 'All the buddhas who have passed away are I myself. In the many different births of the birth stories, too, I myself was, at those various times, King Māndhātṛ, the elephant, Śuka, Vyāsa, Indra, Sunetra and the others.' With what intention did the Blessed One speak, when he told the hundred thousand birth stories?"

The Blessed One said, "Mahāmati, when the tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly complete buddhas, enter the midst of the assembly, they have four kinds of sameness in mind when they utter the words, 'At that time, in that age, I myself was Krakucchanda, Kanakamuni and Kāśyapa.' And what four kinds of sameness do they have in mind? Sameness of letters, sameness of speech, sameness of Dharma, and sameness of body. Mahāmati, the tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly complete buddhas, have these four kinds of sameness in mind when they enter the midst of the assembly and utter those words.

"Now, Mahāmati, what is sameness of letters? The very letters that make my name, Buddha, are the same letters for those buddha blessed ones. Mahāmati, those letters do not differ in their nature as letters. That, Mahāmati, is sameness of letters.

"Now, Mahāmati, what is the sameness of speech of the tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly complete buddhas? The articulation of my speech issues forth with the sixty-four aspects of Brahmā's melodious voice. Mahāmati, the articulation of the speech of those tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly complete buddhas likewise issues forth with the sixty-four aspects of Brahmā's melodious voice. In their nature as the voice of the kalaviṅka bird and the melodious voice of Brahmā, there is no difference between them, nothing more and nothing less.

"And what is sameness of body? I and those tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly complete buddhas are the same and without distinction in the Dharma body, in form, and in the body adorned with the excellent major and minor marks. The one exception is that, for the sake of training beings, the tathāgatas

display various forms in the various destinies of beings."

Now, Mahāmati, what is sameness of Dharma? It is this: those buddhas and I have realized the thirty-seven factors of awakening. Mahāmati, it is with these four kinds of sameness in mind that the Tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly and completely awakened buddhas, make such statements when they go among the assembly. On this it is said:

"Kāśyapa, Krakucchanda,
and Kanakamuni too were I."
Because we are the same in sameness,
I have spoken thus to the Victor's heirs.

Again Mahāmati asked: "The Blessed One has said: 'From the night the Tathāgata attains perfect and complete awakening until the night he passes into final nirvāṇa, in all that time the Tathāgata has not spoken a single syllable, does not speak, and will not speak, for non-speech is the speech of the Buddha.' With what in mind did the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly and completely awakened buddha, say that non-speech is the speech of the Buddha?"

The Blessed One replied: "Mahāmati, I said this with two dharmas in mind. What are the two? They are the dharmatā realized by each for oneself, and the dharmatā of the ancient way. Mahāmati, it is with these two dharmas in mind that I said this.

"What is meant by the dharmatā realized by each for oneself? It is this: the domain of individual self-awareness that those Tathāgatas realized, free from the conceptuality of words and released from the domain of letters and of duality, I too have realized, with nothing added and nothing missing.

"And what is the dharmatā of the ancient way? Mahāmati, it is this: this path of the ancient nature of things is like a mine of gold, silver, and pearls. Mahāmati, the abiding of the realm of phenomena remains whether Tathāgatas appear or do not appear. Its dharmatā, its abiding as Dharma, its immutability as Dharma, continue on like the road to an ancient city.

"Suppose, Mahāmati, that a certain person wandering in the wilderness saw an ancient city entered by a road that does not stray, and went to that city, entered it, dwelt in the city, and enjoyed the activities and pleasures of the city. Mahāmati, what do you think of that? Were the road by which he entered the city and the many features of the city made by that person?"

Mahāmati replied, "No, Blessed One."

The Blessed One said: "Just so, Mahāmati, the dharmatā that I and those Tathāgatas have realized, its abiding as Dharma, its immutability as Dharma, its suchness, its reality, its truth, simply remain. Therefore, for that reason, Mahāmati, I said: 'From the night the Tathāgata attains perfect and complete awakening until the night he passes into final nirvāṇa, in all that time the Tathāgata has not spoken a single syllable and will not speak.'" On this it is said:

From the night on which I realized
to that on which I passed into nirvāṇa,
in all the time between,
I taught nothing at all.
With the personally realized Dharma and the ancient way
in mind, I have proclaimed this.
Those buddhas and I
make not the slightest difference.

Then again the bodhisattva, the great being Mahāmati, made this request to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, please explain the characteristics of the existence and nonexistence of all phenomena, so that I and the other bodhisattva great beings may abandon existence and nonexistence and swiftly awaken fully to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening."

The Blessed One said: "Then, Mahāmati, listen very well and keep it in mind, and I shall explain it to you."

"Excellent, Blessed One," replied the bodhisattva, the great being Mahāmati, and he listened to the Blessed One. Then the Blessed One spoke to him as follows:

"Mahāmati, these worlds rest on two things: they rest on existence and they rest on nonexistence. Having fallen into views that hold to arising and to non-arising, they conceive of an escape where there is no escape.

"Now, Mahāmati, how does the world rest on existence? It is like this: in the world, things arise from causes and conditions that exist, not from ones that do not exist. What exists arises as arising; what does not exist does not. Mahāmati, those who speak thus of things as existing do not speak of causes and conditions and the world as existing from what is causeless.

"And how, Mahāmati, does one rest on nonexistence? It is like this: having accepted attachment, aversion, and delusion, one afterwards conceives of attachment, aversion, and delusion as nonexistent. Mahāmati, there is the one who does not accept things as existent because the characteristics of things are utterly isolated, and who, because the characteristics of things are utterly isolated, does not accept attachment, aversion, and delusion in buddhas, śrāvakas, and pratyekabuddhas. Mahāmati, of these, the one called 'existent' and the one called 'nonexistent', which is the destroyer?"

Mahāmati replied, "Blessed One, it is the one who accepted attachment, aversion, and delusion and later does not accept them."

The Blessed One said: "Excellent, Mahāmati, excellent! Mahāmati, that you have understood it so is excellent of you. Mahāmati, it is not merely the nonexistence of attachment, aversion, and delusion that such a one destroys; he also destroys the śrāvakas, the pratyekabuddhas, and the buddhas. Why is that? Because the afflictions are not apprehended as one or as different, or as internal or external. Mahāmati, because attachment, aversion, and delusion have no body, they are not apprehended as internal or external. Mahāmati, by not accepting the entities of attachment, aversion, and delusion, one also destroys the buddhas, the śrāvakas, and the pratyekabuddhas."

"Because there is nothing to be bound and no cause of bondage, those buddhas, śrāvakas, and pratyekabuddhas are liberated by their very nature. Mahāmati, if there were something to be bound, there would also be bondage and a cause of bondage. Mahāmati, one who speaks in this way is also a destroyer. Mahāmati, that is the characteristic of nonexistence. Mahāmati, it was with this in mind that I said: 'Better a view of a person as large as Mount Meru than the view of emptiness held by one who is proud about existence and nonexistence.' Mahāmati, one who is proud about nonexistence is also a destroyer.

"A mind that has fallen into particular and general characteristics does not fully understand them to be mere appearances of one's own mind. Not understanding this, it views external things as impermanent, and so it imagines the aggregates, elements, and sense sources as divided, split apart moment after moment. If it conceives of what is beyond letters as arising and ceasing through the continuity of a series, that too is destructive."

On this it is said:

"Whatever lies in the domain of mind
Is the two extremes, existence and nonexistence.
When that domain has been wholly abandoned,
Mind too will truly cease.

Because there is no grasping at objects,
It is not that there is no cessation.
Just like the domain of the noble ones,
There is the abode of suchness.

That through conditions, out of existence and nonexistence,
What had not arisen is born,
And having arisen then perishes:
That has no place in my teaching.

If neither buddhas nor non-Buddhists,
Neither I nor any others,
Have established existence through conditions,
How then could there be nonexistence?

Who has ever established existents,
That they should become nonexistent through conditions?
Those who assert arising, through their wrong view,
Imagine views of existence and nonexistence.

Those for whom nothing whatever arises
And nothing whatever ceases,
Since they see the world as void,
Do not grasp at existence and nonexistence."

Then once again the bodhisattva great being Mahāmati addressed the Blessed One: "Blessed One, there is a thorough realization of the distinctions among the different characteristics of the way of the established truth (siddhānta). Through it, I and the other bodhisattva great beings will understand the realization of the characteristics of the way of the established truth, will quickly awaken fully into unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening, and will not fall under the sway of speculators, of misguided non-Buddhists, or of any māras. Please explain to me the characteristics of the way of the established truth. Sugata, please explain it to me. Tathāgata, arhat, perfectly and completely awakened Buddha, supreme among speakers, please explain it to me."

The Blessed One said, "Mahāmati, therefore listen very well and keep it in mind, and I shall explain it to you."

"Excellent, Blessed One," he replied, and the bodhisattva great being Mahāmati listened to the Blessed One. The Blessed One then spoke to him as follows:

"Mahāmati, the characteristics of the way of the established truth of all śrāvakas, pratyekabuddhas, and bodhisattvas are of two kinds, namely the way of the established truth and the way of teaching.

"Mahāmati, the way of the established truth is this: it is the characteristic of the distinction of personal self-awareness. It brings about the attainment of the realization of the undefiled realm, which is free of verbal conceptualization and of letters. It is the intrinsic characteristic of personal realization, which has left behind all non-Buddhists and māras. Having vanquished all those speculators, non-Buddhists, and māras, personal self-awareness shines in its beauty. Mahāmati, that is the characteristic of the way of the established truth.

"What, then, is the way of teaching? It is this: the ninefold teaching expounded in its variety. Abandoning the positions of oneness and difference, of existence and nonexistence, and preceded by the procedures of skillful means, the teaching enters into all beings: whatever each one is inclined toward, that is what is taught to them. Mahāmati, that is the characteristic of the way of teaching, and you and the other bodhisattva great beings should strive in it."

On this it is said:

"The established truth and the ways
Are personal self-awareness and teaching.
Those who see with knowledge of their difference
Do not fall under the power of speculation.

If there is no true thing at all
Such as fools imagine,
How is it that the speculators
Do not hold liberation to be the absence of things?

Even when they look at conditioned things one by one
As bound up with arising and perishing,
The two views grow ever greater,
And, being inverted, they do not see.

When one sees the worlds as imagined, as illusions,
And as like the trunk of a plantain tree,
Nirvāṇa, in which mentation is abandoned,
This alone is the truth.

There is no attachment and no aversion,
There is no delusion and no person.
The aggregates that arise from craving
Exist only as a dream."

Then once again the bodhisattva great being Mahāmati addressed the Blessed One: "Blessed One, please explain to me the characteristics of false imagination. Sugata, please explain them to me. Blessed One, how, as what, through what, and in whom does false imagination come to arise? Blessed One, when one speaks of false imagination as 'false imagination,' Blessed One, what is it that is called false imagination? Through examining what does it become false imagination?"

The Blessed One said, "Excellent, excellent, Mahāmati! In asking about such a matter, Mahāmati, you have set out for the benefit of many people, for the happiness of many people, out of compassion for the world, and for the welfare, benefit, and happiness of gods, humans, and the great multitude of beings. Excellent! Mahāmati, therefore listen very well and keep it in mind, and I shall explain it to you."

"Excellent, Blessed One," he replied, and the bodhisattva great being Mahāmati listened to the Blessed One. The Blessed One then spoke to him as follows:

"Mahāmati, people's conceptuality arises because they are attached to what is falsely imagined as a diverse variety of distinct objects. Mahāmati, there are those who are attached to and cling to the grasped and the grasper, whose understanding has not realized that things are merely appearances of their own mind. And, Mahāmati, there are those who have fallen to the side of views of existence and nonexistence, whose habitual tendencies of discriminating conceptuality toward the views of the non-Buddhists (tīrthikas) have grown very strong. In these beings many minds and mental factors arise, known as 'conceptuality,' because they are attached to perceiving diverse external objects and attached to self and what belongs to self."

Mahāmati said: "Blessed One, suppose people's conceptuality arises because they are attached to falsely imagining a diverse variety of distinct objects.

Suppose those who have fallen into views on the side of existence and nonexistence, into the grasped and the grasper, whose habitual tendencies of discriminating the views of the tīrthikas have grown strong, are attached to perceiving diverse external objects. Suppose they do not know that things are merely appearances of their own mind, and so, attached to diverse things as existent and nonexistent, many minds and mental factors arise in them, known as 'conceptuality.' Blessed One, this conceptuality is turned away from the characteristic of the views that have fallen to the side of the existence and nonexistence of the characteristics of diverse external objects, and that are devoid of entity and nonentity. Likewise, Blessed One, the ultimate too is turned away from the characteristics of valid cognition, the sense faculties, parts, examples, and reasons. Blessed One, how then is it that in the one case conceptuality arises through discriminating attachment to diverse things of unreal objects as existent and nonexistent, while in the case of attachment to and conceptualizing of the characteristic of the ultimate, conceptuality does not arise? Blessed One, if you say that it arises in the one case and does not arise in the other, you will be propounding attachment to the side of existence and nonexistence, and a cause that is not consistent. If you say that the view of false conceptuality arises, then, just as a single form is made up out of the diverse distinct illusory limbs of a person, so diverse characteristics are imagined through discrimination. And because this turns away from conceiving entity and nonentity, your teaching would fall into the view and the outlook of the worldly Lokāyatas."

The Blessed One said: "Mahāmati, conceptuality neither arises nor ceases. Why is that? It is because conceptuality does not arise from existence and nonexistence, because the things that appear as external are not things, and because one understands them as merely appearances of one's own mind. So, Mahāmati, there is neither arising nor ceasing of conceptuality. Mahāmati, nevertheless, I have taught that conceptuality arises, preceded by what has come down from the past, because fools imagine through the conceptuality of their own diverse minds and are attached to the characteristics of diverse things. I taught it to show how these foolish ordinary beings come to comprehend things as merely their own conceptualizing mind. They turn their views away from attachment to self and what belongs to self, and turn away from the faults of cause, condition, and result. By realizing things as merely appearances of their own mind, their mind and outlook are thoroughly transformed. Having gained understanding of all the grounds, they will attain

the domain of personal self-awareness of me, the Tathāgata, the turning away of the five dharmas, of natures, of things, of views, and of conceptuality. Therefore, Mahāmati, I have said this: conceptuality toward illusion arises as attachment to diverse unreal objects, and by fully knowing the objects of one's own diverse conceptuality as they truly are, one becomes liberated."

On this it is said:

Those who say the world arises
Through causes and through conditions
Are bound up with the four extremes;
They do not know my way.

From causes and from conditions
The world is not born as existent or nonexistent.
Since it is in no way existent or nonexistent,
How can fools imagine it so?

Not existent, not nonexistent, not both existent and nonexistent:
When the world is seen in this way,
Then the mind too turns away,
And selflessness is realized.

Because they arise from conditions,
All things are unborn.
All conditions are results,
And from a result no existence is born.

Since a result would then be twofold,
No result is born from a result.
Because it would become twofold,
No resultant thing is found.

When conditioned things are seen
Without perceiving and perceived,
That is the mind-only of no mind;
This too I have taught as mind-only.

"Only" is the shape of essential nature,
Free of conditions and of things;
The ultimate thing, the supreme brahman:
This I have taught as "only."

The self is in truth imputed;
It is not a substantially existent thing.
Likewise the aggregate-ness of the aggregates
Is imputed and without substance.

Sameness is of four kinds:
Arising from marks, from causes, and from things,
And the sameness of selflessness,
The fourth, belonging to the yoga of yogins.

Turning away all views,
Free of conceiving and imagining,
Without object and without birth:
This too I have taught as mind-only.

Neither nonentity nor non-entity,
Entirely free of entity and nonentity,
And likewise liberation from mind:
This too I have taught as mind-only.

Suchness and the limit of emptiness,
Nirvāṇa and the realm of phenomena,
And the diverse mind-made bodies:
These too I have taught as mind-only.

Bound up with the habitual tendencies of conceptuality,
Arising from the diverse mind,
It appears to people as external:
This is the mind-only of the worldly.

What appears externally does not exist;
It is mind that appears as diverse things,
Appearing like body, enjoyments, and abode:
This too I have taught as mind-only.

Then again the bodhisattva, the great being Mahāmati, said this to the Blessed One:

"The Blessed One has said that bodhisattva great beings and others should not grasp the meaning according to the words. How, then, Blessed One, does a bodhisattva great being avoid grasping the meaning according to the words? What is the word, and what is the meaning?"

The Blessed One said, "Mahāmati, then listen very well and keep it in mind, and I shall explain it to you."

Saying, "Excellent, Blessed One," the bodhisattva great being Mahāmati listened to the Blessed One once more, and the Blessed One spoke to him thus:

"Now, Mahāmati, what is the word? It is conceptuality bound up with words and letters. That which comes from the joining of teeth, jaws, palate, tongue and lips, and which is born, as people speak with one another, from the cause of the habitual tendencies of conceptuality, is called the word.

"Now, Mahāmati, what is the meaning? A bodhisattva great being goes alone into solitude. By the wisdom that comes from hearing, reflection and meditation, he uses his own understanding to examine thoroughly the path that leads to the city of nirvāṇa. That path is the domain of the noble ones' self-realized knowledge, and it is preceded by the transformation of the basis of habitual tendencies. He also examines the distinctions among the grounds and the other stations of the grounds, and how one enters into the characteristic of meaning. When he examines these things thoroughly, he is skilled in meaning.

"Moreover, Mahāmati, a bodhisattva great being who is skilled in word and meaning rightly sees that word and meaning, or meaning and word, are neither one nor different. Mahāmati, if word and meaning were different, the word could not be the cause that makes the meaning clear. Yet the word gives access to that meaning, as a lamp does to one's valuables. Mahāmati, it is like a certain person who takes up a lamp and looks at his valuables, saying, 'Here in this place is my wealth, of such a kind.' Just so, Mahāmati, by the lamp of the word, which is conceptualized in speech, bodhisattva great beings gain access to the object of self-realized meaning, which is free from the conceptuality of words.

"Moreover, Mahāmati, consider non-arising, non-cessation, being by nature completely in nirvāṇa, the three vehicles, the one vehicle, the five dharmas, mind, intrinsic nature and the rest. Some cling to these on the basis of clinging to the words just as they are. Because they cling in this way, they fall into views of superimposition and denial, like the conceptuality that sees various illusions. For they conceptualize in one way what abides in another. Mahāmati, various illusions are seen as other than they are. In the same way the childish conceptualize things as other than they are, but the noble ones do not."

On this it is said:

Having conceived of words just as they are,
They superimpose even upon the nature of reality.
Because they superimpose upon it,
Those beings fall into the abodes of hell.

There is no self in the aggregates,
Nor are the aggregates in the self.
They do not exist as they are conceived,
Yet neither are they nonexistent.

The childish conceive
That all things exist.
If things existed just as they are seen,
Then everyone would see the truth.

Since all phenomena are nonexistent,
There is neither affliction nor purity.
They do not exist as they are seen,
Yet neither are they nonexistent.

"Moreover, Mahāmati, I shall explain to you the characteristics of wisdom and consciousness. By thoroughly understanding their distinct aspects, you and the other bodhisattva great beings will comprehend the characteristics of wisdom and consciousness, and you will quickly and fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening.

"Now, Mahāmati, wisdom is of three kinds: worldly, supramundane, and highest supramundane. Among these, what arises and then perishes is consciousness. What neither arises nor perishes is wisdom.

"Moreover, Mahāmati, consciousness falls into signs and signlessness. It falls into existence and nonexistence, and it is born from the cause of various characteristics. The characteristic that wholly transcends signs and signlessness is wisdom.

"Moreover, Mahāmati, the characteristic of accumulating is consciousness, and the characteristic of diminishing is wisdom.

"Now, the three kinds are these: the kind that understands particular and general characteristics, the kind that understands arising and perishing, and the kind that understands non-arising and non-cessation.

"Worldly wisdom belongs to all tīrthikas and all childish ordinary beings, who cling to the positions of existence and nonexistence.

"Supramundane wisdom belongs to all śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas, who cling to an outlook that falls into particular and general characteristics.

"The highest supramundane wisdom is that of the buddhas and bodhisattvas. It thoroughly discerns the dharma that is without appearance. It sees non-arising and non-cessation, and it is free from the positions of existence and nonexistence. It arises because they realize the selflessness of the ground of the Tathāgata.

"Moreover, Mahāmati, the characteristic of non-attachment is wisdom, and the characteristic of attachment to various objects is consciousness.

"Moreover, Mahāmati, the characteristic of arising through the activity in which three things come together is consciousness. The characteristic of an essential nature that does not arise in this way is wisdom.

"Moreover, Mahāmati, the characteristic of non-attainment is wisdom. It is the domain realized by one's own individual noble wisdom, and so it neither enters nor emerges, like the moon in water."

On this it is said:

By the mind, karmas are accumulated;
By gnosis they are analyzed;
And by wisdom the imageless
And powers are fully attained.

The mind is bound up with objects;
Gnosis engages in reasoning;
In the imageless and the distinctive
Wisdom truly and fully engages.

Having abandoned mind, mentation, consciousness,
Perception and conception,
Those who have attained the dharma of conceptuality,
The śrāvakas, are not the Victor's heirs.

In the distinction of fields and patience,
The Tathāgata's gnosis is pure;
It arises for the sake of the distinctive meaning,
Utterly free of all active functioning.

My wisdom is of three kinds:
That by which the noble is made manifest,
That by which characteristics are realized,
And that which is bound up with things.

Not joined to the two vehicles,
Wisdom is free of appearances.
Through clinging to things as existent,
It arises for the śrāvakas.
Because it enters into mind only,
The wisdom of the Sugata is stainless.

Furthermore, Mahāmati, there are nine kinds of views of transformation held by the tīrthikas who teach transformation, namely: transformation of shape, transformation of characteristic, transformation of cause, transformation of reasoning, transformation of view, transformation of birth, transformation of thing, transformation of conditions becoming manifest, and transformation of action becoming manifest. Mahāmati, these are the nine views of transformation. Having reflected on them, all the tīrthikas teach the existence of a self, and transformation as arising from what does not exist.

What, then, is transformation of shape? It is this: because a shape is seen to turn into something else, just as gold is seen to turn into various ornaments. For example, Mahāmati, gold is made into bracelets, rings, pendants, and so forth; when it is transformed it appears to have become various shapes, yet the substance of the gold does not change. In the same way, Mahāmati, some tīrthikas imagine that all things transform, and some imagine it of the cause. Having seized on imputation, these are neither so nor otherwise. Thus all the different transformations should be regarded like curd, milk, liquor, and the ripening of fruit. For example, Mahāmati, curd, milk, liquor, fruit, and the like are each imagined by those tīrthikas to be transformations; but in this case, since external things, which are appearances of one's own mind, have no substance, neither existence nor nonexistence transforms in any way at all. Likewise, Mahāmati, regard this as the operation of the habituated conceptuality of childish ordinary beings. Mahāmati, just as with seeing forms arise in an illusion or a dream, here no dharma whatsoever enters into being or turns back. For example, Mahāmati, just as in a dream one sees the son of a barren woman being born and dying, so too one sees entering and turning back.

On this it is said:

Those who imagine of elements, things and faculties,
Of time, of shape, and of transformation,
And of taking up the intermediate existence,
Are not wise.

The Victors do not imagine
The world as dependently arisen;
Rather, these worlds
Are mere conditions, like a city of gandharvas.

Then again the bodhisattva mahāsattva Mahāmati, in order to elucidate the meaning of the connections of all dharmas, made this request to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, please explain to me the characteristics of connection and non-connection of all dharmas, so that, through fully realizing the specific distinctions of the different characteristics of connection and non-connection, I and the other bodhisattva mahāsattvas, skilled in the means regarding all connections and non-connections, will not fall into the connection that clings to meaning according to the literal sound; so that, skilled in the connection and non-connection of all dharmas, and having destroyed with intelligence the discriminations of words and letters, we will move among the assemblies of all buddha fields, sealed with the seal of the powers, the masteries, the superknowledges and the dhāraṇīs; possessing, through the various light rays of emanation, the ten culminating states, and an intellect perfectly joined, equal to the spontaneous mode of operation of the moon, the sun, a jewel, and the great elements; turning our views away from the characteristics of our own conceptualizing about all dharmas, and, by seeing all dharmas as dreams, illusions and the like, entering into the abode of the buddha ground; and so that, teaching the Dharma to all the realms of sentient beings according to their dispositions, we will lead them, having abandoned the positions of existence and nonexistence regarding all dharmas, which are like dreams, illusions and the like, and will establish them in what is free of conceptions of arising and ceasing by means of the state that engages different verbal expressions. May the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha, please explain this to me."

The Blessed One said, "Excellent, excellent! Mahāmati, therefore listen very well and keep it in mind, and I shall explain it to you."

Saying, "Excellent, Blessed One," the bodhisattva mahāsattva Mahāmati listened again to the Blessed One, and the Blessed One spoke to him thus:

Mahāmati, the linkages of attachment to the words of all phenomena taken literally are immeasurable. There is the linkage of attachment to characteristics, the linkage of attachment to conditions, the linkage of attachment to entity and nonentity, the linkage of attachment to the conceptualization of arising and non-arising, the linkage of discrimination through attachment to cessation and non-cessation, the linkage of attachment to characteristics, the linkage of discrimination through attachment to vehicle and non-vehicle, the linkage of attachment to discriminating the conditioned and the unconditioned, the linkage of attachment to conceptualizing the grounds and the specific characteristics of the grounds, the linkage of realizing one's own conceptualizations, the linkage of discriminating the positions of existence and nonexistence, the ground of the non-Buddhists (tīrthikas), and the linkage of conceptualizing the realization of the three vehicles and the one vehicle.

Mahāmati, these and others are the linkages by which foolish ordinary beings conceptualize their own domains. Bound fast in these linkages, foolish ordinary beings discriminate, attached to and clinging to the characteristic of linkage with entity and nonentity. Like silkworms, because they wish to be linked through the views of their own conceptualization, they wrap themselves and others all around with the thread of linkage spun from the views of their own conceptualization.

Mahāmati, for one who sees all phenomena as utterly secluded, there is here no linkage at all and no characteristic of linkage whatsoever. Mahāmati, because conceptuality does not operate, the bodhisattva, the great being, views all phenomena as secluded and abides in that.

Furthermore, Mahāmati, one who understands external entity and nonentity as characteristics of what appears to one's own mind, who follows mind-only, which is free of appearances, and who sees the linkages of conceptuality regarding all entities, existent and nonexistent, as utterly secluded, finds no linkage in any phenomenon and no characteristic of linkage either. Mahāmati, here there is no bondage whatsoever and no liberation; otherwise, it is through an intellect fallen into error that one conceives of bondage and liberation. Why is that? Because in all phenomena no linkage to existence or nonexistence is apprehended.

Furthermore, Mahāmati, the linkages of foolish ordinary beings are of three kinds: attachment, aversion, and delusion. Then there is the craving for renewed existence that is accompanied by joy and attachment, and that through which, once linked, the linkages of the destinies arise. Here, the linking of sentient beings into the five destinies is linkage. Mahāmati, once linkage is cut off, there is no longer any knowing of linkage or of the characteristic of linkage.

Furthermore, Mahāmati, because of attachment to the condition of the meeting of the three and to the application of activity, the consciousnesses become linked; and through attachment in the manner of uninterrupted operation, there comes to be linkage to existence. By turning away from the condition of the meeting of the three for the consciousnesses, and by seeing the three gates of liberation, no linkages whatsoever arise.

On this it is said:

Unreal discrimination
Is called the characteristic of linkage;
When it is correctly and fully known,
The net of linkage is cut.

Grasping words as knowledge of entities,
Just like the silkworm,
Fools, unskilled regarding linkage,
Are bound by their own conceptuality.

Then Mahāmati again asked: "The Blessed One has said this: 'Whatever entities are imagined by whatever conceptuality, they are merely imputed; they have no intrinsic nature.' Blessed One, if they are merely imputed and no characteristic of an intrinsic nature of entities is found, then, as the Blessed One has said, since all phenomena would be of an imputed nature, there would be no entities of affliction or of purification either."

The Blessed One said: "Mahāmati, so it is; it is just as you have said. Mahāmati, the intrinsic nature of entities is not such as foolish ordinary beings imagine it to be. That is merely imputed; the intrinsic nature and characteristic of entities are not found. Yet, Mahāmati, the intrinsic nature of entities is just as the noble ones realize it to be through noble wisdom, noble vision, and the eye of noble discernment."

Mahāmati asked: "Blessed One, if the essential nature of entities is just as the noble ones realize it, not through the miraculous eye or the eye of flesh but through noble wisdom, noble vision, and the eye of noble discernment, and if it is not as foolish ordinary beings imagine the intrinsic nature of entities to be, then, Blessed One, how will the conceptuality of foolish ordinary beings turn back, since they do not understand the entity that is the noble nature? Blessed One, they are neither mistaken nor unmistaken. Why is that? Because they do not understand the intrinsic nature of the essence of the noble entity, and because they see a turning away from the characteristics of existence and nonexistence. Blessed One, even the way the noble ones discriminate entities does not hold good either, because it is not a sphere of activity concerned with an object having specific characteristics. Blessed One, their intrinsic nature and characteristic of entities too, being taught as an illusion, appear as nothing but the imputed nature. That is to say, through falling into views about the characteristics of entities, it becomes the domain of others; and, Blessed One, because they do not understand the specific characteristics of entities, those are not as they really are, and so there would be an infinite regress."

"Blessed One, when what arises from the cause of the imputed nature is not the characteristic of the intrinsic nature of things, how is it that things do not come to be just as they are imagined, as they are discriminated by conceptualizing? Blessed One, the characteristic of discrimination is one thing, and the characteristic of the intrinsic nature of things is another. Blessed One, conceptuality and the characteristic of intrinsic nature are dissimilar as causes. So when childish ordinary beings imagine them in terms of one another, how is it that things do not come to be just so? Is it in this way, in order to turn back the conceptuality of beings, that you say that things do not exist just as they are discriminated by discrimination? Blessed One, do you turn back the views of existence and nonexistence held by beings, only to establish them in the view of existence, through clinging to the intrinsic nature of things and clinging to the domain and object of noble wisdom? By teaching the entity that is the essential nature of noble wisdom, do you do away with the teaching of the Dharma of utter solitude?"

The Blessed One declared: "Mahāmati, by teaching the intrinsic nature of noble things I neither do away with the teaching of the Dharma of utter solitude nor establish beings in the view of existence. Rather, Mahāmati, it is in order to remove completely the ground of fear for beings who, since beginningless time, have clung to the characteristic of the intrinsic nature of

things, that I teach the Dharma of utter solitude by way of a view that takes as its characteristic clinging to the intrinsic nature of things as known by noble wisdom. Mahāmati, I have not in fact taught an intrinsic nature of things. But, Mahāmati, in this way, having realized for oneself just as it really is, one comes to practise solitude. Seeing that in error there are no signs, one enters into what is merely the appearance of one's own mind, and turns back the views of external appearances as entities and non-entities. Thoroughly sealed by the three liberations with the seal of realizing just as it really is, and having abandoned entities of existence and nonexistence, one comes to abide in direct perception of the intrinsic nature of things, through the intelligence of individual self-knowing.

"Furthermore, Mahāmati, a bodhisattva mahāsattva should not make the proposition, 'All phenomena are unborn.' Why is that? Because the proposition too is included among all things, and because it has the characteristic of proceeding from its own cause, if one makes the proposition and states, 'All things are unborn,' then, Mahāmati, that bodhisattva mahāsattva falls from his proposition. Since the proposition too arises in dependence on that, whoever makes the proposition, 'All things are unborn,' his proposition too is defeated. If, on the other hand, that proposition too is unborn because it is included among all phenomena, then the proposition too is not distinct in characteristic; and because it is unborn, the assertion that all phenomena are unborn is utterly defeated. Owing to the cause, the members of the proposition, the proposition is not born from existence and nonexistence. Mahāmati, that proposition too, being included among all things, has the characteristic of being unborn from existence and nonexistence. Mahāmati, if by means of that unborn proposition one proposes that all things are unborn, even so one falls from one's proposition. The proposition should not be made from the characteristic of things that are not born from existence and nonexistence. Mahāmati, their proposition too has the characteristic of an unborn nature. Therefore, Mahāmati, because it incurs the fault of many errors, you should not make that proposition. And because the members too have the dissimilar characteristic of being causes of one another, and because they are produced, the members should not be put forward as a proposition.

"Mahāmati, it is thus: although a bodhisattva mahāsattva should not make the proposition that all phenomena are unborn, and likewise that all phenomena are empty and without essential nature, Mahāmati, a bodhisattva mahāsattva should teach all things as being like an illusion and a dream. Otherwise,

Mahāmati, so that the childish who have fallen into existence and nonexistence will not be frightened and will not become distant from the Great Vehicle, and in order to remove the ground of fear for the childish, one should teach all phenomena as like an illusion and a dream, because of the characteristic of appearing and not appearing, because of views, and because they deceive the intellect."

On this it is said:

"There is no intrinsic nature and no cognition,
there is no entity and no ground of all;
these are imagined by the childish, like corpses,
by those with wrong conceptions.

In order to proclaim, against all non-Buddhists (tīrthikas),
that all phenomena are unborn:
a thing that is endowed with conditions
is not born for anyone, as existent or nonexistent.

To propose that all things
are unborn does not hold,
for its proof depends upon its cause;
their intellect too will be ruined.

Just as tangled hairs are falsely
seen by people with eye disease,
so this conceptualizing of things
is falsely imagined by the childish.

The three realms of existence are mere imagination;
there is no intrinsic nature of things.
The imagined, as the intrinsic nature of things,
is what the conceptualizers conceive.

Having passed beyond signs, the cognition of things,
and the stirrings of the mind,
my sons, having gone beyond them,
practise nonconceptuality.

Just as, in a mirage,
water is grasped where there is no water,
so are the childish toward appearances;
the noble ones are distinguished from them.

The vision of the noble ones is pure,
born of the three liberations,
freed from arising and perishing,
it moves wholly in the appearanceless.

Things are without appearance,
yet for the yogin they are not nonexistent either;
through the sameness of entity and non-entity
the fruit of the noble ones arises.

How do entity and non-entity
come to be made the same?
When the mind does not know
the stirrings outside and within,
then it brings them to destruction,
and sees the sameness of mind as well."

Mahāmati said: "The Blessed One has said this: when the object to be apprehended is not apprehended by knowledge, then one is established in cognition-only; since there is nothing grasped by cognition, the grasper too is without grasping.

"...since there is no grasping of that, the consciousness proclaimed as 'conceptual thought' does not operate either."

"When you say this, Blessed One, is it that knowledge does not perceive because it fails to comprehend the various particular and general characteristics of things as undifferentiated? Or is it that knowledge does not perceive because the essential nature of things with their various particular and general characteristics is overwhelmed? Or is it that knowledge does not perceive the object to be known because it is cut off by walls, fences, ponds, enclosures, earth, water, wind and fire, or because it is very far away or near? Or is it that the object to be known is not perceived because of having the faculties of the blind, of infants, or of the aged?

"Blessed One, if knowledge does not perceive because it fails to comprehend the various particular and general characteristics as undifferentiated, then, Blessed One, it should not even be called knowledge, for that which does not perceive an existing object is not-knowing. If knowledge does not perceive because the essential nature of things is overwhelmed by the various particular and general characteristics, then, Blessed One, that too is not-knowing; it is not knowledge. Blessed One, knowledge arises when there is

something knowable, not when there is none; and because it is connected with that, it is called knowledge of the knowable. If knowledge does not perceive because things are not perceived when cut off by walls, fences, ponds, enclosures, earth, water, wind and fire, or because they are very far away or near, or because the faculties are deficient through being an infant, aged or blind, then, Blessed One, an existing object is not perceived because the intellect is deficient, and that is not knowledge but not-knowing."

The Blessed One said: "Mahāmati, in that case it is not not-knowing; it is knowledge. Mahāmati, it was not with this in mind that I said, 'When knowledge does not perceive an object that is not perceived, that is establishing it as mere cognition.' Rather, because one comprehends that it is merely the appearance of one's own mind, and because external things, beyond existence and nonexistence, are without substance, knowledge does not perceive an object. Because it is not perceived, neither the knowable nor knowledge arises. Through realizing the three gates of liberation, knowledge too is not perceived. But those given to conceptual thought, whose intellects have been imbued since beginningless time with the habitual tendencies of elaborating existence and nonexistence, do not know it in this way. Because they do not know it, I teach mind-only: that once it is understood that there are no external things of substance, shape or characteristics, conceptual thought does not arise.

"Those who are attached to and cling to grasping at a self and at the characteristics of a self, not comprehending that it is merely the appearance of their own mind, conceptualize knowledge and the knowable as separate. Because they conceptualize knowledge and the knowable as separate, and find no discernment of the existence and nonexistence of external things, they come to rely on the view of annihilation."

On this it is said:

"If, while the object to be perceived exists,
Knowledge does not come to see it,
That is not knowledge but not-knowing:
Such is the way of those given to conceptual thought.
If, through non-otherness and lack of characteristics,
Through obstruction, nearness or distance,
Knowledge should not see,
That is called wrong knowledge.

In infants, the aged, and those gone blind,
If, while the knowable exists,
Knowledge does not arise,
That too is called wrong knowledge."

"Furthermore, Mahāmati, immature ordinary beings, with the beginningless elaborations and the bodily corruption, dance in the dance of their own discriminations, and are not skilled in the teaching of the mode of their own established tenet. Attached to the appearance of their own mind as the characteristics of external things, they are attached to the verbal expressions taught as skillful means, and do not cultivate the mode of their own established tenet, which is pure of the four extremes."

Mahāmati said: "Blessed One, it is so; it is just as you have said. Blessed One, please explain to me the characteristics of teaching and of the mode of established tenet, through which I and the other bodhisattva great beings in future times, being skilled in teaching and in the mode of established tenet, will not be deceived by non-Buddhists and by followers of the śrāvaka and pratyekabuddha vehicles who hold wrong conceptions."

The Blessed One said: "Mahāmati, therefore listen very well and keep it in mind, and I shall explain it to you."

"Excellent, Blessed One," he replied, and the bodhisattva great being Mahāmati listened to the Blessed One, and the Blessed One spoke to him thus: "Mahāmati, the modes of Dharma of the tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly complete buddhas of the past, future and present are twofold, namely the mode of teaching and the mode of setting forth established tenets individually.

"What, then, is the mode of verbal teaching? Mahāmati, it is the explaining of the various sūtras of the Dharma, teaching sentient beings in accordance with their minds and inclinations.

"Mahāmati, what, then, is the mode of established tenet? It is that by which yogins turn back conceptual thought about what is the appearance of their own mind. That is, what is free from the positions of oneness, difference, both and neither; what transcends mind, mentation and mental consciousness; the domain of the noble ones, known individually by oneself; turned away from the characteristics of cause, view and reasoning; not tasted by non-Buddhists or by followers of the śrāvaka and pratyekabuddha vehicles who hold wrong conceptions and have fallen into the extremes of existence and nonexistence:

this I explain as the established tenet. Mahāmati, you and the other bodhisattva great beings should strive in this mode of established tenet and this characteristic of teaching."

On this it is said:

"My mode is of two kinds:
Established tenet and teaching.
To the immature I explain in words;
For yogins there is the established tenet."

Then again the bodhisattva great being Mahāmati addressed the Blessed One thus: "Blessed One, once, on a certain occasion, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha, declared: 'One should not attend upon the Lokāyatikas, who possess mantras and manifold eloquence;

"...nor associate with it, nor honor it, for by relying on it one gathers worldly material things but does not gather the Dharma." Since this is so, why did the Blessed One say that by relying on the Lokāyata, with its mantras and its manifold eloquence, one gathers worldly material things but does not come to gather the Dharma?

"Mahāmati, the Lokāyata is mantras and manifold eloquence. With various reasons, words and phrases it bewilders the childish. It does not do so by being reasonable, and it does not do so by being meaningful. In this way it teaches the talk of the childish, and therefore, Mahāmati, it is called the Lokāyata of mantras and manifold eloquence. Through various pleasing phrases the childish do not enter the true way. Not understanding any phenomena themselves, the Lokāyatikas bewilder the childish with views that fall into the two extremes. Because they are not freed from the confines of the destinies of rebirth, they ruin themselves as well. Not understanding things to be mere appearances of their own minds, and attached to the intrinsic nature of external entities, their conceptuality does not cease.

"Therefore, Mahāmati, the Lokāyata of mantras and manifold eloquence is not freed from birth, old age, sickness, death, sorrow, lamentation, suffering, unhappiness, turmoil and the rest. With words, various phrases, and arguments built from reasons and examples, it bewilders the childish.

"Mahāmati, Indra too had a mind skilled in many treatises, and he taught a treatise on grammar of his own. Yet his disciple, assuming the form and guise of a nāga, issued a challenge in heaven before the assembled retinue of Indra:

'Either I shall break your thousand-spoked chariot, or else my nāga body and my hooded heads shall be cut off one by one.' Having made this challenge, that disciple of the Lokāyata, in the form and guise of a nāga, defeated Śakra (Indra), lord of the gods, who was endowed with the Dharma. He broke the thousand-spoked chariot and then came back to this world.

"Thus, Mahāmati, the Lokāyata is bound up with various reasons and examples. Even one taught by an animal can in this way bewilder the world of gods and asuras with various words and phrases. If it can establish them in attachment to views of accumulation and depletion, what need is there to speak of humans? Therefore, Mahāmati, because the Lokāyata brings about the causes from which suffering arises, it is to be abandoned entirely. One should not resort to it, one should not rely on it, one should not honor it.

"Mahāmati, the Lokāyatikas teach, with various words and phrases, no more than the body, the intellect, and the apprehension of objects. Mahāmati, the Lokāyata, of a hundred thousand, will in later times, in the final five hundred years, have its compendium split apart by teaching views that are the causes of evil conceptions. Through taking in those who are not true disciples, its compendium will split apart. Mahāmati, it is that very compendium of the Lokāyata, bound up with reasons and various words and split apart, that the tīrthikas, attached and clinging to their own reasons, expound; it is not a system of their own. Mahāmati, no tīrthika whatsoever has a system of his own treatise. Rather, they expound that same Lokāyata in many ways, through a hundred thousand gateways of reasoning. Although it is not their own system, out of delusion they do not know that this is the Lokāyata."

Mahāmati said, "Blessed One, if the tīrthikas, attached and clinging to their own reasons, expound that very Lokāyata with various words, phrases, examples and arguments, and it is not a system of their own, then is the Blessed One not also counted among those who set forth the scriptures of all the tīrthikas? For to the gods, humans and asuras who have come and arrived, gathering from every direction, he too teaches, with various words and phrases, that very Lokāyata, and it is not a scripture of his own, is it?"

The Blessed One said, "Mahāmati, I do not expound the Lokāyata, nor do I teach accumulation and depletion. Mahāmati, I teach the absence of accumulation and depletion. Here, Mahāmati, what is called accumulation is the heap of birth; it arises from coming together. Here, Mahāmati, what is called depletion is destruction. What is called the absence of accumulation and

depletion is a synonym for non-arising. Mahāmati, I do not teach anything that belongs among the conceptualizations of all the tīrthikas. Why is that? Because one is not attached to external entities or non-entities, abides in the mere appearance of one's own mind, does not engage conceptuality in the twofold manner, has no domain of signs, and understands things to be mere appearances of one's own mind, one does not engage in conceptualizing what appears from one's own mind. Because conceptuality is not engaged, one enters the three gateways of liberation, signlessness, emptiness and wishlessness, and therefore this is called liberation.

"Mahāmati, I recall that once, when I was staying in a certain place, a Lokāyatika brahmin came to where I was. Without the Blessed One having given him leave, he said this to me: 'O Gautama, everything is made.'

"Mahāmati, I replied to him: 'O brahmin, if everything is made, that is the first Lokāyata.'

"'O Gautama, everything is unmade.'

"'If, brahmin, everything is unmade, that too is the second Lokāyata. Likewise, everything is impermanent, everything is permanent, everything is produced, everything is not produced: these, brahmin, are six Lokāyatas.'

"Again, Mahāmati, the Lokāyatika brahmin said this to me: 'O Gautama, seeing various sound grounds of proof: everything is one; everything is distinct; everything is both; everything is neither; everything depends on causes.'

"'These, brahmin, are eleven Lokāyatas.'

"'Furthermore, O Gautama, everything is declared; everything is undeclared.'"

"A self exists. There is no self. This world exists. This world does not exist. The other world exists. The other world does not exist. The other world both exists and does not exist. Liberation exists. Liberation does not exist. Everything is momentary. Everything is not momentary. Space, nonanalytical cessation, and nirvāṇa, O Gautama, are made. They are unmade. The intermediate state of existence exists. The intermediate state of existence does not exist."

Mahāmati, I said this to him: "O brahmin, if that is so, these too are Lokāyata. O brahmin, this Lokāyata is yours, not mine. O brahmin, I teach that the three realms of existence arise from the cause of the dysfunctional tendencies, the habitual tendencies of conceptual elaboration and conceptual thought from beginningless time. Brahmin, conceptual thought arises because one does not realize that things are merely the appearance of one's own mind. It does not

arise from external things, which are not to be found. Thus the meeting of the three, self, sense faculty, and object, as the tīrthikas hold it, is not mine. O brahmin, I am neither one who asserts causes nor one who asserts no cause. Rather, I establish conceptual thought itself as the apprehended and the apprehender, and I teach dependent origination. This is not understood by those like you, or by others whose mental continuums have fallen into grasping at a self."

Mahāmati, nirvāṇa, space, and cessation cannot even be counted as three, so what need is there to speak of their being made?

Further, Mahāmati, a brahmin Lokāyatika said this to me: "O Gautama, have these three realms of existence arisen from the cause of ignorance, craving, and karma, or are they without a cause?"

"O brahmin, both of these are Lokāyata."

"O Gautama, all things fall within particular and general characteristics."

"O brahmin, that too is Lokāyata. Brahmin, as long as there is stirring of the mind, and attachment to and conceptualization of external objects, so long is there Lokāyata."

Again, Mahāmati, a brahmin Lokāyatika said this to me: "O Gautama, since my renown is made known by establishing the various words, letters, reasons, and examples of all the tīrthikas, O Gautama, is there anything at all that is not Lokāyata?"

"O brahmin, there is something not Lokāyata, which is neither established by you nor unestablished, which is not untaught by various words and letters, and which is not devoid of meaning but is indeed endowed with meaning."

"Is not whatever teaches the unestablished itself Lokāyata?"

"O brahmin, there is something not Lokāyata that is not conceived by any of the tīrthikas, who cling to the conceptual elaboration of external things that are unreal, nor by your intellect. That is to say: conceptual thought does not engage with existence and nonexistence. Through realizing that things are merely the appearance of one's own mind, conceptual thought does not engage. Because there is no grasping at external objects, conceptual thought remains in its own abode. Therefore this, which is not Lokāyata, is mine, not yours.

"'Remains in its own abode' means not engaging. The non-arising of conceptual thought is called not engaging. O brahmin, in that case, that which is not Lokāyata is, in brief, O brahmin, where consciousness does not move. Going, death and transmigration, birth, desire, clinging through attachment, fixation, the bases of views, pride, attachment to various characteristics, coming together, the linking of craving, and attachment to causes: these, O brahmin, are your Lokāyata, not mine."

Mahāmati, the brahmin Lokāyatika came and asked me this, and when I had answered him thus, he fell silent and departed.

Then again a nāga king of the dark faction came in the form of a brahmin and said this to the Blessed One: "O Gautama, nonetheless, the other world itself does not exist."

"Then, young man, from where have you come here?"

"Gautama, I have come here from the White Island."

"Brahmin, that itself is the other world."

Then the young man, defeated and left without eloquence, vanished. Without having asked me, he thinks of proclaiming his own separate tenets, thinking: "The son of the Śākyas is outside my system. He speaks of the non-engagement of afflictions, of the absence of characteristics, and of the absence of causes, and he says that through realizing the characteristic of appearing as one's own conceptual thought, conceptual thought does not engage."

"Mahāmati, why do you too ask me in this way, saying that one who attends upon Lokāyatikas with mantras and various kinds of eloquence comes to gather material things, and does not gather the Dharma?"

"Blessed One, what is the meaning of the words 'material things' and 'Dharma'?"

The Blessed One said: "Mahāmati, excellent, excellent, that you, looking to the multitudes of beings of the future, have set out to investigate the meaning of these two words! Therefore, Mahāmati, listen very well and keep it in mind, and I shall explain it to you."

Saying, "Excellent, Blessed One," the bodhisattva, the great being Mahāmati listened to the Blessed One, and the Blessed One said this to him:

"Here, Mahāmati, what are material things? They are as follows. Material things are contact, mingling, caressing, pride, tasting, attachment to external objects, entering into the two extremes through wrong views, the renewed arising of the aggregates, birth, aging, sickness, and death, sorrow, lamentation, suffering, distress, the arising of turmoil, the craving for renewed existence, and so on. These I and other buddhas call material things. Mahāmati, this is how, by attending upon Lokāyata, one comes to gather material things and does not gather the Dharma, and one attains Lokāyata."

Then, Mahāmati, what is it to gather the Dharma? It is this: to realize the twofold selflessness, that phenomena are one's own mind; to see the characteristic of selflessness in phenomena and in persons, so that conceptuality no longer operates; to know the grounds thoroughly, each higher than the last, and so to turn back from mind, mentation, and mental consciousness; to realize the empowerment into the wisdom of all the buddhas; to take up the endless state; and to have spontaneous mastery over all phenomena. This is called Dharma.

Mahāmati, the talk of the tīrthikas makes the things conceived in the elaborations of all views fall into the two extremes. It is this: fools mostly fall into the two extremes of permanence and annihilation, but the wise do not. Adopting the doctrine of causelessness, one comes to a view of permanence. Holding that when the cause has perished there is no causal thing, one comes to a view of annihilation. Not seeing arising, abiding, and perishing is what is called Dharma.

This, Mahāmati, is the definitive account of Dharma and of material things. You and the other bodhisattva great beings should train in it.

On this it is said:

Through the means of attraction one tames beings;
Through moral discipline one brings them under control;
Through wisdom one destroys their views;
Through liberation one makes them flourish greatly.

All this that the non-Buddhists (tīrthikas) teach
Is Lokāyata, and it is false.
Because they view cause and effect as existent,
They have no established tenet of their own.

One like me alone has a tenet of his own,
Which has abandoned cause and effect;
Entirely free of Lokāyata,
I shall teach it to the assembly of disciples.

It is mind only; there is no appearance.
Free of permanence and annihilation,
As the things grasped and the grasper,
Mind appears in two aspects.

As long as mind operates,
So long is there Lokāyata.
When the world sees its own mind,
Conceptuality does not operate.

Accrual is the effect, the aim accomplished;
Depletion is the effect not seen.
When one fully knows accrual and depletion,
Conceptuality does not operate.

Permanent and impermanent, made
And unmade, other and not other:
All these and the like
Are the ways of Lokāyata.

The Noble Descent into Laṅkā, the sixth section.

Then again the bodhisattva great being Mahāmati said this to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, this which is called nirvāṇa, which all the tīrthikas conceive, calling it 'nirvāṇa, nirvāṇa': of what is it a designation?"

The Blessed One said, "Therefore, Mahāmati, listen very well and keep it in mind, and I shall explain to you how the tīrthikas conceive nirvāṇa, and how nirvāṇa comes about in accordance with their conceptions."

Saying, "Excellent, Blessed One," the bodhisattva great being Mahāmati listened to the Blessed One, and the Blessed One spoke to him thus:

"Mahāmati, some tīrthikas declare that through the cessation of the aggregates, elements, and sense bases, through freedom from attachment to objects, and through seeing that phenomena are not in accord with permanence, the many states of mind and mental factors do not arise; that past, future, and present objects are not recalled; and that, like a lamp, a seed, or the wind, the cause being exhausted, conceptuality no longer

operates. Therefore they form the notion of nirvāṇa, but, Mahāmati, because they hold a view of destruction, they do not pass into nirvāṇa.

"Mahāmati, others declare that when conceptuality regarding objects is exhausted, like an arrow whose momentum is spent, going to dwell in another region is liberation. Again, some tīrthikas declare that liberation comes from the destruction of the view of knower and known. Some conceive liberation as coming from the non-operation of conceptuality and from seeing permanence and impermanence. Some think, 'The many conceptualizations of signs bring about the arising of suffering,' and being unskilled regarding what appears as merely their own mind, and frightened and terrified by signs, seeing signs and longing for bliss, they declare that they have formed the notion of nirvāṇa. Again, some realize the specific and general characteristics of all inner and outer phenomena, and conceive nirvāṇa as this: that past, future, and present things do not perish, because they exist. Some conceive nirvāṇa as the non-perishing of the self, the sentient being, the life principle, the nourisher, the person, the individual, and all phenomena.

"Mahāmati, some tīrthikas of unskilled intellect conceive nirvāṇa as coming from seeing the distinction between primal nature (prakṛti) and the person, and from the transformation of the qualities (guṇas) acting as agent. Some conceive nirvāṇa as coming from the complete exhaustion of merit and demerit; some, from knowing the exhaustion of the afflictions; some, from seeing the worlds as made by the Lord (Īśvara) through his own independent power. Some hold, 'This arising of the world comes from one thing entering into another, not from a cause'; while clinging to that cause, out of delusion they do not understand, and they conceive nirvāṇa as coming from understanding that.

"Mahāmati, some tīrthikas conceive nirvāṇa as coming from understanding the truths and the path. Some fully understand qualities and the possessor of qualities, and by seeing them as one, as different, as both, and as neither, they form the notion of nirvāṇa. Some say that things arise from their own nature: seeing the nature of things to be like the variegated colors of the peacock, the many kinds of jewel mines, or the sharpness of thorns, they conceive nirvāṇa. Mahāmati, some conceive nirvāṇa as coming from understanding the twenty-five principles; some, from protecting the people and upholding the teaching of the six qualities. Some, because they see time as the agent, understand that the arising of the world depends on time, and by understanding it thus, they conceive nirvāṇa. Mahāmati, some conceive

nirvāṇa through existence; some, through nonexistence; some, through fully knowing existence and nonexistence; some, through seeing existence and nirvāṇa as without distinction."

Mahāmati, some who roar the lion's roar of the Omniscient One conceive of nirvāṇa in this way: as understanding that everything is merely the appearance of one's own mind; as not being attached to external things; as being free from the four extremes and seeing things just as they truly abide; as not falling into the two extremes of conceptuality about what is the appearance of one's own mind; as not apprehending grasped and grasper; as not seeing reality established by any valid cognition; as not conceptualizing reality, because conceptualizing deceives, and so eliminating that; as understanding the noble Dharma that each realizes personally within himself; as realizing the two kinds of selflessness; as turning back the two kinds of affliction; as purifying the two obscurations; and as turning away from mind, mentation and mental consciousness through the samādhis of images such as illusion, rising from ground to ground up to the ground of the Tathāgata.

Even though the mistaken non-Buddhist reasoners teach other ideas of this kind, these do not accord with reason and are rejected by the wise. Mahāmati, all of them conceive of nirvāṇa with an outlook that falls into the two extremes. Mahāmati, although all the tīrthikas fully conceive of nirvāṇa through such conceptualizations, in this there is no entering into anything or turning back from anything. Mahāmati, the nirvāṇa of each of the tīrthikas, devoted to their own treatises and examined in various ways, is mistaken; it does not abide in the way they imagine it. Because the mind moves, comes and goes, there is no nirvāṇa for any of them. Mahāmati, you and the other bodhisattvas should train in this, and you should turn away from the views of nirvāṇa held by all the tīrthikas.

On this it is said:

The non-Buddhists who hold views of nirvāṇa
Conceive of it in differing ways.
Theirs is merely conceptual thought;
There is no means of liberation.

Apart from bond and what is bound,
They have entirely abandoned the means;
Though tīrthikas imagine liberation,
They will never be fit for liberation.

To the minds of the non-Buddhist systems
It appears manifold, diverse, and apart.
Since therefore they have no liberation,
How can the foolish imagine it?

Through bad views of cause and effect
All the non-Buddhists are intoxicated.
They speak for the sides of existence and nonexistence;
Therefore they have no liberation.

Those who delight in the elaborations of childish talk
Do not open their minds wide to the real itself.
Talk is the birthplace of suffering in the three realms;
The real itself is the cause that destroys suffering.

Just as a form in a mirror
Appears, and yet does not exist,
So in the mirror of habitual tendencies
The childish see the mind as twofold.

Through not knowing the appearances of mind,
Twofold conceptuality arises.
When the appearances of mind are fully known,
Conceptuality does not occur.

Mind itself transforms into variety,
Yet it is free of mark and basis of marks.
As the childish imagine it,
The aspect that appears does not appear.

Since the three existences are mere conceptuality,
There are no external objects.
The varied appearances of conceptuality
The childish do not understand.

Through distinctions of name and perception,
Conceptuality is taught in sūtra after sūtra.
Apart from the expressions,
What is expressed cannot be known.

Then the bodhisattva mahāsattva Mahāmati said this to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, may the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha, please explain to me the self-awakening of the Buddha, by which I and the

other bodhisattva mahāsattvas, skilled in the nature of the Tathāgata, may bring both ourselves and others to understanding."

The Blessed One said: "Therefore, Mahāmati, ask it yourself, and I shall answer you in the way that suits you."

Mahāmati said: "Blessed One, is the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha, made or unmade, cause or effect, mark or basis of marks, expression or what is expressed, cognition or what is to be known? Blessed One, is he one with such definitive verbal terms, or different from them?"

The Blessed One said: "Mahāmati, in terms of such definitive verbal terms, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha, is neither made nor unmade, neither cause nor effect. Why is that? Because either alternative would be faulty. Mahāmati, if the Tathāgata were made, he would be impermanent; and because he would be impermanent, all effects would also become tathāgatas. That is not what I and the other tathāgatas intend. If he were unmade, then, since he would have no attained nature, the accomplishment of the accumulations would be pointless, and because he would be unmade he would be just like a hare's horn or a barren woman's son.

"Mahāmati, what is neither cause nor effect is neither existent nor nonexistent. What is neither existent nor nonexistent lies outside the four extremes. Mahāmati, the four extremes are the conduct of the world; whatever lies outside the four extremes becomes mere words, like a barren woman's son. Mahāmati, a barren woman's son is mere words and does not fall into the four extremes. Since it does not fall into them, it is no measure of knowledge for the wise. In this way the wise should understand the meaning of the words of all the tathāgatas.

"Mahāmati, the wise should also understand the meaning of what I have taught: 'All phenomena are selfless.' Mahāmati, the being of selflessness is selflessness itself. Like a horse and an ox, all phenomena exist in their own being and do not exist in the being of another. That is, Mahāmati, the being of an ox is not the nature of a horse, and the being of a horse is not the nature of an ox; yet each exists and is not nonexistent. Those two are not nonexistent in their own characteristics; those two exist in their own characteristics. Likewise, Mahāmati, all phenomena are not nonexistent in characteristics; they do exist.

Therefore it is by grasping at conceptual thought that childish ordinary beings come to understand selflessness, and not by being free of conceptual thought. In the same way, all phenomena should be understood as emptiness, as

unarisen, and as without essential nature.

Likewise, the Tathāgata is neither one with the aggregates nor different from them. If he were not distinct from the aggregates, he would be impermanent, because the aggregates are produced. If he were different from them, then, there being two, he would be something other, like the two horns of an ox. Here, because all things are alike, they are not different. Because a distinction in length is seen, they are not different. Mahāmati, the left horn of an ox is other than the right, and the right is other than the left; likewise long and short are other in relation to each other. Likewise various colors are also different from one another. The Tathāgata, too, is not different from the aggregates, the elements, and the sense sources.

Likewise, liberation and the Tathāgata are neither different nor one, for the Tathāgata himself is taught by the word "liberation." If liberation and the Tathāgata were different, he would possess the characteristics of form, and because he possessed the characteristics of form, he would be impermanent. If they were one, there would be no distinction in the characteristics of what yogins attain. But, Mahāmati, yogins do see a distinction, and therefore they are neither one nor different. Likewise, knowledge and the knowable are neither one nor different.

Mahāmati, that which is neither permanent nor impermanent, neither cause nor effect, neither conditioned nor unconditioned, neither intellect nor what is to be known, neither characteristic nor the basis of characteristics, neither the aggregates nor different from the aggregates, neither speaker nor what is spoken, and which has no connection with oneness, difference, both, or neither, is withdrawn from all valid cognition. What is withdrawn from all valid cognition becomes mere words. What is mere words is unborn. What is unborn is unceasing. What is unceasing is like space. Mahāmati, space is neither cause nor effect. What is neither cause nor effect is without any objective support. What is without objective support has transcended all conceptual elaboration. What has transcended all conceptual elaboration is the Tathāgata. That, Mahāmati, is perfect, complete buddhahood. That is buddhahood, turned away from all valid cognition and from all the senses.

On this it is said:

Turned away from valid cognition and the senses,
it is not an effect, nor is it a cause.
It has no intellect and nothing to be known;

it has left behind characteristic and the basis of characteristics.
A buddha depending on the aggregates
has never been seen by anyone anywhere.
What no one anywhere has seen,
how could one contemplate it?

It is not made, nor is it unmade;
it is not an effect, nor is it a cause.
It is not the aggregates, nor joined with the aggregates,
nor joined with anything else, for that would be a mixture.
That which, examined as being some entity,
is not seen to appear,
is not to be conceived as nonexistent either:
that is the true nature of phenomena.

Nonexistence is reckoned as the counterpart of existence,
and existence is reckoned as the counterpart of nonexistence.
Therefore do not understand it as nonexistent,
nor conceive of it as existent.

Those who corrupt the positions of self and selflessness
and engage with mere sounds
sink into the two extremes;
ruined themselves, they ruin the childish.
Whenever one sees my way,
which is free from every fault,
that is seeing correctly,
and such a one does not revile the Guides.

Then again the bodhisattva, the great being Mahāmati, said this to the Blessed One: "In the course of this teaching, the Blessed One has spoken of non-arising and non-cessation, and the Blessed One has also said, 'This non-arising and non-cessation is a byname of the Tathāgata.' When the Blessed One said this, is this non-arising and non-cessation a nonentity, or is it another synonym of the Tathāgata? The Blessed One has explained that all phenomena are unborn and unceasing because one does not see the positions of existence and nonexistence. If all phenomena are said to be unborn, then, Blessed One, since all phenomena are unborn, it would not even be proper to speak of 'phenomena.' But if it is another synonym of some particular phenomenon,

then please explain it, Blessed One; please explain it, Sugata."

The Blessed One said, "Therefore, Mahāmati, listen very well and keep it in mind, and I shall explain it to you."

"Excellent, Blessed One," replied the bodhisattva, the great being Mahāmati, and he listened to the Blessed One. The Blessed One then said this to him:

"Mahāmati, the Tathāgata is not a nonentity. Nor is this a statement that all phenomena are without arising and without cessation, nor does it depend on conditions, nor is my speaking of non-arising meaningless. Rather, Mahāmati, this is a byname for the mind-made Dharma body of the Tathāgata. That unborn which is not the domain of any of the non-Buddhists (tīrthikas), of the śrāvakas, of the pratyekabuddhas, or of the bodhisattvas abiding on the seventh ground, is a byname of the Tathāgata; it is a synonymous term.

"For example, Mahāmati, there are Śakra, Indra, and Puraṃdara, the Destroyer of Cities; hand, doer, and handler; body, frame, and form; earth, ground, and the Bearer of Riches; sky, space, and the passage where things come and go. In this way, many synonymous words are devised for each single thing. Yet although there are many names, one does not conceive of many things, nor do they thereby become without intrinsic nature.

"Likewise, Mahāmati, in this Sahā world system I too resound in the ears of the childish by names numbering three hundred thousand incalculables. Though they speak of me by these, they are known as synonyms for the names of the Tathāgata. Among them, Mahāmati, some know me as the Tathāgata."

Some know me as the Self-Existent (Svayambhū). Likewise, some know me as the Leader, the Guide, the Chief Guide, the Buddha, the Bull, Brahmā, Viṣṇu, Īśvara, the principal (pradhāna), Kapila, Bhūtānta, Ariṣṭanemi, Soma, Bhāskara (the Sun), Rāma, Vyāsa, Śuka, Indra, Bali, and Varuṇa. Still others know me as the Unborn, the Unceasing, emptiness, suchness, truth, reality, the limit of reality, the realm of phenomena (dharmadhātu), nirvāṇa, the Permanent, sameness, nonduality, signlessness, the teaching of the cause by which one becomes a buddha from conditions, liberation, the path, the truths, the Omniscient One, the Victor, and the one whose nature is mind.

Mahāmati, beings in this world system and in others know me by these and other names, countless, fully three hundred thousand, neither more nor less. Like the moon in water, I have neither entered nor emerged, yet the childish grasp me through minds that have fallen into the two extremes. Even so, they

honor me, make me foremost, make images of me, and worship me. But because they are not skilled in the meaning of words and in etymology, they do not know their own way: that these are not different names. Attached to the sounds of explanations and to expressions, they imagine that non-arising and non-cessation are nonexistence, and they do not consider them to be other synonyms of the Tathāgata's name, like Indra, Śakra (Indra, lord of the gods), and Purandara. Because they follow the expression of all phenomena as meaning just what the sound says, they have no taste for teachings that set out the proper mode of each.

Mahāmati, those foolish people say this: "The meaning is just as the sound is; the meaning is nothing other than the sound. Why is that? Because the meaning has no body, the meaning is nothing other than the sound; the sound itself is the meaning." Mahāmati, because they do not fully know the nature of sound, those of unskilled intellect do not know that while sound arises and perishes, meaning neither arises nor perishes. Mahāmati, sound falls into letters; meaning does not fall into letters. Because it is free of both entity and non-entity, it is unborn and has no body.

Mahāmati, because the existence and nonexistence of letters are not found, the tathāgatas do not teach a Dharma that has fallen into letters; rather, they teach a Dharma that has not fallen into letters. Mahāmati, because the Dharma has no letters, whoever expounds a Dharma that has fallen into letters is talking nonsense. Therefore, Mahāmati, I and other buddhas and bodhisattvas have taught that, in terms of explanation and expression, the tathāgatas have not spoken a single letter and will not speak one. Why is that? Because all phenomena have no letters. Yet they do not teach what is devoid of meaning either; they teach by taking up conceptual thought.

Mahāmati, if no phenomena were taught at all, the teaching would perish, and when the teaching has perished, there would be no buddhas, pratyekabuddhas, or śrāvakas either. If there were none of them, who would teach what to whom? Therefore, Mahāmati, the bodhisattva mahāsattva should not be attached to the sounds of explanation and expression.

Mahāmati, the expression of explanation is a delusion, since it proceeds according to the dispositions of sentient beings. I and the other tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly complete buddhas teach the Dharma to beings of differing inclinations in order to turn back mind, mentation, and mental consciousness. It is not to turn them back from the realization of the noble wisdom known

personally by oneself, which comes when the many kinds of conceptual thought have ceased through understanding that all phenomena are without appearance, that they are merely the appearances of one's own mind.

Mahāmati, the bodhisattva mahāsattva should rely on the meaning, not on the letter. Mahāmati, a son or daughter of good family who follows after the letter ruins their own grasp of the meaning and does not bring others to understanding either. Bad logicians, unskilled in the specific characteristics of all phenomena and of the grounds, and not knowing words and etymology, proclaim their own positions with minds fallen into bad views. But if one is skilled in the specific characteristics of all phenomena and of the grounds, understands and realizes the synonyms of words and their etymology, and becomes skilled in the meaning of things and in reasoning, then one satisfies oneself with the bliss of the true signless state and also establishes others properly in the Great Vehicle.

Mahāmati, when the Great Vehicle is properly upheld, buddhas, bodhisattvas, śrāvakas, and pratyekabuddhas are upheld. When buddhas, bodhisattvas, śrāvakas, and pratyekabuddhas are upheld, sentient beings are upheld. When all sentient beings are upheld, the sublime Dharma is upheld. Mahāmati, when the sublime Dharma is upheld, the lineage of the buddhas is kept from being cut off. Because the lineage of the buddhas is not cut off, one is known to attain special births. Therefore, the bodhisattva mahāsattvas who attain those sublime births take up birth there, and, because they firmly uphold the Great Vehicle, through the ten masteries they come to assume various forms and guises. Having understood and realized the guises of sentient beings and the characteristics of their latent tendencies, they teach the Dharma in accordance with suchness.

Here, what is called reality is suchness, not-otherness, reality, the characteristic of neither taking up nor casting away, and the complete pacification of all conceptual elaborations. Mahāmati, because reality has no letters, a son or daughter of good family should not become skilled in clinging to meaning as being just what the sound says. They should not be like one who looks at the finger.

Mahāmati, it is like this. Suppose someone points something out to another with the tip of a finger, and that person looks only at the fingertip and follows it. In the same way, Mahāmati, the hosts of childish ordinary beings, as though childish by nature, cling and are attached to the fingertip of the literal word.

Clinging in this way to the fingertip of the word, they come to the time of death without ever letting go of the literal fingertip and coming to understand the ultimate meaning.

Mahāmati, it is like this. As for the food and drink of the childish, no one eats it without its being cooked. If some were to eat it uncooked, not knowing how to prepare food step by step, they would be regarded as mad. In the same way, Mahāmati, non-arising and non-cessation too will not be beautiful unless they are cultivated. One must certainly cultivate them here, seeing the meaning that the fingertip points to, and not mere words. Therefore, Mahāmati, one should strive for the meaning.

Mahāmati, the meaning is utterly solitary and is the cause of nirvāṇa. The word is bound up with conceptual thought and brings about saṃsāra. Mahāmati, the meaning is found from those of great learning. Mahāmati, what is called great learning is this: being skilled in the meaning, not being skilled in the word. Here, being skilled in the meaning is the view that is unmixed with any of the doctrines of the tīrthikas, by which one neither falls oneself nor causes others to fall. Mahāmati, such great learning in the meaning is truly meaningful. Therefore one who desires the meaning should rely on such people. The opposite of this is attachment to the literal meaning of words, and those who seek reality should avoid such people.

Then Mahāmati, empowered by the blessing of the Buddha, again said this:

"In the view of non-arising and non-cessation, the Blessed One makes no distinction at all. Why is that? Blessed One, the causes of all the tīrthikas are also unborn and unceasing. Blessed One, in your teaching too, space, cessation not brought about by analysis, and the element of nirvāṇa are unborn and unceasing. Blessed One, the tīrthikas also declare that beings arise from a cause consisting of an agent and conditions. The Blessed One, too, giving another name to that very cause and calling it a condition, declares that beings arise from the conditions of ignorance, craving, karma and conceptual thought. And it is the same for you and for them regarding external things arising through external conditions. Therefore, Blessed One, there would be no distinction between this doctrine and the doctrine of the tīrthikas.

"Atoms, the principal (pradhāna), Īśvara, Prajāpati and the rest, together with the nine substances, are unborn and unceasing. Blessed One, in your teaching too, all things are unborn and unceasing, since neither existence nor nonexistence is found in them. Because the elements do not perish, their own

characteristics neither arise nor cease. Whatever transformations they undergo, the elements remain elements; they do not abandon the nature of elements. Blessed One, this has been imagined by you and by all the tīrthikas as a transformation of the conceptualization of the elements. Therefore there is no distinction in this doctrine. Please explain the distinction by which what the Tathāgata teaches is distinct and is not the doctrine of all the tīrthikas.

"Blessed One, if your own doctrine has no distinction, then, since non-arising and non-cessation would be the cause, the tīrthikas too would become buddhas. The Blessed One has said that for many tathāgatas to arise in a single world system is impossible and cannot happen. Yet if, as I say, the doctrine has no distinction, then, since existence and nonexistence of the result have been accepted, there would be many tathāgatas."

The Blessed One said, "Mahāmati, my non-arising and non-cessation is not the same as the tīrthikas' teaching of non-arising and non-cessation, nor is it the same as the teaching of arising and impermanence. Why is that? Mahāmati, for the tīrthikas there is an unarisen intrinsic nature of things, which has attained an unchanging characteristic. Mine does not fall in this way to the side of existence or of nonexistence. Mahāmati, mine is free from the sides of existence and nonexistence. Being free from arising and destruction, it is neither a thing nor a non-thing. Like seeing the various forms of an illusion or a dream, it is not a non-thing either.

"If one asks how it is not a non-thing, it is because the characteristic of the intrinsic nature of form cannot be grasped. Because things appear and do not appear, are grasped and cannot be grasped, all things are therefore neither things nor without an essence. Since, through understanding them to be mere appearances of one's own mind, conceptual thought no longer engages, the world abides in itself and is without activity. Yet the childish conceive it as having activity; the noble ones do not.

"Mahāmati, this is intoxication by conceptualizing unreal objects, like a city of gandharvas or an illusory man. Mahāmati, it is like this. Some who are childish by nature conceive of entering and leaving, thinking, 'These many and various illusory men, beings and travelers have entered the city of the gandharvas; now they have come out.' Yet in truth nothing at all enters or leaves there; their conceptualization is simply mistaken. In the same way, Mahāmati, arising and non-arising are the error of the childish. Just as with the arising of an illusory man, there is nothing at all here that is either conditioned or

unconditioned. Since an illusory man does nothing at all by way of existing or not existing, there is no arising or ceasing."

In the same way, all phenomena too are free of arising and perishing. Fools, by contrast, through perceptions that have fallen into error, conceive of arising and ceasing; the noble ones do not. Here, Mahāmati, what is called "error" is this: things are neither as their intrinsic nature is imagined to be, nor otherwise. If one imagines them otherwise, one becomes attached to the essential nature of all things, and so does not see their solitude. When solitude is not seen, conceptuality does not cease. Therefore, Mahāmati, seeing signlessness is wholesome, and seeing signs is not. Signs are the cause of birth, and so they are unwholesome. Mahāmati, signlessness is the non-engagement of conceptuality, and non-arising is explained as nirvāṇa. Here, Mahāmati, nirvāṇa is this: by seeing reality abiding just as it is, the conceptualizing mind and its many mental factors are thoroughly transformed, and on that basis the Tathāgata realizes it through his own noble wisdom, known individually by oneself. That is explained as nirvāṇa.

On this it is said:

To reverse arising,
non-arising is established.
The teaching of the doctrine of no cause
fools do not understand.

All these are unborn,
without entity, and without continuity too.
Like dreams, like illusions, like a city of gandharvas,
there are things that have no cause.

"Tell me how they are unborn,
without intrinsic nature, and empty."

"Apart from aggregations,
the intellect perceives no entity.
Therefore I have explained them as unborn, empty,
and without intrinsic nature.

Likewise, in each aggregation,
since nothing appears, there is no existence.
Nor, as in the view of the tīrthikas,
do aggregations become imperishable.

Like dreams, tangled hairs,
illusions, mirages, a city of gandharvas,
appearing though they have no cause,
so too is the variegated world.

Disputing by means of the doctrine of no cause,
one establishes the unborn.
When non-arising is established,
my way is not destroyed.

When the doctrine of no cause is taught,
the non-Buddhists grow afraid, saying,
'How, from what, by what,
and where does the causeless come to arise?'

When at some time the conditioned is seen
as not from a cause, as causeless,
then the view of those who speak
of arising and perishing is reversed."

"Is non-arising the absence of entities?
Or is it an examination of conditions?
Or is it a name for entities?
Or is it meaningless? Please tell me."

"Non-arising is not the absence of entities,
nor is it an examination of conditions.
Nor is it a name for entities,
nor is it a name without meaning.

That which is not the domain of śrāvakas,
of pratyekabuddhas, of those who have reached the seventh ground,
nor of the tīrthikas:
that is the characteristic of non-arising.

The reversal of causes and conditions,
the refutation of agents,
the establishment as mind only:
this I have explained as non-arising.

Things that do not come from causes,
free of conceiving and the conceived,
liberated from the positions of existence and nonexistence:

this I have explained as non-arising.

Mind fully liberated from appearance,
free as well of the two natures,
the transformation of the bases:
this I have explained as non-arising.

External things are not nonentities,
nor is there any grasping by the mind.
All views completely abandoned:
that is the characteristic of the unborn.

Likewise 'empty,' 'without intrinsic nature,'
and all such words are imputed.
It is never empty merely by emptiness;
it is the emptiness of non-arising.

From the coming together of conditions
things come forth and cease.
Apart from the aggregation
there is no arising and no ceasing.

As one and as different,
just as the non-Buddhists conceive them,
things are not different,
and apart from aggregation they exist nowhere.

Existent and nonexistent things do not arise;
neither nonexistent nor existent is found anywhere.
Therefore it is aggregation, in another sense,
that comes forth and ceases.

This is mere imputation,
a connection of mutual dependence.
Apart from the connection of conditions
there is nothing to be produced.

Since nothing is produced, there is no arising.
Free of the faults of the non-Buddhists,
I have explained it as mere connection;
fools do not understand.

If, apart from connection,
the production of things is said to exist,
that destroys connection,
and should be known as the doctrine of no cause.

If, apart from connection,
an entity existed for anyone,
connection would then illuminate
the kinds of substances, like a lamp.

Whatever phenomenon the unskilled conceive
apart from connections
is unborn, without essential nature;
its nature is like space.

The nature of reality attained by the noble ones
is a different non-arising:
that in which no arising occurs,
that is the forbearance of the unborn.

When all these worlds
are seen as connection itself,
thinking, 'This is mere connection,'
then the mind too rests in equipoise.

Ignorance, craving, karma, and the rest:
these connections are internal.
The wheel, water, wood, clay, and the rest,
seeds, elements, and so forth, are external.

These are not mere connection.
If some hold that things
arise from other conditions,
that does not stand in reasoning or scripture.

If there is no entity to be produced,
from what condition does the intellect arise?
These produce one another mutually;
therefore know them as conditions.

Heat, moisture, solidity, and motion:
fools imagine these phenomena.
This aggregation is not a phenomenon;

therefore it is without essential nature.

Physicians, according to the patient,
prescribe different treatments,
yet their treatise is not different;
the distinctions are made by the illness.

In the same way, I too, knowing the strength of the faculties
of beings' mental streams,
stained by the faults and failings of the afflictions,
explain the way to the childish.

Though afflictions and faculties differ,
my teaching is not divided.
The peaceful path endowed with eight limbs
is the one vehicle."

Then again the bodhisattva mahāsattva Mahāmati said this to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, all the tīrthikas conceive of impermanence, saying 'impermanence, impermanence,' and you too, in all your teachings and statements, say:

'Alas, formations are impermanent;
they are of the nature to arise and perish.'

"When you say this, Blessed One (the Buddha), is it true, or is it false? Blessed One, how many kinds of impermanence are there?"

The Blessed One said: "Mahāmati, all the tīrthikas imagine it in eight ways, but I do not. What are the eight? Here, Mahāmati, some say that impermanence is the ceasing of undertaking. Mahāmati, what is called 'undertaking' is arising, and not arising is impermanence. Some say that impermanence is the ceasing of shape. Some say that form itself is impermanent. Some say that impermanence is the further, distinct alteration of form. They say that all phenomena, without interruption, continually perish and dissolve of their own accord, and that just as milk turns into curd, which is a distinct alteration, so in all things the impermanence of vanishing from sight and of destruction is at work. Some imagine the entity to be impermanent. Some imagine impermanence as the absence of entities in entities. Some say it is the impermanence that is the non-arising of all phenomena, because impermanence too is included within that.

"Here, Mahāmati, what is called the impermanence that is the absence of entities in entities is this: the own-characteristics of the elements and of what is derived from the elements are destroyed and are not apprehended, and the essential nature of the elements does not come into play.

"Here, what is called the impermanence of non-arising is this: permanent impermanence; not arising from existence or from nonexistence; and the not seeing of any phenomenon at all. When one examines down to the atoms, this not seeing is a term for non-arising, not for arising. Mahāmati, that is the characteristic of the impermanence that is non-arising. Because they do not understand this, all the tīrthikas fall into proclaiming the impermanence of arising.

"Furthermore, Mahāmati, those who hold that the entity is impermanent have imagined it with their own minds. Entities are neither permanent nor impermanent. Why is that? It is like this, Mahāmati: impermanence itself does not cease. Here, Mahāmati, the absence of entities in all entities is the effect of impermanence. Without impermanence, the essencelessness of all entities is not apprehended. Just as with something to be broken by a stick, a stone or a hammer, whichever it may be, and the breaking of it, they are seen to appear without any distinction between them. Therefore impermanence is the cause, and the essencelessness of all entities is the effect. Since there is no distinction of cause and effect such that one could say 'this is impermanence' and 'this is the effect,' cause and effect are not distinct. Because entities have no cause, all entities are permanent.

"Mahāmati, the essencelessness of all entities is causeless, and this the childish ordinary people do not understand. A cause does not produce a dissimilar effect. If it did produce one, then all those entities would be dissimilar effects of impermanence; and if cause and effect came to be without distinction, a distinction between cause and effect would still be seen.

"If their impermanence were an entity, it would fall into being an action, the nature of a cause, and a characteristic. It would also be complete in a single entity or in all entities. Because it falls into being the cause of an action and the characteristic of an entity, impermanence itself would become impermanent. Since impermanence would itself be impermanent, all entities would also become permanent; they would become permanence itself.

"If impermanence were present within all entities, it would therefore fall into the three times. In that case, past form would have perished together with it.

The future too would be unarisen, because form does not arise. In the present, too, form and characteristic are not distinct. Form is a particular arrangement of the great elements. The nature of the elements and of what is derived from the elements does not perish. For the tīrthikas, because it is free of identity and difference, the nature of the elements and of what is derived from the elements does not perish. Because, for all the tīrthikas, none of the elements perish, all three realms of existence are the elements and what is derived from the elements, and arising, abiding and change are designated in them. What other impermanence is there, distinct from the elements and what is derived from them, that the tīrthikas could imagine as impermanence? Since the characteristic of the elements' nature does not perish, there is neither coming into play nor ceasing.

"Here, what is called the impermanence that is the ceasing of undertaking means that the elements do not undertake, that is, originate, other elements. Because their own-characteristics are mutually incompatible, they do not originate anything distinct. Because they possess two aspects, the absence of any distinction of theirs and their again not originating, the notion of impermanence arises with regard to not originating.

"Here, what is called the impermanence that is the ceasing of shape is this: the elements and what is derived from the elements do not change until their destruction. Mahāmati, what is called 'destruction' is analyzing and examining them down to the atoms. Destruction means that long and short are not apprehended, because the shape of the elements and of what is derived from them is seen to be otherwise. It is not because the elements are destroyed; it does not apply to the atomic elements. By viewing it as the ceasing of shape, they fall into the doctrine of the Sāṃkhyas.

"Here, what is called the impermanence of shape is this: for whoever holds that form itself is impermanent, it is the shape itself that is impermanent, not the elements. If the elements were impermanent, there would be no worldly conventions. If there were no worldly conventions, all things would be mere words; and because own-characteristics too are seen to arise, one would fall into the view of the Lokāyatas.

"Here, what is called the impermanence of alteration is this: form is seen to change into something else, but not the elements. It is like seeing the shape of gold and its ornaments change. The gold does not perish into anything other than the substance of gold, yet the shape of the ornament perishes. In this

way and in other such ways, falling into transformation, the tīrthikas conceive views of impermanence."

Even when the elements are burned by fire, one does not burn another, because each is its own characteristic. Mahāmati, if their own characteristic were to cease to exist, the elements and the things derived from the elements would be annihilated.

Mahāmati, my teaching is neither permanent nor impermanent. Why is that? Because I do not accept external things, because I teach the three existences as mind only, and because I do not teach diverse characteristics. The distinctions of the bases of the great elements neither come into operation nor cease. The elements and what is derived from the elements do not enter into a twofold conceptuality. This is because there is no characteristic of grasped and grasper, because the two modes of conceptual activity are fully understood, because one is free from views of external things and of the nonexistence of things, and because one realizes that it is merely one's own mind. Conceptuality operates through the forming activity of conceptual thought, not through what is unformed.

Because one is free from mind, from conceptuality, from things and from the absence of things, and because one realizes that they are merely appearances of one's own mind, all phenomena, worldly, supramundane and supremely supramundane, are neither permanent nor impermanent. Because they do not understand their own conceptuality, the tīrthikas, with minds fallen into the bad views of the two extremes, conceive as impermanent everything, even the person of their discourse, which was never established in the first place.

Mahāmati, the characteristics of all phenomena that arise from conceptuality in the words of all the tīrthikas, and in the worldly, the supramundane and the supremely supramundane, are of three kinds; childish ordinary beings do not understand them.

On this it is said:

The cessation of commencement,
the change of shape and form into something other,
form and things as impermanent:
so the non-Buddhists, intoxicated, conceive.

Since the elements abide as elements themselves,
there is no destruction of things.

Because they are sunk in diverse views,
non-Buddhists conceive impermanence.

For the non-Buddhists, in nothing at all
is there destruction, nor is there arising.
If the things that are elements and derived from them are permanent,
what is it they conceive as impermanent?

All of these are mind only.
As the things that are grasped and grasping,
the mind operates in two modes;
there is no self, nor anything belonging to a self, at all.

From Brahmā and the rest up to the abodes,
I have explained all as mind only.
Without realizing mind alone,
Brahmā and the rest are not established.

This is the third chapter, on impermanence, from the Descent into Laṅkā.

Then once again the bodhisattva, the great being Mahāmati, said this to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, please explain to me the characteristic of the sequence and continuity of cessation of all bodhisattvas, śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas, so that, being skilled in the characteristic of the sequence and continuity of cessation, I and the other bodhisattva great beings will not be confused at the gateway to entering absorption in the bliss of cessation, and will not fall into the confusion of the śrāvakas, the pratyekabuddhas and the tīrthikas."

The Blessed One said, "Mahāmati, listen very well and keep it in mind, and I shall explain it to you."

Saying, "Excellent, Blessed One," the bodhisattva, the great being Mahāmati, listened to the Blessed One, and the Blessed One spoke to him thus:

"Mahāmati, from the sixth ground onward, bodhisattva great beings, śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas enter absorption in cessation. On the seventh ground, moment of mind by moment of mind, bodhisattva great beings enter absorption by removing the characteristic of the essential nature of all things; but śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas do not. The absorption in cessation of those śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas falls into the characteristic of grasped and grasper, accompanied by forming activity. Therefore, since it would not be

fitting for them to attain the characteristic of non-differentiation of all phenomena and the absence of diverse characteristics, on the seventh ground absorption is entered moment of mind by moment of mind. Their absorption is one in which the specific characteristics of all phenomena, wholesome and unwholesome, are not understood. Therefore, on the seventh ground they have no skill in absorption moment of mind by moment of mind, by which absorption would be entered.

"Mahāmati, on the eighth ground the conceptuality and perception of the mind, of mentation and of mental consciousness of bodhisattvas, śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas cease. On the first ground and on the sixth, they directly perceive that the three realms are merely mind, mentation and mental consciousness, devoid of self and what belongs to a self, arising from one's own conceptuality, and not fallen into the diverse characteristics of external things. Otherwise, the very mind of the childish turns into two modes, as things grasped and grasping; those imbued since beginningless time with the habitual tendencies of the negative tendencies of conceptual elaboration do not understand this, because of their ignorance.

"Mahāmati, on the eighth ground is the nirvāṇa of śrāvakas, pratyekabuddhas and bodhisattvas. The bodhisattvas, however, are held back from that bliss of samādhi by the buddhas of samādhi, so that they do not pass fully into nirvāṇa. If they were not held back, then, because the ground of the Tathāgata would not be fulfilled, the work for sentient beings would be cut off, and the lineage of the tathāgata family would be cut off as well. Therefore those buddhas, the blessed ones, also reveal the inconceivable greatness of buddhahood, and for that reason the bodhisattvas do not pass fully into nirvāṇa. Śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas, however, are carried away by the bliss of samādhi, and therefore they come to hold the notion that it is nirvāṇa."

"Mahāmati, I have set forth the following for the bodhisattva mahāsattvas on the seventh ground, for it would not be right that, not knowing the specific and general characteristics and being unskilled in the sequence of the grounds and in their connections, they should fall into the views and paths of the non-Buddhists (tīrthikas). I have set forth skill in becoming familiar with the characteristics of mind, mentation, and mental consciousness; familiarity with the grasping at self and at what belongs to self, with the selflessness of phenomena and of persons, with engaging and turning back, and with specific and general characteristics; skill in the analytical knowledges, free of doubt; the bliss of delight in the masteries; entry into the sequence of the grounds;

and the analysis of the factors conducive to awakening. For that reason I have established the arrangement of the sequence of the grounds. Yet, Mahāmati, in this there is no engaging or turning back whatsoever.

"Rather, it is like this: this sequence of the grounds and their connection, the triple realm designated in its variety, is merely the appearance of one's own mind, and the childish do not comprehend it. Because the childish do not comprehend it, I and those buddhas have established this triple realm designated in its variety as the teaching on the connection of the sequence of the grounds.

"Furthermore, Mahāmati, on the eighth bodhisattva ground the śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas are intoxicated with the intoxication of the bliss of the attainment of cessation. Being unskilled in the mere appearance of their own mind, they fall into the obscuring habitual tendencies of specific and general characteristics and into the view that grasps at the selflessness of persons and of phenomena, and so with regard to that conceptuality they come to have the mind that takes it to be nirvāṇa. They do not have the mind devoted to the Dharma of utter solitude.

"Mahāmati, the bodhisattvas, having seen the door of the bliss of the meditative absorption of cessation, are endowed with their former aspirations, with love, and with compassion, and they know the analysis of what it is to enter the final state; therefore they do not pass into complete nirvāṇa. Yet because conceptuality does not operate in them, they are also in nirvāṇa. Their conceptuality of apprehended and apprehender has ceased. Because they comprehend all phenomena as merely their own mind, conceptuality does not operate in them; and yet those who are free from the conceptuality that clings to the essential nature and the characteristics of mind, mentation, mental consciousness, and external things are not ones who fail to engage for the sake of the qualities of a buddha. For the sake of the personal realization of the Tathāgata's own state, with wisdom going before, they engage, like a person crossing a river in a dream.

"It is like this, Mahāmati. Someone asleep, in a dream, is crossing a great river with effort and great exertion, and before he has crossed it he wakes up. Having woken, he wonders, 'Is this true, or is it false?' And he reflects: 'This is neither true nor false. Rather, I fell into the forms and shapes of the various habitual tendencies of conceptuality arising from what was seen, heard, discerned, cognized, and experienced, and with a mental consciousness that

had abandoned the conceptualizing of existence and nonexistence I saw appearances in the dream I experienced.'

"In the same way, Mahāmati, the bodhisattva mahāsattvas too, on the eighth bodhisattva ground, see that conceptuality does not operate; they see the passage from the first ground up to the seventh and the realization of all phenomena; they see their exertion regarding all phenomena as being like illusions and so forth; and they see the movement of the conceptuality of mind and mental factors that is free from the conceptuality of apprehended and apprehender. Having seen this, they apply themselves thoroughly to the qualities of a buddha. Mahāmati, this is the practice of bodhisattvas for the sake of nirvāṇa, by which what was not realized comes to be realized; it is not destruction. Because mind, mentation, mental consciousness, conceptuality, and perception have become absent, they attain acceptance of the nonarising of phenomena. Mahāmati, since this teaches the Dharma that is free of appearances and isolated from conceptuality, in the ultimate there is no sequence and no connection of the sequence."

On this it is said:

Mind only and the imageless,
The grounds of the buddhas and the abodes:
These have been taught by the buddhas,
Are taught, and will be taught.

The seven grounds are mind;
Here the imageless is the eighth;
Here two grounds are abodes;
The remaining ground is my own nature.

Selfhood and personal self-awareness:
This ground is my own nature.
Supreme among the abodes of Maheśvara,
Akaniṣṭha shines in utter splendor.

Just as from a fire,
Its many-colored rays
Stream forth, pleasing and peaceful;
They emanate the three existences.

Some of the three existences they emanate now,
Some were emanated before;

There the vehicles are taught;
That is the ground of my own nature.

The tenth is the first;
The first is the eighth;
The ninth is the seventh;
The seventh is the eighth;
The second is the third;
The fourth is the fifth;
The third is the sixth:
In the imageless, what order is there?

This is the fourth chapter, on Realization.

Then once again the bodhisattva mahāsattva Mahāmati said this to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, is the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha, permanent, or is he impermanent?"

The Blessed One said: "Mahāmati, the Tathāgata is neither permanent nor impermanent. Why is that? Because in both cases a fault would follow. Mahāmati, the fault that follows in both cases is this: if he were permanent, he would become a cause. Mahāmati, the causes of all the tīrthikas are unmade and permanent; therefore, since the unmade is permanent, the Tathāgata is not permanent. If he were impermanent, he would be made and impermanent. Since the aggregates, the characteristic, and the basis of the characteristic would be absent, with the destruction of the aggregates he would be annihilated; but the Tathāgata is not annihilated."

Mahāmati, everything that is made is impermanent. Like a pot, cloth, a mat, grass, wood, and brick, all of these become impermanent. Since he would then be something made, the accumulations for omniscient wisdom would also become pointless. And since there would be no distinguishing reason, all childish beings would also become tathāgatas. Therefore, Mahāmati, the Tathāgata is neither permanent nor impermanent.

Moreover, Mahāmati, the Tathāgata is not permanent. Why is that? Because, as with space, the accumulations would become pointless. For example, Mahāmati, space is neither permanent nor impermanent. Since it is free of permanence and impermanence, it cannot be described in terms of the faults of oneness, otherness, both, neither, permanence, or impermanence.

Moreover, Mahāmati, if he were permanent by being unborn, he would be equal to the horns of a hare, a horse, a donkey, a camel, a frog, a snake, a bird, or a fish. Because what is unborn would then be permanent, the Tathāgata is not permanent either.

Yet, Mahāmati, there is also a sense in which the Tathāgata is permanent. Why is that? Because the wisdom that has fully comprehended realization is permanent, the Tathāgata is permanent. Mahāmati, the wisdom by which the tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly complete buddhas, have fully comprehended realization is permanent. Whether tathāgatas appear or do not appear, this nature of reality, this immutability of phenomena, this abiding of phenomena, remains in all the realizations of śrāvakas, pratyekabuddhas, and tīrthikas. Though, as with space, the abiding of phenomena does not change, childish ordinary beings do not understand it.

Mahāmati, the wisdom comprehended by the tathāgatas is brought forth by discernment and primordial wisdom. Mahāmati, the Tathāgata is not brought forth by mind, mentation, mental consciousness, the aggregates, the elements, the sense bases, or the habitual tendencies of ignorance. Mahāmati, the whole of the three realms of existence arises from unreal conceptualization, but the tathāgatas do not arise from unreal imagining.

Mahāmati, where there is duality, there are permanence and impermanence, but not where there is nonduality. Mahāmati, since all phenomena are nondual and have the characteristic of being unborn, they are void of duality. For this reason, Mahāmati, the tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly complete buddhas, are neither permanent nor impermanent. Mahāmati, as long as verbal conceptuality operates, so long does the fault of permanence and impermanence arise. Mahāmati, by the exhaustion of the conceptualizing mind, the view of childish beings concerning permanence and impermanence is turned back, but not through the exhaustion of the mind of seclusion.

On this it is said:

Free from permanence and impermanence,
Yet brought forth as permanent and impermanent:
Those who always see the buddhas thus
Do not fall under the sway of views.

With permanence and impermanence,
The perfect accumulation would be pointless.
Through the absence of the conceptualizing mind,

Impermanence and permanence are turned back.

As long as there is any assertion,
So long is everything confused.
Look upon it as one's own mind only,
And do not embark on disputes.

This is the fifth chapter, called "Whether the Tathāgata Is Permanent or Impermanent."

Then again the bodhisattva, the great being Mahāmati, made a request to the Blessed One: "Please, Blessed One, explain to me the coming into operation and the ceasing of the aggregates, the elements, and the sense bases. Please, Sugata, explain it to me. If there is no self, what is it that comes into operation or ceases? Childish beings, abiding in coming into operation and ceasing, do not understand the exhaustion of suffering, and therefore do not know nirvāṇa."

The Blessed One said, "Mahāmati, then listen very well and hold it in mind, and I shall explain it to you."

"Excellent, Blessed One," Mahāmati the bodhisattva, the great being, replied, and he listened to the Blessed One. The Blessed One then spoke to him as follows:

"Mahāmati, the tathāgatagarbha, which is the cause of virtue and non-virtue, which produces all births and destinies, and which is free of self and what belongs to a self, enters perilous destinies like a dancer. Because this is not understood, when it operates together with the activity of conditions, the conjunction of the three, the non-Buddhists, who are attached and cling to causes, do not understand it.

"Perfumed by the many kinds of habitual tendencies of the dysfunction of conceptual elaboration from beginningless time, and called the all-base consciousness, it operates together with the seven consciousnesses born of karma through the ground of ignorance, like the waves of the great ocean: constantly, its body unbroken in continuity, free from the fault of impermanence, turned away from the doctrine of a self, utterly pure in its intrinsic nature.

"The other consciousnesses, which arise and perish, the seven beginning with mentation and mental consciousness, are momentary. Born from the cause of

unreal imagining, they take as their object the activity and particulars of shapes; they are attached and cling to names and signs; they do not comprehend that forms and characteristics are appearances of their own mind; they do not experience pleasure and pain; they are not a cause of liberation; and they take as their object the cause of what is stirred up and produced by names, signs, and the desire that fully arises.

"When those called the appropriated faculties are completely exhausted and have ceased, then, because they do not arise again immediately afterward and others also do not come into operation, the yogins who have entered the meditative attainment of the cessation of perception and feeling, in which the pleasure and pain conceived by their own minds are not experienced, and who are skilled in the four dhyānas, the truths, and the liberations, come to take this for liberation.

If the all-base consciousness, which is proclaimed as the tathāgatagarbha, has not been transformed, the seven active consciousnesses do not cease. Why is that? Because the consciousnesses proceed with it as their cause and with it as their object, and because it is not the domain of any of the yogins in the yoga of the śrāvakas, the pratyekabuddhas and the non-Buddhists (tīrthikas). Through realizing the selflessness of persons, and through grasping the specific and general characteristics of the aggregates, the elements and the sense sources, the tathāgatagarbha proceeds. Through seeing the five dharmas, the intrinsic natures and the selflessness of phenomena, it turns back once it is transformed through the successive progression of the grounds, and it cannot be shaken by the views of the other, non-Buddhist paths.

Therefore one who is firmly established on the bodhisattva ground called Immovable attains the ten paths that are gateways of the truth of samādhi. Being upheld by the buddhas of samādhi, and therefore contemplating the inconceivable qualities of a buddha and his own aspirations, he turns the gateway of samādhi back from the limit of reality. Then, by the path of yoga that is to be known through the noble individual self-awareness and is not shared with any of the śrāvakas, the pratyekabuddhas or the tīrthikas, he attains the ten paths of the noble lineage, wisdom, the mind-made body, and a samādhi free of deliberate effort.

Therefore, Mahāmati, bodhisattva mahāsattvas who seek distinction should purify the tathāgatagarbha that is proclaimed as the all-base consciousness. Mahāmati, if the tathāgatagarbha proclaimed as the all-base consciousness

did not exist, then, Mahāmati, since there would be no tathāgatagarbha proclaimed as the all-base consciousness, there would be neither proceeding nor turning back. Yet, Mahāmati, for childish beings and for noble ones there is both proceeding and turning back, and yogins who do not give up their diligence abide in happiness in this very life through their own individual self-awareness.

Mahāmati, this sphere of the tathāgatagarbha, the all-base consciousness, is hard to comprehend for śrāvakas, pratyekabuddhas and non-Buddhists who hold speculative views. Although it is completely pure by nature, it appears to them as though impure, because it is defiled by adventitious afflictions. It is not so for the tathāgatas. Mahāmati, for the tathāgatas it becomes a domain of direct perception, like a myrobalan fruit in the palm of the hand.

Mahāmati, this very point was set forth in teaching for the sake of Queen Śrīmālā, and for the sake of other bodhisattvas who are learned and whose intellect is pure, subtle and vast: the tathāgatagarbha proclaimed as the all-base consciousness, together with the seven consciousnesses. In order to teach the selflessness of phenomena to the śrāvakas who are attached to the proceeding of consciousness, the domain of the Tathāgata was explained for the sake of Queen Śrīmālā. It is not a domain to be realized by the śrāvakas, the pratyekabuddhas or the other tīrthikas.

Otherwise, Mahāmati, the domain of the tathāgatagarbha, the all-base consciousness, is the domain of the tathāgatas. It is also the domain of bodhisattva mahāsattvas like you, whose inclinations are subtle and learned, who discern with their intellect, and who rely on the meaning. It is not that of the other non-Buddhists, nor of any of the śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas, who are attached to the teachings just as they sound. Therefore, Mahāmati, you and the other bodhisattva mahāsattvas should apply yourselves to this tathāgatagarbha, the all-base consciousness, the domain of all the tathāgatas, which is to be fully understood. You should not be satisfied with merely hearing of it.

On this it is said:

The tathāgatagarbha,
Even when joined with the seven consciousnesses,
Proceeds by way of the twofold grasping,
And through full understanding it turns back.

Mind appears like a reflection,
Imprinted from beginningless time;
When one examines it exactly as it is,
Though it resembles objects, there are no objects.

Just as a child grasps at the fingertip
And does not look at the moon,
So those attached to letters
Do not know my true reality.

Mind abides like a dancer,
Mentation is like a jester;
Consciousness, together with the five,
Imagines appearances like colors.

The Noble Descent into Laṅkā, the seventh fascicle.

Then again the bodhisattva mahāsattva Mahāmati made this request of the Blessed One: "Blessed One, please explain to me the characteristic of realizing the distinctions of the five dharmas, the intrinsic natures, the consciousnesses and the two selflessnesses. It is the characteristic of realizing the distinctions of the two selflessnesses through which I and all the other bodhisattva mahāsattvas will cultivate these dharmas in their successive stages, through which by every means we will enter into all the qualities of a buddha, and through which, having entered into all the qualities of a buddha, we will enter as far as the Tathāgata's own ground of individual self-awareness. Sugata, please explain it to me."

The Blessed One said, "Mahāmati, then listen very well and keep it in mind, and I shall explain it to you."

Saying, "Excellent, Blessed One," the bodhisattva mahāsattva Mahāmati listened to the Blessed One, and the Blessed One spoke to him thus:

"Mahāmati, I shall explain to you the characteristic of realizing the distinctions of the five dharmas, the intrinsic natures, the consciousnesses and the two selflessnesses. They are name, sign, conceptuality, correct wisdom and suchness. This is the entry into the Tathāgata's noble individual self-awareness. It abandons the views of permanence and annihilation, of existence and nonexistence. It is entry into absorption as the gateway to happiness in this very life, an abiding in happiness that becomes directly evident to yogins."

"Here, Mahāmati, it is because they do not understand the five dharmas, the natures, the consciousnesses, the two kinds of selflessness, their own mind, external things, and the absence of things that the conceptuality of childish beings operates. That of the noble ones does not."

Mahāmati asked, "Blessed One, how is it, then, that the conceptuality of childish beings operates and that of the noble ones does not?"

The Blessed One said, "Mahāmati, because they are attached to names, perceptions and conventional signs, childish beings follow after the mind. Following after it, they hold that there are various characteristics. Their thinking has fallen into the view of a self and of what belongs to a self, and so they become strongly attached to the rich profusion of colors. Once attached, and obscured by ignorance, they become intensely passionate. Being intensely passionate, they create karma born of attachment, aversion and delusion. Having created it, again and again, like silkworms, their minds become wrapped in their own conceptuality. They fall into the ocean and the wilderness of the destinies, and like a waterwheel they never pass beyond them.

Because of delusion, they do not know the following. All phenomena are like illusions, mirages and the moon in water. They are devoid of a self and of what belongs to a self. They arise from unreal conceptuality. They are free of any basis for characteristics and free of signs. They are free from the occurrence of arising, abiding and destruction. They arise from the conceptuality of one's own mind. They do not arise from Īśvara, from time, from atoms, or from the principal (pradhāna).

Mahāmati, because they are distracted by names and signs, childish beings conform to signs and so pursue signs.

Here, Mahāmati, a sign is whatever appears to visual consciousness, which is called form. In the same way, for the ear, nose, tongue, body and mental consciousnesses there are what are called sound, smell, taste, touch and mental phenomena. This is what is explained as sign.

Here, Mahāmati, conceptuality is that by which one expresses things in names and says, 'This is an elephant, a horse, a chariot, a foot soldier, a man, a woman, and so forth. It is just so, and not otherwise.' Whatever makes signs distinct in this way is conceptuality.

Mahāmati, correct wisdom is that by which names and signs are not apprehended. Because they are mutually adventitious, consciousness does not operate. Because it is free of permanence and free of annihilation, it does not let one fall to the level of any tīrthikas, śrāvakas or pratyekabuddhas. For this reason it is called correct wisdom.

Moreover, Mahāmati, by that correct wisdom the bodhisattva mahāsattva does not take names to be things. Nor does he take signs to be the absence of things. Such a knowing has abandoned the wrong views of the two extremes of superimposition and denial, and knows that the meaning of names and signs does not operate. That, it is explained, is this suchness.

Mahāmati, the bodhisattva mahāsattva who abides in suchness reaches the domain of a realization free of appearances, and so attains the bodhisattva ground called the Joyous ground. Once he has attained the bodhisattva ground called the Joyous ground, he has turned away from all non-Buddhists and from every destiny of the lower realms. He has truly entered into the realization of the transcendent dharmas. He is free of curiosity about the views of the logicians, and because he is familiar with the characteristics, he cultivates the approach to the Dharma that is led by the understanding that things are like illusions and the like. Step by step, up to the Cloud of Dharma ground, he attains the characteristic of the dharma that is his own noble, individually realized wisdom.

After the Cloud of Dharma ground, the flowers of the samādhis, powers, masteries and superknowledges come into full bloom, and he attains everything up to the ground of the Tathāgata. Having attained this, he is beautifully adorned with the many rays of light of his emanations, which he sends out in order to bring sentient beings to maturity. Like the moon in water, his nature wholly bound up with the limitless state, he teaches the Dharma to sentient beings of differing inclinations.

Mahāmati, because bodhisattva mahāsattvas have entered suchness, they also attain a body free of mind and cognition."

Again Mahāmati asked, "Blessed One, are the three natures included within the five dharmas, or are they established by their own characteristics?"

The Blessed One said, "Mahāmati, within these very five are included the three natures, the eight consciousnesses and the two kinds of selflessness. Here, name and sign should be known as the imputed nature.

Mahāmati, there is the conceptuality that rests on these and operates through them. It is proclaimed as mind and mental factors, and these arise at one and the same time, like the sun together with its rays. Its nature is one's own conceptuality, which grasps the various characteristics. That, Mahāmati, is called the dependent.

Mahāmati, correct wisdom and suchness are indestructible, and so they should be known as the perfected nature.

Moreover, Mahāmati, through attachment to what appears from one's own mind, conceptuality is divided into eight, because one imputes the characteristic of unreal signs. When the two kinds of grasping, at a self and at what belongs to a self, are pacified, the two kinds of selflessness arise.

Mahāmati, within these five dharmas are included all the qualities of a buddha and the connections that distinguish the grounds. Included too are the ways in which śrāvakas, pratyekabuddhas, bodhisattvas and tathāgatas enter into the realization of their own noble, individually realized wisdom.

Moreover, Mahāmati, the five dharmas are sign, name, conceptuality, suchness and correct wisdom. Here, Mahāmati, what is sign? Whatever appears with the characteristics of shape, aspect, distinguishing feature, appearance, form and so forth, that is sign.

That very sign, when it is designated as "pot" and so forth, with the thought, "This is thus and not otherwise," is name. Mahāmati, that by which one utters that name, saying "pleasant" or "armor," and makes the sign clear, and which is proclaimed as mind and mental factors, is conceptual thought. Because these phenomena are not experienced by one another and are not imputed either, the utter non-apprehension of name and sign, up to the complete dissolution of the intellect, is suchness. It is the real, the perfectly ascertained, the ultimate, the intrinsic nature, the essential nature, the unapprehended. As the characteristic of suchness, it has been realized by me and by the other tathāgatas as well, and it has been explained just as it is, designated, analyzed, and made clear. That by which one comprehends and truly realizes, which does not enter into conceptual thought because it is neither annihilation nor permanence, which accords with the noble wisdom realized by oneself, and which is not the domain of those on the opposing side, the tīrthikas, nor of the śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas: that is right wisdom. Mahāmati, these are the five dharmas. Within these very ones are included the three natures, the eight consciousnesses, the two kinds of selflessness, and all the qualities of a

buddha. Mahāmati, you should therefore become skilled in this through your own intelligence. You should also lead others to do the same, and you should not depend on others.

On this it is said:

The five dharmas, the natures,
The eight consciousnesses themselves,
And the two kinds of selflessness:
In these the whole Great Vehicle is contained.
Name, sign, and imputation
Are the characteristic of two natures;
Right wisdom and suchness
Are the characteristic of the perfected.

Then once again the bodhisattva, the great being Mahāmati, said this to the Blessed One: "In the discourses the Blessed One has given, he says that the tathāgatas of the past, the future, and the present are as numerous as the sands of the river Ganges. Blessed One, should this be taken in its literal meaning, or is there some other particular meaning? Blessed One, please explain this."

The Blessed One said: "Mahāmati, it should not be taken in its literal meaning. Mahāmati, the measure of the sands of the river Ganges does not even come to the measure of the buddhas of a single one of the three times. Why is that? Mahāmati, it is like this: since they are both similar and dissimilar to what transcends the highest in the world, the example is no example. Mahāmati, the tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly complete buddhas do not present an example that is dissimilar as though it were similar to what transcends the highest in the world. Mahāmati, it is otherwise. It is in order to make weary the childish ordinary people who are attached to permanence and impermanence, who are ruined by the evil views of the tīrthikas, and who follow the wheel of saṃsāric existence, so that these beings of existence may grow weary of that frightful wheel of existence and, longing for something higher, set out toward what is higher; and it is to show that attaining buddhahood is easy, so that they will take up diligence, thinking, 'The birth of tathāgatas is like the udumbara flower.' Therefore this saying, 'tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly complete buddhas as numerous as the sands of the river Ganges,' is set forth merely as an example.

"In my discourses, having looked upon the beings to be trained, I did say, 'The appearance of tathāgatas is as hard to find as the udumbara flower.' But, Mahāmati, the udumbara flower has never been seen by anyone before, nor will it be seen, whereas, Mahāmati, the tathāgatas are seen in the world and appear even now. When speaking in the context of a talk that establishes my own principle on its own terms, I did not say that the appearance of tathāgatas is as hard to find as the udumbara flower. Mahāmati, when one gives a talk establishing one's own principle on its own terms, one does not use fitting examples for what transcends the highest in the world, for since that would not be credible, childish ordinary people would not come to have faith.

"Because reality transcends mind, mentation, and mental consciousness, examples do not apply to the domain of the noble wisdom realized by oneself. Reality is the tathāgatas, and for that reason examples should not be set up for them. Nevertheless, Mahāmati, this is given merely as an example: the tathāgatas are equal to the sands of the river Ganges. Since they neither think nor conceptualize, they are equal, without any inequality.

"Mahāmati, it is like this. The sands of the river Ganges, even when they are stirred up by fish, turtles, crocodiles, humans, buffalo, lions, elephants, horses, and so forth, do not think or conceptualize, 'We are stirred up,' or, 'We are not stirred up.' They are clear and free of stains, without conceptual thought. In the same way, Mahāmati, the noble wisdom realized by oneself of the tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly complete buddhas is the river Ganges, and its sands of powers, masteries, and superknowledges, even when stirred up by all the fish of the childish tīrthikas and opposing disputants, do not think or conceptualize, because of the aspirations the tathāgatas made in the past. Because they have perfected all the blissful meditative absorptions, they do not think or conceptualize about sentient beings. Therefore those tathāgatas, being without affection or anger, are equal to the sands of the river Ganges; there is no difference.

"Mahāmati, it is like this. The sands of the river Ganges have the nature of the characteristic of earth, so even when they are burned at the burning of the eon, they do not abandon the nature of earth. Mahāmati, earth does not burn, because it is bound up with the element of fire. Childish ordinary people, with minds fallen into error, imagine otherwise, that it burns; but since it has come about from the cause of fire, it does not burn. In the same way, Mahāmati, the dharma body of the tathāgatas is also like the sands of the river Ganges: it is indestructible.

For example, Mahāmati, the sands of the river Ganges are measureless. Likewise, Mahāmati, the measureless rays of light of the tathāgatas are sent forth by the tathāgatas into the maṇḍalas of the assemblies of all the buddhas, in order to urge sentient beings toward full maturation.

For example, Mahāmati, the sands of the river Ganges do not turn into some other nature; sands remain in the very state of sand. Likewise, Mahāmati, for the tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly complete buddhas, the cause of entering any state of existence has been cut off. Therefore there is no entering into saṃsāra for them, and no turning back from it either.

For example, Mahāmati, when sand is taken from the river Ganges, no decrease is apparent, and when sand is added, no increase is apparent. Likewise, Mahāmati, because the Dharma has no body, the wisdom of the Tathāgata neither diminishes nor grows through the work of bringing sentient beings to maturity. Mahāmati, the Dharma has no body. What has a body is subject to destruction, but what has no body is not.

For example, Mahāmati, though one who wants butter and oil may press the sands of the river Ganges hard, there is no butter or oil in them. Likewise, Mahāmati, though the tathāgatas are sorely afflicted by the sufferings of sentient beings, because they possess great compassion, the tathāgatas do not give up the bliss of their aspiration, which rests in the very nature of the dharmadhātu, until all sentient beings have been brought to nirvāṇa.

For example, Mahāmati, the sands of the river Ganges flow in keeping with the current that carries them; they do not flow where there is no water. Likewise, Mahāmati, all the teachings of the Dharma given by the tathāgatas proceed in keeping with the current that flows to nirvāṇa. For this reason the tathāgatas are said to be equal to the sands of the river Ganges.

Mahāmati, this meaning of going does not apply to the tathāgatas. Mahāmati, to go forth is the meaning of going; and, Mahāmati, the first limit of saṃsāra is not known. If it is not known, how can one speak in terms of going? Mahāmati, while the meaning of going is annihilation, childish ordinary beings do not understand this.

Mahāmati asked, "Blessed One, if the first limit of saṃsāra is not known for sentient beings, how then is the liberation of living beings known?"

The Blessed One said, "Mahāmati, through fully understanding external objects as the appearance of one's own mind, the cause, namely the habitual

tendencies of conceptuality that grasp at the negative states, the elaborations of beginningless time, is reversed, and one's own basis is thoroughly transformed. That is liberation, Mahāmati; it is not destruction. Therefore, Mahāmati, talk of endlessness serves no purpose at all. Mahāmati, this so-called end of the endless is a synonym for conceptuality. When one examines it thoroughly with intelligence, there is no other being, outer or inner, apart from conceptuality. Mahāmati, all dharmas are void of knower and known. Otherwise, because conceptuality is not fully understood as the appearance of one's own mind, conceptuality goes on operating; when it is realized, it comes to an end."

On this it is said:

Those who truly see the Guide
as equal to the Ganges' sand,
perfected in the way of the imperishable,
they are the ones who see the Guide.

Just as the sands of the Ganges
are free of every fault,
flow along the current and are constant,
so are the buddhas, buddhahood itself.

Then again the bodhisattva mahāsattva Mahāmati said this to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, Sugata, please explain to me the destruction of all dharmas through their momentary change. Tathāgata, Arhat, Perfectly Complete Buddha, please explain it to me. Blessed One, in what way are all dharmas momentary?"

The Blessed One said, "Then, Mahāmati, listen very well and keep it in mind, and I shall explain it to you."

Saying, "Excellent, Blessed One," the bodhisattva mahāsattva Mahāmati listened to the Blessed One, and the Blessed One spoke to him thus:

"Mahāmati, what are called all dharmas, all dharmas, are these: the virtuous and the nonvirtuous, the conditioned and the unconditioned, the mundane and the supramundane, the blameworthy and the blameless, the defiled and the undefiled, the appropriated and the unappropriated. Mahāmati, in brief, the five aggregates of grasping, which arise from the cause, the habitual tendencies of mind, mentation, and mental consciousness, are imagined as virtuous and nonvirtuous by childish ordinary beings in whom the habitual

tendencies of mind, mentation, and mental consciousness have increased. Mahāmati, the bliss of samādhi and the meditative attainments, being the basis for dwelling happily in this very life, are called the undefiled virtue of the noble ones.

"Further, Mahāmati, the virtuous and the nonvirtuous are the eight consciousnesses. If one asks what the eight are, they are: what is proclaimed as the tathāgatagarbha, the all-base consciousness; mentation; mental consciousness; and the five groups of consciousness spoken of by the tīrthikas. Mahāmati, among these, the five groups of consciousness together with mental consciousness, distinguished as virtuous and nonvirtuous by their division into one moment after another, arise through the continuity of their stream as an undivided body. Having arisen, they perish. Because the appearance of one's own mind is not realized, immediately upon cessation another consciousness arises: the mental consciousness that grasps the particulars of shape and form arises. It arises together with the five groups of consciousness. What does not abide even for the duration of a moment, that I call momentary."

"Mahāmati, the all-base consciousness, which is proclaimed as the tathāgatagarbha, together with the mind, is momentary by virtue of the habitual tendencies of the engaging consciousnesses. By virtue of the uncontaminated habitual tendencies, however, it is not momentary. Childish ordinary beings who are attached to the doctrine of momentariness do not understand this momentariness and non-momentariness of all phenomena. Because they do not understand it, their nihilistic view destroys even the unconditioned phenomena.

"Mahāmati, the five groups of consciousness are not what transmigrates in saṃsāra. They do not experience pleasure and pain, and they are not the cause of nirvāṇa. Mahāmati, the tathāgatagarbha does not itself experience pleasure and pain, yet it is accompanied by their cause. Being bound up with the four habitual tendencies, it proceeds and turns back. Childish beings whose intellects are imbued with the conceptual thought of the view of momentariness do not understand this.

"Furthermore, Mahāmati, gold, the vajra, the relics of the Victor, attainment and the special qualities are indestructible. Mahāmati, if the attainment of realization were momentary, the noble ones would become ignoble. But the noble ones do not become ignoble. Mahāmati, gold and the vajra remain just

as they are even when measured over eons, neither diminishing nor increasing. How, then, can childish beings who are unskilled in the intended meaning of the teaching regard all outer and inner phenomena as momentary?"

Again Mahāmati asked, "The Blessed One has said, 'If one brings the six perfections to completion, one will attain buddhahood.' What are these perfections, and how are they brought to completion?"

The Blessed One said, "Mahāmati, there are three kinds of perfection. What are the three? They are the worldly, the supramundane, and the supreme supramundane.

"Mahāmati, among these, as for the worldly perfections: those who are attached to and fixated on grasping at self and what is mine, who grasp at the two extremes, and who desire objects such as forms for the sake of various places of birth in existence, bring the perfection of generosity to completion. In the same way, Mahāmati, childish beings bring to completion the perfections of moral discipline, patience, diligence, meditative concentration and wisdom, and they also accomplish the superknowledges in order to be born as Brahmā.

"As for the supramundane perfections: just as childish beings desire nirvāṇa as their own happiness, śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas, whose intentions have fallen into the desire for nirvāṇa, apply themselves to generosity and the rest.

"Mahāmati, as for the supreme supramundane perfections: for the bodhisattva mahāsattvas, yogins in the sublime yoga, the perfection of generosity arises for the benefit and happiness of all sentient beings through their apprehending things as merely the appearance of their own mind, understanding duality as their own mind, conceptual thought not engaging, having no grasping at appropriation, and not being attached to the characteristics of their own mind and of form.

"Meditating so that conceptual thought does not engage with whatever is taken as an object: that is moral discipline, and that is also its perfection.

"The patience by which, through fully understanding the grasped and the grasper, that very conceptual thought does not engage: that is the perfection of patience.

"The diligence by which one strives in the first and last parts of the night, and through which, by seeing in accordance with yoga, conceptual thought ceases: that is the perfection of diligence.

"That by which, because conceptual thought has been turned back, one does not fall into grasping at the nirvāṇa of the non-Buddhists (tīrthikas): that is the perfection of meditative concentration.

"As for the perfection of wisdom: when there is no conceptual thought of one's own mind, and when one analyzes all the way to intellectual discernment, one does not fall into the two extremes; and through the transformation of the basis that goes before being indestructible, one applies oneself to attaining one's own noble, individually self-aware knowledge. That is the perfection of wisdom.

"Mahāmati, these are the perfections, and this is the meaning of perfection."

On this it is said:

"Empty, impermanent and momentary:
So the conditioned is imagined as produced.
By the examples of a river, a lamp and a seed,
It is imagined to mean momentariness.

Being without an agent, being momentary,
Being isolated, free from activity,
And the non-arising of phenomena:
These I have taught as the meaning of momentary.

That things perish as soon as they arise
I do not teach even to the childish.
The conceptual thought of entities
Moves without interruption through the realms of rebirth.

The cause that brings that mind into being
Is ignorance.
As long as forms are not known,
Does it remain for just that long?

As soon as it has perished,
Other minds arise.
If form does not endure through time,
Taking what as its object would they arise?

The mind that moves from this to that
Arises from a mistaken cause.
If that is not truly established,
How can it be known to perish in an instant?

The meditative absorptions of yogins,
Gold and the relics of the Victor,
The celestial palace of the Ābhāsvara abode:
These are not destroyed by worldly causes.

The things that endure, the Dharma that is heard,
The perfection of the buddhas' wisdom,
Monkhood, and those who have attained knowledge:
How can these be seen as momentary?

How are illusions, cities of the gandharvas and the like,
And forms momentary?
Forms that are not made of the elements,
And those elements: where have they gone?"

This concludes the sixth chapter, on momentariness.

Then again the bodhisattva mahāsattva Mahāmati said this to the Blessed One:

"Why did the Blessed One (the Buddha) prophesy that arhats will attain unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening, and also that beings whose nature is never to attain final nirvāṇa will become tathāgatas? From the night on which the Tathāgata awoke fully into unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening until the night on which he passed into final nirvāṇa, the Blessed One did not speak or teach a single letter. The tathāgatas always remain in meditative equipoise, and without conceptualizing or analyzing they send forth emanations, and these perform the deeds of a tathāgata. The consciousnesses, too, are explained as having characteristics that differ from one instant to the next. Vajrapāṇi always follows close around him as his attendant. The beginning limit is not posited, yet nirvāṇa is posited. There are Māra and the deeds of Māra, the causes of karma, and karmic obscurations such as the brahmin girl Ciñcā, Sundarī the wandering ascetic, the alms bowl that came back as though washed clean, and so forth. If these are so, Blessed One, how did the Blessed One attain omniscience without having abandoned these faults?"

The Blessed One said, "Mahāmati, therefore listen very well and keep it in mind, and I shall explain it to you."

"Excellent, Blessed One," said the bodhisattva, the great being Mahāmati, and he listened to the Blessed One. The Blessed One then spoke to him as follows:

"It was with the realm of nirvāṇa without any remainder of the aggregates in mind, and in order to encourage those who practice the conduct of a bodhisattva. Mahāmati, in this buddha field and in others there are those practicing bodhisattva conduct who wish to attain final nirvāṇa by the vehicle of the śrāvakas. In order to turn them back from their wish for the śrāvaka vehicle and to inspire them toward the Great Vehicle, emanation bodies prophesied to emanated śrāvakas; it was not done by the buddhas of dharmatā. Mahāmati, it was with this in mind that śrāvakas were prophesied.

"Mahāmati, because liberation has a single taste, there is no difference as regards the abandonment of the afflictive obscuration by śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas; but this is not so as regards the abandonment of the cognitive obscuration. Mahāmati, the cognitive obscuration is purified through the distinctive seeing of the selflessness of phenomena. The afflictive obscuration is purified through the distinctive seeing of the selflessness of persons. The afflictive obscuration is abandoned, because mental consciousness is turned back, by first meditating on the seeing of the selflessness of persons. Liberation from the obscuration regarding phenomena is purified because the habitual tendencies of the all-base consciousness are turned back.

"It is with the ancient way of Dharma in mind: because, being without earlier and later, it does not newly arise, the Tathāgata teaches the Dharma without conceptualizing or analyzing, by means of those very letters that were spoken before. Because he acts with full knowledge, has no lapse of mindfulness, has abandoned the ground of habitual tendencies, is free of the two, death and transmigration, and has abandoned the two obscurations, the afflictive and the cognitive, he does not conceptualize or analyze.

"Mahāmati, the seven, namely the mind, the mental consciousness, the eye consciousness and so forth, are devoid of the side of the virtuous and undefiled and do not transmigrate. Because they arise from the cause of habitual tendencies, they are momentary. Mahāmati, buddha-nature is the cause of transmigration and of nirvāṇa, of happiness and of suffering. Childish ordinary beings, whose minds are distracted by emptiness, do not know its very purity.

"Further, Mahāmati, Vajrapāṇi stays in the presence of the tathāgatas emanated by magical emanation, but not in the presence of the actual tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly and completely awakened buddhas.

Mahāmati, the actual Tathāgata is beyond the epistemic instruments and the faculties of all childish ordinary beings, śrāvakas, pratyekabuddhas and non-Buddhists (tīrthikas). Those who dwell in bliss in this very life realize it through the forbearance that knows the dharmas realized as directly seen. Therefore Vajrapāṇi does not follow it as its attendant.

"All the emanated buddhas do not arise from karma. There is no Tathāgata in them, and there is no Tathāgata apart from them either. Through a combination like that of a potter with his materials and so forth, they perform all activities and also display the major marks; yet they do not teach the discourse that sets forth their own way individually, the domain of noble wisdom realized individually for oneself.

"Further, Mahāmati, childish ordinary beings rely on the view of annihilation because the six groups of consciousness cease. Because they do not realize the all-base, they come to hold the view of permanence. Mahāmati, the beginning limit of the conceptuality of one's own mind cannot be known. Through turning back the very conceptuality of one's own mind, liberation too is known. Through abandoning the four habitual tendencies, all faults come to be abandoned."

On this it is said:

The three vehicles and no vehicle,
the buddhas having no nirvāṇa,
the prophecy that all will be buddhas,
the teaching that they are free from faults,
the wisdom at the culmination of realization,
and likewise the realizations without grasping:
in order to encourage the faint-hearted,
these were taught with an intention in mind.

The buddhas bring forth wisdom,
And they themselves also teach the path.
By that one goes, and not by anything else;
Therefore they do not pass into that nirvāṇa.

Through existence, desire, form and views,
Habitual tendencies become fourfold.
Arising from the mental consciousness,
They abide in the ālaya and in the mind.

The mental consciousness, the eye and the rest,
Being impermanent, are taught as annihilation.
Because they are beginningless, there comes the view of permanence,
And a view that is devoted to nirvāṇa.

Then the bodhisattva mahāsattva Mahāmati, having questioned the Blessed One in verses, again made a request to the Blessed One: "In times to come and in the present, there are sentient beings imbued with the habitual tendencies of meat-eating and the like, beings attached to the food of flesh. So that I and the other bodhisattva mahāsattvas may rid them of their craving for its taste; so that those beings, their craving for taste removed and devoted instead to the food of the taste of the Dharma, may hold all sentient beings dear as an only child and gain loving-kindness for one another; and so that, having gained it, they may be trained through the bodhisattva grounds and swiftly awaken fully to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening, or else, having rested on the grounds of the śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas, may come to attain the unsurpassed ground of the Tathāgata: for this, may the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the perfectly and completely awakened Buddha, please explain to me the Dharma that shows meat-eating to be a fault.

"Blessed One, even the non-Buddhists (tīrthikas), whose teachings are badly expounded, who cling to the views of the Lokāyatas, who take sides on existence and nonexistence, and who proclaim eternalism and annihilation, forbid the eating of meat and do not eat it themselves. How then could it be that in your teaching, Protector of the world, which through compassion has a single taste, and which was spoken by the perfectly and completely awakened Buddha, people eat meat themselves and do not turn others back from eating it? So that I and the other bodhisattva mahāsattvas may teach the Dharma to sentient beings as it truly is, may the Blessed One, who looks upon the whole world with love in every way as on an only child, the one possessed of great compassion, out of that love, please explain well the faults of eating meat."

The Blessed One said, "Therefore, Mahāmati, listen very well and keep it in mind, and I shall explain it to you."

Saying, "Excellent, Blessed One," the bodhisattva mahāsattva Mahāmati listened to the Blessed One, and the Blessed One spoke to him thus:

"Mahāmati, a bodhisattva whose very nature is compassion should not eat any meat, for there are countless reasons. I shall explain just a portion of them.

"Mahāmati, among living beings who have wandered in saṃsāra for a very long time, there is no way to find easily any sentient being who has not been one's father, mother, brother, sister, son, daughter, friend or relative, or someone like a relative. Those who were relatives or like relatives have changed bodies in other lives and been born as wild animals, livestock or birds, in some birthplace or another. How, then, could a bodhisattva mahāsattva who longs for the qualities of a buddha, and who wishes all beings to be as himself, eat flesh that comes from any of the creatures that have become living beings?

"Mahāmati, if even rākṣasas, on hearing this excellent nature of reality of the Dharma of the tathāgatas, turn away from eating meat, shed the nature of rākṣasas and become compassionate, what need is there to speak of people who long for the Dharma? Thus, Mahāmati, because throughout one life after another all sentient beings have been friends and relatives, and in order to cultivate, with that perception, the perception of each sentient being as an only child, a bodhisattva whose very nature is compassion does not eat any meat.

"Mahāmati, a bodhisattva endowed with right conduct does not eat any meat, both because meat is unfit to eat and because of deception. Mahāmati, although the meat of donkeys, camels, dogs, oxen, human beings and the like is not eaten by the world, butchers declare it fit to eat for the sake of money and sell it in the middle of the streets. For that reason too, Mahāmati, a bodhisattva does not eat any meat.

"Mahāmati, because he desires purity, too, a bodhisattva does not eat meat, for meat comes from semen and blood.

"Mahāmati, because it terrifies living creatures, too, a bodhisattva yogin who longs for loving-kindness should not eat any meat. For example, Mahāmati, when dogs see beings who eat dog meat, such as ḍombas, caṇḍālas and fishermen, even from far away, they are seized with terror, and some, thinking, 'They are coming to kill us too,' are brought to the point of death. In the same way, Mahāmati, the other very tiny creatures that live in the sky, on land and in water, as soon as they see meat-eaters from afar, catch their scent with their keen sense of smell and flee swiftly, as people flee from a rākṣasa, and some even fear for their lives. Therefore, Mahāmati, because it causes terror, a bodhisattva who abides in loving-kindness does not eat meat.

"Mahāmati, because meat is resorted to by ignoble people, smells foul, brings disrepute, and is shunned by the noble ones, a bodhisattva does not eat meat. Mahāmati, noble people eat the food of sages and do not eat blood and flesh; for that reason too a bodhisattva does not eat meat.

"Mahāmati, in order to protect the minds of many people, a bodhisattva whose very nature is compassion, wishing to prevent disparagement of the teaching, does not eat meat. It is like this, Mahāmati: in the world there are those who speak in disparagement of the teaching: 'Alas, what sort of ascetic life do these people have? Where is their holy life? Having abandoned the food of the sages of old, they fill their bellies with the food of flesh like beasts of prey, and they roam about this world terrifying the tiny creatures that live in the sky, on land and in water. Their ascetic life has degenerated; their renunciation of evil has been destroyed.

"These people have neither Dharma nor Vinaya!" Speaking this way, those who harbor hostile minds disparage the teaching in many ways. Therefore, Mahāmati, in order to protect the minds of many people, the bodhisattva of compassionate nature who wishes to prevent disparagement of the teaching should not eat any meat.

Mahāmati, because meat is like a corpse, foul-smelling and unwholesome, the bodhisattva should not eat meat. Mahāmati, when the flesh of a dead human is burned, and when the flesh of some other creature is burned, there is no difference whatever in the smell; both are equally foul. For this reason too, Mahāmati, the bodhisattva who is a yogin and desires purity should not eat any meat.

Mahāmati, there are the charnel-ground dwellers; the yogins who stay in remote lodgings in the wilderness and in forests where nonhumans roam; those who practice yoga and abide in loving-kindness; the holders of vidyā-mantras; and those who wish to accomplish vidyā-mantras. Meat hinders their accomplishment of vidyā-mantras, and because it obstructs liberation, it hinders all the yogic accomplishments of the sons and daughters of noble family who have entered the Great Vehicle. Seeing this, the bodhisattva who wishes to benefit the bodies of himself and others should not eat any meat.

Because consciousness that takes visible form as its object becomes the condition that gives rise to attachment, the bodhisattva of compassionate nature, for whom all living creatures have become as his own self, should not

eat any meat. Mahāmati, because even the gods shun one who eats it, the bodhisattva of compassionate nature should not eat any meat. Mahāmati, because even in this very life such a person's mouth becomes extremely foul-smelling, the bodhisattva should not eat any meat.

Such a person sleeps in misery and wakes in misery. He sees evil dreams that make his hair stand on end. When he stays in an empty house or dwells alone in solitude, nonhumans who steal vitality steal his vitality. He is startled again and again, and suddenly becomes frightened and alarmed. He does not know moderation in food, and what he eats, drinks, chews and tastes does not become well-digested nourishment. Worms arise in his belly, he becomes the ground for many skin diseases, and he is made prone to many illnesses. He does not even gain the perception of food as repulsive, whereas I have taught that food is to be regarded like the flesh of one's own child, and like medicine.

Mahāmati, meat and blood are food resorted to by ignoble people and wholly shunned by noble ones, food that brings many faults and is devoid of many virtues, food unfit for sages, unwholesome and improper. How could I permit them to my disciples?

Mahāmati, I do permit, saying that they are suitable and well examined, the foods not shunned by noble ones, which bring many virtues and avoid many faults, the wholesome food of the sages of old: rice, barley, wheat, mung beans, black gram, lentils and the like; ghee, sesame oil, honey, treacle, jaggery, sugar candy, sugar and the like. Even so, Mahāmati, in time to come, foolish people who make conceptual distinctions about the Vinaya, who say many things, who are imbued with the habitual tendencies of a meat-eating lineage and are deeply attached to the craving for taste, some of them, will hold that meat is wholesome food. But, Mahāmati, it is taught that the bodhisattva mahāsattvas hold those foods to be proper: those who have rendered service to the Victors of the past and generated roots of virtue; who are faithful and free of conceptual thought; the sons of the Śākya lineage, the sons and daughters of human family, who are unattached to body, life and possessions, who do not cling to tastes and are not greedy for tastes, who are compassionate, who wish to cherish all living creatures as themselves, and who look upon all sentient beings with love, as on an only child.

Mahāmati, in times long past there was a king named Siṃha Saudāsa. He ate meat as his food, and by indulging in it improperly he craved its taste, grew attached and longed for it, so that he came to eat even human flesh. Because

of this he was abandoned even by his friends, ministers, relatives and kin, to say nothing of the townspeople and the people of the land, and since he had lost his kingdom and his land, he was greatly afflicted.

Mahāmati, Indra too, having formerly attained lordship over the gods, through the fault of the habitual tendency of eating meat took on the form of a hawk, while Viśvakarman, taking the shape and guise of a pigeon, was cruelly tormented. Indra even placed King Śibi, who was faultless and compassionate toward living creatures, on the scales and brought him great suffering. Mahāmati, if, through habituation over many lives, even one who had become Śakra, lord of the gods, was thus led to bring harm upon himself and others, what need is there to speak of anyone else?

Mahāmati, other men who had become lords of men were carried off by a powerful horse and wandered in a wilderness. To sustain their lives they mated with a lioness, and children were born to them. Because of that union with a lion, the prince Kalmāṣapāda and others, through the habitual tendencies of the fault of eating meat in former lives, came to eat human flesh even though they had become lords of men.

Mahāmati, even in this very life, if someone in a village of seven households greatly craves meat and indulges in it improperly, he will be reborn among the savage ḍākas and ḍākinīs who eat human flesh. Mahāmati, after that life, through that same attachment to the taste of meat, such beings also fall into rebirth as lions, tigers, leopards, wolves, hyenas, cats, foxes and owls, births of creatures that eat much meat, and into extremely fierce births such as those of the rākṣasas who eat much meat. For those who have fallen there, even a human birth is hard to obtain, let alone nirvāṇa. Mahāmati, such are the faults of eating meat, and since these and others befall even those who merely indulge in it, what need is there to speak of those who indulge heavily? But by turning away from it, the virtues are very many. Mahāmati, childish ordinary beings do not understand these virtues and faults, nor others besides.

Mahāmati, because they see these and other benefits and faults, it is taught that bodhisattvas, whose very nature is compassion, should eat no meat at all. Mahāmati, if no one ate meat in any way at all, then living beings would not be killed for it either. Mahāmati, innocent living beings are killed mostly for the price they fetch, and only rarely for any other reason.

Mahāmati, the craving for taste is utterly dreadful. Indulging it to excess, people have even come to eat human flesh, so what need is there to speak of

the flesh of wild animals, livestock, birds, and other creatures? Mahāmati, those tormented by craving for the taste of meat set up nets and traps of every kind, and with them fowlers, butchers, fishermen, and others kill, in many different ways, innocent creatures that fly in the sky, walk on the land, and swim in the water.

Mahāmati, those who have become hunters, fierce of mind and as pitiless as rākṣasas, kill and eat living beings while knowing full well that they are living beings, and still compassion never arises in them.

Mahāmati, there is no meat that is permissible, not even the meat called "not done for one, not caused to be done, and not suspected," which one might cite as something I allowed to the śrāvakas. Yet, Mahāmati, in times to come there will be people who have gone forth in my teaching and who profess to be sons of the Śākya, wearing the saffron banner: foolish persons whose minds are corrupted by false reasoning, who dream up many interpretations of the Vinaya, whose view of the transitory collection has grown strong in their disputation, and who are attached to the craving for taste. They will put forward all kinds of semblances of reasons for eating meat, and they will think to slander me falsely. Examining the various incidents that occasioned the rules, they will say, "On the occasion of this incident the Blessed One allowed meat as food, so is it not permissible? He also spoke of it among the delicious foods, and even the Tathāgata himself ate it."

Mahāmati, there is no sūtra in which it is allowed to be eaten, and it is not taught as permissible among the delicious foods either. Mahāmati, if I had wished to allow it, or if it were something my śrāvakas could permissibly eat, would I also have forbidden all eating of meat to the yogins who dwell in loving-kindness and frequent the charnel grounds, and to the sons and daughters of good family who have truly entered the Great Vehicle, so that they might cultivate the perception of all sentient beings as their only child? Mahāmati, I have also forbidden all meat to the sons and daughters of good family who long for the Dharma and have entered any of the vehicles, and to the charnel-ground dwellers who abide in loving-kindness, the forest dwellers, and those who practice yoga, so that they might accomplish every yoga and cultivate the perception of all sentient beings as their children.

In the teachings I have given on various occasions, the bases of training were laid down step by step, like fitting the rungs of a ladder. Having laid down the threefold rule, I forbade also what was prepared for that purpose; therefore

the meat of the ten that die naturally was not forbidden. But here it is forbidden entirely, altogether, in every respect, with no exception whatsoever. Thus, Mahāmati, I have not allowed meat as food to anyone, I do not allow it, and I will not allow it. Mahāmati, I teach that meat as food is not permissible for those who have gone forth.

Mahāmati, whoever thinks to slander me by saying, "Even the Tathāgata ate it," Mahāmati, those foolish persons, abiding in the obscuration of the faults of their own karma, will bring upon themselves what is fruitless, harmful, and painful for a long time.

Mahāmati, my noble śrāvakas do not eat even ordinary food, so what need is there to speak of the impermissible food of flesh and blood? Mahāmati, my śrāvakas, pratyekabuddhas, and bodhisattvas eat the food of the Dharma, not material food, so what need is there to speak of the tathāgatas? Mahāmati, the tathāgatas are bodies of Dharma, sustained by the food of the Dharma. They are not material bodies, and they are not sustained by any material food at all. They have abandoned all the habitual tendencies of seeking through craving for existence and for the requisites of existence; they are free of all the habitual tendencies of the faults of the afflictions; their mind and wisdom are utterly liberated; they are omniscient and all-seeing; they regard all sentient beings equally, as an only child; and they possess great compassion.

Thus, Mahāmati, since I hold the perception of all sentient beings as my only child, how could I allow the śrāvakas to eat the flesh of my own child, let alone eat it myself? That I allowed it to the śrāvakas and ate it myself, Mahāmati, is impossible.

On this it is said:

That great-minded bodhisattvas
Should neither eat nor drink
Alcohol, meat, garlic, or onions,
Supreme Victor, please explain.

Its foul smell is relished by the ignoble,
And it brings disrepute as well.
Meat is the food of beasts of prey;
The great Sage has said it must not be eaten.

The faults that come from eating it,
The benefits of not eating it,

And whatever befalls the eater of meat,
Mahāmati, understand these well.

Because of delusion, and because of kin and friends,
Because it arises from semen and blood,
And because creatures are terrified,
The yogin does not eat meat.

Meats, garlic and onions,
Alcohol of every kind,
Leeks, and wild garlic likewise,
The yogin should always shun.
Anointing with sesame oil should also be shunned.
Since the creatures that dwell in beds
Are crushed within their crevices,
One should not lie down on a bed.

From food arises arrogance;
From arrogance, thoughts arise;
Thought gives birth to desire;
Therefore one should not eat it.
From thought, desire is born;
Desire stupefies the mind;
Through stupefaction one is drawn to union,
And one is born, and is not liberated.

For profit, sentient beings are killed;
For meat, wealth is handed over.
Both of these are doers of evil,
Boiled in Raurava, the Howling Hell, and the rest.

Whoever transgresses the words of the Sage
And with evil intent eats meat,
To ruin both this world and the next,
Has taken up vows in the Śākya's teaching.
Into the most unbearable hells
Those doers of evil go;
In dreadful Raurava and the others
Those eaters of meat are boiled.

Meat that is pure in three respects,
Unconceived, unrequested,
And unurged, does not exist;
Therefore one should not eat meat.
The yogin does not eat meat:
So I and the buddhas have taught.

Beings who eat one another
Are born in the families of carnivores.
Foul-smelling and despised,
And mad, they will be born.
In the families of caṇḍālas and ḍombas,
As dyers, they are born again and again.
In the wombs of the ḍākinī kind
And in the race of piśācas they will be born.
Those lowest of humans
Are born in the wombs of rākṣasīs and of cats.

In the Hastikakṣya and the Mahāmegha,
In the Nirvāṇa and the Aṅgulimālīya,
And also in the Descent into Laṅkā Sūtra,
I have censured meat.
What the buddhas, the bodhisattvas,
And the śrāvakas have censured,
Those who eat it without shame
Will always be born insane.

Because they have given up meat and the like,
Into brahmin families, or as yogins,
As people wise and wealthy,
Those ones will be born.

Seen, heard, or suspected,
All meat is censured.
Logicians born in the families of carnivores
Do not understand this.

Just as desire
Becomes an obstacle to liberation,
So meat, alcohol and the like
Become obstacles.

In times to come,
Meat-eaters speaking out of delusion
Will say, "Meat is blameless and permissible;
So the Buddha taught."

Food that is like medicine,
That is like the flesh of one's own son,
In due measure and as something repugnant,
The yogin takes as food.

Keeping company with lions,
Tigers, foxes and the like,
For one who dwells in loving-kindness,
I have always censured in every way.

Because it contradicts the Dharma of liberation,
Meat, which terrifies people,
Should therefore not be eaten;
This is the banner of the noble ones.

This is the seventh chapter, on not eating meat, from the Descent into Laṅkā, the heart of the teachings of all the buddhas.

Then the Blessed One said to the bodhisattva Mahāmati: "The mantra words of the Descent into Laṅkā, which the buddhas, the blessed ones of the past, the future and the present, have taught, are teaching, and will teach, and which I too now teach in order to protect those who proclaim the Dharma, you should hold. They are as follows: tudṭe tudṭe budṭe budṭe padṭe padṭe kadṭe kadṭe amale amale bimale bimale nime nime hime hime bame bame kale kale kala kale adṭe madṭe badṭe tudṭe rñadṭe spudṭe kadṭe ladṭe padṭe hime hime dime dime cale cale pace pace bhande bhande anche mance ṭuḍāre dhuḍāre paḍāre agke agke magke magke cagkre cagkre dime dime hime hime ṭu ṭu ṭu ṭu ṭhu ṭhu ṭhu ṭhu ḍu ḍu ḍu ḍu ṭṭu ṭṭu ṭṭu ṭṭu svāhā

"Mahāmati, these are the mantra words of the Descent into Laṅkā Sūtra. Whatever son of good family or daughter of good family holds, bears, reads and masters these mantra words, no one will find an opening against them. Whether god or goddess, nāga or nāginī, yakṣa or yakṣiṇī, asura or asura woman, garuḍa or garuḍa woman, kinnara or kinnarī, mahoraga or mahoraga woman, gandharva or gandharva woman, bhūta or bhūta woman, kumbhāṇḍa or kumbhāṇḍa woman, piśāca or piśācī, ostāraka or ostārakī, apasmāra or apasmāra woman, rākṣasa or rākṣasī, ḍāka or ḍākinī, ojohāra or ojohārī,

pūtana or pūtanī, human or nonhuman, none of them at all will find an opening against that person. Should a fierce graha arise, by reciting the mantra over it one hundred and eight times, it will go away weeping and wailing, staring off in one direction.

"Mahāmati, I shall also teach other mantra words. They are as follows: padme padma debe hene hina hine cule culā cule hule hula hule yule yula yule pale pala pale munce chindhe bhindhe bhanche marde pramarde dinakare svāhā

"Mahāmati, if any son of good family or daughter of good family holds, bears, reads and masters these mantra words, then god or goddess, nāga or nāginī, yakṣa or yakṣiṇī, asura or asura woman, garuḍa or garuḍa woman, kinnara or kinnarī, mahoraga or mahoraga woman, gandharva or gandharva woman, bhūta or bhūta woman, kumbhāṇḍa or kumbhāṇḍa woman, piśāca or piśācī, ostāraka or ostārakī, apasmāra or apasmāra woman, rākṣasa or rākṣasī, ḍāka or ḍākinī, ojohāra or ojohārī, pūtana or pūtanī, human or nonhuman, none of them at all will find an opening. Whoever reads these mantra words will have read the entire Descent into Laṅkā Sūtra."

These mantra words were spoken by the Blessed One in order to repel the rākṣasas.

The Noble Descent into Laṅkā, the eighth fascicle.

Then the bodhisattva, the great being Mahāmati, said this to the Blessed One:

"This world, free of arising and perishing,
Is just like a flower in the sky;
Through your wisdom and compassion,
You do not perceive it as existent or nonexistent.

The world, beyond permanence and annihilation,
Is ever like a dream;
Through your wisdom and compassion,
You do not perceive it as existent or nonexistent.

All phenomena are like illusions,
Free of mind and of consciousness;
Through your wisdom and compassion,
You do not apprehend existence or nonexistence.

The selflessness of phenomena and of persons,
And your obscurations of affliction and of the knowable,
Through your wisdom and compassion

And through signlessness, are always pure.

You neither pass into nirvāṇa nor fail to pass;
Nirvāṇa does not abide in you.
You are free of understanding and of what is to be known,
And you have left behind the positions of existence and nonexistence.

Those who see the peaceful Sage
Who is thus free of arising and perishing
Will, in this life and in the next,
Be without attachment and without grasping.

Just as, when the mirage that deceives the mind
Shimmers in the spring,
The deer take it for water,
Though there is no real thing there,

So too the seed of consciousness
Stirs within the domain of views,
And the childish take it to be arising,
Like the floaters seen by one with impaired sight.

Meditation, the object of meditation, the meditator,
Abandonment, and the seeing of the truth:
Whoever realizes that these
Are mere conceptions is liberated.

These phenomena have no core;
They arise from the presuming mind.
The presumption by which one presumes,
"They are empty," is itself empty.

The aggregates, with consciousness the fifth,
Are like the reflection of a tree in water.
Appearances resemble illusions and dreams;
Do not conceive of them through cognition.

When a person sees things as like an illusion, a vetāla,
A mechanical device,
A dream, lightning, or clouds,
Ever cutting the threefold continuum, that person is freed.

Through improper conceptualization,
Consciousness operates in manifold ways,
Eightfold or ninefold,
Just like the waves of the ocean.

Ever produced by habitual tendencies,
Its roots sunk deep and firmly established,
The mind wanders among its objects
Like iron drawn by a magnet.

Abiding in all sentient beings,
The ground of the lineage is free of conceptualization;
When wisdom and the knowable are relinquished
And it is freed from activity, it turns back.

The illusion-like samādhi
That arises from the ten grounds,
And the king of mind, free of perception and consciousness,
Should be beheld.

When the mind has been transformed,
And a lotus-like celestial palace,
An illusory domain, comes forth,
Then one abides there forever.

Having come to abide there,
Through spontaneously accomplished conduct and knowledge,
Like a jewel of many forms,
One acts for the benefit of all sentient beings.

Apart from conceptualization
There is nothing conditioned or unconditioned;
These are like a barren woman's son in a dream.
The childish cling to corrupted positions.

Absence of intrinsic nature, nonarising,
The person, and the continuum of aggregates,
Conditions, elements, the knowable,
Emptiness, existence, and nonexistence:
These I have taught as skillful means.
Though I do not teach characteristics,
The childish grasp at things as real,

As bases of characterization and as characteristics.

Though knowing all, he is not the Omniscient One;
Even in the midst of all, there is no "all."
Childish worldlings imagine, "This is the Buddha,"
Yet he neither knows nor teaches.

This designation is merely a name;
It does not exist by any characteristic.
The aggregates on which it is imagined
Are like a tangle of hairs.

Nothing whatsoever arises from nonexistence,
And nothing is destroyed by conditions.
When one sees the conditioned thus,
As like a flower in the sky or a barren woman's son,
Then, seeing grasped and grasper
To be an error, one turns away from them.

I do not pass into nirvāṇa
As a thing with characteristics and activity;
When conceptualizing consciousness is reversed,
Then I have passed into nirvāṇa.

Just as, when a great river has run dry,
Waves no longer arise,
So too, when it has ceased,
The manifold consciousnesses do not arise.

Empty, without essential nature,
Unborn, like illusions,
Neither existent nor nonexistent:
These things are like a dream.

I teach a single nature,
Free of the signs and reasonings of logicians,
The domain of the noble gods,
Free of the two natures.

There is no grasper and nothing grasped,
No liberation and no bondage;
It is like an illusion and a mirage,

Just like a dream or floaters in the eyes.

When one who seeks the true meaning
Sees without conceptualization or attachment,
That one has entered into yoga
And, without doubt, sees me as well.

There is no cognition there at all,
Just like a mirage in the sky.
When phenomena are known in this way,
Nothing whatsoever is known.

Because the elements are thrown into turmoil,
Things like fireflies,
Though not there, appear in variety to one intoxicated;
Such is the nature of the world.

Though an illusion conjured from grass,
Wood, and pebbles may be beautiful,
That illusion does not exist;
Such is the nature of phenomena.

Phenomena do not arise
From conditions, whether existent or nonexistent;
It is because of error in the three realms
That variety appears.

The world is like a dream in its essential nature;
In it, too, various forms appear.
Contact, enjoyment, the body's going to its end,
The Principal of the world, and its makers are all alike.

This mind has become the birthplace of the three realms;
Deluded mind appears as this world and the beyond.
Because the world does not exist, one should not conceive of it.
Having realized that such is the nature of the world,
One reaches the end of the impure abodes.

Because of delusion, the childish
See arising and perishing;
Those endowed with wisdom
Do not see arising or perishing.

The palace of the gods is Akaniṣṭha.

Wholly rid of every evil,
ever endowed with nonconceptuality,
having abandoned mind and mental factors,
having gained the powers, the superknowledges and mastery,
they, having found mastery in meditative absorption,
awaken there as perfect buddhas.
Their emanations awaken here.
Emanations of the buddhas
arise in countless millions.
From them all the childish
hear the inconceivable Dharma, which is like an echo.

Free of beginning, middle and end,
having abandoned existence and nonexistence,
pervasive, unmoving and pure:
from what is not manifold the manifold arises.
Veiled by the family of cognition,
it abides in all embodied beings.
Though illusion and error are there,
it is not the cause of illusion and error.
Whatever slight thing there is in the worlds
that deceives the mind
is bound up with the two natures
and is conjured by the all-base consciousness.

In the view of mere cognition,
and in dealing with persons and phenomena,
when one has thus meditated on the world
and at some point it is fully transformed,
then he is my son,
who teaches the perfect dharmas.

As heat, moisture, solidity and motion
the childish imagine phenomena.
It is an unreal superimposition,
without characteristic and without basis of characteristic.
In this body made of continua
this is form composed of eight substances;

as the shape of the body and as the faculties
the deluded childish conceive it.
From the coming together of causes and conditions
the childish imagine that things arise.
Not understanding these principles,
they wander in the abode of the three existences.

All things are without intrinsic nature; conceptuality is but the word "fire," and that too does not exist.
Having examined existence as like a dream, like an emanation,
one should not take up saṃsāra, nor take up nirvāṇa.

The mind called "the various seeds"
appears within the domain of mind;
once it has appeared, through the two conceptions
the childish imagine arising.
Ignorance, craving and karma
abide as mind and mental factors;
because it arises from them,
it is held to be dependent.
To conceive them as things
is error, the domain of mind.
It is not established through conception;
it is falsely, erroneously imagined.
From connection with conditions
the minds of embodied beings arise.
When, freed from conditions
and having abandoned its own characteristic,
it no longer abides in a body,
then it is not within my domain.

Just as a king or a merchant
coaxes his children with various animal likenesses,
sets them playing at home,
and shows them meeting the animals of the forest,
so I, with various
mere reflections of phenomena,
explain to my sons
the limit of reality, known personally within.

Just as the waves of the ocean,
arising through the condition of wind,
are set in motion as if dancing
and their stream is never cut off,
so the river of the all-base
arises ever through the condition of objects,
and with the various waves of consciousness
bows and sways as if dancing.
Into things grasped and grasping
the minds of embodied beings enter.
As the childish imagine,
the appearance has no such characteristic.

The supreme all-base consciousness
is cognition; and the all-base,
because it is free of grasped and grasper,
I explain as suchness.

In the aggregates there is no self,
no life-principle and no person.
Consciousness arises,
and consciousness ceases.
Just as a painting appears
high and low, though it is not so,
likewise in things
thingness appears, though it does not exist.
Like a city of gandharvas,
like mirages:
though one always sees appearances thus,
for wisdom they do not exist.

Valid cognition and the faculties are reversed;
there is no result, and no cause either;
it is free of intellect and of what is to be cognized,
and has abandoned characteristic and basis of characteristic.
One who is a buddha by relying on the aggregates
no one anywhere has seen;
what no one anywhere has seen,
how could one meditate on it?

With conditions, reasons and examples,
propositions and causes,
with examples such as dreams, the gandharva's wheel,
mirages, the sun and the moon,
sprouts, light and so forth,
I have refuted these arisings.

Beings are like dreams and illusions,
empty and imputed;
they do not abide in the three worlds,
and so it is too within and without.
By seeing existence as unborn
the forbearance of nonarising arises.
The illusion-like meditative absorption,
and the body too is illusion-like;
the superknowledges, the masteries and the powers
take many forms in his mind.

Those things that are unborn,
empty, utterly without intrinsic nature,
in them, through conditions,
error arises and ceases.
Through what has form and appears external,
it is mind, and mind alone, that appears.
Apart from what the childish imagine,
there is nothing else to be seen.

Connections and the forms of the buddhas,
the elements and their destruction:
by thoroughly trained cognition
the various beings are empowered.
Body, abode and enjoyments
are the three grasped cognitions;
mind, the grasping cognition
and conceptualization are the three graspers.

Conception and examination:
as long as one is in the domain of letters,
because the reasoner is misled by reasoning,
for so long one does not see reality.

When through wisdom
one knows things to be without intrinsic nature,
then the yogin
abides in signlessness and rests from weariness.

When a bird is daubed with ink,
the ignorant take it for a bird of another kind;
so it is for the ignorant childish
with regard to the three vehicles as well.
Here there are no śrāvakas at all,
and likewise no pratyekabuddhas.
Whatever forms of śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas
appear here
are emanations displayed
by compassionate bodhisattvas.

The three existences are mere cognition;
the two natures are imputed.
Because phenomena and persons are transformed,
that transformation is suchness.

The light of sun, moon and lamp,
likewise the elements and jewels,
arise utterly without conceptualization;
so too is the buddhahood of the buddhas.
Just as those with diseased eyes
see a net of hairs wrongly tangled,
so this conceiving of things
is falsely imagined by the childish.
Things of affliction and purification
are like a tangle of hairs:
free of abiding, destruction and arising,
they have abandoned permanence and impermanence.

Just as someone who has eaten datura
sees the world as if made of gold,
and though there is no gold there,
even the ground appears as gold,

so fools are corrupted
by beginningless mind and mental factors,
and existence, arisen like an illusion or a mirage,
they grasp as something real.

The single seed and the seedless,
the even, and the predominant, which has seeds,
and likewise the all-seed:
look at the mind that has become diverse.

When it is pure, it is the single seed;
when fully transformed, it is seedless;
because it does not conceptualize, it is the even;
because it is predominant, lifetimes are mingled.

Because it plants diverse seeds,
it is called the all-seed.
Here nothing arises through conditions,
and nothing whatever ceases.

It is only imagined conditions
that arise and cease.
The three realms of existence are mere designation;
by their own nature there are no things.

Designations as the nature of things
are what logicians imagine.
Those who wish to know the intrinsic nature of things,
being mistaken, do not realize it.

When one sees in this way
that the intrinsic nature of things is unarisen, one is liberated.
Because they share the qualities of an illusion and of nonexistence,
things are spoken of as existing in that same way.

Because they turn away as swiftly as lightning,
therefore know them to be like an illusion.
Nothing is produced and nothing is born;
and conditions too, anywhere at all,

do not exist in the least,
yet some speak of them as functioning.
The connection of arising and perishing through conditions

is not something to be refuted;

what is without intrinsic nature and without cognition,
which fools conceive of in terms of conditions,
that is what is refuted.
Though there is no intrinsic nature and no cognition,

no storehouse (ālaya) and no thing,
foolish and inferior logicians,
like corpses, imagine these.
When the Victor's children

see the world as mind only,
then they attain a body
belonging among the classes of beings,
free of the formations of fools,

and endowed with the powers,
the superknowledges and the masteries.
When there arises the mind
to which all appears as form, the realization

"Here there is no mind and no form;
this is beginningless mistaken mind,"
then yogins, through knowledge,
see beings as without appearance.

Having passed beyond signs, things and cognition,
and the stirring of whatever is cognized,
my children
engage in nonconceptuality.

Illusions, cities of the gandharvas,
tangled hairs and mirages,
though nonexistent, appear to exist;
so it is with things being things.

All things are unborn;
it is mere error that appears.
Fools, delighting in dual conception,
and from error, imagine them to be born.

The mind that belongs to the share of birth,
arising from diverse habitual tendencies,
surges forth like waves on a river;
once that is cut off, it no longer arises.

Just as the mind that apprehends various aspects
enters into the various,
why then does it not likewise
enter into space or a wall?

If the mind were to enter
by apprehending some sign,
then mind too would be produced by conditions,
and mind only would not hold.

It is by mind that mind is grasped;
nothing at all comes with a cause.
The true nature of mind is pure;
in space there are no habitual tendencies.

Through clinging to one's own mind,
mind arises in abundance.
There is no external appearance;
therefore it is mind only.

Mind is the storehouse consciousness;
that which thinks "I" is mentation;
that which grasps objects
is called consciousness.

Mind is always indeterminate;
mentation moves in both directions;
and the consciousness that arises
is virtuous and nonvirtuous.

Body, abode and enjoyments
are the threefold cognition of the grasped;
mentation, the cognition of the grasper,
and conceptual thought are the threefold grasper.

The abandoning of both cognitions
is the gateway to the ultimate.
When one abides in nonappearance,

how could the three vehicles be set out?

Mind only and nonappearance,
the stages and abodes of the buddhas:
these the buddhas have taught,
now teach, and will uphold.

The seven stages are mind;
the eighth is nonappearance.
Here two stages are abodes;
the remaining stage is my own nature.

Pure, and individually self-aware,
this stage is my own nature:
the supreme abode of Maheśvara,
Akaniṣṭha, surpassingly beautiful.

Just as from a fire,
its various rays
stream forth, lovely and peaceful,
and these emanate the three realms.

Some emanate the three realms of existence;
some were emanated before;
there the vehicles are taught:
that is the stage of my own nature.

For passing to the fields and for realization,
there is no time for the stages;
having passed beyond even mind only,
it is the fruit of abiding in nonappearance.

Various aspects, existent
and nonexistent, appear;
fools are corrupted by grasping;
the variety is an inversion.

When there is nonconceptual wisdom,
things cannot exist.
Because mind is not form,
therefore it is nonconceptual.

The faculties are like illusions,
and objects are like dreams;
agent, deed and action
do not exist in any way.

The meditative concentrations, the immeasurables,
the formless attainments, the samādhis,
and the cessation of perception, all without exception,
do not exist in mind only.

The fruit of stream entry,
the fruit of once-returning,
the fruit of non-returning,
and arhatship itself are errors of the mind.

Fools imagine conditioned things
to be impermanent, momentary and empty;
by the examples of a seed, a stream and a lamp
they imagine the meaning of momentariness.

Without agent, momentary,
isolated and free of activity,
and the non-arising of phenomena:
this I have taught as the meaning of momentariness.

Arising from existence and from nonexistence
is what the Vaiśeṣikas and Sāṃkhyas hold,
and all the unanswered questions
were set forth by those very ones.

Answers are of four kinds:
the categorical, by counter-question,
by distinguishing, and by setting aside;
these refute the assertions of the non-Buddhists (tīrthikas).

Conventionally, everything exists;
ultimately, it does not exist.
If the absence of intrinsic nature in phenomena
is held to be the ultimate,

then, for the apprehended object that lacks intrinsic nature,
the conventional is therefore taught.
If things that arise from the cause of verbal expression

had intrinsic nature,

there could be no talk of
"things arising from words being nonexistent."
In this expression there is no thing;
it does not exist even conventionally.
Because inversion does not exist,
apprehension does not exist.

If error existed,
the absence of essential nature would not exist.
Since error is fourfold,
whatever is apprehended
is without intrinsic nature;
it does not exist in any way at all.

This that appears in such variety
is mind imbued with dysfunctional tendencies,
grasping at what appears as form.
External things are the mind's delusion.

Through conceiving and not conceiving,
conceptual thought is abandoned.
On the ground where conceptuality does not conceive,
emptiness is truly seen.

Like many illusory elephants,
like leaves taken for gold,
because the mind is imbued with ignorance,
appearances show themselves to people in this way.

The noble ones do not see error,
yet the real is not found in that place either,
for if the real were found there,
error itself would become the real.

Even when all errors have been abandoned,
if signs still go on arising,
that itself is their error,
like a cataract not fully cleared.

Just as those with diseased eyes,
because of the defect, see hairs,
so too the grasping of childish beings
is deeply engaged with objects.

These three realms of existence are like those hairs,
an error like the water of a mirage.
If one meditates on them as like a dream or an illusion,
one will be liberated.

Conceptualizing, what is conceptualized,
the engagement of conceptual thought,
binding, what is to be bound, and being bound:
these six are the causes of liberation.

There are no grounds, there are no truths,
there are no fields, there are no emanations;
buddhas and pratyekabuddhas
and śrāvakas too are imagined.

Persons, causes and aggregates,
likewise conditions and atoms,
the principal (pradhāna), Īśvara and creators
are conceptualized within mind only.

Mind, in every way and everywhere,
enters into all bodies;
in six ways it grasps the manifold.
The very kind of mind is without defining marks.

The aggregates are without self,
and no self is found in the aggregates.
They do not exist as they are imagined,
yet neither are they nonexistent.

If all things existed
just as the childish imagine them,
if they existed just as they are seen,
then everyone would see the truth.

Because all things are nonexistent,
there is neither defilement nor purification.
They do not exist as they are seen,

yet neither are they nonexistent.

The signs of erroneous conceptualization
are the dependent characteristic.
The name imputed upon that characteristic
is the imputed characteristic.

When the signs of erroneous conceptualization,
arising from conditions and from the conventions of names,
no longer arise there,
that is the perfected characteristic.

Buddhas of maturation,
emanated victors,
bodhisattvas and sentient beings,
the fields in every direction,
illusion-like phenomena and magical displays,
and whatever victors are emanated:
all of these come forth
from Sukhāvatī of Amitābha.

Whatever is taught by emanations,
and whatever is taught by those born of maturation,
the way of the extensive sūtras:
understand their intent.

Whatever the Victor's children teach,
and whatever the guides teach,
is what the emanations teach,
not the Victor of maturation.

These phenomena are unborn,
yet neither are they nonexistent.
They are like a city of gandharvas, an illusion,
dreams and emanations.

The manifold is the activity of mind;
it is mind that is liberated;
what ceases, too, is mind itself;
mind itself arises, and nothing else.

People's mind, imagining the manifold,
shows itself as appearing as objects.
This is mind only, and there are no objects.
Through nonconceptuality one is liberated.

Through proliferation since beginningless time
dysfunctional tendencies have been amassed,
and because conceptuality is imbued with them,
false appearances arise.

What appears as objects is consciousness;
wisdom has the real as its domain.
What has been fully transformed is without appearance;
that is the domain of the noble ones.

The meditative concentration that discerns meaning,
the meditative concentration practiced by the childish,
the meditative concentration focused on suchness,
and the excellent meditative concentration of the Tathāgata.

In terms of the imputed nature,
all phenomena are unborn.
Abiding in the dependent,
people's conceptual thoughts wander.

When the dependent
is free of conceptual thought,
the transformation is suchness,
abiding in the abandonment of thought.

Conceptual thought does not truly exist,
so do not conceive with conceptual thought.
When one conceives those errors
as having the character of grasped and grasper,
the imagining that sees external objects
is the imputed nature.

When, having abandoned all of these,
there is no longer any appearance,
then, on that ground, the divine hands of the buddhas,
coming from fields on every side,
stroke that one's head,

a sign of following suchness.

Because, when examined by the intellect,
intrinsic natures are not apprehended,
therefore they are inexpressible,
and are taught to be without essential nature.

In what is produced by conditions
there is neither existence nor nonexistence.
Those who conceive existence and nonexistence
in things that belong to conditions,
holders of non-Buddhist (tīrthika) views,
know them to have strayed far from the teaching.

In speaking of all things,
whenever they pass on to other lives,
through their mutual conceptual thoughts
they become habituated, and habituated again.

If names were not spoken,
the whole world would be bewildered.
Therefore, to dispel bewilderment,
designations are made with names.

Through three kinds of conceptual thought,
that of names, that of error,
and that produced by conditions,
the childish conceive of things.

Unceasing and unborn,
by nature like space,
whatever is the nature of the absence of things,
that is the imputed characteristic.

Like an optical illusion, like a magical illusion,
a mirage, a dream, a whirling firebrand,
like a city of gandharvas or an echo,
that phenomenon does not arise from conditions.
Nondual with suchness,
emptiness, dharmatā, the limit of reality,
that which is taught as nonconceptual:

that is the perfected characteristic.

The domain of body and speech is false;
nonconceptual wisdom is true.
Because mind falls into the two extremes,
therefore wisdom is nonconceptual.

As long as mind has a domain,
there are the two extremes of existence and nonexistence.
When the domain has been abandoned,
then mind too truly ceases.

Whatever thought conceives
regarding the nature born of conditions,
seeing external objects, is false.
There are no objects; there is only mind.

When one analyzes with reasoning,
grasped and grasper cease.
External objects do not exist
in the way the childish imagine them.

The mind stirred up by habitual tendencies
arises, vividly appearing as objects.
When the two kinds of conceptuality cease,
the true domain is wisdom;
the domain of the noble ones is inconceivable,
and it comes about without appearances.

Name, sign, and imagination
are the characteristics of the two natures.
Right wisdom and suchness
are the characteristic of the perfected nature.

Because father and mother have come together,
the foundation consciousness (ālaya), together with the mind,
like a mouse in a jar of butter,
is born together with the semen.
As the fetal mass, the lump and the swelling, all unlovely,
it is shaped by karma into various forms.
By the wind of karma and the great elements

it develops like a fruit.
With the five, the five, and the five,
and the nine openings,
covered with teeth, nails and hair,
it stirs and is fully born.
Like a worm born in filth,
like people waking from sleep,
the eye opens out toward forms,
and conceptions too increase.
From the two lips and the palate,
having discerned through conceptual thought,
the conceptual construction of human speech
comes forth like a parrot's.

The doctrines of the non-Buddhists (tīrthikas) are clung to;
the Great Vehicle does not stay fixed.
It proceeds in accord with the intentions of sentient beings,
and is no abode for wrong views.
The vehicle of personal self-awareness
is not the domain of logicians.

"After the Protector has passed away,
who will uphold it? Please tell me."

"After the Sugata has passed into nirvāṇa,
one who will uphold the ways
will appear when time has passed;
Mahāmati, you should know this.
In the land of Veda in the south
a monk, glorious and greatly renowned,
whose name is called Nāga,
destroyer of the positions of existence and nonexistence,
having fully taught my vehicle in the world,
the unsurpassed Great Vehicle,
will attain the Joyous ground
and go to Sukhāvatī.

Having wandered through all destinies,
with minds weary of existence,

although they have gone the peaceful path of calm,
they strive at various yogas.
When yogis make such effort,
they see what resembles the shape of sun and moon,
what is like light and like lotuses,
like drawings, like fire in the sky.
These various signs
lead them onto the path of the tīrthikas,
and make them fall as well into the domain
of śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas.

Because there is no grasping at objects,
it is not that there is no cessation;
as in the domain of the noble ones,
the reality of suchness exists.
As it appears to the wise,
it does not appear to the childish:
how all phenomena are unborn
and appear without characteristics.
Just as the childish imagine as gold
a heap of brass that looks like gold but is not gold,
so bad logicians imagine phenomena.

That through conditions, from existence and nonexistence,
something that had not been arises,
and having arisen perishes: such a claim
does not stand in my teaching.
Transformation, time and shape,
the elemental entities and the faculties,
and the taking up of the intermediate state:
those who imagine these are not wise.

The Victors do not proclaim
the world to be dependently originated;
in this world there are only conditions,
like a city of the gandharvas.
'When this exists, this comes to be':
this is a conventional expression of the Dharma;
what is other than convention

is unborn and does not cease.

In eyes, in water, in mirrors,
in vessels and in jewels,
reflections appear in these,
yet the reflection exists nowhere at all.
Just as a mirage in the sky
appears as a thing, so too the mind;
like a dream, like a barren woman's son,
it appears in forms of many kinds.

The Great Vehicle, my vehicle, is not a vehicle;
it has no letters and no sound;
it is not truth, it is not liberation,
it is not the domain of the imageless.
Yet the Great Vehicle is a vehicle
that gives mastery over samādhi,
the mind-made body of various kinds,
adorned with the flowers of the masteries.

Entities and conditions
are neither one nor different;
arisings are taught in brief,
cessations in detail.
Unborn emptiness is one,
and the emptiness of what is born is also one;
unborn emptiness is supreme,
the emptiness of what is born will perish.
Emptiness, suchness and the ultimate limit,
nirvāṇa and the dharmadhātu,
the mind-made body of various kinds:
these I have taught as synonyms."

Whoever conceives of purity through the Sūtras,
The Vinaya and the Abhidharma,
By their words and not by their meaning,
Does not abide in selflessness.

Neither I, nor the buddhas,
Nor the non-Buddhists (tīrthikas), nor anyone at all,

Has ever established existence through conditions;
How, then, could anything come to exist?
And if someone established existence through conditions,
What nonexistence would they have established?
Those who proclaim arising, through their wrong views,
Conceive of existence and nonexistence.

For one for whom nothing arises
And nothing comes to cease,
Since he sees the world as void,
Existence and nonexistence do not approach.

Appearances are like a rabbit's horn;
What exists is people's conceptual thought.
Like deer chasing a mirage,
Those who conceive are mistaken.
Through clinging to conceptual thought,
Conceptuality arises in abundance.
Freed from arising and destruction,
One moves within the imageless.

Profound, vast and extensive wisdom
And perfect buddha fields
Are taught to the children of the Victor.
To the śrāvakas, nonconceptuality:
The three realms of existence impermanent and empty,
Free of self and of what belongs to self.
Conceptual thought that has no cause
Cannot be called conceptual thought.

Just as, in a mirage,
Where there is no water, one takes it for water,
So do the childish toward appearances.
The noble ones are distinct:
The view of the noble ones is pure,
Arisen from the three gateways of liberation.
Specific and general characteristics
Are taught to the śrāvakas.
Nonattachment to all phenomena,

Living alone in solitude,
And the fruit that is not reached by reflection
Are taught to the heirs who are pratyekabuddhas.

The external is the imagined nature;
The dependent arises from its own ground.
Not seeing the delusion that arises from oneself,
Minds therefore run on and on.

The tenth is the first,
The first is the eighth,
The ninth is the seventh,
And the seventh is the eighth;
The second is the third,
The fourth is the fifth,
And the third is the sixth:
In the imageless, what sequence is there?

When things do not appear,
For the yogin there is no nonbeing either.
Through the sameness of being and nonbeing,
The fruit arises for the noble ones.

How are things without thingness?
How is sameness brought about?
When the mind does not cognize
The agitation of outer and inner,
Then it brings about cessation,
And the sameness of mind becomes even.

In saṃsāra, which is without beginning,
The childish are shrouded by grasping at things.
Just as one peg drives out another,
By enticing them, their grasping is turned back.

Having it as cause, it takes it as its object;
It is the support on which mentation (manas) operates;
It also gives forth the cause of mind,
And consciousness too abides in it.

Born of ripening, granted by blessing,
Arising from class and from destiny,
And what is gained in dreams:
The superknowledges are of four kinds.
Whatever is gained in dreams,
Whatever the buddhas grant,
Whatever comes from class, destiny or lineage,
These are not superknowledges born of ripening.

Mind, imbued with habitual tendencies,
Runs on, appearing as things.
When the childish do not understand this,
Then arising is to be taught.

As long as one conceives the external
As things possessed of characteristics,
And does not see one's own error,
So long does mind proliferate.

For whatever reason arising is spoken of,
For that reason appearance is spoken of.
Appearances are not appearances:
Whose, then, of what, and what is said?

Mind is by nature clear;
It is mentation that makes it turbid.
Mentation, together with the consciousnesses,
Constantly plants habitual tendencies.
The storehouse (ālaya) casts the body off;
Mentation longs for a destiny;
Consciousness, seeing the error
That appears as objects, becomes attached.

It is my mind that appears,
And there is no external object.
Meditate thus upon the error,
And keep suchness, too, in mind.

The domain of meditators, karma,
And the greatness of the buddhas:
These three are inconceivable;
The sphere of consciousness is inconceivable.

The future and the past,
Space, the person and nirvāṇa:
These are taught conventionally;
In the ultimate sense there are no letters.

Those within the schools and the non-Buddhists (tīrthikas)
Abide in one and the same view;
Because they are confused about mind-only,
They conceive of external things.

If in a dream one sees consecration,
Pratyekabuddhas and buddhas,
And arhat buddhas,
The seed of awakening grows.

Where are they, and of what kind?
From what, and for what reason?
And the pacifying of the aspects of the illusory mind,
And the positions of existence and nonexistence: please tell me of these.

To those confused about mind-only,
Existence and nonexistence are taught as like an illusion,
As possessed of arising and destruction,
And known as characteristic and what is characterized.

What is called mentation, which conceptualizes,
Together with the five consciousnesses,
Like reflections, like the water of a river,
Arises from the seeds of mind.
When mind, mentation
And consciousness no longer operate,
At that time one attains the mind-made body
And the ground of buddhahood as well.

Conditions, elements and aggregates,
The intrinsic nature of phenomena,
Designations, minds and persons
Are like a dream, like tangled hairs before the eyes.
Seeing the world as a dream, as an illusion,
Abide in what is genuine.
Suchness is free of characteristics,

Beyond reasoning and logical proof;
The personal self-awareness of the noble ones:
Always keep its practice in mind.

Set the world, confused about reasoning and causes,
Within suchness.
Because all conceptual elaborations are pacified,
Wisdom does not enter into error.
As long as one conceives in error,
So long does mind operate through delusion.

Absence of intrinsic nature, and things,
Emptiness, permanence and impermanence:
These are the views of those who proclaim arising,
Not of those who proclaim non-arising.

The world as one, as different, or as both,
Is imagined through Īśvara, through chance,
Through time, the Principal (pradhāna), atoms,
And conditions.

Consciousness is the seed of saṃsāra;
When there is a seed, it arises,
Like a painting when there is a wall;
Once fully understood, it ceases.

Just as people, like illusory men,
Die and are born,
So, because the childish are deluded,
Bondage and liberation appear.

There are two kinds, outer and inner:
Phenomena and conditions.
Meditating thoroughly in that yoga,
One should abide in the imageless.

Mind is differentiated by habitual tendencies,
Yet mind and tendencies are not distinct;
Mind is not distinct in its characteristic,
Yet it is wrapped all around by tendencies.
Regard the tendencies arising

From mental consciousness as stains.
Mind is like a white cloth;
It is made unlovely by the tendencies.

Just as I have taught that space
Is neither an entity nor a non-entity,
So too the universal ground (ālaya) in the body
Is free of both entity and non-entity.

Mind itself, freed of turbidity,
Is the reversal of mental consciousness.
Because it knows all phenomena,
I declare that mind is the Buddha.

The three continua are explained:
Free of existence and nonexistence,
Fully liberated from the four extremes,
Becoming is always like an illusion.

The seven grounds that arise from mind
Have an essential nature that is twofold.
The other grounds and the buddha ground
Are the fully consummate.

The form realm and the formless realm,
The desire realm and nirvāṇa,
And all the domains of mind as well,
Are taught to be within this very body.

As long as there is apprehending,
So long does error come into play.
When one realizes error to be one's own mind,
There is no engaging and no turning back.

There is no birth, and no cause either.
It is through entities that one clings to saṃsāra.
When one sees them as like illusions and the rest,
One does not imagine characteristics.

For the childish, those of feeble intellect,
I myself teach one vehicle, three vehicles,
And no vehicle at all.

For the noble ones there is solitude itself.

Characteristics and conception:
These are my twofold birth.
The teaching of the method is fourfold:
The teaching of reasoning and the established tenet.

Through the distinctions of shape and feature,
Seeing error, they conceive.
Once freed from name and shape,
Intrinsic nature is the pure domain of the noble ones.

As long as conceptuality conceives,
So long is there the imagined characteristic.
Because there is neither imagined nor imagining,
Intrinsic nature is the domain of the noble ones.

Permanent, everlasting, reality itself,
The essential nature of lineage and of entities:
Suchness is free from mind,
And conceptions too have been abandoned.

If there were no entity, there would be no purification,
And no one at all would have afflictions.
Since the mind is pure,
And yet total affliction appears,

Therefore the wholly pure domain of the noble ones,
Reality itself, becomes an entity.
Mind is produced by conditions
And multiplied by conceptions.

When one sees it as like dreams, illusions and so on,
One becomes fully awakened.
The various habitual tendencies, the states of dysfunction,
Are thoroughly joined together with the mind.

To people external things appear,
But that is not the true nature of mind.
The true nature of mind is pure;
Mind arises from error.

Error is the state of dysfunction,
And for that reason mind is not seen.
Suchness is in mere error;
Suchness does not exist apart.

It is not in the formations, nor is it apart from them,
And yet it is through seeing the formations.
When one sees that conditioned things
Are free of characteristic and of what is characterized,

By seeing beings as one's own mind,
For that reason they are abandoned.
Abiding in mind-only,
One should not imagine external objects.

Abiding in the true object,
One should go beyond mind-only.
Having gone beyond mind-only,
One should go beyond the nonappearing.

When the yogin abides in nonappearance,
He does not see the Great Vehicle.
Spontaneous, realized, peaceful,
Fully purified by aspirations,

It is the supreme wisdom that is selfless;
When there is no appearance, it is not seen.
One should look at the domain of mind,
And look as well at the domain of wisdom.

When one sees the domain of discernment,
One will not be confused about characteristics.
The truth of suffering belongs to mind;
The origin is the domain of wisdom.

The two truths and the buddha ground:
Therein discernment fully engages.
Attaining the fruit and nirvāṇa,
And likewise the eightfold path:

Because all phenomena are realized,
The wisdom of the Buddha becomes wholly pure.
Eye and form and light,

Attention and likewise space:

Through these, for people,
Consciousness arises from the universal ground.
The grasped, the grasping, and the grasper,
Name, non-entity, and nonexistence,

And conceptuality without a cause:
Those who think in this way are not wise.
Name has not arisen from the object,
Nor likewise the object from the name.

Do not conceive of conceptions
As arising from a cause or without a cause.
All entities lack intrinsic nature,
And words likewise do not exist.

Not seeing emptiness and the meaning of emptiness,
The childish run astray.
Seeing, with conceit, the positing of truth,
This is an account of what is merely designated.

Since the single one is established as fivefold,
This so-called true one is abandoned.
Elaboration is seized by Māra;
One should pass beyond existence and nonexistence.

Seeing wrong perception as selfless,
One should not yearn for becoming.
Where there is the act of examining,
Mere dispute comes into play.

The supreme truth cannot be spoken;
When this has ceased, the Dharma is seen.
Relying on the universal ground,
Mentation fully comes into operation.

Relying on mind and mentation,
Consciousness comes into operation.
The superimposed and the superimposing,
The true nature of mind, suchness:

When the yogin meditates on this,
He will attain the knowledge of mind-only.
Regarding mentation, characteristics and entities,
There is no conceit of permanent or impermanent.

In the yoga of arising and non-arising,
The yogin has no conceit.
The consciousness that arises from the universal ground
Conceives of two objects.

The single object arising from it
Is not known by two minds.
There is no speaking and there are no words;
Because mind is seen, it is not empty.

Because one's own mind is not seen,
The net of views comes into play.
Conditions do not come;
There are no entities whatsoever.

There are no elements and no aggregates,
No attachment and nothing conditioned.
There is no karma and no fire, nor any before;
Nothing done and nothing conditioned.

There is no extreme and no clinging,
No liberation and no bondage.
There is nothing indeterminate and no entity,
No dharma and no non-dharma.

There is no time and no nirvāṇa,
And even the nature of reality does not exist.
There are no buddhas and no truths,
No fruit and no causes.

There is no distortion and no nirvāṇa,
No arising and no destruction.
The twelve links do not exist,
Nor is there end or endlessness.

In order to abandon all views,
I have taught mind-only.

Body, afflictions, karma, and path,
the agent and the results,
are like a dream and a mirage,
like a city of the gandharvas.

By establishing everything as mind only,
one turns away from the marks of entities.
Because one abides in mind only,
one comes to see permanence and annihilation.

In nirvāṇa there are no aggregates,
there is no self, and there are no characteristics.
Through entering into mind only,
one turns back from grasping at liberation.

What has surely arisen from the cause that makes earth appear
appears to people as something external.
Mind arises from what has no appearance;
therefore the mind does not appear.

To people, habitual tendencies
appear as body, possessions, and abode.
Mind is neither an entity nor a non-entity;
through habitual tendencies it does not shine.

On white, a stain appears;
on a stain, the white does not appear.
Like clouds in the sky,
so too the mind does not appear.

Mind accumulates karma;
wisdom clears it away.
Through discernment one attains
the imageless, and powers as well.

Mind is bound up with objects;
cognition engages in reasonings.
In the imageless and the distinctive,
discernment fully engages.

Those who have abandoned mind, mentation, consciousness,
perception, and conceptualization,
and so attained the nonconceptual Dharma,

are śrāvakas, not the Victor's children.

In the peaceful, distinctive forbearance
lies the virtuous wisdom of the Tathāgata.
Free of all activity,
it arises by virtue of that distinction.

The imagined nature exists;
the dependent does not exist.
The deluded grasp at the imagined;
the dependent is impermanent.

All form derived from the elements does not exist;
form not derived from the elements exists.
A city of gandharvas, a dream,
an illusion, a mirage, are not derived from the elements.

My discernment is threefold:
that by which the noble ones are set apart,
that by which true characteristics are examined,
and that by which entities are analyzed.

The discernment of śrāvakas, and that which, rid of appearances,
is free of the two vehicles:
the first, because it clings to entities as existent,
comes fully into operation;
the other is entry into mind only,
the stainless discernment of the Sugata.

If things were produced by conditions
out of existence and nonexistence,
they would without doubt remain
in views of oneness and difference.

Just as an illusion produced
from many components is not established,
so too the various signs,
when examined, are not established.

The bondage of signs and of dysfunctional tendencies
arises from the mind.
Through not understanding the imagined,

one conceives of it as the dependent.

This entity that is imagined
is itself also the dependent.
The various appearances of the imagined
are conceived by way of the dependent.

The conventional and the ultimate:
there is no third arisen from causes.
The imagined is called the conventional;
its cutting off is the domain of the noble ones.

Like the object of a yogin's meditation,
variety shines forth as one.
In it there are no various aspects;
so too with the mark of the imagined.

Just as those with cataracts,
seeing forms, conceive of variety,
while the floaters are neither form nor formless,
so is the dependent for the wise.

Just as gold that has been purified,
water rid of its turbidity,
and the sky without clouds,
so is the purification of conceptuality.

My śrāvakas are threefold:
the emanated, those born of aspiration,
and śrāvakas arisen from the Dharma,
who have abandoned attachment and aversion.

Bodhisattvas too are threefold.
Buddhas have no characteristics;
in mind after mind of sentient beings
the form of the Buddha appears.

The imagined has no entity;
the dependent exists.
Superimposition and denial,
when examined, are destroyed.

If, while the imagined is no entity,
the dependent were an entity,
what is no entity would become an entity,
and an entity would arise from a non-entity.

Taking the imagined as its basis,
the dependent is apprehended.
From the connection of name and sign
the imagined arises.

When the imagined is utterly unestablished,
it has not arisen from another.
Then the pure essential nature
of the ultimate is known.

Imagination is tenfold;
the dependent is sixfold.
What is individually self-realized is suchness;
therefore there is no distinction.

The five dharmas are suchness,
and so too are the three natures.
When a yogin meditates on this,
he does not pass beyond suchness.

Like stars and clouds,
like the sun and the moon,
like appearances arising from habitual tendencies,
so do the minds of people appear.

These elements have no body;
they lack characteristics and lack a basis for characteristics.
If they are elements of elements,
and form is derived from the elements,
then the great elements are not real,
and no element is derived from elements.

The great elements are the cause;
the results are earth, water, and so on.
Form that is substantial and form that is imputed,
likewise that made by illusion,
the forms of dreams and of gandharva cities,

and the mirage: these are five.

Those given to desire are of five kinds,
and the lineages likewise are five.
There are five vehicles and the no-vehicle;
nirvāṇa is sixfold.

The distinct aggregates are twenty-four;
form, too, is eightfold.
The buddhas are twenty-four;
the Victor's children are of two kinds.

The approaches are one hundred and eight;
the śrāvakas likewise are of three kinds.
The field of the buddhas is one,
and likewise the Buddha is one.

Liberation likewise is threefold;
the mental continuum is fourfold.
My selflessness is sixfold;
the knowable, too, is fourfold.

Free of causes,
rid of the faults of views,
individually self-realized and unmoving,
is the unsurpassed Great Vehicle.

Arising and non-arising
are eightfold and ninefold.
Realization is at once and gradual;
the tenet, too, is one alone.

The formless realm is of eight kinds;
the dhyānas are distinct, of six kinds;
for pratyekabuddhas and the heirs,
emergence comes to be of seven kinds.

The three times, too, do not exist;
there is neither permanence nor impermanence.
Agent, action and result
are like the deeds done in a dream.

Buddhas, śrāvakas, heirs of the Victor,
have no arising at the first or at the last.
They are free from the appearances of mind,
always like phenomena that are illusions.

The womb, the wheel, and likewise birth,
the coming forth and the abode of Tuṣita,
and the going to all the fields as well:
though these appear, there is no birth from a womb.

Transmigration, cause and sentient beings,
and likewise teaching and nirvāṇa,
the truths and the realization of fields,
are projected by conditions.

The world, the forests and the continents,
non-Buddhists, transmigration and selflessness,
dhyāna, the vehicles, the abodes and attainments,
and the domain of the fruits: these are inconceivable.

The lineages of the moon and of the stars,
the royal lineages and those of the gods,
the lineages of yakṣas and of gandharvas,
are born of karma and arise from existence.

When there is inconceivable transformation,
death and transmigration bear habitual tendencies.
When the appearance of death and transmigration is cut off,
the net of afflictions ceases.

Cattle, sheep and servants,
and likewise elephants, horses and the like,
wealth, grain and gold,
and fields and property: these are conceptually imagined.

One should not lie down on beds,
nor should one smear the ground.
Alms bowls of gold, of silver, of bronze,
or of copper, one should not keep.

Cloth dyed blue,
cow dung, ochre,
earth, fruit and leaves:

with these the yogin should always change what is white.

A bowl made of iron, of stone, of clay,
of conch or of crystal,
of the measure of one Magadhan measure,
is what the yogin should keep.

The curved knife for cutting cloth
should be made four finger-widths in size.
The yogin devoted to yoga
should not train in the arts of craft.

The yogin who has entered yoga
should not buy and sell.
Let a lay attendant of the monastery do that;
this I have taught as the Dharma.

With senses restrained and knowing the meaning,
and likewise in sūtra and vinaya,
not mingling with householders:
this I have taught for the yogin.

In an empty house or a charnel ground,
at the foot of a tree or in caves,
in the open air or on a heap of straw,
the yogin should make his dwelling.

In a charnel ground or anywhere else,
one should always wear the three robes.
Whatever is given gladly
should be sewn together to make robes.

Intent on food gained by begging,
one should look ahead a yoke's length.
As a bee goes among the flowers,
so should one go on the alms round.

Mingling with great crowds,
and whatever mingling there is with nuns,
a livelihood that has become mingled in this way
is not fitting for the yogin.

The yogin devoted to yoga
should not attend upon kings and princes,
nor likewise upon ministers and merchant chiefs,
for the sake of food.

Food from houses where there has been a death or a birth,
food from those bound to one by affection and friendship,
and mingling with monks and nuns:
these are not fitting for the yogin.

A monastery from which smoke is rising,
where cooking is constantly done by the regular rite,
and whatever is prepared for one's own sake:
these are not fitting for the yogin.

Seeing the world, with its bases of characteristics and its characterized,
as freed from arising and perishing,
and abandoning the sides of existence and nonexistence,
the yogin should meditate on yoga.

If one does not conceive of arising,
then with samādhi and the powers,
the superknowledges and mastery,
one swiftly becomes a yogin.

One should not imagine the world as coming from atoms, from time,
from the principal or from a creator.
The yogin should not imagine
the world as arising from causes and conditions.

The world is imagined by one's own conceptuality;
it arises from various habitual tendencies.
The yogin should always see
existence as like an illusion or a dream.

Always viewing things as free
from superimposition and denial,
having gone well upon the path of peace,
one undertakes the various yogas.

Do not conceive the three realms of existence
as resembling body, enjoyments and abode.
Having finished the task of eating,

straightening the body, free of thoughts,

bowing again and again
to the buddhas and to awakening,
the one who knows yoga, having fully gathered
sūtra, vinaya and reasoning,

should meditate on the five dharmas, on one's own mind,
and on selflessness.
Personal self-awareness, the pure nature of reality,
the grounds and the buddha ground:

if the yogin meditates on these,
he will be consecrated upon a great lotus.
Having wandered through all the destinies,
with a mind weary of existence,

if the yogin exerts himself,
he sees what resembles the shape of the sun and moon,
what is like light and a lotus,
what resembles patterns, the sky and fire.

Those various signs
lead one onto the path of the non-Buddhists;
they also make one fall
into the domain of the śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas.

When, having rejected all of these,
one has become free of appearances,
then the divine hands of the buddhas,
coming forth from all the fields,

stroke his head:
the sign of correctly following.
Saying that things exist from no cause,
free of eternalism and annihilation,

free of the sides of existence and nonexistence,
they imagine this to be the Middle Way.
Those who speak of causelessness
conceive the view of causeless annihilation.

Because they do not understand external things,
they bring about the destruction of the Middle Way.
Thinking, "It would become the view of annihilation,"
they do not give up grasping at things,

and so, by denial and superimposition,
they come to teach the Middle Way.
Through realizing mind-only
and eliminating external things,

conceptuality is turned back;
that very path is the Middle Way.
It is mind-only; there is no appearance.
Because there is no appearance, there is no arising.

This path of the Middle Way
has been taught by me and by others too.
Arising and non-arising,
things and non-things, emptiness,

and the absence of intrinsic nature in things:
one should not conceive these as twofold.
Because conceptuality does not engage,
the childish imagine that to be liberation.

Because they do not understand the engagement of mind,
they do not abandon the two kinds of grasping.
Through understanding appearances as one's own mind,
the two kinds of grasping are abandoned.

Abandoning and grasping
do not destroy conceptuality.
Through fully knowing the appearances of mind,
conceptuality does not engage.

The non-engagement of conceptuality
is suchness, the abandonment of mind.

Free of the faults of the non-Buddhists (tīrthikas),
If activity should appear,
Since what has ceased does not come into play again,
The wise have held to this.
So that it may be realized,

I and the other buddhas have taught it as buddhahood.
If one conceives of it in any other way,
It becomes the doctrine of the non-Buddhists.

In the unborn there are many births;
Without dying and passing on, there is dying and passing on.
In millions of fields all at once
It appears like the moon in water.
Becoming one and becoming many,
It blazes as fire and pours down as rain.
Becoming mind within the minds of beings,
They teach that all is mind only.
In minds there is mind only,
And the mindless too arises from mind.
Various forms, figures and shapes:
Know them to be understood as mind only.
In the form of the Lord of Sages and the form of śrāvakas,
In the likeness of pratyekabuddhas,
And in other forms of many kinds,
They teach that these are mind only.
For the formless they take a formless form;
For hell beings, the form of hell.
The causes of mind only as well
They show to sentient beings.
When these have been thoroughly transformed,
The illusion-like concentration,
And the mind-made body likewise,
The masteries and the ten grounds are attained.

By their own inverted conceptuality,
By proliferation and agitation,
By what is heard, seen, known and understood,
And by perceptions, the childish are bound.
The dependent nature is the sign;
Whatever is name is the imputed;
Therefore conceptualizing and signs
Arise wholly from the dependent.
When the intellect has taken them fully apart,

There is no imputed and no dependent.
If there is no perfected entity,
How could the intellect conceive of it?
There is a perfected entity
That is free of existence and nonexistence.
What is liberated from the existence and nonexistence of entities,
How could it become two natures?
In the imputed nature
Two natures abide:
The imputed appears in various ways;
The pure is the domain of the noble ones.
The imputed appearing in variety
Is conceived of as "the dependent."
If one conceives of it in any other way,
One comes to abide in the doctrine of the non-Buddhists.
What is imagined by conceptuality is called the imputed;
Because it is seen, it has arisen from causes.
Freedom from these two conceptions
Is the perfected itself.

The Noble Descent into Laṅkā, the ninth and final fascicle.

Fields and emanated buddhas,
The one vehicle and likewise three,
Nirvāṇa and the absence of self:
All are empty and free of arising.
The thirty-six distinctions of buddhas,
The ten distinctions,
And the individual mind-streams of sentient beings:
These are the vessels of the fields.
Just as an imputed thing
Appears to the eye as various,
Yet variety itself is not in it,
So too are beings and the Dharma buddha.
The Dharma buddha is the buddha;
The rest are its emanations.
Sentient beings, through the continuum of their own seeds,
See the buddha appearing.

From connection with signs
Erroneous conceptuality proceeds.
Suchness is not other than conceptuality,
Nor is conceptuality other than signs.
Whatever buddhas there are, of the intrinsic nature, of complete enjoyment,
Of magical display, and of emanation,
The many buddhas, thirty-six,
Are the buddha of the intrinsic nature.

Blue and red, salt,
Conch, milk and sugar,
Astringent fruits, flowers and the like,
Just as the rays from the sun,
And the ocean with its waves,
Are neither one nor different,
So it is with the seven consciousnesses
Together with the mind.
The transformation of the ocean
Is those various waves;
Likewise from the ālaya arise
The various things called consciousness.
Mind, mentation and consciousness
Are designated for the sake of characteristics.
The eight are not distinct in character;
There is no basis of characterization and no characteristic.
Just as the ocean and its waves
Are without difference,
So in the mind the transformation
Into consciousnesses is not found.

Mind accumulates karma;
Mentation, too, gathers it fully;
Consciousness cognizes;
The five imagine what appears.

"In the aspects of blue and red
People's consciousness appears.
The likeness of the waves to mind,
Great Sage, please explain how it holds."

"The aspects of blue and red
Do not exist in the waves.
For the sake of characteristics, to the childish,
The functioning of mind is taught.
In it there is no functioning;
One's own mind is free of anything grasped.
If there were something grasped, the grasper too
Would be established as like the waves.
As body, enjoyments and abode
People's consciousness appears;
Therefore its functioning
Appears to be like the waves."

"If the ocean, in the form of waves,
Is perceived as dancing,
Why is the functioning of the ālaya likewise
Not cognized by the intellect?"

"Because the childish lack understanding,
The ālaya is likened to the ocean;
Because it parallels the arising of waves,
The example is applied."

"Just as the sun rises
On people good, bad and middling,
So you, lamp of the world,
Teach the truth to the childish.
Having fully entered into the Dharma,
Why do you not speak of suchness?"

"If suchness were to be spoken of,
There is no suchness in the mind.
Just as the waves of the ocean,
Or as in a mirror or a dream,
Appear all at the same time,
So too the mind in its own domain.
Since it is not joined with objects,
It arises by gradual functioning.
Consciousness cognizes;
Mentation, too, imagines;

Appearance is manifest to the five;
In meditative equipoise there is no sequence.
Just as some master painter
Or a painter's apprentice
Lays out colors for the sake of a painting,
So is my teaching.
The painting is not in the colors,
Nor in the brush, nor in the bowl.
In order to guide sentient beings
A painting in colors is devised.
Reality is free of letters;
Explanations are deceptive."

Establishing a footing in the dharmas,
the truth is taught to yogins.
The truth itself, realized by individual self-awareness,
free of imagining and of what is imagined,
is what is taught to the Victor's heirs;
to the childish it is explained in other ways.

Just as the various illusions
appear and yet do not exist,
so too the various teachings, though illusory,
are taught in just that way.
What is taught to one
is not what is explained to another.
Just as a physician gives his medicines
to each patient according to the patient,
so the buddhas teach sentient beings,
and teach them also as mind-only.

From the seeds of habitual tendencies toward externals,
conceptual thought arises.
That by which one grasps is the dependent;
what is grasped is the imagined.
Taking an external referent as what is grasped,
and relying on mind as well, it comes to arise.
Error arises in two ways;
there is no cause for a third.

That from which error arises,
and that on which it depends in arising:
for that reason I have taught
the twelve, the eighteen and the six with regard to mind.

From the seeds of self bound up with what is grasped,
clinging to a self arises.
When mind engages in examination,
grasping at phenomena is given up.
The consciousnesses that arise
from the all-base consciousness
are the inner sense sources;
whatever appears is outer.

Just as the unskilled
grasp at hairs and the forms of dreams,
so they imagine the conditioned and the unconditioned
to be permanent, yet these do not exist.
Just as a city of gandharvas,
an illusion, and the water of a mirage
appear though they do not exist,
so too is the dependent.

Designations of a self and of sense faculties
I do not teach with regard to mind.
Mind, mentation and consciousness
are free of characteristics of their own.
Mind, mentation and consciousness,
likewise the two kinds of selflessness,
the five dharmas and the natures:
these are the domain of the buddhas.

By their characteristics they become three,
arising from the single cause of habitual tendencies,
just as a single pigment
appears in various ways upon a wall.
Mind and the two selflessnesses,
mentation and consciousness,
the natures and the five dharmas:

these do not exist in my family.
Free of the characteristics of mind,
having abandoned consciousness and mentation,
the absence of intrinsic nature in phenomena:
this is the family of the Tathāgata.

With body, speech and mind
one should act virtuously in it.
The family of the Tathāgata is pure,
free of all wandering.
Pure through the superknowledges and the masteries,
adorned with meditative absorptions and powers,
with various mind-made bodies:
this is the virtuous family of the Tathāgata.
Stainless individual self-awareness,
free of the characteristic of cause,
the eighth ground and the buddha ground:
this is the family of the Tathāgata.

Excellent Intelligence (Sādhumatī), Gone Afar (Dūraṃgamā),
Cloud of Dharma (Dharmameghā), and the ground of the Tathāgata:
these are the family of the buddhas;
the rest attain the two vehicles.
Because of the distinctions in beings' mindstreams
and because of their characteristics, for the childish
the buddhas taught the seven grounds
that come under the sway of mind.

The dysfunctional tendencies of speech, body and mind
do not occur on the seventh ground;
on the eighth ground their basis
is like a dream or a flowing river.
On the eighth ground and the fifth,
the Victor's heirs know
the crafts, the sciences and the arts,
and in the abodes of existence they even act as kings.

Arising and not arising, empty and not empty:
the wise should not imagine these.

Intrinsic nature and absence of intrinsic nature
do not exist in mind-only.
"This is true, this is true,
this is false": such imagining
is taught to pratyekabuddhas and śrāvakas,
not to the heirs of the Victor.

In mind-only there is no existence;
existence and nonexistence do not come from existence.
There is no momentariness and no characteristic;
there is neither the imputed nor substance.
Conventionally, things exist;
ultimately, they have no intrinsic nature.
Error with regard to what has no intrinsic nature:
that is conventional truth.

Upon all phenomena, which do not exist,
I have made designations.
The verbal conduct of the childish
is utterly devoid of the true.
Things that arise from expression
have a domain of objects;
things that arise from expression
do not exist when looked at.

Like a painting without a wall,
or a shadow apart from a tree stump and the like,
so the pure all-base
is not marred by waves.
Mind abides like a dancer,
mentation is like a jester;
consciousness, together with the five,
imagines appearances like colors.

The teaching of Dharma that accords with the cause,
and whatever is emanated by what accords with the cause:
these are the buddhas of essence;
the rest are emanation bodies.
There are no appearances of various kinds;

mind is deluded by appearance.
As though it were body, enjoyments and abode,
the all-base appears to people.

Mind, mentation and consciousness,
the natures and the five dharmas,
and the two selflessnesses, purified:
these the Guide explains.
The domain of individual self-awareness
that the perfect Buddha explains
is not the domain of logicians,
nor is it that of the śrāvakas.

Long and short and so forth are related;
each comes about through the other.
What proves existence is nonexistence;
what proves nonexistence is existence.
When substance is analyzed into atoms,
one does not conceive of form.
The establishment of mind-only
those of bad views do not believe.

"Empty," "mere conceptual thought,"
or "not empty": such statements
imagine that very thing as existent or nonexistent;
there is no object to be examined.
Through the aggregation of qualities, atoms and substances,
the childish imagine form.
Not a single atom exists;
for that reason too there are no objects.

One's own mind, the shape of appearance,
appears to people as external.
There is no external appearance;
for that reason too there are no objects.
Various tangled hair-nets, illusions,
dreams, cities of gandharvas,
firebrand circles and mirages,
though nonexistent, appear vividly to the eye.

Permanent and impermanent, likewise one,
two and not two, likewise:
bound by faults since beginningless time,
the deluded childish imagine these.
There is no establishing of vehicles;
I have taught a single vehicle.
In order to guide the childish,
I have taught different vehicles.

Likewise the three liberations,
the selflessness of phenomena,
the wisdom of sameness, and freedom from affliction:
these are forgone through that liberation.

Just as a log upon the ocean
is tossed about by the waves,
so too the deluded śrāvaka
is tossed about by characteristics.

For him there is no final consummation,
yet he does not turn back either;
having gained the body of samādhi,
he does not awaken for eons.

Bound to the habitual tendencies of affliction,
yet free of their active outbursts,
they are drunk with the intoxication of samādhi
and dwell in the undefiled realm.

Just as a drunken man
becomes sober once the liquor is gone,
so at that time they will attain
my Dharma body of a buddha.

Just as an elephant sunk in the mire
cannot run this way or that,
so the śrāvakas remain,
sunk in the mire of samādhi.

Through the blessing of the Lord of Men,
empowerment, samādhis and the rest,
purified by aspirations,

arise from the first stage through the tenth.

The horns of a hare, the sky,
and a barren woman's son as well:
just as these are spoken of in words though they do not exist,
so too is conceptualizing about things.

The world arises from the cause of habitual tendencies;
it exists nowhere at all, being neither existent nor nonexistent.
Those skilled in the selflessness of phenomena,
when they see this, become liberated.

Name is the imputed nature;
what arises from another is born of dependence;
suchness is the perfected nature:
this I have always taught in sūtra after sūtra.

Words and letters in great number,
and names in all their particulars:
foolish children of poor understanding cling to them
like an elephant stuck in the mire.

The vehicle of the gods, the vehicle of Brahmā,
and likewise that of the śrāvakas,
of the pratyekabuddhas, and of the tathāgatas:
these vehicles I have taught.

So long as the mind still engages,
there is no end to the vehicles;
when the mind has been fully transformed,
there is no vehicle and no one who goes.

Mind, conceptuality, cognition,
mentation, and consciousness itself,
the ālaya, the stirrings of the three realms of existence:
these are synonyms of mind.

Life, warmth, consciousness,
the ālaya, the life faculty,
mentation, and mental consciousness:
these are distinctions of conceptual thought.

Mind takes hold of the body;
mentation constantly conceives a self;
consciousness, together with the consciousnesses,
discriminates the objects of mind.

Craving is taught to be the mother,
and ignorance is known as the father;
because consciousness cognizes objects,
I have taught it to be the Buddha.

The latent tendencies are the arhat;
the gathering of the five aggregates is the Saṅgha.
Because these are severed without interval,
that is a deed of immediate retribution.

The two selflessnesses and the afflictions,
likewise the two obscurations,
and inconceivable death and transmigration:
through attaining these, one is a Tathāgata.

The established tenets and their ways,
and the teaching as well, individually self-known:
whoever sees and knows their distinction
does not come under the sway of conceptuality.

If, just as fools imagine,
things have no truth,
why do the logicians not accept
that the absence of things is no extreme?

Those who see conditioned things
as bound up with arising and perishing
foster the two views;
they do not understand conditions.

Nirvāṇa, the abandonment of mentation,
that alone is the truth.
The imagined world should be regarded
as an illusion, like a plantain trunk.

Attachment, aversion,
and delusion exist, but there is no person.
The aggregates arise from existence

and are like dreams.

From the night on which I awakened
to the night I passed into complete nirvāṇa,
in all that time between
I have not taught even the slightest thing.

With the way of the individually self-known Dharma in mind
I have fully taught;
between me and those buddhas
there is not the slightest difference.

The self exists as though a substance;
the aggregates are free of its characteristics;
the aggregates exist as entities,
but in them there is no self.

Beset by afflictions and their latent tendencies,
by meditating with discernment,
when beings see their own mind
they are freed from all suffering.

Those who say that the world comes forth
through causes and conditions
and through the reasoning of the four extremes
are not skilled in my way.

The world does not arise as existent or nonexistent;
neither nonexistent nor existent, it is nowhere at all.
How then do fools imagine it
by way of causes and conditions?

When one sees the worlds
as neither existent, nor nonexistent, nor both existent and nonexistent,
then the mind turns back,
and selflessness too is realized.

Because they arise from conditions,
all things are unborn;
all conditions are results,
and craving does not arise toward a result.

Because from a result there would be duality,
a result does not arise from a result;
because of the fault of duality,
no entity is found arising from a result.

When conditioned things
are free of the observed and the observing,
and one sees mind-only, without mind,
that I declare to be mind-only.

Mind is the very form of essential nature,
free of conditions and of entities;
the ultimate essence, the supreme brahman:
of this I speak as "only."

The self is a truth by imputation;
it does not exist as a substance.
The aggregates and aggregate-hood likewise
exist by imputation, not as substances.

Sameness is of four kinds:
of characteristics, of cause, of what arises from entities,
and the sameness of selflessness,
the fourth, for those engaged in yoga.

Turning away all views,
free of what is imagined and of imagining,
without object and unborn:
this I explain as mind-only.

Neither an entity nor a non-entity,
suchness, free of entity and non-entity,
free of mind:
this I explain as mind-only.

Emptiness, the ultimate limit, and suchness,
nirvāṇa and the dharmadhātu,
the manifold mind-made body:
these I explain as mind-only.

Bound up with the habitual tendencies of conceptuality,
the manifold that arises from mind
and appears to people as external:

that is the mind-only of the world.

There is no external appearance;
as body, enjoyments and abode,
mind appears in manifold forms:
this I explain as mind-only.

The wisdom of exhaustion of the śrāvakas,
The birth and arising of the buddhas,
And that of the pratyekabuddhas
Come forth fully through the absence of afflictions.

There is no external form;
It is one's own mind that appears as external.
Because they do not comprehend the mind,
The childish conceive of the conditioned.

Not knowing that external objects
Are one's own mind appearing in variety,
The foolish set out to refute this
With reasons framed to fit a thesis.

There is no reason and no thesis,
Nor are there examples or the members of proof.
One's own mind is the stream of objects;
Whoever knows this is wise.

Whatever is imagined by conceptual thought
Has the imagined characteristic.
With the imagined as its basis,
Conceptual thought sets in motion.

Mutually unseparated and connected,
They arise from the single cause, habitual tendencies.
Because the two arise adventitiously,
The mind of people does not arise.

Mind and mental factors that dwell
In the three realms of existence are conceptual thought.
Whatever engages as the appearance of objects
Is the imagined nature.

Because they possess the seeds of appearance,
The sense sources are twelve.
Because they have a basis and an object,
I have explained them as a mere account.

As a mirror holds a reflection,
And one with blurred vision sees tangled hairs,
So mind veiled by habitual tendencies
Is what the childish see.

Toward objects imagined by their own thought
Conceptuality sets in motion.
External objects do not exist
In the way the non-Buddhists (tīrthikas) imagine.

Just as the childish, not knowing a rope
For what it is, take hold of it as a snake,
So, not knowing objects to be their own mind,
They conceive of them as external objects.

Thus the rope, being simply rope,
Is free of being one or different;
But that which conceives of it as a rope
Is the fault of one's own mind.

Where, examining anything as the entity of anything,
It is not that nothing is observed,
That should not be known as nonexistent;
That is the nature of reality of phenomena.

The counterpart drawn from existence is nonexistence;
The counterpart drawn from nonexistence is existence.
Therefore one should not know it as nonexistent,
Nor imagine it as existent.

When this, which is wholly imagined,
Is examined, it does not have that nature.
Seeing that it does not have that nature,
How could conceptual thought set in motion?

Form has no nature of form,
And likewise pot, cloth, and the rest.
Since appearances do not exist,

Your conceptual thought does not arise.

If your conceiving errs
Regarding the beginningless conditioned,
Who has made entities into real entities
That cycle on? Great Sage, tell me.

Entities have no real entityhood;
It is mind alone that appears.
Because one does not see one's own mind,
Conceptual thought sets in motion.

If the imagined, as the childish imagine it,
Is either existent or nonexistent,
And there were some other mode beside these,
Even the intellect could not conceive it.

If it exists for the noble ones,
It is not what the childish imagine.
If it were contrary to the noble ones,
The noble and the childish would be equal.

Because their minds are fully purified,
The noble ones have no error.
The childish, whose mind-stream is impure,
Conceive of the imagined.

Just as a mother, for her child,
Takes fruits from the sky and says,
"Here, my only child, do not cry;
Take these many kinds of fruit,"

So I, for all sentient beings,
Drawing them on with the various fruits of imagination,
Fully explain the way
That abandons the sides of existence and nonexistence.

If what has not arisen arises
Through conditions and not from connection,
Then what was unborn before is born now,
And it gains no nature of its own.

Without gaining a nature of its own, there is no birth,
Nor is there anything anywhere without conditions.
Those entities that are born, too,
Are nowhere without conditions.

When one sees it thus in this sūtra,
Nowhere is there nonexistence, nor existence, nor their negation.
The wise do not imagine
Entities as arising from conditions.

The non-Buddhists speak to the childish
Of oneness and difference through conditions,
Yet they do not know that beings
Are like dreams and illusions.

The vehicle that is the domain of expression
Is the unsurpassed Great Vehicle.
I have taught its meaning well,
Yet the childish do not know it.

What the miserly śrāvakas
And the non-Buddhists have composed,
Because it is explained through conceptual thought,
Is mistaken about the meaning.

Characteristic, entity, shape,
And name, these four kinds:
Taking these as their objects,
Conceptual thought sets in motion.

Those who hold to one and to many,
Who hold sway in Brahmā's realm,
And over the light of sun and moon as well,
Those who destroy, are not my sons.

Those whose noble vision is perfect,
Who realize and know reality just as it is,
Who are skilled in turning back perception,
And have gone to the far shore of conceptual thought,

They, in my teaching,
Bear the seal of sons who are liberated:
Fully freed from entity and non-entity,

Having abandoned coming and going.

If, when the consciousness of form turns back,
Karma were destroyed,
There would be neither permanence nor impermanence,
And saṃsāra too would cease to be.

What has perished at the time of turning back
Turns back from the object of form;
Karma, free of the faults of existence and nonexistence,
Abides in the foundation of all (ālaya).

In the abode of existence, consciousness
And fallen form are utterly destroyed,
But karma connected with form and consciousness
Is not destroyed.

If a person's karma connected with them
Were destroyed,
Then, since the connection of karma would be severed,
There would be no saṃsāra and no nirvāṇa either.

If, though it has perished, one is born
Into saṃsāra together with it,
Then, since form is connected with it,
It would arise as not different.

Mind, through conceiving of form,
Is neither one nor different.
Because the sides of existence and nonexistence are abandoned,
Entities have no destruction.

The wholly imagined and the dependent
Are not different from each other in their characteristics;
Like the impermanence of form,
Each also gives rise to the other.

If one does not comprehend the imagined,
Which is fully free of one and different,
How could it become existent or nonexistent?
It is like the impermanence of form.

When the imagined is clearly seen,
The dependent does not arise.

When the dependent is clearly seen,
The imagined becomes suchness.
When the imagined is destroyed,
My way too is brought to destruction.
In this teaching of mine
There is superimposition and denial.
Wherever and whenever there are such people,
Those who disparage the Dharma,
They bring my way to destruction.
Do not keep company with any of them.
Whoever superimposes and denies,
And destroys the imagined,
One should not speak with among the wise;
Monks should truly shun them.

Hair-nets, things like illusions,
Like dreams, like gandharvas,
Conceptions like the appearance of a mirage:
Those who view these as existent or nonexistent,
Who would act to gather them in?
They do not train in what is the Buddha's.
They have fallen into the two extremes,
And they bring others to ruin as well.

Those yogins who see
The imagined thing as wholly void,
Fully liberated from entity and non-entity:
Gather those in and keep their company.

Just as the mines found in the world
From which pearls, jewels and gold come forth
Did not arise from the cause of varied karma,
Yet are the livelihood of people,
So too the classes of sentient beings
Are free of the various kinds of karma.
Because there is no appearance, there is no karma,
Nor are there destinies arisen from karma.

As the noble ones meditate,
Things have no thinghood;
Yet as the childish imagine,
Things do exist.

"If things as the childish imagine them
Did not exist,
Then, since all things would be nonexistent,
Who could ever be afflicted?
Yet from affliction over various things
Comes saṃsāra, the faculties coming forth,
And ignorance and the bond to existence:
The arising of embodied beings takes place."

"Those for whom things do not exist
In the way the childish imagine them,
For them the faculties do not engage;
It is yoga itself that engages."

"Blessed One, if the thing that is
The cause of saṃsāra does not exist,
Then the childish, without any striving,
Would reach liberation, free of activity.
If there are no things, how can there be
A difference between your noble ones and the childish?"

"For the noble ones who practice
The three liberations, there are no things.
There are no aggregates, no person, no phenomena,
No specific and no general characteristics.
The faculties and the conditions
I taught to the śrāvakas.
Causelessness and mind only,
The attainments and the grounds,
And each one's own suchness, the pure,
I taught to the children of the Victor.

Those who disparage my teaching,
Wearing saffron robes,
Proclaiming that a result exists or does not exist,
Will appear in times to come.

There are no things; existence through conditions
Is the domain of the noble ones.
The imagined thing is utterly nonexistent;
The logicians are the ones who imagine it.

In times to come
Kaṇāda, childish by nature, will appear,
And through the evil view of those who say there is no result
He will bring many people to ruin.
'Beings arise from atoms;
Atoms themselves have no cause;
The nine substances too are permanent':
So, with evil view, they will teach.
'Substances are produced by substances,
And qualities likewise by qualities.'
Positing a thinghood of things that is something other,
They bring what exists to ruin.

If what had not arisen were to arise,
The world would have a beginning.
But I have taught that saṃsāra
Has no prior limit.
You who count up the whole of the three realms of existence:
If what had not arisen were to arise,
Then dogs, camels and donkeys too
Would no doubt grow horns.
If form, consciousness
And the eye arose having not arisen,
Then crowns, mats, cloth and the like
Would come forth from a lump of kneaded clay.
A mat is not present in cloth,
Nor is cloth present in reeds.
If one thing arises from one alone,
Why would anything not arise from conditions as well?

'That life and that body,'
And the arising of what had not arisen at all:
All these are what others assert,
And I too have explained them thoroughly.
The opponent's position is to be stated,

And their understanding is to be turned back;
Having turned their understanding back,
I explain my own position.
Thinking, 'My disciples, a deluded crowd,
May come to dwell in positions of existence and nonexistence,'
I have therefore stated
The assertions of the non-Buddhists (tīrthikas).

Kapila too, of evil understanding,
Teaches his disciples
That beings are born from the Principal (pradhāna)
And from the transformation of the qualities.

It is neither arisen through conditions nor unarisen.
Conditions do not exist,
And because conditions have no entity,
What has not arisen does not arise.

Free of the positions of existence and nonexistence,
Abandoning causes and conditions,
Without arising and without perishing,
Abandoning the basis of characteristics: this is my own position.

When one constantly sees the world,
Which is like an illusion or a dream,
Free of causes and conditions,
As causeless, conceptual thought does not engage.

When one sees becoming as causeless,
Like a city of gandharvas, like a mirage,
Ever like a net of hairs,
Free of the positions of existence and nonexistence,
Abandoned by cause and condition,
The cause of mind is purified."

"If there are no things,
And mere mind too does not exist,
How could there be mind without things?
It is not tenable even as mind only.
Taking things as their object,
People's minds come to arise.

How could there be mind without a cause?
It is not tenable as mind only."

"In the way things are for the noble ones,
Suchness and mind only exist.
Those who say they do not exist
Are unskilled in my way.
If mind engages in things
As apprehended and apprehender,
That is the mind of the world;
It is not tenable as mind only.
If body, possessions and abode
Arise like a dream,
Mind would become twofold;
But mind has no twofold characteristic.
Just as a sword does not cut its own edge,
And just as a finger
Does not touch its own tip,
So it is with mind viewing itself.
There is no other and no dependence,
And there is no imagined thing.
The five dharmas and the two minds as well,
Being without appearance, do not exist.
What is to be produced and what produces:
The characteristic of things is of these two kinds.
Having the producer in mind,
I taught the absence of intrinsic nature."

If conceptual thought arose
In the shape of objects of manifold aspects,
Then even a rabbit's horn and the sky
Would come to appear as objects.

If there were an object not imagined,
The mind too would appear as an object.
An object imagined
As distinct from mind is never observed at all.

In saṃsāra, which has no beginning,
Objects exist nowhere at all.
If the mind had not been nourished,
How could it come to appear as objects?

If it were nourished by what does not exist,
A rabbit's horn would become so as well.
Conceptual thought nourished
By a nonexistent thing does not arise.

Just as it does not exist now,
So too it did not exist before.
Where there is no object,
How could a mind bound to objects come about?

Suchness, emptiness, the ultimate limit,
Nirvāṇa and the dharmadhātu,
And the nonarising of phenomena:
These are the nature of the ultimate.

Because they conceive of causes and conditions,
And do not fully understand
That existence is causeless and has not arisen,
The childish fall into existence and nonexistence.

"Mind becomes manifest where there is no appearance,
And distinctions arise from a beginningless cause.
If there have been no objects since beginningless time,
By what do distinctions arise?

If it were nourished by what does not exist,
Then even the poor would become wealthy.
How does mind arise without objects?
May the Sage please explain this to me."

"All of these are without cause;
There is no mind and no sphere of activity.
Mind too is not nourished;
The three realms of existence are free of an agent.

In order to refute arising,
Nonarising is established.
The teaching of causelessness

The childish do not understand.

All of these are unarisen,
Yet they are not nonexistent things.
Like dreams, illusions and cities of the gandharvas,
There are things that have no cause."

"Why have you spoken to me
Of the unarisen, of the absence of intrinsic nature,
And of emptiness as well?"

"When things do not appear
Apart from combinations,
Then they are unarisen and empty,
And I have explained them as without intrinsic nature.

Dreams, floating hairs, illusions,
Cities of the gandharvas and mirages
Appear even without a cause;
The diverse world is just like this.

Likewise, in each single combination,
Since there is no appearance, it does not exist.
Combinations are not transformed by destruction
As in the view of the non-Buddhists (tīrthikas).

Disputing through the doctrine of causelessness,
Nonarising too is established.
When nonarising is established,
My way is not destroyed.

When the doctrine of causelessness is taught,
Fear arises in the tīrthikas, who say,
'How, from what, by what,
And where does causeless arising occur?'

When conditioned things are seen
Not as from a cause but as causeless,
Then the view that speaks
Of their arising and perishing is turned back."

"Is nonarising the nonexistence of things?
Or is it dependence on conditions?

Or is it a name for things?
Or please tell me, is it something without meaning?"

"Nonarising is not the nonexistence of things,
Nor is it dependence on conditions.
Nor is it a name for things,
Nor is it a name without meaning.

That which is not the domain
Of śrāvakas, of pratyekabuddhas,
Of those who have reached the seventh ground,
Or of tīrthikas: that is the mark of nonarising.

The turning back of causes and conditions,
The negation of agents,
And the establishing of everything as mind only:
These I have explained as nonarising.

Things not arising from causes,
The abandoning of conceiving and conceived,
Freedom from the positions of existence and nonexistence:
This I have explained as nonarising.

Mind free of appearances,
Having abandoned the two natures as well,
The transformation of the bases:
This I have explained as nonarising.

External things are neither things nor nonthings,
Nor is mind grasped at all;
All views are utterly abandoned:
That is the mark of nonarising.

Likewise emptiness and absence of intrinsic nature:
All the words gathered from these should be examined.
It is never empty through emptiness;
It is the emptiness of nonarising.

From the combination of kinds of conditions
Things come forth and cease.
Apart from the combination
There is no arising and no ceasing either.

In terms of oneness and difference,
As the tīrthikas imagine,
Things are not distinct,
And apart from combination they exist nowhere at all.

Existent and nonexistent things do not arise;
Neither nonexistent nor existent, they are nowhere.
Therefore it is otherwise: it is the combination
That comes forth and ceases.

This is mere convention;
It is a linkage of mutual dependence.
Apart from the linkage of conditions
There is nothing to be produced.

Since there is no producing, there is no arising,
Free of the faults of the tīrthikas.
I have explained it as mere linkage;
The childish do not understand.

To say that somewhere, apart from linkage,
There is a production of things
Destroys linkage;
It should be known as the doctrine of causelessness.

If somewhere, apart from linkage,
A thing existed for anyone,
Then substances, like a lamp,
Would illuminate the linkage.

Whatever phenomenon the unskilled imagine
Apart from the linkages
Is unarisen and without essential nature;
Its nature is like space.

The nature of reality attained by the noble ones
Is another nonarising;
The nonarising of that
Is the forbearance of nonarising.

When all these worlds
Are seen as linkage itself,
Thinking, 'This is mere linkage,'

Then the mind settles in equipoise.

Ignorance, craving, karma and the like
Are the inner linkages.
The potter's wheel, clay, rod, churning stick and the like,
Seeds, elements and so on, are the outer.

This is mere linkage.
Whoever holds that any entity
Arises from other conditions
Does not abide in reasoning or scripture.

If there is no thing to be produced,
From what condition does cognition arise?
Since these become conditions for one another,
Therefore they are known as conditions.

The properties of heat, moisture, solidity and motion
Are imagined by the childish.
They are not phenomena in a combination;
Therefore they have no essential nature.

Physicians, according to the patient,
Prescribe different treatments,
Yet their treatise contains no difference;
It differs only as divided by the illness.

Likewise I too, knowing the mental continua of beings,
Stained by the faults of afflictions and defects,
And knowing the strength of their faculties,
Teach the way to the childish.

Though afflictions and faculties differ,
My teaching is not divided by that.
The peaceful path endowed with eight limbs
Is a single vehicle.

Pot, cloth, diadem and horn;
The rabbit's horn is a cause of nonexistence.
What arises from a collection of causes
You should not take to be nonexistent.

By reason of existence there is nonexistence;
Without it, nonexistence could not be nonexistent.
Existence arises from its counterpart, nonexistence;
Each is the cause of its counterpart."

On what does it take its stand,
and who conceives of what as appearing?
What is it that depends on something?
It is causeless, and yet not without cause.

If it depends on something else,
and that in turn appears in something else,
there would be an endless regress,
and whatever there is would become nothing at all.

Just as an illusion appears
in dependence on leaves, wood and the like,
so, in dependence on things,
variety appears to people.

The net of illusion is not leaves,
it is not pebbles, it is not wood.
Fools see the illusion;
the illusionist sees its basis.

Likewise, being based on things,
what difference could there be?
When it appears, there being no duality,
in what, and how, could one examine it?

In conceptual thought there is nothing conceived,
and conceptual thought too does not exist.
Since there is nothing in conceptual thought,
there is no nirvāṇa and no saṃsāra.

Since there is no conceptual thought,
conceptual thought does not operate.
If it does not operate, how could there be mind?
Mind-only would not be tenable.

Because intentions are many and diverse,
the teaching has no core;
since it has no core, there is no liberation,

and there is no world of various kinds.

There is no external appearance
of the kind that fools imagine.
Mind appears like a reflection,
stirred up by habitual tendencies.

Since existence and nonexistence have not arisen,
all things are unborn.
All of these are mind-only,
utterly free of conceptions.
Fools speak of things on account of conditions;
the wise do not.

Intrinsic nature is free of mind,
and mind proceeds to the noble ones.
Sāṃkhyas, naked ascetics, Vaiśeṣikas,
and likewise brahmins and Pāśupatas
fall into views of existence and nonexistence,
bereft of the meaning of the isolated.

Absence of intrinsic nature, the unborn,
emptiness, illusion, the stainless:
the buddhas and you as well,
for whose sake have you taught these?

For yogins who seek the mind,
who are free of views and speculation,
the buddhas have taught yoga,
and I too have fully taught it.

If all this is mind,
on what does the world rest?
Why do people appear
coming and going on the earth?

Just as birds in the sky,
moved about by conception,
without abode and without support,
move there as if upon the ground,

so all embodied beings as well,
moved about by conceptual thought,
roam within their own mind
like birds in the sky.

It is taught that mind operates,
appearing as body, enjoyments and abode.
How and why are there appearance and operation?
Tell me about mind-only.

Body, enjoyments and abodes,
appearance and operation, and habitual tendencies:
through conceptualizing appearance and operation
these arise for those who do not exert themselves.

The object is the thing imagined;
mind arises from the object.
By fully understanding the mind that appears,
conceptual thought does not operate.

When one sees the conditioned
as imputed names, as free of names,
and as devoid of intellect and the knowable,
at that time one is liberated.

That it is the imposing of name upon name:
just this is what is to be known.
Those who know it otherwise
do not know; they are not knowers.

Within the five dharmas, the natures,
the eight consciousnesses,
and the two kinds of selflessness,
the whole of the Great Vehicle is contained.

When beings see
that it is void of intellect and the knowable,
then conceiving name upon name
does not come into play.

Because mind is seen, activity
and the conceiving of letters turn back.
Because one's own mind is not seen,

conceptual thought fully operates.

Like the formless aggregates,
there is no counting among them.
The elements are distinct, and form is a form of characteristics;
how then do forms become many?
Because characteristics are relinquished,
it is not derived from the elements, nor is it the elements.

If form were a characteristic other than these,
why would it not arise through the aggregates?
Free of aggregates and sense sources,
when one sees the absence of characteristics,
because one sees that phenomena lack a self,
then mind turns back.

Because objects and faculties differ,
consciousness arises as eightfold.
In terms of characteristics it is threefold,
and where there is no appearance it turns back.

The universal ground is the self of the mind,
and consciousness itself is what is "mine."
Through dualistic grasping it fully operates;
when it is thoroughly understood, it turns back.

When one sees, free of one and many,
that there is no movement,
then self and what is "mine"
are no longer conceived as two.

What has not entered does not increase,
nor is it the cause of consciousness.
What has ceased, being free of cause and effect,
does not enter again.

Why is it that the worlds
are conceptual thought, mind-only? Tell me.

Free of causes and connections,
free of characteristics and what they characterize,
one's own mind appears in variety

and is imagined as though it were seen.

Knowing the appearances of mind,
and because objects other than mind are grasped,
when the intellect does not see,
one falls into the view of nonexistence;
since one is grasping it as mind,
how would that not ever come about for one?

Conceptual thought is neither a thing nor a non-thing;
therefore existence is not born.
Because the appearances of mind are fully understood,
conceptual thought does not operate.

The non-operation of conceptual thought
is the transformation that is without basis.

Refuting the four alternatives:
if things possessed causes,
that would merely make a different distinction of names;
it would not be proven.

Because causes and conditions come together,
And because a cause has been ruled out,
These things are inferred from their meaning;
Otherwise they would arise from a cause.

If the conditions are impermanent,
The fault of permanence is turned back.
Because, for the childish, things are impermanent,
There is no arising and no destruction.

Whatever is in the very act of perishing
Does not appear as a cause.
How, and through what, could what is unseen be one?
From the impermanent, becoming does not arise.

Beings are trained through the means of gathering;
They are brought under control through moral discipline;
Through wisdom, views are destroyed;
Through liberation they are greatly increased.

All this is Lokāyata;
Whatever the non-Buddhists (tīrthikas) teach is false.
Because they view cause and effect as existent,
They have no established tenet of their own.

One such as I alone has a tenet of his own,
Which has utterly abandoned cause and effect
And is completely free of Lokāyata;
I shall teach it to the assembly of disciples.

It is mind only, and nothing appears.
Having abandoned permanence and annihilation,
As the things that are apprehended and the apprehender
Mind appears in two ways.

As long as the mind is active,
So long is there Lokāyata.
When the world is seen as one's own mind,
Conceptual thought does not occur.

Coming together is the result, the aim accomplished;
Exhaustion is the result unseen.
When coming together and exhaustion are fully understood,
Conceptual thought does not occur.

Permanent and impermanent, made
And unmade, other and not other,
All of these and the like
Are the way of Lokāyata.

Gods, asuras, and humans,
Animals, hungry ghosts, and the realm of Yama (the Lord of Death):
These, where embodied beings are born,
Are taught as the six destinies.

Through superior, middling, and inferior karma
One is born among them.
If one guards all that is virtuous,
One will, above all, be liberated.

"To the assemblies of monks you have taught
That in each and every instant
There is life, birth, and death.

Please explain to me the intent of this."

"Just as from one form there comes another form,
So mind, too, comes together and then perishes.
Therefore to the disciples
I teach birth from one instant to the next.

Form, and the conceptualizing of form,
Arise and operate in the same way.
Conceptual thought is birth;
There is nothing other than conceptual thought.

What I have taught as instant by instant
Was taught with reference to conditions.
When grasping at form has been abandoned,
There is no birth and no destruction.

Conditions and what is born from conditions,
Ignorance, suchness, and the rest,
Operate by way of two factors:
Two persons, and likewise two minds."

"If phenomena that are conditions
And those born from conditions are not distinct,
Permanence and the rest would become results,
And conditions, too, would become causes.

Because cause and effect are upheld,
The words of you and of the buddhas
Would be no different from the non-Buddhists';
Therefore, great Sage, they would not be noble."

"Within a body just a fathom long
The world, the origin of the world,
And the path leading to cessation
I have fully taught to the Victor's children.

Grasping at the three natures,
Ordinary beings, with views of apprehended and apprehender,
Conceptualize phenomena,
Both mundane and supramundane.

Therefore, having first examined,
One should speak of the natures;
But in order to turn back views
One does not imagine a nature.

Because of the fault of deterioration there is no vow,
And mind, too, does not become active.
It becomes active because of dualistic grasping;
Suchness is nondual.

From ignorance and craving
Consciousness and the rest have not been born;
Nor are they born from what is endless, from what is made,
Or from the making of becoming.

The destruction of things
Is explained by the unskilled in four ways.
Because twofold conceptual thought is at work;
Yet there is neither existence of things nor their nonexistence.

When one has seen what is free of the four extremes,
In which both views have been abandoned,
The operation of twofold conceptual thought
Does not manifestly occur.

Because the intellect rises up
Toward things that are unborn,
And toward things that are born it is the same,
One does not imagine them."

"How self and others
May never be mixed with existence and nonexistence:
The reasoning that turns back both views,
O Protector, tell me this."

"Unmixed with the doctrines of the non-Buddhists,
Leaving pratyekabuddhas and śrāvakas behind,
So that the Victor's children may not perish,
Is the Victor's practice of realization.

Liberation, the caused and the causeless as well,
Are of one characteristic in being unborn.
Through other designations these deceive;

The wise always abandon them.

Like clouds, like banks of cloud, like rainbows,
Like mirages, tangled hairs, and illusions,
All things arise from one's own conceptions;
The non-Buddhist world imagines them through causes of their own.

The unborn, and suchness,
The limit of reality, and emptiness:
These are names for form;
One does not imagine them as nonexistent.

Like 'hand' and 'doer' in the world,
Like Indra, Śakra, and Purandara,
So, too, the intrinsic nature of all things
Is not to be imagined.

Emptiness is not other than form,
And the unborn is likewise.
Because they are not other, they are not to be imagined;
Doing so leads fully into the fault of views.

Because the characteristics of things are grasped,
There is imagining and conceptual thought;
When thorough imagining is grasped,
There is long, short, round, and the rest.

Mind is imagining;
Mentation is thorough imagining;
Mental consciousness, conceptual thought,
Has abandoned marks and the basis of marks.

Whoever looks on the non-Buddhists' unborn
And on my own way alike,
His conception makes no distinction
And leads fully into the fault of views.

Intent, the unborn,
And the very meaning of the unborn:
Whoever knows these, knowing the reasoning,
They know my way.

The intent that has a purpose in view,
And the unborn, which has no basis:
The full understanding of these two meanings
I have taught as the unborn."

"Do unborn things exist,
Or is it not so? Tell me, great Sage.
Is it unlike the doctrine of no cause,
Or would it be mixed with nonexistence and with those doctrines?"

"The doctrine of no cause and the unborn
Are not the same; that is the view of the non-Buddhists.
Because it is free of existence and nonexistence,
I have taught it as mind only."

Arising and non-arising,
which spring from the causes of views, abandon them!
Non-arising belongs to those who teach that there is no cause,
and arising becomes a ground for causes.
In what is spontaneously accomplished there is no activity;
if there were activity, it would be mixed with views.
Through skillful means, aspiration, and the rest,
you have spoken to me of the view itself.
Since all phenomena are nonexistent,
how then does a maṇḍala arise?
Because it is free of grasped and grasper,
there is no engaging and no turning back.
From one thing another thing is seen,
and mind, too, arises from that.
The non-arising of phenomena:
how have you taught this to me?
If they do not know that all is mind only,
it is for that reason that this is taught.
In all that the great Sage has taught,
what comes earlier and what comes later conflict.
Free of the views of the non-Buddhists (tīrthikas),
rejecting unequal causes and the absence of cause,
engaging and turning back:
the best of speakers has taught these to me.
Free of existence and nonexistence,

not destroying cause and result,
the linking of the sequence of the grounds:
the Lotus-Eyed One has taught this to me.
The world, fallen into the two extremes,
is thrown into turmoil by views;
because of arising, non-arising, and the rest,
it does not realize the cause of peace.
I have no maṇḍala whatsoever;
I do not expound the nature of reality.
If there were two, it would be a fault;
the buddhas have purified duality.
Things are empty and momentary,
without intrinsic nature and unarisen.
Proponents of wrong views, obscured, imagine them otherwise;
the Tathāgatas do not.
How, and in what ways,
do objects become directly perceived,
and how does conceptual thought engage
and turn back? Please explain this to me.
Because it is endowed with vivid color,
seeing form gathered up by proliferations,
conceptual thought engages
even toward things outside.
By fully knowing that very thing
and seeing the object exactly as it is,
the mind in accord with the noble lineage
does not engage.
Apart from the elements,
there is no arising of things.
The mind, which seems ever to be arising,
contemplate as unborn.
Do not conceptualize conceptual thought;
the wise are free of conceptual thought.
If one makes conceptual thought an object of examination,
it is not nonduality, it is not nirvāṇa.
The way of asserting non-arising
appears like an illusion;

an illusion arises without a cause,
and so the tenet is overstepped and lost.
The mind, habituated since beginningless time,
appears like a reflection;
it is like an object, yet it is not that there is no object.
Contemplate it correctly, just as it is.
Just as a form in a mirror
appears, free of oneness and difference,
and yet is not nonexistent,
so is the characteristic of arising.
Just as gandharva cities, illusions, and the like
depend on causes and conditions,
so too is the arising of all things;
it is not that they do not arise.
Through being imagined as self and as phenomena,
conceptual thought, like a person,
engages in two ways of engaging;
the childish do not realize this.
The incomplete, those under the power of conditions,
likewise śrāvaka arhats,
the Victors dependent on their own power, and the dependent:
these are taught as the five śrāvakas.
Perishing at another time,
the ultimate, the mutual,
and impermanence: these four kinds
the unskilled, childish imagine.
Through guṇas, atoms, and primal nature (prakṛti) as cause,
the childish, fallen into the two extremes,
holding to the positions of existence and nonexistence,
do not know the means of liberation.
Just as a child takes the fingertip
to be the moon, and nothing else,
so those attached to the letters
do not realize my suchness.
The elements, discordant in their characteristics,
give rise to material things;
that is the abiding of the elements.

What derives from the elements is not made by the elements.
Fire burns form;
the water element has the nature of an emanation;
wind scatters form.
How then could things arise from the elements?
Consciousness and the aggregate of form:
these are two, not five.
The different enumerations of the aggregates
I have also explained in a hundred ways.
The distinctions of mind and mental factors
are an engaging that fully engages,
mingled with the aspect of form;
the form of mind does not derive from the elements.
Blue and the rest are white by their counterpart;
by the counterpart of white and the rest, blue.
Cause and result, production,
existence and nonexistence, emptiness,
the proof, the proven, and what is to be proven,
cold and hot, the mark and its basis,
all these and others like them
the logicians have not established.
Mind, mentation, and the six consciousnesses,
these are accompanied by self;
free of oneness and difference,
the ground of all (ālaya) engages.
Sāṃkhyas, the Naked Ones, Vaiśeṣikas,
and logicians who speak of Īśvara
fall into the positions of existence and nonexistence;
they are excluded from the meaning of solitude.
The distinctions of shape and figure
are born from the elements, but are not elements.
Non-Buddhists say that what derives from the elements
and the elements themselves both arise.
Other non-Buddhists, apart from these,
imagine that they are not born from causes.
Those who rely on the positions of existence and nonexistence,
through delusion, do not comprehend.

Associated together with mind,
yet free of mentation and the rest,
the being whose characteristic is pure
abides together with wisdom.
Whatever form and karma there are,
aggregates arisen through objects as cause,
and beings, too, without appropriation,
do not abide where there is no form.
Because there would be no sentient beings,
those who speak of beings would have no self;
because consciousness, too, would not arise,
those who teach no-self would fall into annihilation.
Its four stations,
how could they exist without form?
Because there are no outer or inner things,
consciousness does not engage.
Just as the logicians accept
aggregates of the intermediate state,
so too, for one born in the formless realm,
why would there be no form of existence?
If beings had no consciousness,
they would be liberated without striving.
Without doubt this is the claim of the non-Buddhists;
the logicians do not understand.
There, form too exists;
where there is no form there is no view;
since that is absent, there is no tenet,
there is no vehicle and no destiny.
Consciousness, arisen from habitual tendencies,
endowed with the sense faculties:
of its eight kinds, one part
does not grasp at the time of the instant.

Just as form does not come into play,
so neither do the faculties and their powers.
Therefore the Blessed One, too,
taught that the faculties and the rest are momentary.

If form has not become an object of conception,
how could it enter consciousness?
And if it has not entered consciousness,
how would saṃsāra come to be born?
That it comes into play the very moment it arises
is not what the Guide teaches.
The conceptualizing of things
stirs in beings without interruption.
The faculties and the objects of the faculties
belong not to the wise but to the foolish.
The childish grasp by way of names;
the noble, through names, are skilled in meaning.
In the six there is no appropriation;
what has appropriation is not taken up.
Free from the fault of existence,
the noble ones speak without drawing distinctions.
Logicians who have abandoned knowledge,
frightened by permanence and annihilation,
childish as they are, draw no distinction
regarding a self in the conditioned and the unconditioned.
In what is one there is giving;
in what is distinct, it does not exist either.
It is one together with mind,
and distinct from mentation and the rest.
When the giving proclaimed of mind and mental factors
is separated from appropriation,
how then is one
to understand it as one?
The object of what has appropriation,
by way of karma, life, agent and the like,
through modes of the similar and dissimilar,
they establish, though it does not exist.
Just as fire burns all at once
both the fuel and the burning,
so too the self with its appropriation:
why do the logicians not teach it?
Whether ever arisen or unarisen,

if mind is utterly luminous,
why do the logicians not make use
of the examples that establish a self?
Logicians who have abandoned the method,
deluded in the thicket of consciousness,
in their wish to speak of a self,
rush this way and that.
To be realized by individual self-awareness,
the self has the characteristic of purity.
That buddha-nature, the tathāgatagarbha,
is not the domain of logicians.
If one comes to know the distinction
between what is appropriated and what appropriates,
and the characteristics of the aggregates,
the wisdom of the method will arise.
What the non-Buddhists (tīrthikas) speak of
they conceive as something like an essence of the all-ground;
but the phenomena accompanying the self
they have not expounded.
When these are thoroughly distinguished,
when there is liberation and the seeing of truth,
the mind that purifies even the afflictions
to be abandoned by meditation and by seeing
is luminous by nature;
the tathāgatagarbha is virtuous.
The appropriation of sentient beings
is free of the finite and the infinite.
Just as, through cleansing, the color of gold,
gold ore and sugar
are seen, so likewise
is the sentient being in the aggregates.
There is no person and there are no aggregates;
the buddhas, whose wisdom is undefiled,
have meditated on what is ever peaceful;
in them I take refuge.
That the luminous nature of mind
is accompanied by the afflictions of mentation and the rest,

and by the self,
the supreme of speakers has taught.
Mind is luminous by nature;
what is other than it is beginningless.
The karma accumulated by these,
through it, the two become afflicted.
Because it is joined with beginningless,
adventitious afflictions,
the naturally luminous self is afflicted;
like cloth, it becomes pure.
Just as cloth, or likewise gold,
being stainless, is as though rid of faults,
endures and does not perish,
so is the faultless self.
In a drum, a conch or a lute,
some who are unskilled search
for the perfection of its sweet sound;
so it is with the person in the aggregates.
Treasures and jewels in the earth,
and likewise waters too,
though present, are not seen;
so it is with the person in the aggregates.
Mind and the host of mental factors,
and the qualities of the self, joined with the aggregates,
are not known by the unskilled;
so it is with the person in the aggregates.
Just as the child in a pregnant woman,
though present, is not seen,
so the self in the aggregates
is not seen by those who lack understanding.
Just as the lethal power in a drug,
and just as the fire in the firewood,
are not seen by those who do not know the method,
so it is with the person in the aggregates.
Though impermanence and emptiness
are present in things,
the unskilled do not see them;

so it is with the person in the aggregates.
The grounds, the masteries, the higher knowledges,
the supreme consecration,
and the distinctive meditative absorptions:
if there were no self, these would not exist.
When a destroyer comes along
and says, "If it exists, show it!",
the wise should instruct him,
"Show me your own conceptual thought!"
Those who harm the Buddha's Dharma,
holding views on the side of existence and non-existence,
proponents of no-self, one should not converse with;
they should be excluded from the formal acts of the monks.
Burning down the forest of no-self,
freed from the faults of the tīrthikas,
like the blazing fire at the end of time,
this teaching of the self blazes forth.
Treacle, honey and sugar,
butter, sesame and the like,
though each has its own taste,
are not truly known unless tasted.
Though the self in the aggregates one sees
is sought in five ways,
the unskilled do not see it;
the wise, seeing it, are liberated.
Through examples such as spells
mind cannot be understood;
in what, for what reason and for what purpose
the composites exist is not understood.
Phenomena differ in their characteristics;
mind alone is not grasped.
Into causelessness and non-occurrence
the logicians fall in fault.
The yogin who follows and observes the mind
does not see mind by means of minds.
If the seeing arises from appearance,
from what cause does appearance arise?

I am of the Kātyāyana lineage,
come forth from the Pure Abodes;
I teach sentient beings the Dharma
that leads to the city of nirvāṇa.
This is the ancient path;
I and the tathāgatas
in three thousand sūtras
have thoroughly explained nirvāṇa.
In the desire realm and the formless realm
one does not become a fully awakened buddha;
in Akaniṣṭha of the form realm,
free of desire, you awaken.
The cause of death is not the object;
the cause is being bound to the object.
By wisdom the afflictions are slain;
this is the sword's edge of discipline.
How do selfless phenomena,
like illusions and the rest, come to exist or not exist?
To the childish they appear as real;
how could selflessness itself not exist?
Because of what is made and what is unmade,
a cause does not bring anything into operation.
All these are unborn;
the childish do not know it.
The causes are unborn;
those are made by conditions.

If those two are not produced,
how can they be imagined through causes?
As prior, as subsequent, and as simultaneous:
thus the dialecticians teach causes.
Through appearance, disciple, substance and the like,
they explain the arising of things.

Through marks produced by conditioning
a buddha is not one who bears the marks;
those are the qualities of a wheel-turning monarch,
and by them a buddha is not described.

The mark of a buddha is wisdom,
utterly free of the faults of views,
realized by the vision of individual self-awareness,
utterly destroying every fault.

For the deaf, the mute, the blind, the one-eyed,
the aged with wrinkled skin,
and children in particular,
there is no pure conduct.

By hidden, manifest, and divine
marks one is a wheel-turning monarch.
Some with manifest marks go forth;
the other two are heedless.

Vyāsa, Kaṇāda, Ṛṣabha,
Kapila, and the leader of the Śākyas:
after I have passed into nirvāṇa,
these and others will appear.
A hundred years after my nirvāṇa,
Vyāsa and likewise the Bhārata,
the Pāṇḍavas and the Kauravas;
after the Nandas, the Mauryas will appear.
After the Mauryas, the Nandas and the Guptas
come the basest of barbarian kings.
After the barbarians, turmoil with weapons;
after the weapons, the age of strife.
At the end of the age of strife
the world will not cultivate the true Dharma.

When these and others have passed,
beings revolve like a wheel.
Because fire and the suns come together,
the desire realm is burned up;
and later, where the world had stood,
it becomes a place of divine substance.
The four castes, the lords of men,
the sages, and the Dharma as well,
the Vedas, Dharma-giving, sacrifice,

and the forms of Dharma will come forth.

Through tales, protective rites and the like,
through bare texts, explanations and commentaries,
and through "Thus have I heard" and the rest,
the world will become utterly deluded.

Having made it well and cut it,
one should apply color over it.
With blue, with cow dung, with mud and the like,
the cloth should be thoroughly marked.
The body adorned with these robes,
the marks of the non-Buddhists (tīrthikas) abandoned,
the yogin expounds the teaching:
that is the banner of the Buddha.
One should drink water strained through a filter
and tie on a waist cord;
at the proper time, as is fitting,
one eats alms food, avoiding the low.

Divine substance comes from the heavens;
the other two come from humans.
Perfect with precious marks,
a lord of beings born as a god,
teaching the Dharma that benefits toward heaven,
he holds sway over the four continents.
Having ruled the continents for a very long time,
through craving he comes to ruin.

The age of the immature and the age when refuge arose,
likewise the twofold age and the age of strife:
I and others belong to the perfect age,
the Śākya Lion to the age of strife.
Siddhārtha, the son of the Śākyas,
Viṣṇu, Vyāsa, Īśvara,
and other non-Buddhists like them
will appear when I have passed into nirvāṇa.

"Thus have I heard" and the rest
are the discourse of the Śākya Lion;

tales and what happened in former times
will be held to be Vyāsa's.
Viṣṇu and Īśvara as well
will proclaim a creator.
From my nirvāṇa onward
such things as these will come about.

My mother is Vasumatī,
my father the brahmin Prajāpati;
I am of the Kātyāyana clan,
and my name is Viraja, the Victor.
My father, grandfather, and I myself
were born in the land of Campā;
his name is Somagupta,
and he was born of the lunar clan.
Having entered upon liberation and practiced austerities,
having explained the ways in a thousand forms,
having empowered Mahāmati
and made the prophecy, I pass into nirvāṇa.

Mati will bestow the Dharma,
and through the Dharma will give it to Mekhala and some others;
because Mekhala's disciples are weak,
at the end of the eon it will perish.

Kāśyapa and Krakucchanda,
the pure guide Kanakamuni,
I, Viraja, and others:
all these are victors of the perfect age.
After them, in the perfect age,
a guide called Mati,
a teacher of the five knowables,
a great hero, will appear.
Not in the other two; no protector has arisen there,
and in the later age of strife too
no protector of the world will appear.
In the perfect age they attain complete awakening.

So that it is not stolen and can be recognized,
uncut, with its hem,
with patterns like the eyes of a peacock's tail
one should draw designs on the upper robe.
Between one eye and the next
make the measure two or three finger-widths.
If it is drawn otherwise,
even the immature will become attached.

Always quench the fire of attachment,
and bathe with the water of wisdom;
diligently, through yoga,
keeping the three junctures and the three restraints.

When arrows, stones, wood and the like
are set in motion by throwing and so on,
when one rises, another falls;
so it is with virtue and nonvirtue.

The single is not many;
because their characteristics differ, it is found nowhere.
All who receive are like the wind;
those who give are like a field.

If the single were to become many,
all would be unmade;
and if made, it would perish.
This is the way of the dialecticians.
It is like a lamp or a seed;
since they are alike, how could it become many?
"In such a way it becomes many":
that is the way of the dialecticians.

From sesame no beans will grow;
rice does not come from the cause of barley.
Wheat and the various kinds of grain:
how could the single become many?

Pāṇini the grammarian,
Akṣapāda, Bṛhaspati,
Brahmā, Garga,
and the founder of the Lokāyatas will appear.

Kātyāyana the composer of sūtras,
Yājñavalkya likewise,
Bhudhuka, and the astrologers
will appear in the age of strife.

For the world that has made merit,
Bali, the glory of creatures, will appear,
the protector of all dharmas,
King Bali, the giver of the earth.

Vālmīki and Masurākṣa,
Kauṭilya and Āśvalāyana,
and Ṛṣabha too, of great and pure glory,
will appear in times to come.
Siddhārtha, the son of the Śākyas,
Bhūtānta and Pañcaśikha,
Vāgbali and Medhāvin
will appear in a later time.

When I dwell in the forest,
Brahmā will give me
a staff, a skin,
a girdle and a water pot.
A great one endowed with yoga,
the sage called the Stainless,
will become a teacher who expounds liberation.
Saying, "This is the banner of the Sage,"
Brahmā, with hundreds of Brahmās
and with many gods,
will cast it down to me from the lofty sky,
and then that lord himself will vanish.
Indra together with the gods,
Virūḍhaka and the others,
will offer me in my forest dwelling
various robes and all the alms bowls.

What the proponents of non-arising hold to be a cause,
whether it has arisen or is yet to arise,
they establish as the unarisen;

it is spoken of as mere words.

The cause that makes that mind arise
is ignorance.
As long as forms are not known,
for that long does it remain?
The very instant it has perished,
other minds arise.
If form does not endure in time,
on what object do they focus as they arise?
The mind that passes from one thing to another
arises from a mistaken cause.
If that is not established at all,
how is it known to perish in an instant?

The meditative absorption of yogis,
gold, the relics of the Victor,
and the celestial palaces of the Ābhāsvara abode
are not destroyed by worldly causes.
The abidings and the dharmas attained,
the perfect wisdom of the buddhas,
monkhood and the attainments of knowledge:
how can these be seen as momentary?
How are the forms of illusions,
of cities of gandharvas and the like, momentary?
The elements do not become elements;
in beings they hold no elements.

Mind arises from the cause of ignorance
and has been accumulated since beginningless time.
The logicians imagine
that in arising it perishes and is wholly connected.

The doctrine of the Sāṃkhyas is twofold:
transformations come from the principal (pradhāna);
when the principal exists, the result exists;
they establish the result as its very self.
In the principal and in the operation of entities
they proclaim the distinctions of the qualities.

The variety of causes and results
is absent in transformation.

Just as pure mercury
is not tainted by stains,
so too the abode of the ālaya
of all embodied beings is pure.
The smell of asafoetida and of garlic,
what is seen in the child of a pregnant woman,
the taste in salt and the like:
why do they not become like seeds?

The same, different,
likewise both, and neither:
there is no cause for existence;
in the conditioned it does not exist, yet it is not nonexistent.
The self exists just as the horse does,
the aggregates being devoid of the nature of the cow.
As for the conditioned and the unconditioned,
their nature is inexpressible and unutterable.

Seeing wrongly in terms of scripture and reasoning,
stained by the views of logic,
without analysis they speak of a self.
It is not without cause, and it does not exist elsewhere.
Theirs is an accumulation of faults;
one does not contemplate the aggregates as a self.
Identity and difference from them
the logicians do not understand.
Just as a reflection appears
in mirrors, in water and in eyes,
free of being one or different,
so is the person in relation to the aggregates.

Meditation, thorough meditation, and the meditator;
the path, the truths and seeing:
when these three are thoroughly cultivated,
one is liberated from wrong views.
Like lightning that perishes as soon as it is seen,

like the wheel in the opening of a house,
so too, regarding the changes of all phenomena,
do not conceptualize as fools do.

Nirvāṇa through the absence of entities
bewilders the minds of fools.
Because there is seeing things just as they are,
and the seeing of the noble ones,
one should cultivate a transformation
free of arising and perishing,
rid of the existence and nonexistence of entities,
free of characteristic and the characterized.
Free of the talk of non-Buddhists,
having abandoned name and shape,
cultivate the transformation
of the bases of inner views.

Through contact and torment
come the bodies of gods and of hell beings;
for them there is no intermediate existence;
they are produced by consciousness.
Those who arise in the intermediate existence,
born of womb, egg, warmth, moisture and so forth,
like the many various beings,
contemplate as going and as destinies.

The talk of the views of non-Buddhists,
devoid of scripture and reasoning,
which brings the side of affliction and decline,
the wise do not engage in.

First, from appropriation,
one discerns distinctions by analyzing the self.
To discern distinctions without analysis
is to discern the features of a barren woman's son.

Beings seen through miraculous power
are beyond the fleshly eye and wisdom;
the form of all embodied beings
is abandoned in the aggregate of formations.

Turning good and bad in color,
distinguished as liberated and not liberated,
one clearly sees the abiding of formations
that belong to the formations of divine substance.
Those with form at the junctures of destinies
are not the domain of logicians.
I have passed beyond the domain of humans,
but the other, base logicians have not.

If there is no self and yet mind arises,
from what does it arise?
Like a river, a lamp or a seed:
why is its arising not explained thus?
When consciousness has not arisen,
there is no ignorance and so forth.
Without that, how could consciousness
come to arise as a continuum?

The three times, the timeless,
and the inexpressible: these five kinds
the logicians declare
to be what is called the Buddha.

Knowledge that arises with formations as its cause
is not expressed by formations;
knowledge accomplished by formations
is held to be included among formations.
"Because this exists, this arises":
this teaches, making it clear,
that conditions have no cause.
Since that is absent, there is no agent.

Wind moves fire and clouds,
but it does not produce them.
If, once moved, they are stilled by it,
how are beings brought about?
The conditioned and the unconditioned
are said to be free of appropriation.
How then do fools imagine

that fire is produced in it?
If for people fire arises
through mutual strength and power,
then since beings are to be examined like fire,
by whom have they been brought forth?

The cause of the aggregates and the assemblages of sense sources
is mentation and the rest.
Without a self, always like a house of many guests,
it operates together with mind.
These two are always luminous,
free of cause and result.

They are not established as fire is established;
The dialecticians do not understand.
Mind and sentient beings are nirvāṇa,
Luminous by their very nature;
Through the faults of mentation and the rest,
The afflictions, like space, are not different.
Like the elephant's bed and the rest, it existed before;
It is stained by the views of the non-Buddhists (tīrthikas),
Veiled by the mental consciousness,
And refined by fire and the like.
By that one sees correctly, just as it is,
And having seen, one destroys the afflictions too.
Fully abandoning the examples of what is dense,
These are the domain of the noble ones.
By distinguishing knowing and the knowable,
Those two are not to be imagined as other.
The foolish do not understand this,
And speak about what cannot be expressed.
Just as children take a drum made of sandalwood
To be something else,
So bad dialecticians take
The knowledge that is like sandalwood and aloeswood.

Having risen, one does not take food afterward.
With bowl, dwelling and felt mat,
Free of faults such as a changing face,

One should partake of food in purity.

Whoever weighs this way with reasoning,
Faithful, a diligent yogin free of conceptual thought,
Who has come to rely on the meaning of non-abiding,
Should practice the modes of the Dharma as one treats gold.

The fool conceives conditions as possible or impossible;
That is the net of bad views, together with its stains.
Turning away from attachment, aversion and delusion,
The one without attachment is empowered by the Buddha's hand.

The non-Buddhists are corrupted by the position of a cause;
Others again are confused by conditions;
Others, since things arise without a cause,
Hold to the meaningless, which is annihilation.

Mentation, consciousness,
And the transformation of maturation:
Mentation arises from the ground of all,
Consciousness arises from mentation.
From the ground of all, every mind
Arises like waves.
All arise from the cause of habitual tendencies,
And arise in accordance with conditions.
Distinct moments are linked by connection;
One's own mind grasps at objects.
The characteristic of shape, completely pure,
Arises from mentation, the eye and the rest.
Linked together from beginningless time,
The appearance of objects arises from habitual tendencies.
Whatever appears is the appearance of mind.
Reversing the views of the non-Buddhists,
Arising from its cause, and otherness too,
Taking that as their object, come into operation.
From that, views and cognitions
Enter fully into saṃsāra.

Things are like dreams and illusions,
Like the cities of the gandharvas,

Like a mirage and the moon in water;
Meditate on your own conceptuality.
In the mode of engagement is suchness;
Correct wisdom is its basis.
The illusion-like samādhi, the Heroic Progress and the rest,
Other meditative absorptions,
The superknowledges and the powers,
The illusion-like wisdom,
And empowerment by the Tathāgata
Are attained on entering the grounds.
When one sees beings as conceptuality,
Then the mind turns back,
And one attains the Joyous ground,
The ground of a buddha, and the grounds.
Because the basis has been transformed,
Like a jewel of many colors,
One acts for the benefit of sentient beings,
Just like a reflection in water.
Free from the positions of existence and nonexistence,
Free from duality and nonduality,
When one has passed beyond the śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas,
One comes to the seven grounds.
By seeing one's own individual Dharma,
The true ground is purified,
And the Great Vehicle, which has abandoned
The outsiders, the non-Buddhists, shall be taught.
When one is fully transformed in conceptuality,
Death, transmigration and destruction are abandoned;
Like a jewel of hare's hair,
The way is also taught to the liberated.
Just as words rest upon words,
So too, if reasoning rests on reasoning;
Therefore it is the reasoning of reasoning.
Do not conceive of it otherwise!
The eye, karma, craving,
And ignorance likewise are improper;
Name and form and the minds,

And the turbid mind as well, are likewise.

The Great Vehicle sūtra called The Noble Descent into Laṅkā, as much of it as there is, is complete.

Gö Chödrup, a follower of the tradition of the Blessed One, translated it from a Chinese text and finalized it.

Translator's Notes

• Rāvaṇa: the Tibetan name used here literally means "Screamer," the standard rendering of Rāvaṇa, who in the verses also names himself Daśagrīva. The line rendered "graced by Śuka and Sāraṇa" reads literally "adorned by parrot and sāra"; it is taken as Śuka (translated as "parrot") and Sāraṇa (transliterated), Rāvaṇa's ministers in the Rāmāyaṇa tradition. The line "not speaking of it openly to him" is obscure in the Tibetan and is translated literally. "Kapriyaṅgu" in the description of the ochre cloth is transliterated in the Tibetan and its exact sense is uncertain. In the list of the bodhisattvas' qualities, "masteries" renders the term otherwise used for empowerment, here in the sense of the bodhisattva masteries (vaśitā).
• "He abode in the stirring of conceptuality" renders the Tibetan as it stands; the sense in context (after the transformation of the basis) would rather be abiding where conceptuality no longer operates, and the Sanskrit is commonly understood that way, so a negation may have been lost in transmission. "The three continua" is rendered literally; it is usually understood as the three continua of mind, mentation and consciousness, or as the defilement-, karma- and birth-continua. "The Dharma that is seen" means the Dharma realized in this very life.
• "Thorough transformation" renders □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□, likely reflecting the Laṅkāvatāra's notion of the transformation of the basis (parāvṛtti). The phrase rendered "a miraculous power that has turned away from characteristics" is syntactically difficult in the Tibetan; the rendering follows the most natural reading.
• The phrase rendered "You whose crown sways, ask me without delay" is uncertain; the Tibetan wording is terse and could also be read as a description of Rāvaṇa's manner. The "tathāgatas in their essential nature" contrasts with the "emanations conjured by magical power", corresponding to the Sanskrit distinction between the fundamental buddhas and their magically created emanations. The three grounds named are the eighth, ninth and tenth bodhisattva grounds.
• "Differences of pleasant form, of speech and of movement" renders a compressed Tibetan phrase that literally reads "differences of form of pleasure, of expression, and of going"; the exact sense of the first member is uncertain. "Never attained a body" translates the Tibetan literally; it means that these things lack any substantial reality.
• The phrase rendered "together with the bodhisattva Mati" could also be read as "together with bodhisattvas of intelligence"; the Tibetan is ambiguous. The term rendered "masteries" in the question on attainments is here taken as vaśitā, which fits the sūtra context better than the glossary's "empowerment". The syllables rendered "ever" in "Is ever like a dream" are read as an equivalent of "constantly", since the written form is unclear.
• The verse lines beginning "Best of speakers, tell me!" and similar are the questioner's (Mahāmati's) requests; in the Buddha's reply the refrain □□□□□□□□□□□ recurs, here rendered "this you asked me" as he restates the questions. □□□□□□ here is plainly an epithet of the Buddha, who hears and answers the questions, so it is rendered "the great god" without a gloss

as Śiva. □□□□□□□□ ("strange ones") is rendered "heterodox ones," following the sense of the corresponding Sanskrit list. □□□□□ ("drawings") may reflect a reading of Sanskrit citra where the original intended citta ("mind"). The phrase "king of transformation" and "king of the imageless" is translated literally and is obscure. □□□□□□□ is an unidentified unit or numeral, given phonetically as "shudok." The weight units ri, nam, zho and sang are Tibetan measures standing in for Indian ones and are kept in phonetics. "Peppercorn" for □□□□□□□□ (Zanthoxylum) is approximate. "Flesh-eaters" (□□□) is taken here as the general class of meat-eaters rather than specifically piśācas.

• "Statement" renders □□□ (Skt. pada), the term for the hundred and eight propositions. The verse line on the lowly and Akaniṣṭha is terse in the Tibetan. It is rendered literally, and the sense is that buddhahood is attained in Akaniṣṭha rather than in the desire realm. The phrase rendered "the essence and the classes" (□□□□□□□□□□□□□□) is obscure, and the rendering is tentative.

• "Characteristic of its own kind" renders rigs kyi mtshan nyid (Skt. jātilakṣaṇa), the consciousness's own original nature, as distinct from its functioning and its karmic aspect. The pair "the lowest and Akaniṣṭha" plays on Akaniṣṭha, the name of the highest heaven, which literally means "not the lowest". In the pair "gods and non-gods", □□□□□□□□□□ is taken in its literal negating sense to match the pattern of the list, rather than as "asuras".

• "The domain where the sons of the buddhas pass beyond" renders the terse □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□; the Sanskrit tradition reads it as the domain of progressing through the stages of the buddhas' sons (the bodhisattva grounds). The phrase "in which the conditions for conceptuality do not return" is a literal rendering of a compressed expression whose exact construal is uncertain.

• "Bodhisattvas endowed with that activity": the Tibetan reads "endowed with arising and activity." The Sanskrit appears to say these bodhisattvas are free from the activity of arising. I have translated the Tibetan as it stands.

• Several verses form a dialogue between Mahāmati and the Blessed One; the Tibetan marks no speakers, so quotation marks indicate the alternation (the humble verbs and "Great Sage, please explain" identify Mahāmati's questions). "Like a lame donkey" follows the Tibetan simile as it stands; it describes how the yogin leaves behind the characteristics of mind, wisdom and gnosis.

• The final sentence follows the Tibetan, which says that "in them too there is no space." The Sanskrit is commonly read as "nor is space absent from them." Mahāmati's objection is likewise kept as a statement, as the Tibetan has it, although the Sanskrit frames it as a rhetorical question. "The natures" in Mahāmati's request refers to the three natures, here unnumbered.

• The terms rendered "buddha of natural outflow" (niṣyandabuddha), "buddha who flows forth in accordance with the nature of reality" (dharmatāniṣyandabuddha) and "buddha of the nature of reality" (dharmatābuddha) follow the sūtra's distinctive classification of buddhas. Here □□□□□ is rendered "continuum" (the mind-stream), not "tantra". The phrase □□□□□□□□□, "together with a person who wields it", is compressed in the Tibetan and seems to mean the illusionist's human effort working with the spell. The sentence about the illusory person in the paragraph beginning "Furthermore" is syntactically dense; its rendering follows the Tibetan word order as closely as sense allows.

• The text reads □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□, which makes no sense; it is translated as □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□, "unconditioned (unmade) space," the standard example paired with nirvāṇa and cessation. The phrase rendered "in which inconceivable habitual tendencies are transformed and which is free from death and transmigration" is grammatically ambiguous in Tibetan. It may also be read as "free from the death and transmigration that is the inconceivable transformation of habitual tendencies." That reading echoes the doctrine of "inconceivable transformational death." The translation follows the Tibetan word order.

• The opening argument is compressed in the Tibetan; it is rendered closely as it stands, as a hypothetical reductio against the tīrthikas' inferred permanence. "The wisdom of individual self-awareness that has become the all-base" follows the Tibetan literally; the point is the transformed all-base consciousness, which the śrāvakas do not take as their basis.
• 'Dod chen pa is rendered "icchantika," the standard Sanskrit equivalent in this sūtra. In the sentence on the dependent nature, the Tibetan reads "abiding and non-apprehension" (gnas shing mi dmigs pa); the extant Sanskrit has "basis and object" (āśraya, ālambana), so mi dmigs is taken as a slip for dmigs and translated as "basis and object."
• The "two natures" in the opening verse are the imputed and the dependent natures, contrasted with the perfected nature. In "devoid of mind, mentation and consciousness, of the five dharmas and of the natures," the natures are understood as the three natures (svabhāva). The heading "The Noble Descent into Laṅkā, the third fascicle" marks a fascicle division in the Tibetan text and has been kept. The sentence defining denial is terse in the Tibetan; it is rendered according to its most natural sense: when what was superimposed is not found, failure to discern leads to rejecting everything.
• In the verse, the Tibetan "a body that is an assembly" and the word rendered "fashioned" are obscure; the Sanskrit of this verse is generally understood to speak of an emanation body free of activity and conditioning. The Tibetan is translated as it stands.
• In the list of attributes the non-Buddhists ascribe to the self, the Tibetan as written reads "without permanence" (rtag pa med pa). This contradicts the argument, which turns on both doctrines calling their principle permanent, and the corresponding Sanskrit has "permanent." I have translated "permanent" as the evident reading.

The clause "this is because there is a cause of distinct characteristics" is rendered as the Tibetan stands. The Sanskrit is commonly understood with a negation here, but the Tibetan has none.
• The term rendered "masteries" in the description of the mind-made body is the Tibetan word glossed elsewhere as empowerment; here it stands in the standard list of powers, masteries and superknowledges and corresponds to Sanskrit vaśitā, so "masteries" is used. The verse items are technical: "the Principal" is the Sāṃkhya pradhāna (primal matter), "the Lord" is Īśvara, and "the Creator" is the agent posited by other schools. The Tibetan does not give a separate explanation of the fourth quality; the account of the third quality runs directly into the aspiration toward the noble ones' personal wisdom, and this is translated as it stands.
• In Mahāmati's first request the Tibetan has a double negative, literally "would not become non-conceiving of all things as arising gradually and all at once"; the sense required by context, and attested in the Sanskrit, is that they would not conceive of things as arising gradually or simultaneously, and it is translated accordingly. In the verse "Exist nowhere and at no time," the syllable written gag is read as gang/gar ("anywhere"), an evident copyist's slip. Tibetan ma red is read as ma rnyed, "not found." The six causes follow this text's own list, which differs from the Abhidharma list of six causes.
• In the dream-speech clause, the Tibetan "the absence of the object of realization" is taken as "the absence of the object once one has awakened," with "realization" in its sense of waking. The animals in the simile are rendered as made of clay. The Tibetan as written has a word meaning "frightening." A similar-looking word meaning "clay" plainly fits the toy animals used to lure children, and that evident reading is translated here.
• The unstated subject of "they will set up the components of the three means of valid cognition" is supplied from context as the non-Buddhists of the preceding passage. The list of graspings translates the standard Sanskrit series ātman, poṣa, puruṣa and pudgala: self, sustainer, cosmic man, person.

• In the echo simile the Tibetan reads "name" (□□□), which makes no sense among the causes of an echo; it is read as "person" (□□), as the Sanskrit parallel also has. In the passage on the hundred and eight nonappearances, the phrase rendered "gradually establish" reads literally "establish the final ground"; it is taken as "gradually" in line with the Sanskrit krameṇa. "The three continua" translates □□□□□□□□□□, here meaning streams of continuity, not tantras.
• The line rendered "the divine hands of the buddhas" reads literally "the hands of the buddha-gods." The Sanskrit parallel speaks of the buddhas' hands consecrating the yogin's head. "Blessing" renders the Tibetan for adhiṣṭhāna, the empowering sustenance of the buddhas.
• The phrase rendered "has not taught it in a manner of his own" is obscure in the Tibetan (it contains the word □□□□□□, "foolish"); the rendering follows the general sense of the argument, in which Mahāmati objects that the Buddha's account of causation does not differ from that of the tīrthikas. The "distinguished ground" in Mahāmati's question refers to the tenth ground, Cloud of Dharma, where the empowerment of the hand is conferred.
• The name of the world-system has been translated from the Tibetan as "Unblinking, Sweet Fragrance," since a Sanskrit form could not be confirmed with certainty. The word rendered "ordinary" translates a Tibetan term meaning something common or of little worth. The noble ones regard delusion only as such, not as an object of noble wisdom. The exact sense of the term in this sentence is somewhat uncertain. "Delusion" translates the Tibetan for error, Sanskrit bhrānti.
• "Negative propensities" renders gnas ngan len (Skt. dauṣṭhulya), the latent dysfunction of body and mind. In the sentence beginning "Mahāmati, an illusion arises through the power of another person's spell," the Tibetan has no explicit subject before ni; the context and the parallel Sanskrit show that "illusion" (sgyu ma) is meant, and it has been supplied.
• In the first verse, the third line reads in this Tibetan "like what comes from causes and the rest" (rgyu las sogs). The Sanskrit of the Laṅkāvatāra here reads "like an illusion and the rest" (māyādi). This suggests an original sgyu ma that became rgyu, but the line is translated as it stands.

The statement that elephants, horses and other animals that go upon the ground are called the "group of phrases" rests on a Sanskrit pun. The word pada means both "phrase" and "foot" or "footprint," so padakāya also means "a set of tracks."

Here, lung ston and lung bstan mean "to answer" a question, not "to prophesy." The four kinds of answer are, traditionally, the direct answer, the answer by distinguishing, the answer by counter-question, and setting the question aside.
• The phrase rendered "has at most seven more lives in existence" reads □□□□□□□□□□□, which is obscure as written. The translation follows the evident sense, a stream-enterer of the lowest kind with up to seven more births, which is also the standard doctrine. Here □□□□□□ (gati) is rendered "course", in the sense of a path of progress, rather than "destiny".
• In the final paragraph □□□□ is rendered "reasons" rather than "cause," since it stands alongside thesis and example in a list of the elements of logical argument (hetu as logical reason). The list of sensual acts (fist, palm, "joining the lower bodies") is obscure in the Tibetan and is rendered literally.
• In the final paragraph, □□□□□□□□ is rendered "the masteries" (Skt. vaśitā), the bodhisattva's powers of control, rather than "empowerments," since the context lists attainments of the higher grounds. "Gone Far" is the seventh bodhisattva ground (Dūraṅgamā).
• In the list the eighth item is written "rig pa" (knowledge), but in its explanation it is "rigs pa" (reasoning), which fits the definition and the Sanskrit yukti; I have rendered "reasoning" in both places. The word "rgyud" in this passage means "continuum" or "stream," not "tantra."

• In the verse "its cutting off is the domain of the noble ones," the Tibetan verb is read as "cutting off" in line with the Sanskrit of this verse; it could also be read as "explaining it." In the verse on the perfected entity, the Tibetan is ambiguous and could also be read as "if the perfected entity is existent or nonexistent." The reading "if there is no perfected entity" follows the sense of the Sanskrit.
• The phrase rendered "when they have abandoned all the habitual tendencies of faults" reads □□□□□□□□□ in the Tibetan, which does not construe. It is taken as a slip for □□□□□□□□ ("when ... of faults"), which fits the sense and the following clause. In this sūtra, □□□ in the mind-made body passage and verses is rendered "mastery" (vaśitā) rather than "empowerment," as the context requires.
• In "particular and general" the Tibetan seems to lack the noun "characteristics" after "general". I supplied it from the sense of the passage and from the Sanskrit parallel. The name □□□□□□ is rendered Māndhātṛ following the Sanskrit parallel (rājā māndhātā), although the usual Tibetan for Māndhātṛ is different. "Death and transference of inconceivable transformation" refers to the subtle death of the noble ones beyond ordinary rebirth (acintyapariṇāmikī cyuti).
• The phrase "they conceive of an escape where there is no escape" renders □□□□□□□ in the sense of release or escape (Skt. niḥsaraṇa), as the parallel Sanskrit indicates. In "not apprehended as internal or external," the Tibetan reads □ ("I"), taken as a slip for □□ ("internal"), matching the preceding sentence.
• "Destroyer" renders the Tibetan for the Sanskrit vainā́sika, the nihilist who denies everything, continuing the discussion of the preceding piece. "The way of the established truth" and "the way of teaching" render the paired terms siddhānta-naya and deśanā-naya. The line rendered "being inverted, they do not see" could also be read as "they do not see its reversal."
• "The supreme brahman" renders □□□□□□□□□□□□; here □□□□□ most likely stands for the neuter brahma, the pure or holy state, rather than the god Brahmā. The phrase □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□, rendered "what has come down from the past," is obscure in this context.
• □□□ is rendered "word" throughout (Skt. ruta, the spoken sound or letter), in contrast to □□□, "meaning" (artha). In "the characteristic of accumulating," □□□□□□□□□□□ is read as "accumulating" (Skt. upacaya), in contrast to □□□□□, "diminishing" (apacaya), rather than as "and so forth." The "three coming together" refers to the meeting of sense faculty, object and consciousness.
• The verse line on śrāvakas, "those who have attained the dharma of conceptuality," is translated as the Tibetan reads; Sanskrit witnesses and commentators read the verse differently, and its exact sense is debated. "Fields" in the verse beginning "In the distinction of fields and patience" follows the Tibetan, which may reflect a different Sanskrit reading. The ornament rendered "pendants" is uncertain; the Sanskrit parallel appears to list a svastika-shaped ornament. "Connection" renders the term used throughout this section for the binding linkage (saṃdhi) between dharmas and attachment.
• "Linkage" renders the Tibetan term corresponding to Sanskrit saṃdhi, here the binding or attachment that ties beings to concepts and, in the rebirth context, links them into the destinies. "The meeting of the three" refers to the conjunction of sense faculty, object, and consciousness. One occurrence of the name Mahāmati is misspelled in the Tibetan and was read as Mahāmati.
• "Utter solitude" renders □□□□□□□□□□□□ (Skt. vivikta), the isolation or freedom from conceptual constructs that the Laṅkāvatāra associates with the realization of noble wisdom. In the verses, "ground of all" renders □□□□□□□ (ālaya). The line "To propose that all things are unborn does not hold" renders □□□□□□, literally "is not stable"; the sense is that the proposition is not established.

• "Mere cognition" renders rnam par rig pa tsam (vijñaptimātra). The verse line "Through non-otherness and lack of characteristics" is terse in the Tibetan and its exact construction is uncertain. The final quotation continues into the next piece.
• The Tibetan here reads □□□□□□□□□□ ("absence of depletion") in the definition "is destruction"; the sense requires plain □□□□, "depletion," and it is translated so. The phrase □□□□□□□□□□□□□□ in the list of sufferings is rendered simply as "sorrow"; □□□□□□□□ looks like a scribal intrusion. The phrase "of a hundred thousand" applied to the Lokāyata is kept as literally as the Tibetan allows; it apparently refers to the vast extent of that body of teaching.
• Lokāyata is the Indian materialist or "worldly" school of argument; its adherent is rendered Lokāyatika. "Material things" renders the Tibetan for Sanskrit āmiṣa, worldly gain or carnal enjoyment, contrasted with Dharma. The speaker of the line "Is not whatever teaches the unestablished itself Lokāyata?" is not marked in the Tibetan; it is taken here as the brahmin's interjection. In the list of what is Lokāyata, the single word rendered "fixation" is terse and its exact sense is uncertain. "Caressing" in the list of material things is tentative.
• Here □□□□□□, earlier rendered Indra, stands for the creator god Īśvara in the Sanskrit parallel (īśvara as independent agent), so it is rendered "the Lord (Īśvara)". In the list of nirvāṇa theories, "seeing signs and longing for bliss" follows the Tibetan as written; the Sanskrit parallel speaks of longing for the bliss of signlessness. "The six qualities" refers to the six measures of statecraft (ṣāḍguṇya).
• In "all effects would also become tathāgatas," the Tibetan reads □□□□□□□□□□□□□, where □□□□□ ordinarily means "we." The rendering "all effects" follows the evident sense of the argument, namely that if the Tathāgata were a made thing, every made effect would be a tathāgata. A reading such as "we effects" is possible but unlikely.
• "If he were not distinct from the aggregates": the Tibetan as written reads "if he were not one with the aggregates," which contradicts the argument (identity with produced aggregates would entail impermanence); the evident sense, matching the Sanskrit, is translated. Similarly, "because a distinction in length is seen, they are not different" is rendered as written, though the Sanskrit parallel says such a distinction shows difference. In the verse "is not to be conceived as nonexistent," the Tibetan reads "impermanent," evidently a slip for the near-identical "should not be conceived," which the context requires. In the sentence about the Buddha's many names, the Tibetan lacks the negative of the Sanskrit parallel (that the childish do not know these as the Tathāgata's names); it is translated as it stands. The lists of synonyms (hand, body, earth, sky) render Sanskrit synonym sets with English equivalents.
• The Tibetan reads that the childish "grasp" or "understand" (□□□□□□□□□□) the Tathāgata through minds fallen into the two extremes. The Sanskrit parallel has a negation ("do not understand"), but the Tibetan is translated as it stands.

The names in the first list are given in their Sanskrit forms following the Sanskrit parallel: □□□□□□□□ is Rāma, □□□□□□□□□□ is Vyāsa, □□□□□□□□ is Bali, □□□□□□□□ is Bhūtānta, and □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□ is Ariṣṭanemi. "The ten masteries" renders □□□□□□□ (the ten vaśitā).
• "Cessation not brought about by analysis" renders the Abhidharma unconditioned dharma apratisaṃkhyānirodha. In Mahāmati's final argument the Tibetan reads "my doctrine"; contextually it seems to mean the doctrine as Mahāmati is construing it (the Buddha's teaching seen as indistinct from the tīrthikas'), and it is rendered "if, as I say, the doctrine has no distinction." "Illusory man" here translates the ordinary word for person in the phrase "magical man," not the Sāṃkhya puruṣa.
• "Solitude" renders □□□□□□ (Skt. vivikta), the isolation or voidness of things from imagined nature. The line "External things are not nonentities" follows the Tibetan literally; the Sanskrit parallel speaks of neither external existence of things nor grasping by mind, and the Tibetan

line is terse. In the verse on the lamp, the construal follows the sense of the Sanskrit, in which dependent connection would reveal substances as a lamp does. The quoted verse at the end continues into the next piece, where the quotation is closed.

• The phrase rendered "impermanence itself does not cease" is terse in the Tibetan ("does not itself engage/come into play"); the rendering follows the evident sense of the argument. The paragraph on the "impermanence of shape" echoes the earlier listed view that "form itself is impermanent"; the Tibetan here reads "shape," and this is kept as written.

• The phrase rendered "even the person of their discourse, which was never established in the first place" is obscure in the Tibetan, and the sense is uncertain. On the seventh ground, the Tibetan leaves the subject of "absorption is entered moment of mind by moment of mind" unstated, and the passage could refer either to bodhisattvas or to śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas; I have kept it impersonal. "The first ground and the sixth" follows the Tibetan literally; it may be meant as the range from the first through the sixth grounds.

• Maheśvara here names the highest abode at the summit of the form realm (associated in this sūtra with Akaniṣṭha and the final ground), not the god Śiva as such. In the verses, "abodes" renders the term for the stages of dwelling (vihāra). The phrase "the bliss of delight in the masteries" follows the Tibetan, which seems to read a Sanskrit compound slightly differently from the extant Sanskrit, where it refers to consecration in the masteries.

• In the sentence about the accumulations for omniscient wisdom becoming pointless, the text reads "because of childish beings," which makes no sense here; the translation follows the evident reading "because of being made," which matches the argument that a made Tathāgata would render the accumulations pointless. In the final paragraph, the point is that such yogins mistakenly take the mere cessation of the seven consciousnesses for liberation.

• "The ten paths that are gateways of the truth of samādhi" follows the Tibetan as written. The corresponding Sanskrit is generally understood as the gateways of the bliss of samādhi, so the Tibetan "truth" may reflect a different reading of the source. "Intrinsic natures" translates the term for svabhāva, which in this context refers to the three natures of Yogācāra doctrine.

• "Correct wisdom" renders □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□ (samyagjñāna), one of the five dharmas. The phrase □□ is obscure. It is rendered here as "his nature wholly bound up with the limitless state," and that reading is tentative. In this non-ritual context, □□□ is taken as "masteries" (vaśitā) rather than "empowerment."

• "Pleasant" or "armor" renders the Tibetan literally as examples of names uttered; the corresponding Sanskrit has different examples, and the Tibetan words may reflect a misreading in the translator's source. In the passage on showing that buddhahood is easy to attain, the Tibetan as it stands has "the birth of tathāgatas is like the udumbara flower" without a negation; the sense in the Sanskrit is that tathāgatas are not as rare as the udumbara, and I have translated the Tibetan as written. "Clear and free of stains" reads the evident dwangs ("clear") for the written "dang sa." Here dbang is rendered "masteries" (vaśitā), not "empowerment," since it stands in a list with the powers and superknowledges.

• The phrase rendered "Otherwise" corresponds to Sanskrit anyatra, which can also mean "except"; the sense is that conceptuality operates only because one's own mind's appearances are not understood. In "to go forth is the meaning of going," the Sanskrit parallel reads "going means destruction"; the Tibetan here says that entering or going forth is what going means, and I have followed the Tibetan.

• The phrase describing the tathāgatagarbha as "not experiencing pleasure and pain yet accompanied by their cause" follows the Tibetan wording, which is compressed and could also be read as the tathāgatagarbha being the cause, together with which pleasure and pain are experienced. The Sanskrit reads more simply that it transmigrates and proceeds together with the cause of pleasure and pain. In the final verse, the Tibetan word that the glossary gives for a class of spirits (bhūta) here clearly means the material elements.

• The clause "because, being without earlier and later, it does not newly arise" renders a terse Tibetan phrase whose exact construction is uncertain. In the passage on the actual Tathāgata, the word rendered "faculties" is the ordinary word for sense faculties, not the name Indra. The "alms bowl that came back as though washed clean" refers to the episode in which the Buddha returned with an empty bowl after his alms round.
• The opening verses close the preceding chapter; their sense is compressed, and the reading of the first stanza's last two lines follows the parallel Sanskrit sense (beings go by that path, and so they do not reach final cessation). The four habitual tendencies are taken as those of existence, desire, form and views. Here □□□□□□□□ is rendered "living creatures" rather than the spirit class, since the context is ordinary animals. The quoted criticism continues into the next piece.
• □□□□□□ is taken as King Śibi of the well-known story of the hawk and the pigeon, since the narrative plainly refers to it; the Tibetan form is unusual. □□□□□ is taken as sugar candy (Skt. khaṇḍa) and □□□□ as treacle (Skt. phāṇita), on the basis of the parallel Sanskrit list of foods. The clause about those who "indulge heavily" is compressed in the Tibetan and has been rendered according to its evident sense.
• The phrase rendered "whose view of the transitory collection has grown strong in their disputation" is obscure in the Tibetan; the sense is that these monks hold to the view of a real self (satkāyadṛṣṭi) and dispute accordingly. Where the Tibetan has "would I also have forbidden" without an explicit negative, it is read as a rhetorical question, which agrees with the argument that meat was never permitted. "The ten that die naturally" refers to the meat of ten kinds of animals that have died of natural causes.
• "Ever like a dream" renders □□□□□□□, which is not a clear word; read as □□□□□□□, "continually," matching the Sanskrit sadā. □□□□□□, which recurs in the spirit lists, is rendered as ḍāka and ḍākinī; □□□□□□□□ as pūtana; □□□□□□□ as ostāraka; and □□□□□□□□□□ as apasmāra, following the standard equivalents. The phrase "pure in three respects" follows the Tibetan list of unconceived, unrequested and unurged.
• "The domain of the noble gods" renders □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□ literally; the intended sense may be the domain of the noble ones' divine (meditative) abiding. "The Principal of the world" takes □□□ as the Sāṃkhya pradhāna, listed with the "makers" as imagined creators. The final line opens a verse that continues in the next piece.
• "In the view of mere cognition" reads the unusual □□□□□ as □□□□, "view." The line "conceptuality is but the word 'fire'" renders the obscure □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□; □□□ might instead mean "burning," giving "conceptuality is the burning of fire." In the bird simile, the two bird names, □□□□□ and □□□□, could not be identified with confidence. They are rendered generally as "a bird" and "a bird of another kind."
• In the verse on Akaniṣṭha, the Tibetan reads "speech" (ngag), which makes little sense; I have read it as "pure" (dag), a similar-looking syllable that matches the sense of the parallel Sanskrit verse. "A body belonging among the classes of beings" renders an obscure expression that likely refers to the emanation body taken on by bodhisattvas. In the verse on the Vaiśeṣikas and Sāṃkhyas, the term usually meaning "indeterminate" refers here to the questions left unanswered, as the following verse on the four kinds of answer shows.
• In the verse beginning "These phenomena are unborn," the second line reads literally "nor are they pure" (de dag pa), which does not fit; the sense of the parallel verse and the metre suggest a dropped syllable for "nor are they nonexistent" (de dag med pa'ang), and it has been translated so. The three characteristics (imputed, dependent, perfected) and "transformation" (parāvṛtti, for □□□□□□□□□□□□□) are Yogācāra technical terms.
• The three embryological terms (□□□□□, □□□□□□, □□□□) correspond to the standard fetal stages (Skt. peśī, arbuda, ghana); their exact correspondence here is uncertain, so they are rendered

descriptively. □□□□ (the southern land of Nāga's appearance) corresponds to Vedalī in the Sanskrit; I keep the Tibetan form. In the verse on the masteries, □□□ renders vaśitā ("mastery"), not empowerment; □□□ in the final list is the "ultimate limit" (bhūtakoṭi), not an "extreme".

• The verse listing "the tenth is the first, the first is the eighth" and so on refers to the bodhisattva grounds (bhūmis): in the imageless there is no real sequence among them. The Tibetan uses collective forms with □□ for several numbers, but the sense is plainly ordinal and they have been rendered so. In "the heirs who are pratyekabuddhas" the Tibetan reads □□□□□□□□□□□□□□, apparently the "sons who are pratyekajinas," set beside the "children of the Victor" (bodhisattvas) of the earlier verse. "Those within the schools" renders □□□□□□□□□□□□, Buddhists of the sectarian schools who are placed here alongside the non-Buddhists.

• In the verse on birth and cause, the Tibetan reads "like causes and the rest" (rgyu), which makes little sense. I have followed the evident reading "illusions" (sgyu), a one-letter difference.

The Sanskrit of the famous verse on nonappearance says the yogin abiding there "sees the Mahāyāna." This Tibetan has the negative, and the translation follows the Tibetan.

The verse beginning "Seeing, with conceit, the positing of truth" and the one that follows it ("the single one is established as fivefold") are obscure, and the rendering is tentative.

In the line "no karma and no fire," "fire" (me) is odd in a list of doctrinal categories. It is kept as written, but it may be a scribal slip.

• In the second stanza the Tibetan reads "one comes to see permanence and annihilation" with no negation; the Sanskrit parallel probably means that one abiding in mind only does not see them. The positive reading is translated as it stands. The six-line stanza on the śrāvakas' discernment is syntactically compressed in the Tibetan. The rendering follows the likely sense that the śrāvakas' discernment operates through clinging to entities, while the stainless discernment of the Sugata is free of appearance and of the two vehicles. "Those given to desire" probably renders icchantika, those cut off from the roots of virtue, though the Tibetan wording here is not the usual one.

• "Curved" renders the obscure syllables at the start of the line on the cloth-cutting knife; the reading is uncertain. In the line on improper food, the Tibetan has "wood" (shing), which makes no sense there; it has been read as "death" (shi), giving the standard prohibition of food from houses of death or birth.

• The text as written has a word meaning "by the foolish" where "the childish" (ordinary beings) is plainly required; it is translated as "the childish." In the line "the masteries and the ten grounds," the term usually rendered "empowerment" here denotes the bodhisattva masteries (vaśitā); in the three-nature verses the same word is short for the dependent nature. In "The five imagine what appears," the Tibetan reads "the fifth," evidently for "the five," the five sense consciousnesses. The quotation marks follow the dialogue between Mahāmati and the Buddha implied by the context; the Tibetan gives no explicit speaker labels.

• In the line "grasp at hairs and the forms of dreams," the syllable ska (□□) makes no clear sense here; it has been read as a near-duplicate of skra, "hair," in the sense of the illusory hair-nets mentioned later.

The phrase "do not occur on the seventh ground" renders □□□□□□, which could also be read as "the seven grounds." It is taken as the seventh ground because the following line contrasts it with the eighth.

Excellent Intelligence, Gone Afar and Cloud of Dharma are the ninth, seventh and tenth bodhisattva grounds. "Dependent" and "imagined" are two of the three natures (paratantra and parikalpita), and "the natures" refers to these three natures.

• The simile rendered "like a plantain trunk" translates a Tibetan phrase meaning literally "a water-born heap." The plantain is the usual image of hollowness, but the reading is not certain. In the verse on conditions, "craving" follows the Tibetan as written. A reading "existence" (a similar spelling) would also fit the argument. The line on the logicians, "the absence of things is no extreme," is obscure in the Tibetan and is rendered literally. Here "brahman" denotes the supreme state, not the god Brahmā.
• In the verse beginning "Not knowing that external objects," the word usually meaning "extreme" is taken as "thesis" (the proposition of a formal proof), since the following verse lists reason, thesis, examples and members of proof. The question "Who has made entities into real entities that cycle on?" renders an elliptical phrase; it may also be read as asking how entityhood brings about saṃsāra. The double negative in "It is not that nothing is observed" is kept as the Tibetan has it. "Those who destroy" renders an obscure phrase whose object is not stated.
• The word rendered "people" in "the livelihood of people" is written □□□□□, which is unclear; it has been taken as "those born, people." The line "There is no other and no dependence" appears to split the term "dependent nature" (paratantra) across the line for metrical reasons. The epithet □□□□□ before Kapila is obscure and has been left untranslated. Speakers are inferred: the quoted objections and the question addressed to the Blessed One, marked by humble verbs, come from the questioner, and the replies from the Buddha.
• "Nourished" renders □□□□□□, in the sense of mind being fostered by habitual tendencies; here it is not the name Vyāsa. The line pairing the rabbit's horn with "a cause of nonexistence" is terse in the Tibetan. It seems to mean that the rabbit's horn serves as the stock example of what does not exist, in contrast to pots, cloth and the like, which arise from collections of causes.
• The line "Intrinsic nature is free of mind, and mind proceeds to the noble ones" is obscure in the Tibetan; the term rendered "intrinsic nature" could instead be the Sāṃkhya "primal nature" (prakṛti), given the Sāṃkhyas named in the next line. The verse beginning "Knowing the appearances of mind" is syntactically difficult and is rendered tentatively. "The five dharmas, the natures" refers to the standard Laṅkāvatāra set of five dharmas and three natures (svabhāva). "The transformation that is without basis" reflects the doctrine of the transformation of the basis (āśrayaparāvṛtti).
• In the line rendered "Because cause and effect are upheld," the Tibetan reads "good" (bzang ba); this has been read as "held, upheld" (bzung ba), which fits the argument. The verse "Like 'hand' and 'doer' in the world, like Indra, Śakra, and Purandara" plays on synonyms (two Sanskrit words for "hand," and three names of Indra) to show that different names refer to a single thing. "The three natures" and "the natures" here are the three natures (trisvabhāva) of Yogācāra, not the primal nature of Sāṃkhya. Several verses are terse, and the speaker changes without any marker. The questions are taken as Mahāmati's and the answers as the Buddha's, following the vocatives and humble or honorific verbs.
• The stanza on the "five śrāvakas" is obscure in the Tibetan; its items are rendered literally and their exact identification is uncertain. "The water element has the nature of an emanation" renders the Tibetan as written; one would expect a quality such as moisture or cohesion, and the original sense is unclear. "The meaning of solitude" renders the term for the isolated, ultimate meaning (viviktārtha).
• The repeated word rendered "giving" translates the Tibetan as written; its sense in this discussion of self and appropriation is obscure, and the underlying Sanskrit may have meant something other than generosity. "The lethal power in a drug" renders a phrase that literally reads "the killing of medicine". Throughout this passage the text voices a qualified, tathāgatagarbha-based teaching of a pure "self" set against non-Buddhist and nihilist views;

the translation keeps the Tibetan wording without harmonizing it.
• □□□□□□□□ is taken as the Bhārata (bhāra "burden"), matching the list of epic and dynastic names; □□□□□ in the dynastic list is taken as the Guptas. The verse on the ages (□□□□□□□□□□□□, □□□□□□□□□□□□□□, □□□□□□□□) is obscure. The Tibetan seems to be rendering the four yugas, with □□□□□□□□ as the kṛta or "perfect" age, but the first terms are translated literally. The lines about Mati and Mekhala are terse; the rendering follows the most natural reading of the Tibetan. "Bhudhuka" is kept as the Tibetan transliterates it, since its identity is unclear. Somagupta is taken as the father's name.
• The verses of this closing section are terse and in places obscure in Tibetan. "Ṛṣabha, of great and pure glory" may instead name a separate figure (perhaps a Vimalaśrī) rather than describe Ṛṣabha. In "the fleshly eye and wisdom," the Tibetan has only "of flesh," taken here as shorthand for the fleshly eye. "The wheel in the opening of a house" and "a house of many guests" render obscure similes literally. "In beings they hold no elements" is a tentative reading.
• This version of the sūtra was translated from Chinese, and these closing verses are terse and in places obscure. "The elephant's bed" renders the Tibetan literally; the image is unclear. "The Heroic Progress" renders the samādhi known as Śūraṅgama. "The seven grounds" follows the Tibetan, where one might expect a reference to the eighth ground as the stage beyond the śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas. The quatrain on taking food appears to be a monastic rule embedded among the verses.

Colophon

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Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.